
Guilds & Dragons
Book Two
The Dragon's Hearth
A Web Novella Edition

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Chapter 1: The Morning After

Morning arrived with a vengeance.

Shade woke first. He was still exhausted, but lying motionless had begun to seem like a reliable way to fuse every muscle in his body into one continuous ache.

He tried to sit up.

Everything complained.

“Oh,” he croaked. “That was a tactical error.”

Beside him, Rakihi gave a sound halfway between a groan and a satisfied hum.

“Tactical victory,” she corrected without opening her eyes. “Tomorrow can worry about the errors.”

On his other side, Arcebek stretched, heard several joints pop, and immediately regretted the decision.

“All right,” she rasped. “I take back every time I called you three fragile. I am wrecked.”

Elcia did not move.

A blanket concealed everything but Elcia’s brown curls. She lay on her stomach, apparently considering whether getting out of bed was a worthwhile pursuit.

After a long silence, her voice emerged from beneath the covers.

“Mercy,” she said. “I’ve changed my mind. I want mercy.”

Rakihi laughed and immediately clutched her ribs. “Careful. That hurts.”

Shade managed to swing his legs over the edge of the bed.

The floor seemed farther away than usual. His thighs burned, his back protested, and his shoulder bore bite marks alongside scratches and a collection of unmistakably finger-shaped bruises.

“You’re limping,” Arcebek pointed out.

“So are you,” he shot back.

“I’m fine,” Arcebek lied. Then she tried to stand and caught the bedpost with both hands.

Rakihi rolled onto her back and surveyed the ceiling through a spectacular tangle of blue hair.

“If a demon comes through that door,” she said, “we’re finished. Not because we couldn’t fight it. I simply refuse to battle anything while my joints have this many complaints.”

Elcia finally emerged from beneath the blanket. Even in undeath, colour warmed her cheeks.

She touched her neck, then her lips, as though checking whether the sensations of the night had been real.

“I understand why mortals write poetry about this,” she announced. “I also understand why they sometimes spend hours afterward staring at the ceiling.”

Rakihi turned to her with a wicked smile. “You really did beg for mercy. Actual words. Out loud.”

Elcia pulled the blanket halfway back over her face.

“In my defence, I was unprepared. I had decades of catching up to do.”

Shade coughed, ears pink.

Arcebek found her way toward the washbasin, bumping Shade's shoulder quite deliberately as she passed.

"Backlog cleared. New rule: no demon-hunting, bargaining with gods, or experiments in necromancy for at least twenty-four hours. We are officially on recovery leave."

"Lana will approve that?" Shade asked skeptically.

"Lana doesn't need to know why we're moving like we fought a hill full of giants," Arcebek said. "She'll assume it was training. Technically, she'll be right."

"Team-building exercise," Rakihi suggested. "Intensive coordination drills."

" 'Endurance training,'" Elcia added dryly.

Shade covered his face. "Please stop. My dignity has suffered enough."

"You didn't seem very dignified last night," Rakihi murmured.

"Rakihi," he groaned.

She grinned, then softened, rolling back to face Elcia.

"How's the warmth?" she asked more softly. "Too much? Too little?"

Elcia's expression went thoughtful.

"Different," Elcia said. "The dullahan pull is still there—the road, the thresholds. But beneath it, there's a glow, like banked coals. Touch means something now. More than pressure." She glanced between them. "I feel as though I belong to something beyond the curse."

Shade's chest tightened.

"If that ever changes," Shade said, "tell me. I can ease the flow or stop it. You are not trapped by what we did."

Elcia smiled, small and crooked.

"I promise. For now, I'm getting used to it."

Arcebek splashed water on her face, then patted around for a towel.

"You all handled it well," she told Elcia. "You talked, checked in, and made sure the magic wasn't getting ahead of you."

Rakihi tilted her head. "High praise from the queen of bad decisions," she said.

"Former queen," Arcebek corrected. "Now I'm a responsible eldritch consultant and relationship scheduler. It's dreadful. I love it."

Shade stood and stretched, cautiously this time.

His body complained.

Beneath the soreness, though, was a quiet certainty that he belonged here.

"I have survived worse battles," he said, testing his shoulders. "Few were this enjoyable."

Rakihi's smile went soft. "Same," she admitted.

Elcia worried at the edge of the blanket.

“I…” she began, then stopped, embarrassed.

“Yes?” Arcebek prompted.

“I’m glad it was with you,” Elcia said. “All of you. After what happened to me—after what I became—it matters.”

Rakihi drew her into an embrace. Shade leaned in beside them, and Arcebek reached back until she found Elcia’s ankle and gave it a reassuring squeeze.

“Good,” Arcebek said simply. “Then we did something right.”

For a while they stayed together in comfortable silence.

Rakihi, naturally, broke it.

“Breakfast. Who’s making it? Because if you expect me to stand at a stove like this, we’ll starve.”

Shade sighed and forced himself to his feet.

“I will,” Shade said. “If I stay here any longer, I may fossilise.”

Elcia tested her footing. “I’ll help. Arcebek can lecture us while we chop things. About schedules, boundaries, and why certain activities are forbidden the night before a mission.”

“I have several lectures prepared,” Arcebek said.

Rakihi groaned into the pillow. “We’ve created a monster,” she mumbled fondly.

In the doorway Shade glanced back at the tangle of blankets and the three women looking considerably less indestructible than usual.

For all the aches and laughter, they looked happy.

He thought of the fears each of them had brought to this house, and how little room those fears had been given last night.

He smiled.

“Next time,” he said, “we warm up first.”

Rakihi threw a pillow at him.

Arcebek laughed.

Elcia shook her head, muttering something about dragons and their terrible puns.

By the time they reached the kitchen, the house smelled of fresh bread and there was already an argument over who had stolen whose pillow. Shade found the sound wonderfully ordinary.

Chapter 2: Lana's Shadow

Lana's office smelled of ink, old parchment, and the faint remains of a meal abandoned in favour of work.

Shade closed the door at her gesture and took his usual place before the desk.

She studied him, one finger tapping a stack of reports.

"I have a mission for you," she said. "Only you. Not your party."

He straightened. "All right. What do you need?"

Lana leaned back.

"For the next month, I want you as my shadow. Bodyguard, if you prefer. Where I go, you go—meetings, inspections, council sessions, the entire miserable circuit."

He blinked.

"Me? You want me following you around like an oversized, heavily armed cloak?"

"Precisely. You can glower at nobles, loom over merchants, and discourage anyone tempted to be clever."

He pictured himself standing behind her in a council chamber while she argued over budgets. He knew battlefields; this would be unfamiliar territory.

"Why now?" he asked.

Her gaze shifted toward the window and the distant sounds of the city.

"Because in the last few months my guild has acquired a dullahan, persuaded a death god to amend his arrangements, promoted a dragon and his chaos party to Gold, and welcomed back a warlock with fresh opinions about outer powers. People are noticing."

"People," he repeats.

"Councillors. Rival guilds. Cults displeased that we sent one of their demons home in pieces." Her mouth tightened. "My name is on more lists than it used to be. Some of those lists worry me."

Shade went still.

"You believe someone will try to hurt you."

"When power shifts, someone always tests the edges. I'd prefer company when they do." She met his eyes. "You know my weaknesses. You're difficult to bribe, harder to frighten, and exceptionally difficult to kill."

Shade considered the words.

By Lana's standards, that was practically affection.

"There's a catch," she added.

"Several, I imagine."

"First, the work will be boring: council chambers, merchant halls, legal hearings. Second, no Elcia, no Rakihi, and no bringing your terrifying partners along for moral support. This assignment is yours.

Third, it lasts a full month. You'll be off field missions. You can go home each night, but your days belong to me."

Shade considered the terms.

He understood guard duty. He also understood how much he had come to rely on the others fighting at his side. Elcia's tether stirred faintly at the back of his awareness.

Lana folded her hands.

"You may refuse. I mean that. I'm not conscripting you. Talk to your household first." She almost smiled. "I only met Arcebek again yesterday. I am not taking you away for a month without consulting the warlock, the bard, and the death knight. I enjoy being alive."

"A wise precaution," Shade said.

"I try. Give me your answer tomorrow."

He inclined his head. "I will."

He turned toward the door.

"Shade?"

He looked back.

For once, she set aside the guildmaster's expression.

"This isn't punishment," she said. "I trust you. That's the whole of it."

The words caught him off guard.

"I know."

And he realised he did.

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All three were in the sitting room when he returned.

Rakihi had curled up in a chair with a book. Arcebek sat on the floor against the couch, carving a small piece of wood by touch. Elcia stood at the window, polishing her armour while she watched the street.

"A month?" Rakihi repeated when he finished. "Shadowing her? Like a very pointy scarf?"

"Meetings, council sessions, inspections. No fieldwork."

Arcebek gave a low whistle. "She's making you a visible deterrent. Smart woman."

Elcia turned from the window. "I can still sense you through the tether. When you're distressed, it hums. That could give us warning if a threat to Lana is more subtle than a knife."

"I had considered that. We will need to be careful how we use it."

"So," Rakihi said, counting on her fingers, "you'll be gone during the day, home at night, taking no missions, and watching wealthy people posture at each other?"

"Yes."

She wrinkled her nose. "Sounds dreadful. Do you actually want it?"

Shade thought before answering.

“Part of me does. Guard duty is simple: keep someone alive. I understand that. But I will miss you, even if it is only during the day.”

Arcebek set aside her knife and the piece of wood.

“Do you want the work?” she asked. There was no accusation in the question.

He took a moment to consider.

“Yes. Lana is right about the pressure she faces. I would rather be there when it arrives. And I owe her something for making room for us here.” His mouth curved. “Besides, I confess to some interest in the faces of certain councillors when they see me behind her chair.”

“Petty dragon,” Rakihi said fondly.

Elcia studied him. “Do you feel obliged to accept because she’s Lana?”

Shade shook his head.

“I would worry every time she left the guild without protection. I prefer being useful to sitting here imagining what might happen.”

Arcebek nodded. “That sounds like a choice.”

She climbed onto the couch and leaned forward.

“Then here’s my view. I won’t enjoy losing you from the field for a month. But we’ve only just reached Gold. We can afford a quieter stretch.”

“And I could use a few weeks without nearly dying,” Rakihi admitted. “Perhaps I’ll finally write down my songs before I forget the lyrics.”

“Elcia and I can handle patrols and simple escorts. Nothing that needs the full dragon treatment. Mina and Tomas could use some practice leading smaller jobs, too.”

Elcia smiled. “We can manage bandits without you. The roads will still be there in a month.”

She faced Shade directly.

“My concern is that you’ll work yourself to exhaustion and call it standing in a corner. If you accept, schedule time to feed on gems. Remind Lana that you are not an inexhaustible ornament.”

Rakihi snapped her fingers. “A feeding chart! I’ll draw little sapphires.”

“Please not on the wall,” Shade said.

“Especially on the wall. Visual accountability.”

Arcebek laughed. “If Lana sees it, gods help us.”

“She’ll add columns,” Rakihi said.

All four winced.

Then Arcebek found Shade’s hand and squeezed it.

“I support it,” she said. “Provided it’s what you want, not what you feel you should want. I trust Lana not to turn you into a decorative coat rack. And I rather like knowing the person keeping this circus legal has a dragon at her back.”

Rakihi leaned over her chair and caught his other hand. “I’m fine with it too. We’ll miss you during the day, but you come home every night. That’s not negotiable.”

Elcia joined them. “And if something goes wrong—with politics, threats, or Lana trying to sacrifice herself for someone—you tell us. You don’t carry it alone.”

“Agreed,” Arcebek said. “I also expect every scrap of gossip. Preferably a daily account of which councillor nearly got set on fire.”

Shade laughed.

He had feared they might resent the separation. Instead they were planning ways to make it work.

“Then I’ll accept—with conditions. I come home every night, I keep up my gem-feeding, and I call for help if the danger exceeds what I can manage.”

“Good,” Arcebek said. “If Lana tries to squeeze more out of you, I’ll have a word.”

“I would pay to hear that conversation,” Rakihi said.

“You might hear it from the street.”

Elcia rested a hand on his shoulder.

“You’ll do well. You have considerable experience placing yourself between dangerous things and people with opinions.”

Rakihi grinned. “The nicest way anyone’s ever called you a meat shield.”

He rolled his eyes, unable to hide a smile.

“Thank you. All of you.”

Rakihi pulled him down for a kiss. “Go be Lana’s terrifying accessory. We’ll keep the house standing.”

Arcebek kissed his knuckles. “And when you get home, we’ll make sure you actually rest.”

Elcia gave him a small, steady smile, the sort that carried more assurance than a speech.

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The next morning Shade returned to Lana’s office.

“Well?” she asked.

“I accept.”

She nodded, though he caught the relief she tried to hide.

“Good. We start tomorrow. Today you rest, eat something that glows, tell your partners they were right, and buy a cloak that doesn’t look as though you dragged it off a corpse.”

“You are concerned with fashion now?”

“Optics. There’s a difference. If I’m going to have a dragon-shaped shadow, I want him to look deliberate, not like something I found on a battlefield.”

Shade laughed.

“As you wish.”

She gave him a searching look.

“They’re truly all right with this? Arcebek didn’t threaten to curse my tea?”

“Not directly. She approves—with conditions.”

“Of course she does.” Lana reached for a stack of documents. “Then for the next month, you’re mine from dawn until dusk.”

She stood and tucked the papers under one arm.

“Let’s see how many secrets this city can keep when there’s a dragon standing in the room.”

To Shade’s surprise, the prospect stirred anticipation rather than dread.

“Lead on,” he said.

Chapter 3: The Problem with Lying

The house had reached that quiet hour when no one wanted to move, much less speak.

Arcebek slept with an arm across Rakihi's waist. Elcia rested on Shade's other side, eyes half closed as she listened to rain against the shutters.

Shade lay watching the ceiling, warm and comfortably exhausted, until Rakihi broke the silence.

"Hey, Shade?"

He hummed. "Mm?"

She shifted against his shoulder. "Why are you so bad at lying?"

That woke him up.

He turned toward her. "I am not that bad."

"You're dreadful. You go stiff, your voice becomes terribly careful, and your eyes do that thing. Even Lana notices, and she thinks sarcasm is a food group."

Elcia made an amused sound. "She is right. It is very obvious."

Shade prepared a defence, then remembered every failed attempt to deflect an awkward question since his arrival.

"Fair," he admitted.

"So why?" Rakihi asked. "It isn't just honesty. You can dodge questions perfectly well, but you can't seem to tell a convincing lie."

He took his time answering.

The hearth cracked softly. Arcebek murmured in her sleep and turned over.

Shade exhaled.

"In the court where I grew up, lying was usually pointless. Sometimes dangerous."

"Because dragons?" Rakihi asked.

"Because of the Empress. And her eyes."

Elcia became more attentive. "The eyes your mother's emissary mentioned? The ones that can see an object's past?"

"Yes. My mother and some of the older broods can look backward through things—and through people. It is different from Arcebek's sight, or your curse."

He shifted higher against the pillows.

"Imagine a palace where the Empress can look at a cup and see the conversations held over it. Where she can look at the floor and know who crossed it, or at you and know what you would rather keep hidden."

Rakihi fell quiet.

"That sounds horrible."

“It is efficient,” he said dryly. “Secrets rarely last. Those who wish to deceive learn to construct half-truths that survive inspection from several directions.”

“And you?” Elcia asked.

“I never mastered it. My siblings could say one thing and mean three. When I attempted the same, Mother would look at me and say, ‘Again, Shade. The truth this time.’”

Fondness and old embarrassment mingled in his voice.

Rakihi traced a circle on his chest. “Did she punish you for lying?”

“Not always. Not as you might expect. But being caught in a poor lie before the court cost you trust. Requests were delayed. Projects lost funding. And if a lie concerned Void movements, treaties, or the front lines, the consequences could be deadly.”

He rested his head against the pillows.

“Eventually I stopped trying. Silence was safer. Sometimes I answered another question. But a direct lie beneath her gaze made you more conspicuous, not less.”

Rakihi considered that.

“So you brought the habit here.”

He smiled.

“An old reflex. I still expect a lie to cost me trust I cannot afford to lose—even with Mother a world away.”

Elcia nodded. “That explains why your silences are so loud. You don’t lie; you simply stop speaking, and we know something hurts.”

“Like with the demons,” Rakihi said. “And the Void. And all three of us.”

Shade winced. “I am learning.”

Rakihi lifted her head to see his face.

“For what it’s worth, I like that you’re bad at it. When you say something sweet or ridiculous, I know you mean it.”

“Even when I am being an idiot?”

“Especially then. Anyone can say pretty things. You blush and look as if you want the floor to swallow you whenever you admit you’re frightened.”

“And you still tell us uncomfortable truths,” Elcia said. “That matters.”

Shade considered their words.

“Would you rather I could hide things more skilfully? The worst of what I am—or was?”

Rakihi snorted. “We share a house with a dragon, a blind warlock whose eyes see things they shouldn’t, and a dullahan who can detach her head. Our opportunities for appearing ordinary are limited.”

Arcebek stirred. “My eyes are beautiful. Shut up.” Then she rolled closer, flinging an arm across them.

“See?” Rakihi said. “We are a disaster. Better an honest one.”

Shade found her hand beneath the blanket.

“I shall try to keep the honesty and lose the reflex to retreat into silence.”

“That’s all I ask. Well, that and perhaps not volunteering the necromancy experiments the instant Lana asks whether we’ve done anything reckless. Give her some warning.”

Shade laughed.

“No promises.”

“Terrible liar,” Rakihi reminded him.

“Precisely,” Elcia said.

Shade sighed, comfortably outvoted.

“Very well. I will practise strategic omission. Sparingly.”

Rakihi settled against him again, her hair brushing his jaw.

“Good. My hopeless, honest disasters.”

Elcia brushed his arm before settling beside him.

In the dark, Shade thought of the Empress’s court: all those secrets examined beneath ancient, merciless eyes.

Then he looked at the women beside him, who knew more about him than anyone in Aleris and still chose to stay.

Here, the truth was not a weapon waiting to be used against him.

It was something he could give freely.

Chapter 4: A Paladin's Oath

The morning began peacefully.

That lasted until Elcia chose to make an announcement while Shade was drinking his tea.

Rakihi was buttering bread, Arcebek sorting coins by touch, and Elcia had been suspiciously quiet since they sat down.

Shade should have recognized the warning.

"I've made a decision," Elcia announced, in the careful voice she used when she had rehearsed an argument a dozen times.

Shade made an encouraging noise over the rim of his cup.

"I'm going to train to be a paladin," she said calmly.

Shade inhaled his tea instead of swallowing it.

He nearly choked.

Rakihi squealed as tea sprayed across the table. Arcebek recoiled, and the nearest bread roll suffered an undeserved soaking.

Shade coughed, eyes watering. "You're going to what?"

Elcia blinked at him, all innocence. "Become a paladin," she repeated. "Was I unclear?"

Rakihi slapped the table. "Oh, I support this. A holy dullahan. A death knight paladin. We're going to break so many theologians."

"Which order?" Arcebek asked. "Please tell me before I start screaming."

Elcia folded her hands, composed.

"Not the celibate kind," Elcia said firmly. "I checked that first."

Rakihi almost fell off her chair laughing. "I love you."

Arcebek pinched the bridge of her nose. "Good," she muttered. "That was going to be an issue."

Shade could only stare.

"Elcia. You are undead, bound by a death-curse, and you want to become a god's shining sword."

"Yes," she said. "Perfect fit."

"That isn't—" He stopped. "Which order?"

Elcia's mouth twitched, betraying the unease beneath her composure.

"The Order of the Weighing Scales. They serve Kael Varis, god of judgment, thresholds, and reckoning. They value justice." She paused. "Perhaps at almost any cost."

Shade pressed two fingers to his forehead. "Of course they do."

Rakihi perked up. "Kael Varis?" she said. "That's the one with the black-and-white scales and the 'no one escapes the balance' sermons, right?"

“Yes. But the part that matters to me is standing at a door and telling someone they don’t get to pass through it to hurt people.”

“That order excommunicated a duke for tax fraud,” Arcebek said, “then helped replace him with his own steward.”

“Ah,” Shade said. “Them.”

“He stole grain from starving villages. They tried him fairly, he confessed, and he refused to make amends. So they replaced him.”

Rakihi pointed a knife at her, grinning. “See? This is the ‘interesting’ part of your morality we keep talking about.”

“People who prey on the weak deserve to be stopped,” Elcia said. “If the law won’t stop them, someone must. The Scales understand that.”

“They also have a reputation for zeal,” Shade said. “And none of us is a simple case.”

Elcia turned to him, expression softening.

“I know. That’s why I’ve been talking to them privately, rather than pledging myself to the first cleric with a codex. I wanted to know whether they would even accept me.”

Arcebek’s head tilted. “And?” she asked. “What did they say about the ‘undead’ thing?”

“They called me complicated. An unwilling curse. A walking injustice that refused to lie down.” Her gaze found Shade. “They approve of what you did to the death god who held my leash.”

“Wait. Kael Varis isn’t the god who held your curse?”

“No. The old god hoarded souls and demanded silence. Kael Varis judges conduct and weighs amends. They have been at odds for centuries.”

Arcebek snorted. “So if you join, we’re officially on one side of that argument,” she said. “Great.”

Rakihi nudged Shade. “She’s found a faith that suits her. Imagine: fewer lectures about unfinished business and more ‘I have sworn an oath; let me smite that landlord.’”

Shade rubbed his temples. “I love you,” he told Elcia, “and your sense of right and wrong terrifies me.”

She had the nerve to look pleased.

“Thank you,” she said.

He gave her a look. “That was not a compliment.”

“For me it is,” she said. “You hate demons and anyone who acts like them. I… hate injustice that looks respectable. We match.”

Arcebek set down her coins. “All right. Jokes aside—why this, Elcia?”

Elcia looked at her hands before answering.

“At the castle I was a weapon. Joren’s weapon. The god’s. They sent me against villagers who had done nothing wrong, collecting debts built on lies. I could fight the leash, but never decide where it dragged me.”

Her fingers tightened against the tabletop.

“I want more than freedom from that leash. I want to choose where I ride, and why. I want an oath I can believe in.”

She met each of their eyes in turn.

“I don’t trust many gods. But Kael Varis keeps records. He weighs amends alongside wrongs. I want to learn that discipline. The curse gives me power; training could teach me where to aim it.”

The tightness behind Shade’s eyes began to ease.

“That,” he said, “I understand.”

Rakihi kicked his ankle under the table. “Also,” she added, grinning, “paladin dullahan girlfriend is hot.”

Elcia spluttered. “That is not the point.”

“It is a point,” Arcebek said. “Just not the moral one.”

Arcebek’s smile faded as she turned toward Elcia.

“Then here’s my condition. If the order ever starts using you the way Joren did—talking about necessary sacrifices and acceptable losses—you leave. You come home, and we work out what to do next.”

Elcia nodded, serious. “Deal,” she said.

“And don’t turn that judgment on us without hearing us first. If we make a mistake, we talk about it and put it right.”

A flicker of hurt crossed Elcia’s face. “I would never—”

“I know,” Arcebek said gently. “That’s why I’m saying it now. You belong to yourself, Elcia. Don’t give an oath the right to take that away.”

Rakihi took Elcia’s hand. “I trust you with a sword and I trust you with an oath. Just promise you won’t put the oath above yourself.”

Shade exhaled, then nodded.

“I’ve known paladins in my mother’s war,” Shade said. “Some were magnificent. Others grew so rigid they broke. You still prefer a sharp line between right and wrong.”

Rakihi snorted. “Says the dragon who wanted to toss a whole cult into the sun.”

“I have grown,” he said, deadpan.

Elcia huffed a laugh despite herself.

“I know I’m severe,” Elcia admitted. “I want clean answers. That’s part of why I need teachers who will challenge me—people who can show me how to hold to a code without becoming its prisoner.”

“That,” Shade said, “helps.”

He took a breath.

“Then you have my support. I want to meet your mentor, and I want to hear about your vows before you take them. If anyone asks you to burn a village for the greater good, I reserve the right to carry you out over my shoulder.”

Elcia's eyes softened. "Agreed," she said. "All of it."

Rakihi beamed. "Lana is going to love this paperwork. 'Our gold party now contains a dragon, a warlock with eyes in another realm, a bard of chaos, and a paladin dullahan of questionable but sincere morality.'"

Arcebek groaned. "She's going to need another bottle for that meeting," she said.

Shade finally smiled, rubbing his face.

"You startled me," Shade told Elcia. "But I'm proud of you. This is a path you chose, not a punishment somebody imposed."

She smiled back, quiet and bright.

"Thank you," she said. "And for the record… I love you too. All three of you. Even when you give me headaches about 'nuance.'"

Rakihi raised her cup. "To nuance," she said.

"To justice with guardrails," Arcebek added.

"To paladins who know when to put the sword down," Shade said.

Elcia hesitated, then lifted her own cup.

"To trying," she said. "And to remembering that justice at almost any cost must still have limits."

They drank.

Shade's headache remained, though its cause had changed.

He could bear worrying about a dangerous path if Elcia was the one who had chosen it.

He could live with that.

He would still have to explain the occasional holy glow to Lana. That, he suspected, would be the truly dangerous part.

Chapter 5: The First Week

The first week made a determined effort to be boring.

Shade had expected veiled threats, assassins, perhaps a cultist hiding in the rafters.

Instead, he got paperwork.

Mountains of it.

Lana's days started early and ended late.

He kept one pace behind Lana and half a step to the side: close enough to intercept a threat, far enough to let her work. By the second day, the staff had learned to steer around the combined presence of guildmaster and dragon.

Most of their battles were administrative.

Requests for aid, disputes over contracts, petitions from villages that could pay only in grain and promises.

Lana listened, asked exactly the question that mattered, made a note, stamped the request, and moved on. Shade began to understand how much unseen work supported every mission he had ever taken.

One afternoon, she shoved a ledger across the desk toward him.

"Tell me if I'm missing something," she said. "We're running light on mid-rank healers. I can reshuffle, but I don't want to strand any routes."

Shade scanned the names, assignments, and travel times. It looked like a campaign map stripped of its banners.

"You're overcommitting these healers," he said, tracing a sequence of assignments. "Three long journeys without adequate rest. They'll start making mistakes."

"I thought so." Lana leaned in. "Where do we find the room?"

He followed the routes in his head.

"Put these five on the northern roads, with novice support at both stops. Your gold party is wasted on goblin nests; send them after the trolls, and the bronze team can take safer work."

She smirked. "You're annoyingly good at this," she said.

"I was trained for logistics. Mother's court didn't let young dragons choose battles without learning how to supply them."

"War by way of spreadsheets," Lana muttered. "I knew I liked you."

By the end of the week, his days had acquired a rhythm.

He opened doors and watched faces: merchants who flinched at the word audit, nobles who swelled with pride whenever they said "my lands."

Every so often, she'd tilt her head back and ask, low enough no one else heard:

"Anything off?"

He'd answer in the same murmur:

“He is lying about how many guards he can spare,” Shade might say. Or, “That one is frightened, not stubborn.” And sometimes, “Give her a way to save face, or she will dig in.”

It was nothing like a battlefield.

Yet he was beginning to see why it mattered.

He still came home with a skull full of numbers and words, feeling as though someone had beaten him with a very courteous stick.

And then there was the council.

Thirteen of them, not counting Lana.

Guild representatives. City officials. Temple liaisons. One noble whose family had “historically advised” the guild and very clearly thought that meant “now.”

They gathered around a circular table old enough to have survived several generations of arguments, speaking calmly about matters that made Shade’s scales itch.

Budgets. Jurisdiction. The appropriate compensation for “collateral damage.”

Lana had warned him beforehand.

“Don’t hit anyone,” she’d said. “No matter how much they deserve it. If I need you, I’ll say your name. Otherwise you stand there and look like you’re thinking about how flammable everyone is.”

Easy, he’d thought.

It was not easy.

Within an hour he understood: this was war conducted slowly, with more paper and less screaming.

Thirteen wills, each absolutely convinced they were protecting the city in the right way.

The High Priest arguing that more resources should go to temple-run shelters instead of caravan protection. The trade representative insisting that without safe roads there was no city. The noble wanting stricter controls on “adventurer behavior” because one bronze party had apparently insulted his cousin’s dog.

Lana navigated it all with that terrifying, controlled irritation Shade had grown to respect.

“No, Lord Harven, insulting noble property will not become a guild offense. Yes, Father Alren, you may have the cult reports. No, you may not purify a suspect before a hearing. And yes, the eastern road needs protection—but not at the south’s expense.”

Shade watched.

And listened.

He began to understand where the guild’s decisions came from.

Every fee, every escort, every rescue had passed through some room like this, emerging from bargains no adventurer ever saw.

By mid-day, his head pounded.

Then someone proposed pulling gold-ranked parties from frontier patrols to guard a noble wedding.

Shade actually felt his eye twitch.

Lana noticed.

“Shade,” she said, so mildly half the room missed the warning in her tone, “how many demon cult traces did your party find beyond the southern watch last month?”

He stepped forward just enough to be seen but not loom.

“Six. Two active, four abandoned. All on approaches to the villages you call less critical. We killed one lieutenant, but the others will probe for gaps.”

The noble who’d made the suggestion shifted in his chair.

Shade met his gaze without blinking.

“Demons care nothing for your cousin’s wedding. Leave the frontier unguarded and they will notice.”

Silence.

Lana smiled her sharp, professional smile.

“Thank you,” she said. “Recommendation stands: gold parties remain where the problems are.”

They moved on.

The meeting ground onward.

For every clear victory, Lana conceded three smaller points, choosing which compromises the guild could afford.

When the council finally dispersed, Shade was exhausted—not from fighting, but from resisting the urge.

From holding still.

He walked Lana back to her office in silence.

She dropped into her chair, rubbing at her temples.

“Well?” she said after a bit, eyes closed. “Still glad you said yes?”

He considered.

“My head hurts,” he said honestly. “And I wanted to bite at least four people.”

“Only four?” she muttered. “I’m impressed.”

He hesitated.

“Is it worth it?” he finally asked.

She opened one eye.

“You saw them try to strip the south of protection. Would they have backed down without us?”

He thought of the circle of iron in the demon lieutenant’s chamber. Of frontier villages with no walls, just tired farmers. Of how quickly demonic corruption took root when no one was watching.

“No,” he admitted. “Not so readily.”

“Then there’s your answer. Even if the work feels like steering a cart full of cats while they argue over who invented wheels.”

He huffed a tired laugh.

“You spoke when it mattered and kept quiet when it didn’t,” she said, more gently. “Most people never learn both.”

“It is… a different battlefield,” he agreed.

“Exactly,” she said. “Go home, Shade. You look like someone tried to explain tax codes to you using interpretive dance.”

“Worse,” he said. “They used… subcommittee language.”

She shuddered. “Out,” she said. “Before you give me hives.”

He bowed, mostly out of habit, and left.

✦ ✦ ✦

By the time Shade reached the manor, the sky had deepened from violet to blue-black.

The door opened before he reached for the handle.

Rakihi stood there, hair loose, wearing one of his shirts like a dress.

“You look like someone spent all day squeezing your brain in a vice,” she observed.

He exhaled. “Accurate.”

She stepped aside to let him in, then rose on her toes to kiss his cheek.

“Come in. There’s a bath ready. Elcia filled it, and Arcebek threatened the elementals until they got the temperature right.”

He blinked. “You… didn’t have to.”

“Yes we did,” she said. “You’re doing politics. That’s worse than demons. Sit.”

He let himself be herded.

The bath eased the ache in his shoulders.

Elcia traced idle circles against his knee beneath the water while Arcebek, seated on a nearby chest, recounted the day’s absurdities at the Broken Anvil until he laughed.

When he climbed into bed, his hair was damp and his thoughts finally quiet.

He lay there on his back as they piled in around him.

Rakihi curled against his chest, humming.

Arcebek settled at his side, one arm across his stomach.

Elcia tucked herself beneath his other arm, her borrowed warmth steady against his ribs.

“You were quiet tonight,” Elcia murmured.

“Lot on his mind,” Arcebek said. “How many idiots did you resist strangling?”

“At least eight,” he said.

“Proud of you,” Rakihi mumbled.

He stared at the ceiling.

“I listened for hours to people argue about who deserved help, who had to wait, and who could be written off.”

Rakihi’s fingers toyed with the edge of his shirt. “And?” she asked.

“I wondered whether the patience was worth it, when a sword and fire could settle so much faster.”

He felt them all go a little still.

“Then I remembered the southern villages. If all that talking keeps one of them from meeting a demon unprepared, the headache is worth it.”

Arcebek snorted softly. “Look at you,” she said. “Becoming a tiny bit of a civic-minded adult. Disgusting.”

“When I met you,” Elcia said, “you wanted to solve everything with overwhelming force. You still can. But now you’re willing to sit through a council session to move one coin to the right place.”

“That’s worse than any demon,” Rakihi said. “And hotter.”

He made a helpless sound.

They chuckled.

Silence settled for a while.

Then Rakihi said, very softly: “Is it enough?”

He blinked. “What?”

“Coming home,” she said. “Us. Does it make the politics worthwhile? Or does it feel as though the work is swallowing you?”

He turned his head until he could see her face in the low light.

“I wondered that too, somewhere between the third and fourth argument over caravan taxes. Then I imagined not coming home. Not having you here to ask.”

His arm tightened around her, around all of them.

“That made the answer simple.”

Rakihi’s eyes shone.

“Okay,” she whispered. “Good.”

Arcebek nudged his ribs. “Tell us if it stops being simple. We can always remind you how to be reckless.”

“I am counting on it,” he said.

Elcia smiled against his shoulder. “Justice in the day,” she murmured. “Chaos at night.”

“It is… a good balance,” he agreed.

The headache had not quite gone.

Tomorrow’s agenda already waited for him.

But with Rakihi’s hair against his chin, Arcebek’s palm over his heart, and Elcia’s tether humming quietly through his bones, he could face it.

The council could have the daylight.

These hours belonged to them.

No ledgers, no judgments, no arguments to settle.

Only the warmth of people who wanted him home.

He closed his eyes and held them a little closer.

For now, that was enough.

“Sleep,” Rakihi murmured. “We’ll still be here in the morning. Lana can wait until you’ve had at least one nice dream that doesn’t involve budget spreadsheets.”

“Please,” Arcebek muttered. “If he starts talking in his sleep about subcommittees, I’m moving out.”

Elcia chuckled, low. “You’re not,” she said.

“Shut up,” Arcebek replied, fond.

Shade closed his eyes.

The council chamber rose before him one last time: its table, its faces, its endless demands.

Rakihi shifted closer. Arcebek sighed against his shoulder. Elcia held his arm.

The chamber faded.

He slept with the knowledge that three people had chosen him as surely as he had chosen them.

For once, his dreams were free of councils.

Chapter 6: The Second Week

The second week announced itself like gathering weather.

At home, each member of the household had found a rhythm.

Shade was the one still learning his.

✦ ✦ ✦

House rhythm

Mornings belonged to Elcia.

Serah, a wiry human with cropped hair and flint-hard eyes, arrived at dawn to drill Elcia in the Order of the Weighing Scales' discipline.

Shade watched once from the upstairs window.

From the upstairs window, Shade watched Elcia raise her shield while Serah circled her in the yard.

"Again," Serah said.

Elcia thrust.

"Again."

Serah corrected her footwork with a sharp tap of a practice blade.

"You're too used to being pulled," Serah said. "Dullahans ride where the leash yanks them. Paladins choose."

"The road pulls at me," Elcia said. "So does the curse. So does he." She tipped her chin toward the house, where Shade pretended not to listen.

"Then learn which pull to follow. You may not be able to silence the road, but you can choose your direction."

By breakfast, Elcia returned sore, damp with exertion, and plainly satisfied.

Midday belonged to Arcebek.

Her study had become an imp-operated branch office.

Far too many messengers came through it.

They arrived through the high window in pairs, buzzing and smoking, bearing contracts, management notices, and demands that sent Arcebek into three-language tirades.

Shade passed by her door one afternoon and caught:

"Tell Grath'thol that if he wants that clause added, he can drag his own decrepit aura into the boardroom and argue with the people I just saved." An imp squealed in protest. "Yes, I know I'm only a partner. I'm also the reason he isn't being hollowed out and worn as a hat. Tell him to redraft it."

The imp departed with scorched wings.

By evening she would sometimes collapse facedown on the sofa. "One more proposal for cross-realm synergy," she announced once, "and I'm moving into a cave."

Evenings belonged to Rakihi.

Her name appeared on the noticeboards of three inns.

The Broken Anvil on Firstday and Fourthday. The Lantern Hook on Secondday. The Blue Door—smaller, stranger, full of off-duty mages—on Fifthday.

Some nights she came home brimming with stories and half-written verses.

Others she returned hoarse and tired, ink on her fingers, still alight with the pleasure of performing.

“Apparently I’m ‘that bard with the dragon ballads and the grim girlfriend,’” she reported cheerfully. “Which is rude, because I’ve written at least two songs that don’t mention you at all.”

They listened to her stories, and she listened to theirs.

More often than not, she told hers with her head in Shade’s lap, Elcia perched nearby and Arcebek following each voice by ear.

✦ ✦ ✦

Guild work

Shade and Lana, meanwhile, spent the week beneath an entirely different kind of storm cloud.

They began with recruit assessments.

They set up at a side table in the guild’s main hall. Lana with a slate and a thin stack of recommendations. Shade in his armor, mostly for effect, leaning against a post.

The hopefuls came one by one.

A farm boy with arms like rope, clutching a homemade spear.

“Why adventuring?” Lana asked.

“For the pay,” he said honestly. “And because I’m tired of watching things happen and not being able to stop ‘em.”

Shade studied his rough, steady hands. The mention of danger had not made him flinch.

“Frontier work,” Shade murmured, low enough only Lana heard. “Paired with someone older. He’ll stay if the first job doesn’t break him.”

Lana nodded, made a note.

Next came a mage dressed in pristine robes embroidered with expensive sigils; his perfume announced him before he reached the table.

“Experience with hostile magic?” Lana asked.

“I placed top of my class in evocation,” the mage said with a tiny smile. “I’ve studied five demonologies and written two theses. I’m very good with theory.”

Shade caught him glancing at the mission board, drawn to dramatic bounties rather than the ordinary work.

“Start him on warding and support,” Shade advised after he left. “A demon will not care how highly his professors thought of him.”

“Your bleeding heart is showing,” Lana murmured.

He didn’t deny it.

The third applicant was an older swordswoman, scarred across the jaw, with a blade worn from years of service.

“Retired once,” she said, when Lana asked. “Didn’t stick. I don’t like sitting while others bleed. Figured I can stand at a door or three before my knees give out.”

Shade liked her at once.

“Escort duty and training,” he recommended. “She’ll protect the recruits and frighten anyone who thinks a caravan is easy prey.”

“Already did,” Lana said. “You’re predictable.”

“You asked for my judgment.”

“I did. Doesn’t mean I can’t mock you for it.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The visiting guild leader

Midweek, the guild leader from Riverwatch arrived.

Teron Dast had broad shoulders, greying hair, and a ring on every finger. Riverwatch sat where three trade routes met a river; the man carried the faint scent of fish and expensive cologne.

They met in Lana’s office, Shade standing behind her as usual.

“Lana,” Teron said, opening his arms like they were old friends. “You’re a hard woman to pin down.”

“Occupational hazard. You said you had business.” Lana gestured toward Shade. “My shadow. Ignore him unless you intend to stab me.”

Teron’s eyes flicked to Shade, weighing.

“Impressive accessory,” he said. “I hear he does more than loom.”

“On occasion,” Shade said mildly.

Teron laughed as though they had shared a joke.

Neither Shade nor Lana joined in.

They talked routes first.

Riverwatch had had its own demon-flavored problems lately; cult signs in the docks, a summoned thing that had chewed its way into a warehouse before being banished at great cost.

“Word travels,” Teron said. “Your people have been clearing tunnels, and a lieutenant came apart under their swords. Whatever you angered may seek another route. I’d prefer it not be the river.”

“Join the club,” Lana said. “What are you proposing?”

“An information exchange, for one,” he said. “Joint patrols, maybe. If cults are spreading beyond one city, we don’t win this by hoarding intel.”

Shade watched his hands.

They didn't fidget.

But when he spoke of "joint patrols," his fingers brushed the ring with the seal of his own guild.

Shade doubted safety was Teron's only concern.

Teron glanced at him again.

"I also hear," he said casually, "that your gold parties are growing. Stronger than they have any right to be. If you ever feel like… leasing one for a season…"

Lana's smile sharpened. "You're trying to rent my people?"

"Share," Teron corrected. "I'd pay well. Your dragon and his little storm squad could save us a lot of trouble."

Shade kept his face neutral.

Shade could already see the complications: a different command structure, distant obligations, a longer separation from home.

Lana didn't even glance back at him.

"They are not for hire," Lana said. "We can share intelligence and discuss joint work when it serves us both. Shade's party stays here."

Teron's smile thinned for a fraction of a second, then smoothed.

"Worth a try," he said.

The negotiations continued over maps of cult sigils and old sightings, with neither guildmaster prepared to reveal everything.

They reached an agreement of sorts.

Shade suspected they would revisit it.

On the way out, Teron paused in the doorway.

"If you ever get tired of city politics here, dragon," he said conversationally, "Riverwatch could use someone who sees storms coming. Not as Lana's shadow. As a commander."

Lana stiffened, just a little.

Shade met his eyes.

"I have commanders," he said, calm. "And storms of my own. But I'll send you word if any of them look like they're heading your way."

Teron smiled, not entirely pleasantly.

"I'll hold you to that," he said, and left.

After Teron left, Lana remained silent long enough for Shade to wonder whether she was angry.

"You're not allowed to run off to Riverwatch without six months' notice," she said at last.

"I have no plans to leave," he said. "You are stuck with me."

"Good," she said. "I've already assigned you too much work."

✦ ✦ ✦

Off-the-books

The unofficial meetings were worse.

Each began as a request for a quick word and ended behind a closed door.

The High Priest asked first.

“Guildmaster. Shade,” he said, nodding to each. “I thought we might speak… less formally. About the cult situation.”

They met in a side chapel that smelled of incense and disuse.

The High Priest was smiling, though his eyes never softened.

“You are doing valuable work,” he said. “Uncovering these demonic threads. The church would like to… assist.”

“By…?” Lana asked.

“Coordinating our efforts. The temple knows how to address heresy. If your adventurers reported suspected cult activity to us first, we could decide which cases needed firm action.”

Shade knew the meaning of that phrase.

He had heard it before.

In another war, it had been written in star-blood.

“We will keep sharing reports, Father,” Lana said. “As we have. But my people report to me. I choose when to call for temple aid.”

“You don’t trust us?” the priest asked mildly.

“I trust that your definition of firm action includes more pyres than mine,” Lana said. “No offense.”

“Some taken,” he said.

Shade stepped in then, quietly.

“If the evidence concerns your god’s domain, we will call you,” Shade said. “If it concerns something older or hungrier, we will call someone who knows what it costs to face such things.”

The priest studied him.

“You speak as if from experience,” he said.

Shade didn’t answer.

He didn’t have to.

Lana cut the meeting short after that.

“One private conversation survived,” Lana muttered as they left. “Barely.”

The second was with the trade representative.

He was all smiles and concern.

“We both want safe roads and prosperity,” the trade representative said. “If we agree on our positions before council, we can avoid unpleasant surprises.”

“You want my plans before I announce them,” Lana said, “so you can undermine the parts you dislike.”

He laughed. “Such an ugly way of putting it,” he said.

Shade studied the man’s ink-stained hands. They were soft, unmarked by weapons.

“Which villages become acceptable losses,” Shade asked, “as long as the caravans reach the city?”

The smile vanished from the representative’s face.

“We must consider the greater good—”

Lana stood.

“Meeting over,” she said. “You’ll get my agenda when everyone else does.”

He sputtered. “Guildmaster, be reasonable—”

“I am being reasonable. You are trying to cheat.”

Lord Harven requested the third meeting.

It was the least pleasant of the three.

His private garden was old and immaculate; generations of his family had walked beneath its trees.

Shade stood beside Lana, aware of the wealth it took to make a place feel so effortlessly permanent.

“You’ve risen quickly,” Harven said to Lana. “And… gathered interesting allies.”

His gaze slid to Shade, then away, like touching something hot.

“Thank you,” Lana said. “You asked to speak?”

Harven’s smile never reached his eyes.

It didn’t reach his eyes.

“Clarity. We have old agreements, Guildmaster. My family’s place in the guild’s structure has always been understood.”

“Yes,” Lana said. “You get a seat on the council. You don’t get to dictate guild policy. That hasn’t changed.”

“You bring outsiders into your councils. Monsters. Undead. Creatures beyond the curtain.” His glance touched Shade. “Now I hear your dragon and his companions are challenging gods and redistributing curses.”

Shade went very still.

Lana’s voice went flat. “Do you have an actual point, my lord?” she asked.

Harven looked her full in the face.

“If something goes wrong,” he said softly, “if the balance tips, if the city suffers for your… boldness… someone will have to answer for it. I want to know if, when that time comes, you plan to stand alone. Or if you expect the old families to burn with you.”

Shade’s fingers twitched.

He wanted to stand between Lana and the noble, bare his teeth, and ask whether Harven expected the city to burn quietly while his family arranged an escape.

He stayed where he was.

This was Lana's answer to give.

He let Lana answer.

"That depends on whether the old families intend to help hold the line," Lana said, "or spend the next year stabbing me in the back while we defend it."

Harven's smile didn't move.

"I see," he said. "Then I suggest you tread very carefully, Guildmaster. Storms are coming. And even dragons can drown."

He left without waiting for dismissal.

Lana didn't move until he was gone.

"I hate nobles," Lana said when he had gone.

"Not all of them," Shade said.

"Eighty percent," she corrected. "You're fine. Elcia's pending."

He almost smiled.

"Storms," Shade repeated.

Lana glanced skyward.

Real storm clouds were climbing above the western roofs.

"You like storms, don't you?" she asked.

"In a manner of speaking, I was forged in one."

"Enjoy this one, then. The kind in the sky is easier to manage."

✦ ✦ ✦

Rain arrived that night.

It drummed over the manor roof and sang through the gutters. Lightning flickered beyond the city, pale veins across the dark.

Shade stood at the window and watched.

Every flash illuminated the wet rooftops. Between thunderclaps, the city seemed to hold its breath.

Behind him, home carried on.

Rakihi sang softly in another room as she worked out a melody. Elcia recited lines of the Oath of Balance, trying the words on for size. From the study came Arcebek's voice: "I said limited interface, not open season on my retinae. Get back here!"

He smiled.

He knew how to read the sky.

Human storms were more complicated.

But he was beginning to recognize their pressure lines and shifting fronts.

He could learn to navigate those too.

He turned away from the window when Rakihi called his name.

“Shade! Your turn to pick the story! Something not about demons, Lana, or taxes!”

He left the window for the sitting room, where they would crowd together beneath blankets and complain about cold feet.

Tomorrow would bring new recruits, private demands, and polite threats.

Tonight, the thunder could make all the noise.

Inside, he needed only to be Shade.

A dragon.

A guildmaster’s shadow.

And someone loved.

He took his place beside them.

For the moment, that was enough.

Chapter 7: An Unwanted Education

By the third week, Shade had begun to notice a pattern.

He was no longer merely Lana's shadow.

He was her spare pair of hands, her second set of eyes—and, increasingly, the person whose judgment she tested before making a decision.

✦ ✦ ✦

"You're not subtle, Lana."

At first, the changes were small.

"Read this contract," she would say, dropping a merchant house's proposal onto his desk. "Tell me where it smells wrong."

He would skim the pages, frown, and tap a clause.

"Here. 'Hazard bonus to be determined at the discretion of the contracting party.'"

"Exactly. If they meant to pay fairly, they'd have written down the numbers. Fix it."

So he rewrote the clause, balanced the terms, and returned the contract.

Soon she stopped staying to watch.

"Shade will brief them," she told a junior clerk one afternoon, heading for another meeting. "Listen when he says no."

Or at council prep:

"These are the three hills I'm willing to die on this week," she said, shoving her notes at him. "What are yours?"

He would circle two of her choices and add a third. She would study it, nod, and fold the suggestion into her plans.

By midweek, she had moved him from the chair behind her to a seat at the negotiating table.

"I'll take notes," she said blandly, dropping into a side chair while he stared. "You talk."

"That's your job," he said.

"It's also yours," she replied. "Someday. Maybe. Humor me."

Two days later, the truth finally caught up with him.

They were alone in her office, rain threatening at the windows. As he returned a file to the shelves, he realized how many decisions had passed through his hands before reaching hers.

He turned.

"You're grooming me," he said.

Lana paused halfway through pouring tea and raised an eyebrow. "That's a dramatic word for paperwork."

“You are,” he insisted. “This is less ‘bodyguard’ and more… apprentice. You could have asked any senior adventurer to stand in the corner and look threatening. Instead you’re having me vet contracts, run briefings, argue with councilors, shadow off-the-books meetings. You’re… training me to take over.”

She set the teapot down, very carefully.

“I’m training you to be capable of it,” she said. “There’s a difference.”

He folded his arms. “Explain it.”

She leaned back in her chair, studying him.

“This job kills people. Sometimes literally. More often, it wears them down a compromise at a time. If I’m taken out—assassins, politics, sheer exhaustion—I won’t have the guild falling into the lap of whoever shouts loudest or bribes best.”

She pointed her pen at him.

“You already understand the work. Maps. Logistics. Where people need to stand so fewer of them die. I’m adding budgets and council egos to the battlefield. If you ever want this chair, you should know what it costs.”

“And if I never do?” he asked quietly.

“Then you’ll be the most overqualified advisor in three kingdoms,” she said. “And whoever does sit here will have to deal with you in their doorway every time they do something stupid.”

Shade considered the offer—and the escape it left him.

“It still feels like grooming,” he muttered.

“Good. That means it’s working.” Her voice softened. “I’m not pushing you, Shade. I’m giving you options. You’ve had too few of those.”

He had no easy answer for that.

He exhaled. “You could have said that sooner,” he said.

“And missed the look on your face when you worked it out?” Lana smirked. “Absolutely not.”

He tried not to smile.

He failed.

“Fine,” he said. “I will… keep learning. No promises about the chair.”

“Wouldn’t trust you if you made any,” she said, and went back to her tea.

✦ ✦ ✦

Home, same storm – plus spice

The rest of the household had their own battles to fight.

Elcia spent mornings getting hammered—sometimes literally—by Serah’s paladin drills, then came home bruised and quietly proud.

Rakihi rotated between inns, occasionally turning up with new songs and a suspicious amount of tip money for “totally not flirting my way into free drinks, Shade, how dare you.”

Arcebek argued with more imps than seemed physically possible. One afternoon, five crowded her desk and talked over one another until she clicked her tongue. They fell silent like scolded crows.

Then came the weekend.

Rakihi had drawn a big, dramatic symbol on the wall calendar: four interlocking circles and what might have been a heart on fire.

“All-four date night,” she’d announced. “Elcia’s in charge. She promised something spicy.”

“Spicy as in food,” Shade had asked, wary, “or spicy as in… you.”

Elcia had just smiled, small and secretive. “Both,” she’d said. “Probably.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The date

Saturday dawned grey but warm.

Shade endured a final half-day of Lana’s “just skim this” reports before she dismissed him.

“Go,” she said. “You’re vibrating. If you’re useless tomorrow, I’m blaming them.”

He went home.

The house smelled wonderful.

Not merely of bread and stew. A layered heat of unfamiliar spices reached him before he opened the kitchen door, sharp enough to make his eyes water.

Elcia stood at the stove, sleeves rolled, hair tied back. A row of jars sat open on the counter: reds, ambers, dark browns. The air shimmered faintly with their combined magic.

Rakihi perched on the table, stealing bits from a plate and getting smacked away by a wooden spoon.

Arcebek sat on the counter, blind eyes turned toward the sizzling pan, grinning.

“You’re home,” Elcia said, without looking, shoulders relaxing.

“Yes,” he said. “And apparently underdressed.”

Rakihi wolf-whistled. “Oh, we’re fixing that,” she said. “Elcia’s banned armor for tonight. Clothes only. Nice ones. You own at least one shirt that isn’t black, I’ve seen it.”

Arcebek hopped down, feeling for his hand. “Come on,” she said. “Your dullahan’s going to a lot of trouble. We’re not eating this in travel gear.”

He surrendered to the change of clothes: a dark blue shirt Elcia liked, soft trousers instead of leather. By the time he returned, the table was ready.

Not the everyday table.

Candles, good plates, and the cloth they had been saving for a special occasion.

Elcia had changed as well.

She wore no armor.

A dark surcoat lay over soft trousers and a white shirt open at the throat. Her paladin sash—black and white, the Scales' colors—hung loosely at her waist. She looked less like a death knight and more like someone who had finally learned to come home.

It suited her.

"What's all this?" Shade asked, taking it in.

"Elcia's Spicy Justice Night," Rakihi said solemnly. "Trademark pending."

Elcia rolled her eyes, but her cheeks colored.

"Sit," she said. "Before it gets cold."

The food earned its name.

Heat spread across Shade's tongue and warmed his face. Alive, he thought, was an odd word for a meal, but it seemed appropriate.

There was stewed meat with unfamiliar peppers, fragrant rice, and flatbread brushed with oil and a seasoning that made Rakihi fan her mouth and swear.

"Where did you learn this?" Shade asked between careful bites.

"Temple kitchens," Elcia said, trying not to look smug. "Kael Varis' people feed their paladins well. The cook owed me a favor."

"It's amazing," Rakihi mumbled around a mouthful. "I would betray at least two minor gods for this bread."

"You did," Arcebek said. "You spent twenty minutes telling a kitchen angel why neutrality was cowardice."

Rakihi waved a hand. "Semantics."

They lingered over the food.

And the conversation.

Elcia told them about Serah forcing her to argue the opposite side of a moral dilemma until she wanted to scream. Rakihi countered with a drunk student who had tried to seduce her using a poem stolen from a temple hymn.

Shade contributed one of Lana's more ridiculous council exchanges ("No, Lord Harven, we are not allocating hazard pay for your dog.").

By the time their plates were empty, the easy warmth around the table had settled into something quieter.

Elcia waited for a lull.

Then she cleared her throat.

"Okay," she said. "Spicy part two."

Rakihi lit up. "Oh this I want to see."

Arcebek tilted her head. "Should I be nervous?"

"A little," Elcia said with a smile. "In a good way."

She stood, pushed her chair back, and reached into a pouch at her belt.

Four small objects struck the table with a soft clink.

Coins—but not gold.

Nor were they ordinary temple tokens.

Each thin disc bore a set of scales on one side and a second engraving on the other.

—and something else on the other.

Shade picked his up.

On its reverse were four small figures, carefully if imperfectly carved: a dragon, a lute, a warlock's flame, and a helmeted head separated from its shoulders.

He swallowed.

"You had these… made," he said.

"I bribed a novice enchanter," Elcia said. "He's terrible at secrecy and good at carving."

Rakihi turned hers over, eyes shining. "Is this—"

"A token," Elcia said. "Of an oath. My… oath."

Arcebek's fingers brushed the engraving, gentle.

"What kind of oath?" she asked, very soft now.

Elcia swallowed.

She drew a steadying breath.

"Kael Varis teaches that justice isn't… abstract," she said. "It's measured in who you stand for. Who you answer to. Who you allow to call you back when you go too far."

Her gaze moved from one face to the next.

"In the castle, I had no one to answer to. Joren and his god pointed, and I rode. No one could call me back. Nothing balanced the scales."

She closed her hand around her own token.

"I don't want that again," she said. "So I went to Serah. And the temple. And I asked if there was a way to… bind myself. Not just to Kael Varis. To you."

Shade felt his heartbeat stumble.

Rakihi went very still.

Arcebek's grip on the coin tightened.

Elcia gave them a helpless smile.

"They have a rite," she said. "Not used often. It's for… hearth-wardens. Guardians who swear not just to 'the world' or 'the city,' but to a specific threshold. A home. A… family."

She set her token down again, neatly.

"I want to take that oath," she said. "To be your paladin. To weigh your needs into my sense of right and wrong, not… outside it. So if I start becoming one of those paladins who burns villages 'for the greater

good,' you have… leverage. A claim. You can stand in front of my god and say, 'No. She swore otherwise.'"

Silence held the room.

"And the spicy part?" Arcebek asked hoarsely.

Elcia's smile turned crooked. "The rite is usually done in public, with witnesses," she said. "I talked them into letting us… adapt it. Private. At home. Less chanting, more… you."

Rakihi flushed. "Oh," she said. "Oh."

Shade found his voice. "What does it… entail?" he asked.

"Nothing you don't want," Elcia said quickly. "Standing in a doorway. A few words. A… symbolic weight." She hesitated. "And… later, if we want, we can… seal it in our own way. But the core is just… this."

She tapped the coins.

"Four tokens. Four people. One promise: I will not use my new power to judge you from above. I will stand with you. And you"—her gaze was steady, fierce—"promise you'll drag me back if I forget."

Arcebek released a breath.

"You ridiculous, wonderful woman," she said, voice rough. "Yes."

Rakihi wiped her eyes with the heel of her hand. "You're… giving us a legal way to yell at you in front of your god," she said. "I'm in."

Shade's chest tightened.

It was almost painful, and wholly welcome.

"Are you sure?" he said quietly. "This is… a lot. Binding yourself to us this way."

"We're already bound," she said. "This just… gives it names. Rules. A shape my order understands."

He closed his fingers around the coin.

"Then yes," he said. "If you want three entirely unqualified, deeply biased mortals to be your… moral oversight committee, we accept."

Rakihi snorted, crying again. "We're the worst tribunal," she said.

"The most honest," Elcia replied.

Arcebek pushed her chair back, standing.

"Threshold, then," she said. "Where?"

Elcia smiled.

"Front door," she said. "Where else?"

✦ ✦ ✦

They kept the rite simple.

No robes or incense. Only four people, barefoot on cool stone, standing in the open doorway while the night breeze touched their ankles.

Elcia took her place in the threshold itself.

One foot inside, one outside: the dullahan poised between road and home.

Rakihi stood to her left, coin in hand.

Arcebek to her right, fingers wrapped tight around hers.

Shade behind them, slightly back, like a pillar.

Elcia lifted her token, voice steady.

“I, Elcia Bramblecrown,” she said, “swear to weigh you into my scales. To guard this house, these hearts, with the same ferocity I would guard any village. To never call my god’s judgment down on you without first letting you call judgment on me.”

A faint pressure brushed Shade’s skin.

Nothing like the presence of his gods.

Cooler. Sharper.

Attentive.

Kael Varis was listening at the door.

Elcia went on.

“If I start to see only black and white,” she said, voice softer now, “you will remind me of grey. If I start to call cruelty ‘necessary,’ you will drag me back. I give you that right. I want you to take it.”

Rakihi swallowed hard.

Arcebek’s jaw clenched; her free hand trembled.

Shade stepped forward, token warm in his palm.

“I, Shade,” he said quietly, “accept that right. I swear to stand between you and any who would twist this oath. Even… yourself. And to remember that your blade cuts both ways: for strangers, and for us.”

Rakihi followed, voice wobbly but sure.

“I, Rakihi,” she said, “promise to yell at you if you start sounding like the scary sermons. And to sing for you when the weight gets too heavy. And to never, ever let you think we love you for what you can smite, instead of who you are.”

Arcebek last.

“I, Arcebek,” she said, low and fierce, “swear to call you on your bullshit. Holy or otherwise. To watch your back, your front, and that stubborn head of yours. And to remind any god who comes sniffing that you belong here first.”

The pressure in the air changed.

The balance shifted.

A scale settling into place.

An answer without words.

“Done,” she whispered.

She stepped over the threshold and into the house.

The air seemed warmer.

Warmer.

Claimed.

Rakihi reached her first, nearly knocking her off her feet. Arcebek folded her arms around them both, and Shade drew all three close.

For a while, they were only a tangle of arms, laughter, and tears, framed by the open door.

“Spicy enough?” Elcia managed into someone’s shoulder.

“Emotionally?” Rakihi sniffed. “Ten out of ten. Morally flustered.”

“Spiritually?” Arcebek said. “Absolutely illegal. I love it.”

Shade’s lips brushed Elcia’s hair.

“Now,” she added, voice dropping, “we can… do the other kind.”

Rakihi gasped. “Elcia,” she said. “Did you just paladin-kink us?”

“Maybe,” Elcia said, and this time her smile was spicy.

They went inside together, and the door closed on the night. The oath remained, a quiet weight around the house, as familiar as its wards.

Whatever followed was their business.

In the morning, Shade woke sore and content, the coin he had slept with beneath his shirt still faintly warm against his chest.

Lana might be preparing him to run a guild.

Storms might be gathering over Greenhollow.

There would be demons, councils, and gods to contend with.

But this house held three people he loved, people who had chosen one another with eyes open and promises freely given.

He could live with that.

He could even learn to govern a world that contained it.

Chapter 8: The Fallen Gold Squad

Council day was already tense when the door slammed open.

Shade sensed the panic in the corridor before the doors flew open. Around him, the council's argument tightened into sudden silence.

A runner stumbled past the guards, leathers half-fastened and mud crusted to his knees.

"Guildmaster!" he gasped. "Message from the hall—gold squad survivor—half-dead—demanding to see you—"

The chamber erupted in questions. One lord rose halfway from his chair, sputtering about protocol.

Lana cut him off.

"Sit down." She turned to the runner. "Status?"

"Sit down," she snapped at the room, then to the runner: "Status?"

He gulped air. "They carried him in bleeding—Yarin from the Iron Wolves—he won't talk to anyone but you, ma'am."

Shade was on his feet before she said, "With me."

They were out the door before the noble finished sputtering.

✦ ✦ ✦

The infirmary was a scene of controlled chaos.

Healers moved between cots amid the smells of blood, poultices, and spent magic.

Yarin lay on a central bed, his chest bound in dressings and one leg splinted. Gold-ranked, Shade remembered. A heavy shield, a heavier laugh, and patience with new recruits.

Now blood loss had hollowed his face.

He tried to sit when Lana came near.

She put a hand gently but firmly on his shoulder. "Report from lying down," she said. "That's an order."

Yarin coughed blood into a bowl a healer hurried beneath his chin.

"The village," he rasped. "You were right. All the signs—every trail—" He shook his head, furious. "We thought we were ready. We weren't."

Shade stepped closer, helm under his arm. "Slow," he said. "What did you find?"

Yarin fought to focus on him.

"Whole place is wrong," he said. "Smiles too wide. No kids in the streets. The elder greeted us like we were expected." His fingers twitched like they wanted to close around a sword hilt that wasn't there. "They led us to the meeting hall. Below it…"

He swallowed.

"Dungeon," he said. "Not just a nest. A built one. Full circle. Old stone, fresh sigils. They've dug deep, tied it into a rift. We saw the marks. Lieutenant already anchored."

Cold settled in Shade's stomach.

"You engaged?" Lana asked.

"We didn't make it to the core," Yarin said bitterly. "We hit a forward chamber, thought it was the heart. It was… a feeder. Ate two of us before we realized. The lieutenant's not even… there yet. Just pushing through. We tried to pull out. They knew all the exits. Villagers turned on us in the streets. I—" He coughed again, hard. "I ran. They let me. Wanted you to know."

Shade knew that cruelty. One survivor, sent home to carry the fear.

He had seen it before.

Lana's jaw clenched.

"How long?" she asked. "Since you left the village?"

"Day and a half," he whispered. "We rode hard. I—" His eyes flickered, unfocused. "I think… the earth's thinner there. It stank."

He flinched, as if the smell were still in his lungs.

Shade met Lana's eyes over the cot.

They had followed signs of cult activity toward that village for weeks.

Now they knew what lay beneath it.

And how little time they had.

Lana straightened.

"Thank you, Yarin," she said. "You did what you had to."

He let his head fall back, shaking.

"Kill it," he muttered. "Burn the whole fucking thing. Don't let them—"

"We won't," Shade said quietly.

Yarin relaxed a fraction.

The head healer glared at them until they stepped back and let him work.

✦ ✦ ✦

Lana rounded on the corridor as soon as the infirmary door closed behind them.

"Of course it's that gods-damned village," she snarled. "Right where the council least wanted to admit there's a problem. I knew something was wrong."

She paced three strides one way, three back.

"What do you need?" he asked.

She stopped dead.

"Everything I can't get in time," she snapped. "That's the problem. I can't pull half the guild off their posts overnight without leaving the rest of the territory naked. I can't wait a week, or we'll be dealing with a fully manifested lieutenant and a fortified dungeon, not a half-grown cancer."

She swallowed a curse, then met his eyes.

“Fine. We do what we can now. Assemble the Black Squad. Meet me at the gates in ten minutes.”

He didn’t even have to ask.

Black Squad: Lana’s ugly little nickname for the dragon, the warlock, the bard, the dullahan—and whoever else they trusted to walk into hell.

Shade understood.

“Yes, Guildmaster,” he said, and turned on his heel.

✦ ✦ ✦

Shade ran.

He took the guild steps two at a time and raced through the market, past people buying bread and arguing over fish prices, none of them aware of the danger gathering beyond the walls.

The manor’s door flew open before he reached it. Wards recognized his signature; the house knew when one of its own came home at a sprint.

Rakihi was in the hall, shirt half-buttoned, hair in a messy knot.

“I heard the runner,” she said, eyes wide. “What—”

“Gold squad hit,” he said, already moving for the weapon rack. “Cult village. Full dungeon. Lieutenant anchoring. Lana needs Black Squad at the gate in ten minutes.”

Shock vanished from Rakihi’s face, replaced by focus.

“Got it,” she said. “I’ll cancel tonight’s set and warn Lysa to listen for fallout.” She grabbed her lute and a small, battered satchel she always kept half-packed. “Arce! Elcia!”

“In here!” Arcebek’s voice from the study, followed by the crash of a chair as she bolted out, tying her hair back with one hand, the other already reaching for the familiar weight of her focus.

“What happened?” she demanded.

“Cult core. Full dungeon. Demon lieutenant under a village,” Shade said, strapping on his greatsword harness. “Yarin from the Wolves barely made it back.”

Arcebek’s jaw tightened. “Of course it’s demons,” she muttered. “Outer board is going to make so many smug noises about this.”

Elcia came down the stairs at a jog, half in armor already, buckling her breastplate as she moved. Her training tabard was thrown on crooked over it.

“I heard ‘dungeon,’” she said. “How bad?”

“Lieutenant not fully through,” Shade said. “Yet. Villagers compromised. Full cult nest. We’re first strike. Backup as soon as Lana can scrape bodies together.”

“Elcia Bramblecrown, provisional paladin of Kael Varis,” Arcebek said dryly. “You are absolutely on deck.”

Elcia’s eyes went hard.

“Good,” she said. “I owe that death god’s rival at least one favor. And if there’s a rift, I want a look.”

Rakihi tore through the house, gathering weapons and potions.

She pressed the emergency bag of sapphires into Shade's hands with an expression that promised consequences if he failed to eat them.

He took them without protest, tucking them into an inside pocket.

"Feed on the road," she ordered. "No arguments."

"On the road?" he asked dryly. "You want me to choke to death on a sapphire at full gallop?"

"At least suck on one," she shot back. "You're not going into a demon dungeon on council calories."

They were out the door in under eight minutes.

Even his mother's drillmasters would have approved.

✦ ✦ ✦

The gates were already half-open.

Lana waited on horseback just inside them, armored for once, a dark cloak pinned at her shoulder. She would not be riding out; Shade saw what that decision cost her.

A handful of riders waited with her: Mina and Tomas, faces set; Varinel, bow already strung; two more veterans Shade recognized from other gold teams.

"Good," Lana said as they approached. "You beat my worst-case guess."

Her gaze swept over them, assessing equipment, injuries, and readiness.

Rakihi had her spells ready. Elcia held her shield close. Otherworldly sigils flickered around Arcebek's wrists. Shade stood armored and cloaked, his greatsword across his back.

"You take point," she said to him. "You know these things better than anyone. Objective: cut the head off before it fully pushes through. Kill or disrupt the ritual core. Rescue anyone in the village who's still… salvageable. Don't die." A beat. "Very important last step. Don't make me replace you, it's expensive."

"Backup?" he asked.

"I'm calling in every favor," she said. "Temple strike team, Riverwatch aid if Teron's as smart as he thinks he is, whoever can ride fastest without leaving our flanks open. Best case, the second wave hits a stabilized situation. Worst case, they hit smoke."

He nodded.

She hesitated, then leaned forward in the saddle.

"When you see the core," she said quietly, "remember you're not in your mother's war. You do not have to burn the world to stop it. You have people now. Use them."

He met her gaze, something tight in his chest.

"I will," he said.

She straightened. "Black Squad," she called, voice carrying. "You're clear to move. Bring my people home. Burn the rest."

They rode.

✦ ✦ ✦

The road vanished beneath the horses' hooves.

They rode hard, covering mile after mile without speaking.

Wind struck Shade's face. For the first time in weeks, the rhythm of hooves and rattling tack cleared his thoughts.

A storm lay ahead.

This, at least, he understood.

Rakihi rode light and low, eyes narrowed, already humming under her breath. Warding rhythms, anchoring beats. Her fingers tapped patterns on her saddle horn, building spells before she'd need them.

Arcebek sat her mount like someone born in the saddle, cloak snapping behind her. Every so often she'd flick her fingers in the air, checking invisible threads.

"There's… pressure," she shouted over the wind. "Outer noise. Nothing's slipped the curtain, but something's leaning."

"Lieutenant's sponsor?" he called back.

"Probably," she said. "Or some middle manager with too much ambition. Either way, we're not their primary channel. Yet."

Elcia rode at his other side, solid as a wall. Her new tabard fluttered over her armor, black-and-white scales stark.

"How are your oaths?" he asked.

She huffed a short laugh. "Heavy," she said. "Good. Kael Varis likes this kind of problem. 'Hidden rot. Corrupted leadership. Threat to the balance.' It's practically in the brochure."

"Will they… object to demons?" he said.

"Violently," she said. "On principle."

"Good," he replied.

Behind them, Mina and Tomas kept pace, faces tight but determined. Varinel rode rear guard, eyes scanning tree lines, every now and then calling a warning about bad ground.

Shade reached into his pocket with one hand, fingers closing around a sapphire.

He tossed it back, working it between his teeth like hard candy.

Rakihi shot him a sideways look and gave an exaggerated thumbs up.

Elemental energy seeped steadily into him.

He drew it in with care.

The gods noticed.

Fenris: Better.
Ifret: Don't overdo it.
Terra: Ground yourself. This is their home, not a warfront.
Djing & Djang: Fast, fast, fast—
Buyakugan, delighted: Oh, good. Storm and gems. Just like old times.

The village was still hours away.

As the riders pushed onward, the light began to change.

Clouds gathered ahead, heavy with something more than rain.

The wrongness settled behind Shade's eyes and beneath his tongue.

Rakihi's song shifted without her seeming to decide it, threads of minor key edging in.

Elcia's jaw clenched.

Arcebek inhaled sharply at one point and muttered, "They're layering it. Sloppy, but ambitious."

"How bad?" Shade asked.

"On a scale of one to 'corporate plane of endless screaming'?" she said. "We're at… seven and climbing."

"Good thing we like a challenge," Rakihi called, voice too bright. "Right?"

No one answered.

None of them needed to.

The sun was dropping toward late afternoon when they crested the final rise.

The village lay in a shallow bowl below.

At a distance, nothing seemed amiss.

Houses, fields, smoke drifting from chimneys.

But Shade saw the pattern.

His breath chilled.

Even from here, he could feel what had been done.

Footpaths curved with deliberate precision. Wells stood at ritual intervals. The meeting hall occupied a knot in the land's hidden lines.

Above it all, heat-haze shimmered in the afternoon air.

Ordinary eyes might miss it.

Shade, Arcebek, and Elcia could not.

Something beneath the village was breathing.

Slowly. Deeply.

And it was beginning to wake.

Shade drew his horse to a halt.

The rest of the squad reined in beside him, staring down.

Rakihi swallowed. "Yeah," she said. "That's… bad."

Elcia's hand closed around her holy symbol, knuckles white. "Kael Varis sees this," she murmured. "And does not approve."

Arcebek's blind eyes turned toward the meeting hall as if she could see through stone. "There's a circle under there," she said. "Big. Sloppy. Hungry. They're using the villagers as insulation."

Shade rolled his shoulders, feeling the familiar, hated chill that always came before demons.

Lana was waiting behind them.

Yarin lay broken in the infirmary.

Elcia's oath rested on all four of them.

Shade steadied his breathing.

"All right," he said. "We go down. We break their lines. We keep the lieutenant from getting all the way through. We get out whoever we can. No heroics. No martyrdom. We do this together."

Rakihi straightened, drawing a slow breath.

"Black Squad," she said, voice shaking only a little. "Let's go ruin some cultists' day."

They kicked their horses into motion.

Down toward the village.

Down toward the dungeon.

Down into the heart of the storm.

Chapter 9: The Black Squad

The reinforcements were late.

Not too late to help, perhaps. But horses had limits, and gathering a relief force took time.

By the time they crested the last rise, the village lay silent.

Not a scream or a shout came from its streets.

The silence was worse.

✦ ✦ ✦

Serah led the temple strike team, her tabard snapping in the wind.

Beside her, one of the guild's veteran captains reined in hard, eyes narrowed.

"Where are the screams?" he muttered. "Smoke? Fire?"

There was neither.

The village looked abandoned in the middle of an ordinary afternoon. Houses stood intact; smoke curled from a few chimneys. Whatever had happened here had ended before the reinforcements arrived.

They rode in slowly.

It didn't take long to find the first bodies.

The first bodies wore cult robes.

Several lay scattered across the road.

Their throats had been cut with the precision of someone fighting to end a battle, not prolong it.

Serah dismounted, knelt by one.

"No signs of struggle," she said. "No defensive wounds. He didn't get a swing."

They found the remains of the ambush in the square.

It was not difficult to reconstruct.

"How many did they send?" one of the younger paladins whispered, staring.

The ground told the story.

Marks on rooftops, behind carts, and inside doorways revealed where the cultists had waited. In the dust lay circles scratched for their casters. The entire square had been turned into a killing ground.

Someone had broken it.

Cultists lay across the square.

None wore guild colors.

Here, a heap of robed figures fused together, skin glassy and slick, as if they'd been flash-melted into a single lump.

There, a line of corpses pinned to a wall by spears of stone that had erupted from the cobbles, still humming faintly with elemental resonance.

An alley where three lay with their necks twisted at the same impossible angle, eyes wide in frozen terror—no marks on them at all except the lingering taste of Rakihi's fear-magic in the air.

Burned demon-sigils fouled the air.

The veteran captain whistled under his breath.

"Ambush backfired," he said.

Serah's gaze tracked the scatter.

"Not simply backfired," she said. "They triggered it. The Black Squad answered before the cultists could regroup."

She pointed with two fingers.

"First volley from the roofs—see the scorch on the thatch? Shade must have answered with a curtain of force; the arrows are embedded in the ground there, not in people. Then Elcia hit this flank; those are paladin strikes, clean and overcharged. Arcebek or Rakihi did… that." She nodded at the melted-together mass. "And once the first line broke—"

"—no one got away," the captain finished, grim.

No tracks led away from the village.

Only toward its center.

As though the fighting had drawn everyone inward.

Someone from the temple team swallowed hard. "Maybe the villagers—"

"Look at their hands," Serah said shortly. "Marks. Sigils. These aren't innocents. These are further in than half the cultists we've hauled off in chains. The innocents, if there were any, are either hiding… or already gone."

"But where did they go?" someone asked. "The dragon and his lot?"

The trail ended at the meeting hall.

The stairs descended into darkness.

Blood made the steps slick.

More cultists lay below, some crushed against walls cracked by tremendous impacts. Others bore injuries that drew hasty purification prayers from the temple warders.

As the reinforcements descended, the battle revealed itself in fragments.

Here: a fallen paladin trainee of Kael Varis, tabard of black and white smeared dark. Elcia's sigil, answered.
There: a demon-mark, half-formed, scoured out with something burning enough that the rock around it had bubbled. Arcebek's work.
Farther down: a place where the hallway bent wrong for a few feet, like reality had hiccuped. Rakihi's echoing voice still clung there, laughter-gone-weapon.

Through it all ran the deep tracks of armored boots, and gouges where Shade's oversized blade had braced against something pushing toward the surface.

None of the fallen were members of the Black Squad.

Either the four had died farther in—

—or they were waiting.

At the final door, charred sigils crawled over stone webbed with cracks. The reinforcements readied weapons and wards without being told.

The captain gave Serah a short nod.

She gestured to their two strongest fighters.

They drove their shoulders against the door.

They put their shoulders to the door.

It gave with a long, grinding crack.

The smell reached them first.

Not quite rot.

Something worse.

Hot iron, old incense, and the ozone of discharged magic, underlaid by the sickly trace of a demon's passing.

Beyond was a vast cavern.

Stone pillars carried twisted sigils around a summoning circle inlaid with metal and bone. In its center, the lieutenant's anchor—a half-melted mass of corrupted stone and demon-flesh—still smoldered.

Four figures stood beyond the ruined anchor.

The Black Squad.

Shade stood nearest the circle.

His helm was off, his hair damp with sweat. One gauntleted hand held the greatsword driven through the remains of the lieutenant's core; his storm-blue eyes had yet to lose their unnatural brightness.

Residual lightning danced around him, and his shadow stretched across the cavern wall with the suggestion of wings.

Elcia stood to his left.

Her tabard was torn, her armor dented, and one edge of her shield blackened.

Kael Varis' mark still burned along her sword. Around her lay the remains of creatures that had come too close.

Her gaze snapped toward the door.

Her eyes burned with fierce awareness.

Arcebek stood to his right.

Her cloak was singed, her braid partly unraveled, and eldritch glyphs crept over her smoking gloves.

Her sightless eyes shone with a pale, impossible light, as if something vast were looking out through them.

The floor before her had folded into an unnatural angle before springing back. The air above it still trembled.

Rakihi stood just behind them, one hand braced on a pillar and the other wrapped around her lute.

Her hair had come loose, her lip was split, and her throat looked raw.

The fading resonance of her magic hung in the cavern: laughter and terror tangled together.

A few cultists lay near the chamber walls, beyond the reach of the direct attacks.

None had escaped the fight unscathed.

When the reinforcements forced their way inside, all four turned at once.

The newcomers stopped beneath four exhausted, dangerous gazes.

Nobody moved.

Then Shade lowered his shoulders.

“You’re late,” he said, voice rough.

Serah finally breathed again.

“We hit traffic,” she shot back automatically, because anything else would have broken something in her chest. Her gaze flicked to the rapidly decaying mess impaled under his blade. “Status?”

“Lieutenant banished,” Arcebek said, voice low and dry. “Anchor broken. Circle trashed. Rift… pissed off but shrinking.”

Elcia cleaned her sword against a bare patch of stone.

“Cult leadership dead,” she added. “The few who tried to surrender are tied up in the antechamber. They can face judgment where the walls don’t drip.”

Rakihi pushed off the pillar with a wince, rolling one shoulder.

“There were… not many of those,” she said quietly. “They believed in this. Hard.”

A young paladin behind Serah made the warding sign with shaking fingers.

The captain stared at the ruined anchor.

“You were ordered to reconnoiter, stabilize, and wait for reinforcements,” he said, still struggling to take in the devastation.

Shade almost smiled.

“They didn’t… give us much time,” he said. “We adapted.”

Serah surveyed the chamber.

Charred sigils. The shattered anchor. Deep gouges where Shade had stood his ground while something pushed back.

Adapted.

She supposed that was one word for it.

She stepped inside, boots catching in the demon residue, and bowed her head.

“Kael Varis bears witness,” she said. “This was good work. Terrifying, and probably a bureaucratic nightmare, but good.”

Some of the tension left Elcia’s shoulders.

Behind Serah, whispers started.

“Them.”
“Lana’s black team.”
“Did you see—”
“That was a lieutenant—”

By sundown, there would be stories.

Yarin would hear that the thing which had destroyed his team was gone.

Lana would receive a report that only hinted at what her squad had endured.

And in the weeks ahead, other towns would find names of their own for the four:

The Black Squad.
Lana’s Reapers.
The Grim Four.
Those Fools From The Manor.

Priests would mention them in warnings and battlefield prayers: “May the gods send a dragon and his three terrors when the dark comes knocking.”

Parents in border villages would threaten unruly children with tales of the guild’s reapers, half in jest.

In darker places, cultists would share the same warning:

Avoid Greenhollow. The guild has them.

Some would speak with reverence.

“They stood before a lieutenant and did not break.”

Others with dread.

“They don’t leave much behind.”

Neither would quite capture what happened.

✦ ✦ ✦

In the ruined chamber, none of those stories existed yet.

There was only exhaustion.

Shade freed his greatsword. The ruined core slumped and began to dissolve.

He stumbled; Elcia steadied him by the elbow without a word.

Arcebek hissed softly as she flexed her fingers, burned sigils fading from her skin. “Outer management is going to whine about this,” she muttered. “Good.”

Rakihi rested a trembling hand between his shoulder blades.

“You all right?” she asked, very quietly.

He nodded once.

“We stopped it,” he said. “Before it… learned this place properly.” His eyes flicked up to the reinforcements, took in the mix of awe and unease. “And we didn’t bring the ceiling down this time.”

“See?” Rakihi whispered, a wobbly grin tugging at her mouth. “Growth.”

Serah studied them a moment longer.

Young, in some ways.

Older than most could imagine, in others.

A dragon holding onto restraint by habit and promise.
A paladin-dullahan whose oath had just been stress-tested in real fire.
A warlock who had stared into outer dark and told it “no.”
A bard whose voice could tilt a room from laughter to terror in a heartbeat.

They were no formal order.

No knightly company with a noble crest.

But Greenhollow would make legends of them regardless.

“Grab the survivors,” Serah said finally, turning to her own people. “Secure the site. We’ll need scribes and warders down here for a week. And someone tell Lana: her Black Squad lived up to the name.”

She glanced back one last time as she left.

The four of them stood for a moment longer over the rapidly-decaying corpse of the lieutenant, framed in the ruin of its would-be throne room like figures in a dark painting.

Grim.

Tired.

Unbroken.

Storms, Serah thought. No wonder Lana keeps them close.

Then she went to work.

And behind her, the story of what had happened here started its long, inevitable walk out into the wider world.

Chapter 10: Onyx Badges

For once, the guildhall smelled less of steel and old ale than of a feast.

Roasting meat, woodsmoke, wet wool and spilled drink crowded the air. Beneath it all ran the restless excitement of victory, held in check by grief.

Lana had ordered the feast before the Black Squad finished its debriefing.

“Tonight,” she’d said, voice leaving no room for argument, “we eat. For them, and for you. We can argue about budgets and demon politics tomorrow.”

Tables were hauled into place, benches dragged from storerooms and cooks pressed into service. Someone scoured every inn within three streets for extra chairs.

By the time Shade and the others arrived, washed and out of their armor, the hall was packed.

Guild members filled most of the benches, but they were hardly alone.

Temple staff, traders and people from neighboring villages had come to share the food and honor the dead.

Conversation dipped when people noticed them.

Then a pair of hands began to clap.

It spread.

It never became a triumphant roar. Tonight demanded something steadier. Applause rolled down the hall, gathering strength until it reached the four of them.

Rakihi flushed to the tips of her ears.

Arcebek muttered, “Oh, gods,” and edged toward the shelter of Shade’s shoulder.

Elcia squared her shoulders, proud and uncomfortable beneath the Scales embroidered on her tabard.

Shade could only stand there, exhausted by what they had survived and unexpectedly moved by the welcome.

Lana was at the high table, though she’d refused to sit on the central, slightly raised seat they usually saved for guildmasters during formal events.

Tonight, the raised seat at its center stood empty.

It was reserved for the Iron Wolves who would never sit at the guild’s tables again.

An Iron Wolves tabard lay folded across the chair. Before it stood a full tankard, untouched.

The Wolves who had not taken part in the doomed mission gathered close to it, their faces drawn and their eyes red.

Lana stood as the Black Squad approached.

“Up here,” she called. “Front and center. You’re my excuse to make the council pay for this much meat.”

They obeyed.

Plates and tankards appeared in their hands. Conversation swelled around them, carrying relief, sorrow and the questions no one quite dared ask.

When everyone had food and a drink—or at least knew where to get seconds—Lana banged the butt of a spare spear on the floor twice.

The hall quieted.

She stayed where she was.

She had never needed a table to command a room.

Her voice carried just fine.

“Listen up,” she said. “We lost people this week.”

A few people nodded. Others lowered their eyes.

“The Iron Wolves went into a pit with no proper intel on how deep it went,” Lana went on. “They did their job anyway. Because that’s what we do.”

She rested a hand briefly on the back of Yarin’s empty chair.

“Most didn’t come back. They struck the first wall so the rest of us would know where it stood. They gave us a chance to act. We remember them.”

Tankards lifted in quiet salute around the room.

“To the Wolves,” someone said.

“To the Wolves,” the hall echoed.

Lana let the moment sit, then turned to the four by her table.

“And these idiots,” she said, her voice roughening, “went into that same pit a day and a half later, knowing what waited there—and walked out.”

There was a ripple of something—pride, awe, a faint edge of fear.

“They cut out the rot. They destroyed a lieutenant before it could reach our streets. And when the second wave arrived”—she nodded toward Serah and the reinforcements—“they found a battlefield already won, not another slaughter.”

She paused.

“I won’t give you a speech about heroes. You know what the job costs. You did what needed doing, and the nightmares will probably find you soon enough. But I’ll be damned if the guild doesn’t recognize it.”

She nodded to one of the clerks.

He stepped forward with a small wooden box.

Lana flipped the lid.

Inside, on dark cloth, lay four badges.

Four oval badges lay against dark cloth, their polished onyx bearing the guild crest in raised gold. A discreet mark beneath each crest denoted a standing above Gold—not an official rank, but a designation everyone in the hall would understand.

These were the people Lana would call when ordinary measures failed.

She picked up the first.

“Shade,” she said.

He stepped forward.

He remembered another hall, vast with dragonfire and starlight, where his mother had pinned a command insignia to his chest before an audience capable of leveling mountains.

This hall smelled of ink, beer and mortal sweat instead of the old wars.

And yet—

Yet when Lana fixed the onyx badge beneath his ordinary guild insignia, its weight felt no less real.

“Black designation,” she said, low enough he had to lean in. “It means: when the worst thing comes knocking, I send you. It also means you’re allowed to tell me when I’m being an idiot about where I send you.”

He huffed something like a laugh. “I’ll try not to abuse it,” he murmured back.

“Do,” she said. “Keeps me honest.”

Next: Arcebek.

She stepped forward, suddenly self-conscious, worrying the edge of her sleeve between her fingers.

Lana fastened the badge to the strap beneath Arcebek’s collar.

“Warlock Arcebek,” she said. “For telling horrors beyond the curtain to take a number and get in line behind your own morals. Black designation.”

Arcebek snorted, though her voice caught when she tried to answer.

“Now you’re officially my problem,” Lana added, just for her.

“I was already,” Arcebek muttered. “This is just branding.”

Lana’s mouth twitched.

Elcia came next.

Lana raised a brow at the Scales on her chest.

“Paladin and dullahan,” she said. “Overachiever.”

“Bad influence,” Elcia said, glancing briefly at Shade, Rakihi, Arcebek.

Lana actually smiled at that.

She pinned the badge on the strap of Elcia’s shield harness.

“For taking your second leash in your own hands,” she said quietly. “And for pointing it at the right targets. Black designation.”

Elcia’s eyes warmed.

“Thank you,” she said simply.

Finally: Rakihi.

Rakihi approached with a half-bow that turned into a flourish, drawing laughter from the closest benches.

“You sure you want to do this?” she stage-whispered. “Gives me way more material for ballads.”

“Rakihi of Too Many Songs,” Lana said dryly. “For scaring cultists, demons, and half my staff with nothing but your voice and some very bad decisions. Black designation.”

She clipped the badge to the leather strap Rakihi wore diagonally across her chest.

Rakihi looked down at it, then up at Lana, uncharacteristically serious.

“We’ll try to be worthy of it,” she said.

“Don’t,” Lana replied. “Just keep being inconvenient to the things that need inconvenient people.”

Then she turned back to the hall and lifted her own tankard.

“To the Iron Wolves,” she said again, louder this time. “To the Black Squad. To everyone who went into the dark this week so the rest of us didn’t have to.”

“To the Wolves! To the Blacks!” someone shouted.

Shade winced at the nickname, but there was no stopping a hall full of drinking adventurers.

The hall roared it back.

Tankards clashed. Mead spilled. The room loosened into something that could be both a celebration and a memorial.

✦ ✦ ✦

Afterward, the feast found its own unruly rhythm.

Mead kept coming.

The cooks barely kept pace.

Someone started a game of “which demon was the ugliest,” which devolved quickly into “which council member probably is a demon.”

Stories followed.

Serah told, with elaborate hand gestures, the tale of the first time she’d seen a demon gate: “—and then the idiot kicked it, as if you can kick a hole in reality—”

Varinel reluctantly recounted the time Shade had fallen out of a tree during what was supposed to be a stealth recon.

Rakihi demanded in return that someone tell a story about Lana, and after enough drinks one of the veteran captains obliged with a tale of a much younger Lana punching a noble in the face “for trying to pay us in ceremonial tokens instead of actual coin.”

Every few minutes somebody dragged Shade into another conversation.

“Tell us what it felt like,” a younger adventurer begged. “Facing a lieutenant.”

He thought about snarling teeth and hot wind and the sensation of a will like a burning brand shoving against his.

He also thought about Rakihi’s voice in his ear, Arcebek’s glyphs anchoring the circle, Elcia’s shield slamming into place beside him.

“Terrible,” he said. “Familiar, too. But we faced it together. Remember that part.”

Rakihi, three drinks in, hopped onto a table (to Lysa's horror) and launched into a ballad she absolutely was not finished with, about "the dragon and his three terrible brides" tearing a demon apart underneath a village that had forgotten how to sleep.

The rhymes were rough, but by the second chorus half the hall was singing along.

Arcebek heckled from her seat:

"You make me sound much taller!"

"You are taller in my heart!" Rakihi yelled back, and nearly fell off the table laughing.

Elcia, cornered by a cluster of curious paladins and guards, found herself explaining Kael Varis' view on "justified force" and how it intersected with not turning your loved ones into moral projects.

"Isn't it… hard?" one asked, blinking. "Having your oath bound to… them as well as the god?"

Elcia looked across the room to where Shade and Rakihi were mock-arguing about whether demons or nobles had better fashion, and where Arcebek was grimly arm-wrestling a veteran twice her size.

She watched Shade and Rakihi mock-argue about whether demons or nobles dressed better. Beside them, Arcebek was arm-wrestling a veteran twice her size.

"It's heavier," she said. "But it's also… truer. Oaths without names are easy to twist."

The paladin considered that, then nodded slowly.

Lana moved through the feast with a watchful eye.

She checked on the injured and the exhausted.

She refilled the Wolves' tankards without forcing them to speak.

Catching Shade's eye once, from across the room, when someone called them "her grim reapers."

He grimaced.

She just shrugged.

"Could've been worse," she mouthed.

He snorted.

As the evening deepened, the crowd rearranged itself into clusters of tired, tipsy adventurers.

Benches migrated. People leaned against one another rather than sitting upright.

Shade found himself at a corner table, Rakihi tucked under one arm, Arcebek leaning against his other side, Elcia's legs stretched out under the table and tangled with his.

They were flushed, pleasantly unsteady and far too full.

Rakihi's eyes were heavy-lidded as she traced the outline of the new badge on his chest.

"Best of the best," she murmured. "Can you believe that?"

He remembered the dead cultists, the shattered demon core and Yarin lying pale in the infirmary when they visited to tell him the mission was done.

"Yes," he said. "But I hope they remember what it cost the last best, too."

Elcia nudged his ankle with her boot. "We will," she said. "That's the point."

Arcebek, head tipped back on his shoulder, yawned.

“I hate that Lana was right,” she muttered.

“About what?” Rakihi asked.

“That if we kept doing what we were already doing,” Arcebek said, “we’d end up with stupid little bits of metal that say ‘please throw us at worse problems.’”

Rakihi snorted.

“You love it,” she said.

Arcebek’s mouth curled. “A little,” she admitted.

It was late when they finally made their farewells.

They traded last jokes, drained the last tankards and escaped into the cool streets.

The walk home was less dignified than their entrance to the hall.

Rakihi insisted she was walking perfectly well.

She promptly stumbled. Shade caught her and carried her the rest of the way like an indignant, oversized cat.

Arcebek walked with one hand on his elbow and the other in Elcia’s, not because she needed the guidance—her other senses were doing just fine—but because she wanted it.

Elcia declared herself sober enough to lead the way, then misjudged the step into the yard and caught herself with an oath that would have impressed Brannoc.

The house greeted them with the soft, familiar thrum of wards recognizing their signatures.

Inside, the noise of the guildhall seemed impossibly far away.

Their house no longer felt like a staging point between battles.

It felt like somewhere they had earned the right to rest.

They made it as far as the big bed and no farther.

Boots came off. Clothes followed with less urgency. Four onyx badges were laid carefully on the bedside table.

They settled together in a familiar tangle.

Rakihi sprawled across Shade, fingers threaded into his shirt. Arcebek curled against his side, forehead beneath his jaw. Elcia lay on the other side, one arm draped across all three, her shield still within reach.

“Hey,” Rakihi mumbled, already almost gone. “We didn’t die.”

“High bar,” Arcebek murmured.

“We also… stopped something that would have killed many more,” Elcia added, voice soft and fading.

Shade let his eyes close.

The applause and laughter lingered in his ears, along with the new title people had given them: grim reapers.

Beneath the noise, one memory remained clear.

The memory of Lana's hand on his shoulder.

When the worst thing comes knocking, I send you.

He should have felt crushed by it.

Instead, with his three partners pressed close and the last taste of mead on his tongue, he felt something unexpected.

Contentment.

Satisfied.

Not the brittle pride of the dragon court.

Something quieter, and harder won.

For tonight, the balance had tipped in the right direction.

He smiled, small and unguarded, into the dark.

By the time sleep took him, the last coherent thought in his head was:

Best of the best, he thought. But ours. Not theirs.

That night his dreams held fewer demons than usual.

Instead, Arcebek argued with a celestial auditor, Rakihi struggled to rhyme "dullahan" with "casserole," and Elcia declared a demon contract null and void under clause seventeen, subsection B.

Morning arrived with birdsong, sunlight and the smell of bread from the kitchen.

They woke with sore throats, mild hangovers and the sort of deep contentment that did not erase the blood or the fear.

For the moment, it made both easier to bear.

Chapter 11: Dinner with the Goddesses

Shade chose a quiet evening to ask.

Elcia had finished her drills. Rakihi had come home from performing. Arcebek had, for once, escaped her imps and their Infernal arguments.

The four of them sat down to dinner without a crisis demanding their attention.

Bread cooled beside the steaming stew. They had barely begun to eat when Shade cleared his throat.

He cleared his throat.

“I have… a question,” he said.

Three sets of eyes swung to him.

Arcebek turned her face toward his voice. “That tone never precedes anything simple,” she said.

Rakihi poked him in the ribs with her spoon. “Spit it out, dragon.”

He hesitated.

“Would you like to meet my gods?” he asked.

Silence.

Even the fire seemed to hold still.

Rakihi’s spoon clattered into her bowl. “Yes,” she blurted. “Obviously. Absolutely. Immediately. How is this even a question?”

Elcia stared. “That’s… possible?” she asked, voice reverent and a little alarmed.

“At the place where I repaired the stones,” Shade explained. “The elemental convergence makes it easier for them to manifest here.”

Arcebek tapped her fingers against the table, thinking.

“They know about us,” she said. “Obviously. We literally swore over their stones. But meeting face to face—”

“Face to… much more intimidating face,” Rakihi supplied.

“—that’s another thing,” Arcebek finished. “What do they think of us?”

Shade smiled crookedly. “They think you are good for me. And dangerous. From them, that is praise.”

Elcia drew a deep breath, squared her shoulders.

“I would be honored,” she said. “If they’ll have us.”

Rakihi bounced in her seat. “I’m going to meet the beings who used you as a war-asset and still didn’t manage to break you,” she said. “This is, like, religious therapy. Let’s go.”

Arcebek exhaled. “All right,” she said. “But if any of them tries to recruit me into a multiversal pyramid scheme, I am leaving.”

“Terra might offer you a garden,” Shade said. “That is the closest thing.”

“Sold,” Arcebek muttered.

✦ ✦ ✦

The convergence shrine had changed in the night.

During the Storm Festival, lightning had hammered the stones and rain had soaked the clearing. Tonight it stood silent beneath the stars.

A broken plinth rose inside a ring of standing stones. Four old trees marked the cardinal points, while a young sapling bent toward the open sky at the center.

Shade had arranged a simple table on the broadest slab. Shallow candles surrounded five offerings: glowing coals, clear water, fresh earth, a rune-marked metal rod, and a scattering of feathers and dandelion seeds.

Their dinner sat there too, mostly untouched.

“The food is for us,” Shade explained. “The offerings are for them. They have no need to eat, but they appreciate the gesture.”

Rakihi eyed the coals. “Right, no offering myself to Ifret by falling into the fire,” she muttered. “Got it.”

Elcia adjusted her cloak, eyes roaming over the stones. “This place feels… good,” she said. “Old. Balanced.”

Shade nodded. “That is why we used it for the repair.”

Arcebek folded her arms. “Protocol?” she asked. “Do we kneel, bow or submit an appointment request in triplicate?”

“Do not kneel,” Shade said at once. “Treat them as dangerous elders: respectfully, but without worship. They are not the gods of this world.”

He took a breath.

“All right,” he said. “Stay… close. If anything feels wrong, say so immediately.”

Rakihi stepped to his left, threading her fingers through his.

Elcia took his right.

Arcebek put a hand flat on the table between the offerings, grounding herself.

Shade reached for the bracelet on his wrist, fingers brushing each gemstone in turn.

Fire.
Earth.
Water.
Lightning.
Wind.

The air grew heavy.

It was nothing like the pressure beneath the cult village. This presence did not intrude.

It felt like standing at the shore as a great wave gathered: power enough to crush them, choosing instead to hold back.

He spoke in Draconic first, then in the older, stranger set of tones that weren’t quite words.

“Five,” he murmured. “If you have time and tolerance, I ask you to look this way. I bring… family.”

The coals in the small brazier flared.

The first flame unfolded into a shape.

✦ ✦ ✦

Ifret emerged from the fire as though it were a doorway built for her alone.

She was tall and beautiful in a way that had little to do with softness: sharp lines, fierce eyes and the bearing of someone whose orders had shaped wars.

Her hair fell in a long, dark red sheet down her back, catching sparks as if they were jewels. Her eyes were the same color, ember-bright and knowing. Behind her, a golden arc of metal curved like half a halo, framing two pairs of blood-red wings folded neatly in.

In her hands, she leaned lightly on a gold-and-crimson scythe, its blade lazily licking with flame along the edge.

“Child,” she said, and even her voice was warm. “You took your time.”

Shade’s throat went tight. “Ifret,” he said. “I… was not sure—”

“You weren’t sure it was safe for them,” she corrected. “That is why I waited. And why Fenris won a bet.”

Rakihi made a small strangled noise. “You’re… gorgeous,” she blurted, then clapped a hand over her mouth. “Sorry, that was probably—”

Ifret’s gaze slid to her.

“True,” she said simply. “And you must be the one who keeps setting his heart on fire.”

Rakihi turned the color of a ripe tomato. “I—maybe—in a metaphorical and sometimes literal sense—”

Ifret’s mouth curved, wicked and pleased. “Good. He runs cold when he thinks too much.”

Her attention swept to Arcebek.

“Warlock,” she said. “Your threads reek of outer things.”

Arcebek straightened. “Occupational hazard,” she said, voice carefully light. “I keep the doors shut, when I can.”

Ifret’s eyes narrowed, then softened a fraction. “And you’ve bartered your sight for leverage over them. Bold.” She inclined her head. “As long as you do not invite them to the heart of his house, we have no quarrel.”

“They try, I shove back,” Arcebek said. “Deal.”

Ifret’s gaze caught Elcia next.

“Death-knight-paladin,” she mused. “That is new.”

Elcia swallowed. “Elemental Ifret,” she said, choosing the formal address Shade had used once. “I serve justice and the hearth that holds him. I will not turn your weapon into indiscriminate ash.”

“Good,” Ifret said. “I dislike waste.” Her eyes came back to Shade, softening. “You chose well, little spark.”

Shade coughed. “They… chose me,” he said.

Ifret snorted. “Argue semantics with Terra. She’s next.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The air thudded once, like a distant drum.

The stone beneath their feet hummed.

The ground opened beyond the table, and Terra rose from it as if the earth had decided to take a human shape.

She was short, even beside Rakihi.

She had the build of an avalanche—thick arms, broad shoulders and curves that suggested the mountain had a sense of humor.

Her skin was the rich brown of deep soil. Flowers—tiny white blossoms, bluebells, small curling vines—grew through her deep green hair in wild disarray. Her eyes were pure onyx, glossy black, with no visible whites.

She had an enormous sword slung over one shoulder, a slab of solid onyx with edges sharpened to impossible fineness, carved with shifting runes that looked like cracks in old stone.

She dusted her hands off as she finished emerging.

“Well,” she said, her voice warm and deep as tilled soil. “He finally brings people home, and they’re not screaming or on fire. Progress.”

Shade winced. “Terra…”

She grinned—sharp, fond.

“And you must be the reason,” she added, looking the others over.

Her gaze landed on Rakihi first.

“Fae,” she noted. “Rootless, but you plant songs wherever you go. I like that.”

Rakihi beamed. “Thank you. I like your… sword. And your everything.”

“Mm,” Terra said, amused. “Don’t flirt unless you plan to help weed the garden.”

Rakihi blinked. “Is that… a euphemism?”

“Yes,” Ifret said.

“No,” Terra said, at the same time.

They looked at each other, then laughed.

Terra turned to Arcebek, eyeing the faint scorch-marks on her clothes. “You’ve been standing where things crack,” she said. “You patch more than you break, for all your talk.”

Arcebek shrugged. “If they break the world, there’s nowhere left to snark from,” she said. “Self-interest.”

Terra’s onyx eyes softened. “Honest,” she said. “Good. We’re tired of zealots who pretend they don’t enjoy the burn.”

Then Elcia.

Terra stepped closer, unabashedly taking her chin in one hand to turn her face this way and that like a smith inspecting metal.

Elcia held very still.

“Stubborn,” Terra murmured. “Held together by will, spite and a curse that no longer knows how to own you. You stand like a door that refuses to fall.”

Elcia’s voice, when it came, was quiet. “I’d like to be a door that opens the right way,” she said. “But I’ll take ‘stubborn’ for now.”

Terra smiled, small and satisfied, and patted her cheek. “We can work with that.”

Her hand dropped to Shade’s shoulder, squeezing once.

“You’re not dead,” she said. “And you ate the gems she keeps nagging you about. Well done.”

Rakihi hissed. “You knew?”

Terra shrugged. “I am in the stones. I feel when he forgets to chew. He is bad at self-care.”

Ifret made an indignant noise. “We’ve been saying this for centuries.”

“There are more,” Shade said quickly. “Fenris will want—”

“Already here,” a familiar voice said.

✦ ✦ ✦

Water in the little bowl on the table rose up in a clean column and folded like cloth.

Fenris stepped out of it.

She looked enough like Shade to make Rakihi stare.

Blue hair cropped short on one side and long on the other, eyes exactly his shade of stormy ocean, face angular and fierce.

Flanked on either side by two translucent wolf-spirits—one pale as mist, one dark as deep water. Two hand-axes hung at her hips, their blades etched with runes that looked like frozen waves.

At first her expression was all ice: guarded and stern.

Until she saw Shade.

Then it cracked, just enough, into something warm and achingly gentle.

“There you are,” she said, stepping forward. “Alive. Mostly in one piece. About time you showed me the ones keeping you that way.”

He bowed his head. “Fenris,” he murmured. “I—”

She grabbed him by the shoulders and pulled him into a fierce, ribs-creaking hug.

He froze for a heartbeat, then relaxed into it.

When she let him go, she looked past him to the others.

“You,” she said, nodding at Rakihi. “Fairy. Song-maker. You’ve been walking him home from nightmares.”

Rakihi's throat bobbed. "Trying," she said. "He's very… heavy."

Fenris' mouth quirked. "Dragons are," she said. "Use the wolves if you need to." One of the spirit wolves padded over and shoved its spectral head under Rakihi's hand until she squeaked and started petting it.

"You," she said to Arcebek. "You've been shoving back when outer things tried to tug him out past the curtain."

Arcebek's smile went crooked. "Someone has to," she said. "Apparently telling horrors 'no' is my new brand."

Fenris' eyes softened. "You stand in a different war than ours," she said. "But you push in the same direction. I respect that."

Elcia was last.

Fenris studied her for a long moment.

"With you," she said finally, "it is simple. You look at him and do not see weapon or asset. You see Shade. You would stand between my leash and his neck if I pulled too hard."

Elcia met her gaze without flinching. "Yes," she said.

Fenris' smile was small and real. "Good," she said. "If we ever panic and forget that he is a person, shout louder than we can."

Then she slid back a step, eyes flicking upward.

"Lightning's getting impatient," she murmured.

✦ ✦ ✦

The air cracked.

Not with thunder. A change in pressure and a sharp scent of ozone announced her.

More like a subtle shift in pressure, a smell of ozone without a bolt.

Then Buyakugan stood before them.

One heartbeat there was empty air; the next, a tall fox-woman stood where the light seemed a little too bright.

Her clothing was a careful, elegant blend of kimono layers and shrine-maiden garb—white and deep indigo, embroidered with stylized stormclouds and lightning bolts.

Her hair fell in a long, immaculate sheet of snow-white down her back, matched by the lush tails that swayed behind her—Shade wasn't sure how many; they kept blurring when he tried to count. In her right hand she held a nodachi so absurdly long it should have been unwieldy, yet she moved it like a fan.

Her eyes were piercing, electric blue, with little arcs of light flickering in the irises.

"Shade," she said, inclining her head. "You continue to find trouble. At least this time you also find… company."

Her gaze swept the group.

Rakihi swallowed a sound that might have been “oh no she’s hot too” and clapped both hands over her mouth again.

Buyakugan’s lips twitched.

“You have a type,” she observed to Shade. “Chaotic.”

“It… seems so,” he admitted.

She stepped closer, tails brushing the stone without making a sound.

“To stand in storms,” she said, “you need people who won’t blow away. These three—” she nodded at Rakihi, Arcebek, Elcia “—are… anchored. Good.”

Her attention snagged on Elcia’s tabard.

“Kael Varis,” she mused. “The Ledger-Keeper. Fussy. Very particular about balance sheets.”

“You… know him?” Elcia asked, startled.

Buyakugan huffed. “We’ve argued in storm-rooms,” she said. “He scolds me for knocking over his little mortal dominoes. I remind him that stagnation is just rot in a nice outfit.” Her smile sharpened. “If he ever tries to claim you away from this hearth, I will be… displeased.”

Elcia blinked. “I… will keep that in mind?”

“Do,” Buyakugan said.

Her gaze went to Arcebek next.

She studied Arcebek, taking in the strange light that moved behind her sightless eyes.

“You’ve seen a different sky,” she said. “One with teeth behind it.”

Arcebek’s mouth tightened. “Yes,” she said. “I told it to get in line.”

Buyakugan laughed, soft and delighted. “Oh, I like you,” she said. “If the outer things fuss about your contracts, send them my way. I enjoy electrocuting solicitors.”

Rakihi finally found her voice. “I love all of you,” she muttered under her breath. “In a respectful, not-going-to-start-a-cult way.”

Buyakugan’s ears flicked. “Good,” she said. “We have enough cults.”

Then she sighed and rolled her shoulders.

“Wind is sulking,” she said. “If we don’t let them in, they’ll start knocking over chairs.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The leaves around the clearing stirred.

The breeze came from every direction at once.

A breeze that tasted like high cliffs and dawn carried a few dandelion seeds up from the table, spinning them lazily.

Then the air shimmered.

Djing and Djang had always been difficult to look at.

Even Shade had trouble focusing on them when they didn’t want to be seen.

Tonight they made themselves easier to see.

Two figures hovered side by side.

Human-shaped, but more suggestion than flesh, their edges continually shifting from whitish to grayish to blackish and back again.

Where one blurred toward white, the other darkened; where one flickered, the other steadied. Twin faces, never quite the same when you blinked, but always sharing a grin that looked like mischief had been poured into a mold and given eyes.

Their hands, when they clasped them, were solid enough to tug at each other's sleeves. Their feet didn't quite touch the ground.

"Hi," they said together, voices overlapping and out of sync.

Shade bowed his head instinctively. "Djing. Djang," he said. "Thank you for staying… mostly on this side."

"Mostly," one of them said.

"Mostly," the other agreed.

Their attention zipped to Rakihi and stuck there.

"Oooooh," they breathed. "You're the music."

"I—yes?" Rakihi said faintly.

They zoomed closer.

One moment they stood across the table; the next they hovered beside her elbows, peering at her like curious birds.

"You make patterns," one murmured.

"And then you break them," the other added, delighted. "We like that."

They spun around her once, a little breeze kicking up her hair and making her squeal.

"Hey!" she laughed. "At least buy a bard dinner before you whirl her."

"We brought wind," one said seriously.

"And lightning soup," the other added, pointing at the bowl of water that now had tiny sparks dancing in it.

Arcebek snorted. "They're perfect," she muttered. "And terrifying."

Djing and Djang drifted toward her, their heads tilted at identical angles.

"You," one said. "Stand in still places."

"And shake them," the other finished. "Good. Stagnant air smells bad."

They turned to Elcia.

For once, they sobered a little.

"Door," one said.

"Threshold," the other agreed.

“You used to be a road with no choice.”

“Now you’re a crossroads.”

They reached out—one finger each—and poked her forehead lightly.

“Elcia?” one said.

“Remember to turn sometimes,” the other finished. “Straight lines are boring.”

Elcia’s lips twitched. “I’ll… do my best,” she said.

They nodded, solemn as only wind-twins could be, which was to say not very.

✦ ✦ ✦

For a while, gods and mortals simply shared the table.

The clearing had become an impossibly small dining room for impossibly large guests.

Ifret accepted a chicken leg Rakihi nervously offered, turned it over in her fingers, and then simply held it near her lips—the meat blackening and sizzling as the idea of fire licked it.

Terra ran heavy fingers over the grain of the wood, murmuring in a language that sounded like stones shifting; a tiny vine poked out of a crack near the edge.

Fenris leaned on a pillar and whittled absentmindedly at a chunk of ice that hadn’t been there a moment ago, letting it fall into the water bowl to cool it.

Buyakugan sprawled with entirely unnecessary grace on a half-floating cushion of air, nodachi across her knees, tails fanning like a throne.

Djing and Djang made tiny dust-devils in the crumbs.

Shade watched his partners take in the sight of his gods.

Rakihi’s expression was a mix of awe, glee, and a faint, terrified delight, like someone at the best and worst concert of their life.

Elcia’s eyes shone, shoulders relaxing more the longer she watched Terra and Fenris quietly argue about soil composition.

Arcebek sat straighter than she had in weeks. She was wary, but no longer seemed to be bracing for judgment.

Ifret eventually turned back to Shade.

“You wanted this,” she said. “For them, or for you?”

“Both,” Shade said. “They walk beside me. They deserve to know who else shares that road. And you deserve to see what my home has become.”

Fenris hummed approval.

Terra nodded. “Roots grow stronger when they tangle,” she said.

Buyakugan flicked an ear. “Also easier to electrocute things that try to pull one out,” she added.

Djing/Djang giggled. “And more fun in storms,” one said.

“Much more,” the other agreed.

Elcia cleared her throat.

“May I ask something?” Elcia said, addressing the table.

The elemental gods turned their attention to her.

She didn’t flinch.

“Do you… mind us?” she asked. “Us loving him. Him loving us. You made him for war. We… pull him toward other things.”

Silence.

Then Ifret snorted, unexpectedly soft.

“We made him to fight endings,” she said. “The Void. The things that don’t care about anything but unmaking. We did not make him to be miserable.”

Terra grunted. “A tool that never rests snaps,” she said. “You keep him from snapping. That makes you… part of the frame.”

Fenris’ gaze softened. “We send him into storms. You are the harbor he swims back to. Without that, he would go under. We know it.”

Buyakugan rolled her eyes heavenward. “We may be terrifying, but we’re not his mother,” she said. “We don’t get to veto his lovers. We just… worry less, now.”

Djing and Djang drifted closer, one on either side of Shade’s head, leaning in like overexcited siblings.

“He laughs more now,” one said.

“He sings with her,” the other added, nodding at Rakihi.

“He argues with you,” one said to Arcebek, amused.

“And he sleeps like he’s not waiting to die,” the other finished, unusually solemn.

They looked at each other and then at Elcia.

“We like you,” they said together.

Rakihi sniffled. “Okay,” she said thickly. “That’s unfair. You can’t be eldritch and sweet.”

Arcebek exhaled, her shoulders finally easing.

“Good to know,” she said. “I was fully prepared to have to lawyer at elemental gods.”

“If you try, bring snacks,” Terra said. “We like your bread.”

Buyakugan’s gaze slid back to Shade, suddenly sharp.

“You know this doesn’t get you out of anything,” she said. “We’re still calling when demons move. When the Void shifts. When the outer things send you legal documents in triplicate.”

“I know,” he said. “But now they know, too.”

He looked at Rakihi, Arcebek, Elcia.

“If I go,” he said, “they will be watching over me alongside you. That changes how I face the road.”

Ifret’s expression softened into something almost maternal.

“Good,” she said. “Maybe this time, when the big storms come, you won’t sprint at the horizon alone.”

Fenris lifted her axes in a small, silent toast.

Terra thumped her onyx sword into the ground once.

Buyakugan inclined her head like a queen acknowledging a treaty she actually liked.

Djing and Djang blew a gust of warm wind across the table that smelled like first rain and new leaves.

The candles guttered.

The air lightened.

One by one, the gods' forms thinned.

Ifret stepped back into the brazier's coals, fire folding around her like a cloak.

Terra sank into the stone with a satisfied sigh, stray flowers left behind.

Fenris and her wolves flowed into the water's reflection, ripples smoothing into glass.

Buyakugan dissolved into a thousand tiny sparks that rose and winked out among the stars.

Djing and Djang drifted away on opposite winds, leaving laughter behind them.

The weight in the clearing lifted.

Shade finally released the breath he had been holding.

His hands stopped trembling.

For a time, nobody spoke.

Then Rakihi broke the silence.

"Your gods are so much."

Arcebek let out a shaky laugh. "Yeah," she said. "And somehow I feel… less like an imposter, not more. That's new."

Elcia's eyes were bright. "They were… nothing like Kael Varis," she said. "But I think he'd… respect them. And you. More than I realized."

Shade looked at them—his lovers, his hearth, his anchor points—and felt something settle in his chest he hadn't known was loose.

"You are all… very brave," he said quietly. "Most mortals who see them that close either start a religion or run away."

Rakihi sniffed. "We already have a religion," she said. "It's called 'making sure you don't do anything too stupid with your cosmic powers.'"

Elcia smiled. "And each other," she added. "That, too."

Arcebek reached for the bread, tearing off a piece and popping it into her mouth.

"Next time we invite them to dinner," she said, "I'm charging consultation fees."

Shade laughed, openly this time.

They shared the remains of the meal and gathered the offerings before starting home beneath a sky that seemed less indifferent than it had before.

At the edge of the clearing, as they stepped back onto the ordinary road, Rakihi slipped her hand into his again.

“So,” she said. “Think Lana would believe us if we told her we had dinner with five gods in the woods?”

Shade considered Lana’s face.

“No,” he said. “But she would find a way to bill them for hazard pay.”

They all laughed.

Behind them, the convergence stone hummed once, content.

Ahead, the city lights waited.

Between the ancient gods behind them and the mortal city ahead, four figures walked side by side.

Not alone.

Not anymore.

Chapter 12: The Absent Guildmaster

The fifth week of Shade's apprenticeship began with three sentences he would remember for the rest of his life.

Lana didn't even sit down.

He entered Lana's office expecting ledgers, council preparations and another argument about caravan routes. Instead he found her in a traveling cloak, with a packed bag beside a suspiciously tidy desk.

She looked up as he closed the door.

"Good," she said. "You're here."

The scales at the back of his neck prickled.

"What's wrong?" he asked.

"Nothing yet," she said. "Which is why I'm doing this now, before anything catches fire."

She picked up a thin stack of folders, tapped them into order, then put them in his hands.

"I'm going away for a month," she said. "You're in charge. If you need to get a hold of me, don't."

For a second he was almost sure he'd misheard.

"What?"

Lana's mouth curved, not quite a smile. "I'm taking leave. Proper leave. Out of the city, out of easy messenger range. If I stay, I'll keep 'just handling one more thing' until I fall over in this chair and mildew into the upholstery."

She nodded at the folders clutched in his hands.

"That," she went on, "is a neat little bundle of 'how not to let that happen to you.' Current missions, standing agreements, the things that will explode if you ignore them and the things that will only smoulder."

He looked at the folders, then back at her.

"Lana," he said. "I am your shadow. Your… deterrent. Your extremely armed cloak. I am not—"

"Guildmaster material?" she supplied. "Tell that to the last four weeks of you doing half my job."

She came around the desk. This close, he could see the strain around her eyes, the exhaustion she usually hid beneath sheer stubbornness.

"To the outside world," she said softly, "there is no 'acting.' For a month, you are the guild. You sign, it stands. You speak, it's policy. You piss someone off, they are officially pissed at us."

"That seems," he said carefully, "unwise."

"Yes," she said. "But so is letting the council smell blood. If I vanish and leave a vacuum, they'll fight over it. If I vanish and leave a dragon with a terrifying reputation and a proven track record of not being bribeable, they'll grumble and test you, but they won't move as fast."

He pictured the faces around the council table: the noble who spoke of acceptable losses, the priest who wanted pyres, the merchants who counted profits more readily than lives.

“They’ll test you,” Lana said, as if reading his mind. “They’ll try to see what they can get away with. That’s fine. Let them push a little. Learn their angles. Just don’t let them move the pillars.”

Shade swallowed.

“And if something happens you can’t handle?” he asked. “If a demon nest opens in the square? If cults move faster than we thought? If—”

“If something truly catastrophic happens,” she said, “you already know who to call that isn’t me. There are other guilds. Other gods. Your own… entourage.” Her eyes flicked briefly toward the bracelet on his wrist. “You are not alone here, Shade. Not in any sense.”

Still, he could not let it go.

“My mother,” he said slowly, “did not send me here to take over your guild.”

Lana snorted. “Your mother sent you here to learn how to live among mortals without breaking us,” she said. “Congratulations. This is part of it. Somebody has to keep this place functional while I lie on a beach or stalk cults in another district or sleep for a week, and you are unfortunately competent.”

“That does not sound like a compliment,” he muttered.

“It is in my language,” she said.

Silence settled between them.

“You can say no,” she added. “I meant that, when I told you before. I have contingency plans that don’t involve you. Boring, messy ones. Paper solutions. You are my first choice, not my only one.”

He weighed the offer.

Yarin was still recovering. The lieutenant’s dying scream haunted his sleep. There were Teron from Riverwatch, the High Priest, Lord Harven and a dozen other pressures he had watched Lana hold at bay.

And now she was asking him to hold them for her.

“No,” he said quietly. “I… will do it.”

Lana’s shoulders eased.

“Good,” she said. Then, because she was Lana: “If you’d said no, I’d have respected it. And then tried again in six months.”

Shade gave a helpless breath of laughter.

She clapped him once on the shoulder, harder than strictly necessary.

“Remember three things,” she said. “Delegate. Don’t bleed for people who won’t lift a quill for themselves. And if they forget you’re terrifying, remind them. Gently. At first.”

“That is three and a half things,” he said.

“Consider it a bonus,” she replied.

She collected her bag and headed for the door.

“Lana,” he said.

She paused with her hand on the handle, looking back.

“If the council asks where you’ve gone?” he asked.

“Tell them,” she said, “that this was absolutely their idea. They wanted ‘more distributed responsibility.’ They have it.”

She opened the door.

“Try not to burn the place down,” she added over her shoulder. “That’s my job.”

Then she was gone, down the stairs and out of the guild before Shade could think of another objection.

The door closed quietly.

Shade stood alone with the folders in his hands and a responsibility heavier than any armor he had worn.

A hesitant knock finally broke the silence.

He turned.

One of the senior clerks peered in, hair frazzled, ink on her fingers.

“Um,” she said. “Guildmaster? The morning approvals…?”

Only then did the truth settle into place.

Slowly, Shade nodded.

“Send them in,” he said. His voice came out steadier than he felt. “We have work to do.”

His first day passed in a blur of signatures, complaints and decisions no one else wanted to make.

He approved missions, read grievances and reassigned squads three times before he understood that Lana had balanced them by temperament as carefully as by rank. Twice he refused people who had expected the new guildmaster to be easier to sway.

By sunset, a headache had settled behind his eyes, as persistent as a dull knife.

He walked home through the city almost without seeing it.

The manor’s door opened before he reached it.

A small stone elemental held it with both hands, solemn as a doorman. The warmth hit him first: firelight, cooking, the murmur of familiar voices.

He stepped into the welcome warmth.

They were already at the table.

Rakihi sat half-perched on a chair, one knee drawn up. Arcebek angled herself to hear both the kitchen and the dining room, drumming her fingers on the table. Elcia had just washed; her damp hair clung to her neck, and her armor lay stacked by the wall.

All three turned toward him.

“You’re late,” Rakihi said. “We were about to send a search party. Or eat without you. I hadn’t decided which was funnier.”

“You look like someone lost a fight with a ledger,” Arcebek observed.

“There is ink on your sleeve,” Elcia added.

Shade glanced down. There was ink on his sleeve. He rubbed at it with his thumb and sat.

He let the warmth of the room settle around him: the smell of stew, the murmur of voices, the familiar hum of the wards.

Rakihi leaned across the table a little.

“Bad day?” she asked, more gently.

“Yes,” he said. “And… no. Complicated.”

“Those are the worst kind,” Arcebek said. “The ones you can’t just stab.”

Shade drew a breath.

“There is something I need to tell you,” he said. “Before you hear it as rumor in a tavern or from a very excited junior adventurer.”

That got their full attention.

Arcebek’s fingers stilled. Elcia set down her spoon. Rakihi watched him over the rim of her cup.

“All right,” Arcebek said. “Tell us.”

He looked from one face to another before folding his hands on the table.

“Lana,” he said slowly, “has taken leave. She left this morning. For approximately a month.”

Rakihi’s jaw dropped. “She what?”

Elcia’s brows drew together. “Is the council informed?” she asked at once. “The other guilds?”

“Yes,” he said. “She told them. And then she told them… something else.”

He braced himself.

“Effective immediately,” he said, because that was how Lana would have phrased it, “I am… the de facto guildmaster. While she is away.”

Silence fell.

Then Rakihi made a strangled noise between laughter and disbelief.

“I’m sleeping with the guildmaster,” she blurted.

Arcebek choked on her drink.

Elcia hid a laugh behind her hand.

Shade closed his eyes briefly. “That is not,” he said, “the primary concern here.”

“Excuse you,” Rakihi said, already grinning again. “It is a concern. A very important, very funny concern.”

“We are all,” Elcia said, recovering, “sleeping with the guildmaster. If we are… being precise.”

Arcebek wiped her mouth and turned her sightless gaze toward him, her smile warm beneath the mischief.

“Well, then,” she said. “Congratulations. Promotion?”

“Temporary insanity,” he said. “She gave me her work and then left the city. She also said, and I quote, ‘If you need to get a hold of me, don’t.’”

Rakihi slapped both hands on the table, delighted. “She did not,” she said.

“She did,” Shade said wearily.

“Gods,” Arcebek muttered. “That sounds exactly like her.”

Shade slumped in his chair.

“I spent the entire day signing things I do not feel qualified to sign,” he admitted. “People called me ‘Guildmaster.’ A clerk apologized for using my old title. There is a pile of petitions in her office that I am fairly certain breeds when no one is looking.”

Elcia’s expression softened.

“You said yes,” she said. It wasn’t quite a question.

He nodded once.

“I did,” he said. “Because if I had said no, she would have found another way. One that probably involved more risk for the guild and more power for the council. And because,” he added, quieter, “I did not like the idea of her leaving without someone at that desk I trust.”

Rakihi grew more serious.

“Do you… want it?” she asked. “Beyond the month, I mean. The chair. The job.”

He considered the question.

“I want it not to fall into the wrong hands,” he said eventually. “Whether or not those hands are mine long-term… I do not know. Yet.”

Arcebek leaned back, thinking.

“All right,” she said. “Here’s how this is going to work, then.”

He looked up.

“You,” she said, pointing in the vague direction of his voice, “are not going to try to do Lana’s job alone out of some misguided martyr impulse. You’re going to let the staff do their parts. You’re going to bring home the problems that hurt your head, and we are going to help you untangle them before you march back in and terrify people with good policy.”

“That is not how guildmasters—” he began.

“That is exactly how this guildmaster is going to do it,” she interrupted. “Or I will personally tell Lana you tried to burn yourself out on her behalf, and she will come back just to yell at you.”

Rakihi nodded solemnly. “She would,” she agreed. “I’d pay to see it, but I’d rather not have you crisp around the edges.”

Elcia rested her forearms on the table, leaning in.

“The guild is… your responsibility now,” she said. “But it is not just yours. It is also ours.” She tapped the table lightly. “We live here. We fight for this city. We will support you. That includes stopping you if you start thinking you have to save everyone alone.”

For the first time that day, Shade felt some of the weight lift.

“I do not know how to be a guildmaster,” he said quietly.

“Good,” Rakihi said. “We don’t need another Lana. We already have one. Somewhere on a beach. Being very bad at relaxing.”

Arcebek snorted.

“Besides,” Rakihi went on, bright again. “Think of the potential. ‘Guildmaster Shade, Scourge of Demons and Paperwork.’ The songs write themselves.”

“Please do not write songs about paperwork,” he said.

“I make no promises,” she replied.

Shade laughed.

Their stew had cooled, but he barely noticed. The problem remained enormous; it no longer seemed quite so solitary.

By the end of the meal, they had a plan.

Arcebek would sit with him the next evening and go through the senior staff list, sorting names into “trust,” “watch,” and “absolutely not.” Rakihi would start listening in taverns for the shape of the rumors already forming and nudge them into less destructive paths. Elcia would speak to the city watch and temple wardens she trusted, quietly reinforcing that the guild’s change in day-to-day leadership did not mean its vigilance had weakened.

Shade let them divide the work without protesting.

He watched them across the table.

At the warlock who had walked out of corporate hell and come back fiercer. At the fairy who’d traded wings for freedom and made a home in his storms. At the dullahan who’d bound herself both to a god of balance and to a very mortal hearth.

Guildmaster, he thought, trying the word again.

Then another thought followed: ours.

“Thank you,” he said simply.

Rakihi flicked a pea at him. “You’re welcome, boss,” she said.

“Do not call me that,” he said automatically.

She grinned. “Too late.”

Later, when they went to bed, Shade listened to rain on the roof and the breathing of the three women curled around him.

Lana was gone.

Storms were coming.

For at least a month, the guild’s tangled responsibilities would rest in his hands.

Terrifying.

Absurd.

And, with his family beside him, possible.

Chapter 13: The Numbers Behind the Names

The next morning brought no demons, no cultists, nothing he could solve with a sword.

It brought numbers.

Shade's second day as guildmaster began when the senior clerk marched him into the records room and shut the door behind a formidable stack of ledgers.

"Before you go to war with anything," she said briskly, "you need to know what you have. Sit."

He sat.

Old paper and ink scented the room, threaded with the metallic tang of anti-mould wards humming in its corners. Shelves crowded the walls, their folders, tablets and labelled boxes arranged with terrifying precision. A mission board occupied the remaining space, its coloured tags annotated in a meticulous hand.

The clerk set a ledger before him. Then another. Finally, she added a stack of loose sheets for good measure.

"Adventurer availability," she announced, as though laying weapons on a rack. "By rank, current status and projected status."

Shade blinked at her. "…Projected?"

"Injured, cursed, on leave, temporarily petrified," she explained. "Some will return to duty. Some won't. Knowing the difference keeps a mission staffed instead of filling a memorial wall."

That, at least, he understood.

"All right," he said. "Show me."

They began with the people behind the numbers.

Bronze, Silver and Gold. Adventurers bound to long-term contracts, and those passing through in search of something more exciting—or more deadly. Those sleeping in guild bunks, those renting rooms in the city, and those who appeared to sleep nowhere anyone could account for.

There were more names than he had imagined.

And, somehow, fewer.

One hundred and sixty-three adventurers registered to the guild. Only fifty-two were technically available that day. Twelve were recovering from injuries and expected back within a fortnight. Beside five names, the clerk had written "probably not returning"—a careful phrase that covered several grim possibilities.

"Standing parties," the clerk said, opening another ledger. "Teams with established records. We try not to split them up. Anyone who has survived together that long has earned some consideration."

Ink connected the names into groups. Some had remained together for years; others had replacements squeezed beside crossed-out entries. Every alteration suggested a story Shade suspected he would rather not hear.

His finger stopped at the Iron Wolves. He needed no explanation for the names struck through beneath that heading.

“How many free agents?” he asked.

“Seventeen currently unattached,” she said. “Most of them Bronze.”

Shade breathed out slowly.

They moved on.

Then came the accounts: mission fees, guild shares, city stipends and purchases. The cost of the bunks, training halls, wards and armoury. The number of people living under the guild roof, whether they were staff, families or adventurers with nowhere else they wished to go.

“If the caravans are delayed, how many nights can we feed everyone?” Shade asked. The question came from the part of him that still thought in sieges.

The clerk paused, then reached for a slate.

By the time she finished calculating, he had made his own estimate.

Neither answer pleased him.

Next came the missions.

New requests, open contracts, completed work awaiting a client’s confirmation. Then one column caught his eye.

“What does ‘pending clarification’ mean?” he asked.

The clerk grimaced. “It means someone wrote ‘Help, goblins,’ and considered the matter explained. We asked for details. Until they answer, we can’t tell whether it’s a nest or three fools in masks.”

“How many of those do we have?”

“Seventeen.”

“Seventeen,” he echoed.

“Yes, Guildmaster.”

He rubbed his temples.

At intervals, a knock interrupted the deceptive order of the ledgers.

A party captain furious that another team had been given “their” mission. A merchant offended by the hazard surcharge on his supposedly simple escort contract, despite a route passing a known bandit haunt. A junior adventurer who had set part of the western training yard alight and wanted to tell the guildmaster “before someone tells it wrong.”

Shade dealt with each problem in turn.

No, parties did not own missions; assignments depended on suitability and availability. Yes, a good record counted for something. No, threatening to join another guild would not change the safety rules.

Yes, the surcharge remained. No, the merchant’s generosity at a councilman’s last party had no bearing on it.

Yes, reporting the fire had been the right decision. No, Shade did not believe the adventurer was cursed to cause explosions. Yes, he would help repair the targets.

Between interruptions, the ledgers began to seem almost peaceful.

By late afternoon, his eyes burned, his writing hand had cramped and a dull ache pressed behind his forehead.

The clerk, to her credit, did not hover.

“Tomorrow we’ll look at the trends,” she said. “The past year, at least. It’s the best way to see where the cracks are spreading.”

“Tomorrow,” he said, and didn’t let himself sag until he’d left the room.

He walked home counting what he could not forget: seventeen unattached adventurers, fifty-two available, twelve likely to return, seventeen requests lacking vital information. Four major food routes into the city, two more vulnerable than the council cared to admit.

By the time the manor door shut behind him, the headache had made itself at home.

Rakihi took one look at him and pressed a mug of something hot and bitter into his hands without a word. Arcebek steered him into a chair. Elcia forbade him to touch another sheet of paper until he had eaten.

He obeyed. Arguing with all three at once rarely ended well for him.

That night, with their familiar warmth gathered around him, even the day’s absurdities seemed survivable.

Almost manageable, he thought as sleep claimed him.

The following morning proved otherwise.

He’d barely made it through breakfast when the knock came.

It was neither a messenger’s sharp rap nor the impatient pounding of someone with urgent news. Three measured taps sounded against the door.

Shade’s shoulders tightened before he had properly decided whether to be annoyed.

A small air elemental whirled ahead of him and opened the door. The guild runner outside shifted from one foot to the other, clearly wishing himself elsewhere.

“Sorry to disturb you, Guild—Shade,” the boy corrected himself, flushing. “A message from the council hall. They request your attendance at today’s sitting. As guildmaster.”

Shade stared at him.

“Today,” he repeated. “Today today?”

“Yes, sir. They said, ‘Of course the guildmaster knows the schedule,’ and laughed. I laughed too, only then it stopped being funny, and—”

“Thank you,” Shade interrupted gently, before the boy unravelled completely. “Tell them I’ll attend.”

The runner escaped as though fleeing a dragon’s lair. To be fair, he had been standing on the threshold of one.

Shade shut the door and rested his forehead against it.

Behind him, chairs scraped.

“The council?” Arcebek asked.

“Yes,” he said.

“When?” Rakihi said.

“In—” He glanced at the light through the window and calculated. “—about three hours.”

Rakihi made a strangled sound. “And when were you planning to tell us you had your first solo council meeting?”

“When,” Shade answered hollowly, “someone had the courtesy to tell me about it.”

For a moment, silence. Then all three spoke at once.

“No agenda?” Arcebek demanded.

“No briefing papers?” Elcia asked.

“Oh, we are going to make them regret that,” Rakihi declared.

Shade turned to face them, uncomfortably close to feeling ill.

“I am not prepared,” he admitted. “Lana always reviewed the agenda with me the evening before. We had time to plan. I have yesterday’s numbers, a headache and a vague sense of which councillors I dislike. Nothing more.”

Arcebek was already reaching for the notes he had brought home.

“Then we prepare you,” she said. “Three hours is not enough. It is also not nothing.”

“I cannot learn everything in three hours.” He heard the complaint in his own voice and hated it.

“Nobody expects you to,” Elcia said. “Except, apparently, you.”

Rakihi rose onto her toes, barely containing her restless energy.

“Right,” she said. “What is the worst thing that happens if you go in unprepared?”

“They outmanoeuvre me. I agree to something I should refuse. I fail to stop a proposal that hurts the guild. I—”

“Stop,” Arcebek said sharply. “Pick one. The most likely.”

He stopped, considered the question and forced himself to answer honestly.

“They test me,” he said at last. “Push for concessions Lana would refuse. Try to bind me to decisions I cannot easily reverse.”

“Then that is our priority,” Arcebek said. “Make no promises you cannot keep. Listen. Learn who presses and who waits.”

Rakihi nodded. “You’re very good at listening, actually. The intense, unsettling kind.”

“That is not a strategy,” he said.

“It is when you’re a dragon,” she replied. “Sit. Eat. Then we’re giving you a crash course.”

The next three hours dissolved into overlapping voices and diagrams hastily drawn on spare sheets.

Arcebek reviewed the council meetings he had attended with Lana, drawing out patterns he had noticed without naming. Elcia listed likely concerns from the watch and the temples: disturbances, patrol changes, cooperation and jurisdiction. Rakihi cheerfully drilled him in five polite variations of “I must

consult my staff before answering," ranging from genuine interest to a warning that further pressure might involve demons.

When he finally fastened his cloak, Shade still did not feel ready.

At least he no longer felt quite so much like a man entering battle blindfolded.

At the door, he paused.

Rakihi rose on her toes to kiss his cheek. "You'll be fine. If someone gives you trouble, imagine their internal organs. It'll improve your stare."

"That is not how that works," he said weakly.

"It is exactly how that works," she insisted.

Arcebek squeezed his hand. "You don't have to win every exchange today. Just don't lose anything that matters."

Elcia laid two fingers against the pulse in his wrist, offering something almost like a paladin's blessing.

"If they forget who you are," she said softly, "remind them. Kindly, for now."

He carried her words with him into the street.

By the time he reached the council hall, the headache had returned with the patience of an old enemy. Carved stone and self-important pillars towered above him; the city crest watched from over the doors.

Shade stopped at the foot of the steps.

He was not prepared—not as he wanted to be. Names, figures and half-understood alliances crowded his thoughts.

For one absurd moment, he wanted to turn back, crawl into bed between the people he loved and leave the city to argue with itself.

Instead, he drew a breath.

Counted to five.

Let it out.

"You have faced Void spawn," he reminded himself under his breath. "You can survive a room full of mortals talking."

His legs remained disappointingly unsteady.

They carried him up the steps anyway.

Chapter 14: The First Council

The ambush started politely.

The councillors offered all the usual courtesies: murmured greetings, rustling robes and the soft clink of signet rings against wood as they took their places around the curved table.

Shade occupied Lana's chair at the narrow end. Its high back felt too shallow against his shoulders, and the position left him unpleasantly exposed. He folded his hands on the polished table and resisted calculating how quickly he could overturn it for cover.

"Guildmaster Shade," said the Lord of Trade, smiling without warmth. "We appreciate your… prompt assumption of responsibilities during Guildmaster Lana's absence."

Shade inclined his head. "The guild remains at the council's service."

Their attention settled on him, weighing and measuring.

They appeared to expect an adventurer out of his depth: Lana's formidable enforcer in a borrowed coat, easily provoked and accustomed to solving problems with steel.

They would have to revise their expectations.

The High Priest cleared his throat. "In that spirit," he began, "we have a number of small matters requiring your… fresh perspective."

Small matters. Of course.

The first matter concerned routine patrols, presented as though the city itself hung in the balance.

"Temple wardens report more disturbances near the western docks," the High Priest said. "Brawls, drunkenness, the usual trouble. The guild previously supplied an additional patrol once per tenday, at Lana's discretion. We propose three, paid from guild funds, as a gesture of commitment to the city's… spiritual wellbeing."

Several heads nodded, already watching him.

Agree, and he would drain the guild's limited people and money. Refuse, and they could accuse him of neglecting public safety.

Shade allowed a measured silence.

"Which disturbances?" he asked.

The priest blinked. "Pardon?"

"The details," Shade replied mildly. "How many incidents? Where and when? You say the number has increased. By how much? I trust your wardens to make reports, High Priest, but I need evidence before committing three patrols each tenday. And I need to know whether adventurers are the proper response."

The priest had apparently brought neither figures nor a convincing explanation.

Shade recalled one of Lana's lessons: You understand supply lines, and you frighten people without trying. Those are advantages. Use them kindly, when you can.

He folded his hands a little more neatly.

“For now,” he continued, “two Silver-ranked parties are on light duty after a recent mission. I can have them assist the wardens on existing dock patrols for the next fortnight, coordinated through the watch, at no charge to the temples. That gives us time to decide whether a permanent expansion would be useful—or merely theatre.”

“Efficient,” observed the Lord of Trade, sounding almost surprised. “Prudent.”

The High Priest’s expression tightened, but he could hardly object without making his motives plain. Around the table, the councillors reconsidered their approach.

Lord Harven delivered the next test under cover of concern for the granaries.

“With Lana absent, supply security must be your highest priority,” Harven said. “Bandit activity along the southern road has increased. I suggest permanently assigning some of your crisis teams to caravan duty. The city would, naturally, contribute what it can.”

In other words, tie the Black Squad and similar teams to wagons, keep them away from more sensitive matters and hope the promised payment arrived before winter.

Shade smiled, very slightly.

“Lord Harven, yesterday I reviewed the guild’s records.” The admission seemed to surprise him. “Four principal food routes serve the city. The southern road is the shortest and the most vulnerable. The bandits know it as well as we do.”

Harven’s jaw tightened.

“For the next month, I intend to stagger high-value shipments across the eastern and northern approaches where possible. We can use smaller decoy caravans on the southern route, with escorts operating on irregular schedules. Mid-ranked parties should deter opportunists without exhausting our emergency response.”

He let his gaze rest on Harven a fraction too long.

“If my crisis teams are guarding wagons,” he asked softly, “who responds when the threat is not bandits on the road, but demons in a cellar?”

A murmur passed through the room. One merchant winced, perhaps remembering how recently a supposedly ordinary cellar had concealed something far worse.

Harven opened his mouth, then shut it. The point had landed.

The meeting continued in much the same fashion.

Questions about the budget met exact figures: bunkroom repairs, wound salves, hazard pay and the “small adjustments” certain councillors had pressed Lana to accept.

Proposals for extra patrols in noble districts ended when Shade asked whether they meant to prevent crimes or merely remove people they disliked seeing.

When someone dismissed the seventeen missions awaiting clarification as trivial, Shade’s expression went cold. “The last request that concealed its dangers cost the Iron Wolves dearly. We held their memorial three weeks ago. I will not risk another squad to spare a client a few questions.”

By the third exchange, the atmosphere had changed.

He could feel it as surely as a change in the wind.

The councillors began to listen instead of laying traps.

Not all of them. Some would always resent hearing no, especially from a man they had mistaken for hired muscle. But those Lana considered the city's real backbone—even when they annoy me—were studying him with a different sort of care.

There is the general, he imagined them thinking. Not merely the upstart.

The stories about the upstart were not entirely false. They were simply incomplete.

When the meeting adjourned, the tone of their questions had shifted from "How far can we push him?" to "How do we work with him?"

Shade left with his head humming, though the sensation was closer to the aftermath of a hard-won fight than the panic of that morning.

The headache was still there.

At least he understood the ground on which he had been fighting.

Roasting meat and spiced wine greeted him when he opened the manor door.

For a heartbeat he wondered whether he had forgotten a celebration. Then Rakihi collided with him, laughing, her arms around his waist.

"You came back!" she announced against his chest. "Alive, and without smoke pouring from your ears. I win."

"You were betting on whether I would… combust?" he asked, bewildered.

"Metaphorically," she said. "Mostly."

Arcebek leaned in the dining-room doorway, one hip cocked and her head turned toward his voice. Her smile was slow and unmistakably pleased.

"So," she said. "Did you let them walk all over you, or are we still allowed to be seen in public with you?"

"They tried," he said. "I redirected their efforts."

Elcia appeared behind Arcebek, wiping flour from her forearm with a cloth. The ordinary domestic sight made Shade's chest tighten.

"The watch captain sent word from the hall," she said. "Apparently the council's little test went badly. For the council."

Rakihi leaned back to study him. "You routed them, didn't you?" she demanded, delighted.

He remembered Harven's expression as the caravan proposal unravelled, and the High Priest's reluctant agreement to wait for evidence.

"I believe I made my position clear," Shade admitted.

Arcebek's grin widened. "Good," she said. "Lana's going to be so annoyed she missed it."

A fire elemental in the kitchen swelled with pride as a pot simmered at precisely the right temperature.

Rakihi seized his hand. "Food first, boasting second. Then we get you drunk. Or comfortably warm, at least."

"Is this a tactical decision?" he asked, letting himself be tugged toward the table.

“Yes,” she said solemnly. “Morale maintenance.”

The meal was simple and abundant: roasted vegetables, fresh bread and a stew that tasted as though someone had followed the recipe instead of arguing with the pot. Wine filled chipped but spotless cups.

They made him tell the story of the council meeting three times.

First came the plain account, so Arcebek could hear every detail. Then Elcia supplied dry corrections—“You did not threaten to feed him to demons; you implied he underestimated them.” Finally Rakihi performed increasingly extravagant impressions of the councillors, each less accurate and funnier than the last.

Halfway through the second telling, Shade caught himself laughing.

The knot he had carried since Lana’s announcement loosened.

“You did well,” Elcia told him quietly while the others disputed the last piece of bread. “They wanted a blunt instrument. They met a blade with an edge.”

He began to dismiss the compliment. She gave him a look that stopped him.

“You did well,” she repeated. “You are allowed to know it.”

He nodded, once.

When the dishes were cleared and the wine was gone, their celebration softened into something familiar and unhurried.

Rakihi threaded her fingers through his beneath the table. Arcebek leaned against his shoulder. Elcia rested a hand at the back of his neck, her thumb easing the tension there.

“We are proud of you,” Arcebek said, with the certainty of a fact entered in a ledger.

Shade tried to answer. For once, none of his languages seemed adequate.

They didn’t ask him to explain.

Later, the warmth followed them down the hall. They left their clothes, armour and titles behind, until guildmaster, warlock, bard and paladin were simply four people laughing softly together in the dark.

The evening had been a celebration, but not of conquest. He had spent the day defending the guild in a room full of powerful people, and now he was home with the people who made that effort worthwhile.

As he drifted toward sleep, Rakihi’s hair brushed his nose, Arcebek’s hand lay over his heart and Elcia’s quiet presence rested against his back. A thought came to him:

Lana had not thrown him to the wolves after all.

She had left him with a pack of his own.

Chapter 15: Trials of Leadership

Morning arrived with pleasantly aching muscles and a much clearer sense of purpose.

Shade left before the others were fully awake, his cloak thrown over a shirt and his hair damp from washing. Autumn air stung his cheeks as he crossed the square. Yesterday's headache had faded to an unpleasant memory.

The guild hall had already begun its morning bustle: cutlery clattered in the mess, voices carried from the common room and boots thudded on the stairs. Several adventurers looked up in surprise to see him alone at that hour.

"Guildmaster," one said, offering something between a bow and a flinch.

Shade didn't linger.

He went straight to the main training hall.

The sand had been freshly raked. Blunted blades, staves and padded glaives lined the walls, while practice targets waited at the far end. Two junior instructors were arguing over drill schedules; both straightened when he entered.

"Clear the floor," Shade instructed. "Send word through the guild. I want every adventurer currently here to report to the training hall—Bronze, Silver and Gold."

The younger instructor gaped. "All of them?"

"Everyone who can be spared," Shade clarified. "Leave departing parties to their preparations and do not interrupt urgent duties. The rest have an hour."

The instructors exchanged a look. Then, slowly, nodded.

"Yes, Guildmaster."

The news spread at once. Messengers hurried through the corridors, voices repeated the summons in disbelief, and coins quietly changed hands over what the new guildmaster might be planning.

By the time the hour was up, the hall was crowded.

Bronzes gathered in mismatched armour. Silvers arrived with the easy bearing of people who had survived long enough to trust their own judgement. A few Golds stood with folded arms, studying him.

Shade waited at the centre of the sand without his cloak or coat, his sleeves rolled to the elbows. The onyx badge at his collarbone stood out against his plain shirt.

He let them gawk for a moment.

"I have spent two days learning about you from records," he began when the hall quieted. "Names, ranks, injuries, missions."

A murmur.

"Those figures tell me how many people I can send out," he continued. "They do not tell me who keeps a clear head with a weapon in hand, who overextends, who panics, or who will drag their comrades out of danger when everyone else has given up."

That got their attention.

“So,” Shade said simply, “today I learn that.”

He took a blunted greatsword from the rack. It was oversized for most fighters; in his hands it looked entirely natural.

“This is an assessment, not a lesson,” he said. “Today I need to see how you fight. If you learn something from watching one another, so much the better.”

He planted the sword’s tip in the sand and leaned on it lightly.

“Bronzes first. Then Silvers, then Golds. One at a time—or in pairs if that is how you normally fight. Come at me intending to win. Holding back tells me something too.”

Silence, then a disbelieving laugh somewhere at the back.

“You can’t spar the whole guild,” someone muttered.

Shade smiled, very slightly.

“Try me,” he said.

They did.

Shade set his pace as he would for a battle whose end he could not yet see.

Some Bronzes approached nervously; others swaggered. Their borrowed stances came from instructors, tavern stories and misplaced confidence. Shade used only enough strength to expose a mistake without causing real harm.

A sun-browned girl charged with a chipped shortsword, swinging wildly. Shade caught her blade, turned her momentum against her and tapped the back of her knee with his flat. She landed in the sand with a startled grunt.

“You have courage,” he told her. “Keep it. But courage without a guard gets people killed. Watch before you strike. Work on that with your instructor, then try again.”

A boy held his spear as though it were a broom. Shade disarmed him in three movements, then took a moment to adjust the boy’s grip.

“Here and here. A spear gives you reach. Don’t choke it or let it pull you. Make it follow you.”

He stepped back. “Next.”

The Silvers presented a different challenge. Their mistakes were older, worn into habit. Shade gave them room to reveal those habits.

A laughing knife-fighter attacked with more flair than caution. Shade slipped past her flourishes and clipped her wrist with the flat of his blade. One knife spun into the sand.

“Your rhythm is good,” he said as she cursed. “Your left hand gives you away after the third flourish. Change it before an enemy learns to anticipate you.”

Another Silver was older, with a scar across one cheek, an axe and a shield. Shade met his steady assault with a longer exchange of ringing blows before slipping past the shield and stopping his sword just short of the man’s throat.

“Solid,” Shade said with a nod. “You move as though you know where your squad stands. Keep that.”

By the time the Golds approached, the mood had changed.

The watchers had fallen quiet except for the occasional wince or impressed whistle. Someone had begun calling the session “the Black sign,” half as a joke—as though being summoned onto the sand by an onyx-badged guildmaster were an omen.

The phrase spread almost immediately.

The first Gold was a lithe woman carrying a quarterstaff, tattoos winding down both arms. She circled with professional caution.

“You know this is unnecessary, Guildmaster,” she said. “Our records—”

“Then show me,” he replied, moving before she could finish.

The Golds pressed him harder than the others. He welcomed the challenge.

For each opponent, he made the smallest adjustment required.

A hammer fighter threatened to crush whatever he struck. Shade stayed beyond the weight of each blow until the man’s arms tired, then dropped him with a precise strike to the ankle.

A mage entered with a staff and wards flickering around her fingers. Shade allowed three spells, studied the timing, then used the gust from her fourth to slip inside her guard.

“I am not trying to humiliate you,” he told her when she scowled. “I allowed magic because you rely on it. I needed to see whether fear disrupts your habits. It did not. That matters.”

The final Gold left the sand bruised and breathless, grinning through a split lip. By then the whole hall had seen the same thing.

Their Black-ranked guildmaster neither shouted nor boasted. He offered corrections when needed, but spent most of the morning watching.

He watched.

He measured.

He gave each adventurer enough pressure to reveal their strengths—and the weaknesses that might one day cost a life.

At midday, the silence around him had changed. It was no longer the uncertainty of his first days in Lana’s chair. It held the wary respect people gave a storm they could see approaching.

“He’s a Black sign,” a Bronze whispered as Shade passed. “If he calls your squad onto the sand, you’re on his board. For the serious work.”

He did not correct them.

They were not entirely wrong.

The afternoon brought quieter work, no less important for its lack of swords.

Shade returned to Lana’s office and its ledgers, the morning’s sparring leaving a few bruises beneath his shirt. He found them oddly reassuring.

The names on the pages now came with faces, stances and the sound of boots striking sand. The records felt less abstract.

Wolves’ Howl first.

He opened their page and rested his fingertips against its corner.

The latest report was a tangle of corrections: “Objective failed. Cave system larger than briefed. Goblin numbers underestimated. Squad withdrew under heavy pressure. Two injured; no fatalities.” Beneath it, Lana had written: “Review assignments. Overconfidence and poor scouting. Preventable failures.”

Shade remembered the captain from the morning’s sparring: broad-shouldered, tense with anger, swinging as though he could strike the word failed from the record.

Caravan duty would bruise his pride.

That was part of the point.

Shade pulled a fresh sheet toward him.

To: Captain Deren, Wolves’ Howl

Subject: Temporary Assignment — Southern and Eastern Routes

For the next two tendays, your squad will escort caravans on the southern and eastern routes, rotating according to the attached schedule. This is neither a demotion nor a punishment.

Your last assignment demanded decisions based on poor maps and incomplete intelligence. Escort duty will give you changing conditions to manage without sending you into another uncharted nest. Use the time to rebuild discipline, communication and patience. We will review your performance at the end of the assignment.

—Guildmaster Shade

He sanded the ink and sealed the letter.

Next: Wind Dancers.

Their records offered a contrast: mages, two druids and a ranger, with a history of clever solutions and well-timed support. Lana’s approving marks crowded the margins. Shade had watched them move that morning—agile and observant, less formidable in a direct clash than in avoiding one altogether.

A routine escort would waste their talents.

Reconnaissance of bandit territory would not.

Shade started another letter.

To: Captain Mirenne, Wind Dancers

Subject: Reconnaissance and Mapping — Outer Woodlands

Beginning tomorrow, your squad is assigned to observation and scouting along the northern and western treelines. Locate suspected bandit camps, map approaches, estimate their strength and note any signs of cult or demonic activity.

Engage only if you have no safe alternative. Mobility and awareness are your advantages; use them. I need maps and reports another squad can act on without walking into surprises.

Report daily by sending or in writing, as circumstances permit.

—Guildmaster Shade

He attached the latest sightings and marked the areas that troubled him.

The remaining assignments followed the same principle.

Teams that had grown too comfortable were moved toward work that would challenge rather than break them. Eager Bronzes accompanied steadier Silvers as additional hands. A weary Gold party received a week of low-risk city duty, overseeing a warehouse boundary dispute so tedious it might remind them why peace was worth protecting.

His tutors had taught logistics with stones on maps and neat columns of numbers.

These numbers had faces.

His hand cramped again by late afternoon, and his eyes ached from deciphering other people's handwriting. Yet the assignment board was taking on a pattern he recognised.

Weak points supported. Strong teams repositioned. Overstretched people given room to recover.

A network that could bend without breaking.

He pinned the last order beside Lana's desk and stepped back.

Alone, he tried to imagine what she would say.

She would probably roll her eyes and call him a show-off. Later, perhaps, he would find a line in the margin of a report: "Your caravan rotation kept two merchants alive. Annoyingly effective."

He smiled despite himself.

Shade cleaned his pen, extinguished the candle he had lit for the comfort of its flame, and gathered the orders for the clerk.

The corridors felt different when he emerged.

Adventurers no longer fell silent because they did not know what to make of him. They gave him the careful space people left around a working forge: respect mixed with a healthy awareness of the heat.

He did not mind.

He had endured storms, fire and enemies far worse than a difficult guild.

If they insisted on calling him the Black sign—an omen, a warning or a promise—he would give the name meaning.

When he put his name to an order, it would mean he had considered the people who would carry it out. He would not waste their lives.

Chapter 16: Sparring and the Blood Reavers

The next morning's sparring ended as the previous day's had begun: with sweat in Shade's eyes and sand in his boots.

Not everyone had attended the first Black-sign session. Shade summoned the stragglers—squads returning late, night owls, and those who had somehow missed the announcement—and faced them one by one until his shoulders ached. The instructors watched with the wary expressions of people calculating how long their guildmaster would need to recover.

He had just sent the last breathless Bronze back to the line when the training-hall door opened, and a familiar voice cut through the smell of sand and steel.

"Guildmaster," Arcebek called, voice lilting with amusement. "Are you done terrifying the children?"

He turned.

Arcebek stood in the doorway, staff balanced over one shoulder, dark braid trailing down her back. In her free hand she carried a picnic basket large enough to provision a siege. The mischief in her smile completed the picture.

"That depends," Shade said, nodding toward the basket. "Should they be afraid of that?"

A ripple of laughter moved through the room.

Arcebek turned her head toward the laughter, listening to the change in the room, and smiled with evident satisfaction.

"You," she said to Shade, "are coming with me. Now. Before you decide to spar with the furniture as well."

He glanced toward the instructors. One raised both hands and retreated two exaggerated paces.

"Training hall is yours, Guildmaster," he said cheerfully. "Try not to break anything on your way out."

Shade gave up.

The hill beneath the old windmill had become theirs without anyone quite deciding it should.

It lay just beyond the city, far enough for the streets to fade to a distant murmur. The windmill's stone base offered shelter from the breeze, while long grass rippled beneath a sky strewn with slow-moving clouds.

Arcebek spread the blanket with practiced hands, smoothing its edges before settling where she could feel the breeze on her face. Shade watched an escaped strand of hair brush her cheek, then remembered the basket in his hands.

"When you said lunch," he admitted as he sat beside her, "I expected something smaller."

Arcebek laughed. "I have never been accused of doing anything by halves. Besides, you keep forgetting to eat. Consider this an intervention."

She wasn't wrong.

The contents of the basket made her point more thoroughly than any lecture could.

There was oven-warm bread, cheese, slices of cold spiced meat, pickled vegetables, and a jar of the honey-sweet spread Rakihi had recently become obsessed with. A bottle of wine nestled among the dishes, plainly intended to be shared at leisure.

They ate in the comfortable silence of people who had long since stopped mistaking quiet for distance.

Arcebek asked for guild gossip. Shade offered Harven's expression during the council meeting, the junior clerks drilling without being ordered, Wolves' Howl's caravan assignment, and the Wind Dancers disappearing into the woods with maps and unearned confidence.

She hummed her appreciation, laughing outright when he reached the more theatrical collapses from the Bronze sparring sessions.

"And your week?" he asked. "Any extraplanar horror demanding ownership of Tuesdays? An eldritch audit, perhaps?"

"Quiet," she said, in the tone of someone who knew the word was temporary. "Paperwork. Scrying for my employers. A letter from an imp that smelled of sulphur and bad intentions."

He raised a brow.

"I sent it back with an invoice," she added. "If they want my attention, they can pay for it."

Shade laughed despite himself.

As the food disappeared and the wine bottle grew lighter, the wind rose and settled again. Eventually Shade stretched out on the blanket, Arcebek reclining against his chest, her head beneath his chin as her fingers wandered along his forearm.

They did not talk about guild politics then.

She told him about tasting proper coffee in a city three kingdoms away and nearly selling her soul for a reliable supply. He recalled a tutor at the Blue Court who insisted that generals must understand movement that did not end in blood—and had therefore attempted to teach him to dance.

"Not hopeless," she judged after hearing how he had stepped on three noble toes in one evening. "Stiff, certainly. But trainable."

"I feel very reassured," he deadpanned.

"And for the record," she added, prodding his ribs, "a hilltop lunch with one lover is not favouritism. It is a tactical retreat. If all three of us tried to claim you during the day, the guild would never see you again."

He considered objecting. The case against him was rather strong.

Their kiss was unhurried, born of contentment rather than urgency. It might have led somewhere less suitable for an exposed hillside, had they not both known the guild would eventually come looking for him.

When the shadows lengthened and only the last honest mouthful of wine remained, Arcebek sat up with a sigh.

"Back to the wolves, then," she said.

"Some of them are quite disciplined," he replied.

"Mmh. You keep telling yourself that."

They returned to the guild carrying an empty basket and the scent of sun-warmed grass.

They had barely crossed the entrance hall when a runner skidded to a stop, flushed and breathless.

“Guildmaster! Oh, thank the gods, you’re here. We have a… situation.”

Arcebek’s mouth twitched. “Of course we do,” she murmured.

Shade adjusted his grip on the empty basket. “What kind of situation?”

“The Blood Reavers, sir. They cleared a bandit camp—no trouble there—but celebrated afterward. There was a brawl at the Copper Tankard.”

Shade rubbed the bridge of his nose. The all-female Blood Reavers were efficient and ruthless in the field, and just as enthusiastic when enjoying a night off.

“Anyone hurt?” he asked.

“Mostly pride, sir. And some furniture. The watch has them in a holding room. They asked whether you might collect your adventurers before they have to start filing reports.”

Arcebek made a thoughtful noise, turning her head toward where Shade was breathing.

“Well,” she said. “Lunch was nice while it lasted.”

The watch barracks smelled of stale sweat, old timber, and the particular frustration of people whose shift should have ended an hour ago.

Through the holding-room window, Shade spotted four women lounging on benches with the careless assurance of lions confined to a kennel.

Sera, their captain, wore a split lip and the expression of someone convinced she had won the argument regardless of the outcome. The others bore bruises that suggested they had contributed enthusiastically.

A sergeant met them in the corridor, helmet under one arm, his expression carefully neutral.

“Guildmaster. Warlock.” He nodded to each. “No blades drawn, so by city standards it was minor. Three chairs broken, two tankards smashed, and a bard who may never forgive them. I would rather not spend the evening on forms.”

“You have our eternal gratitude,” Arcebek said dryly.

Shade studied the women for another moment.

“Open it,” he said.

The sergeant unlocked the door and stepped aside with an expression that suggested he expected excellent entertainment.

The Blood Reavers looked up as the door swung inward.

“Guildmaster,” Sera said, rising with a half-bow. Her disordered braids undermined the attempted dignity. “We were just—”

“Celebrating,” Shade supplied. “I heard.”

Behind him, Arcebek folded her arms. Her voice was mild enough to make Shade straighten instinctively.

“Celebration is permitted. A brawl that brings the watch running is another matter. Do you recall our little conversation about choosing your battles and not turning every tavern into a war zone?”

One Reaver started to speak. Arcebek angled her head toward the voice.

“Before you answer, consider whether you would enjoy hearing your excuse repeated at the next guild assembly.”

Every mouth closed.

Sera’s defiance diminished, though it did not disappear.

“We cleared the bandit nest ahead of schedule. Fewer injuries than the last squad. People at the Tankard bought us drinks, then some fool made a remark about where women with swords belonged, and—”

“You showed him,” Arcebek finished. “Naturally.”

Shade exhaled slowly.

“I won’t tell you to stand quietly while someone threatens you,” Shade said. “If someone lays hands on you, you can defend yourselves. If bystanders are in danger, put a stop to it. That much is clear.”

He met each woman’s eyes before continuing.

“But you represent the guild. Once chairs fly and musicians get knocked over, the story becomes ‘guild adventurers wrecked a tavern.’ The insult that started it will vanish in the retelling. Which version do you think the city will remember?”

The youngest Reaver winced. At least one of them understood.

“We cannot control every rumour,” he said. “We can avoid giving people a convenient truth to build lies around.”

“Besides,” Arcebek observed, “you exchanged a perfectly good celebration for an evening in a holding cell. A tragic waste of opportunity.”

That got a reluctant laugh from at least two of them.

Shade let his mouth twitch.

“Here is what happens next. You apologise to the innkeeper and pay for the damage, including anything the watch has missed. You need not apologise for protecting yourselves, but you will make it plain that the guild does not approve of destroying other people’s property.”

He paused.

“For the next week, day-shift assignments only. Consider it a temporary curfew.”

Groans.

“Guildmaster,” Sera protested. “That’s—”

“A consequence,” Arcebek said sweetly. “A gentle one. Unless you would prefer kitchen duty.”

That shut them up.

The sergeant coughed into his hand, suspiciously close to a laugh.

“Are we clear?” Shade asked.

The Reavers muttered agreement. Sera managed a reluctant “Yes, Guildmaster.”

“Good. You’re free to go. Try to last a tenday before your next performance. Some of us have paperwork to finish.”

As they filed past, one of them—bruised, grinning—murmured, “Nice to know the new boss still comes to bail us out.”

Shade raised an eyebrow. “I came to spare the sergeant his paperwork,” he said. “This time.”

She smiled wider and scurried after her captain.

That evening, the manor felt less like a house than a comfortable den.

They gathered in the main room with plates balanced on their knees. Rakihi draped herself over the sofa arm; Elcia sat beside the hearth; and Shade found himself wedged between Arcebek’s thigh and a cushion with a determination to escape.

“Tell us again,” Rakihi demanded, halfway through her second cup. “Especially the part where you scolded the Blood Reavers like schoolchildren.”

“I did not—” Shade began.

“You absolutely did,” Arcebek said. “Very attractively, too. They’ll remember that lecture for weeks.”

Elcia’s mouth twitched. “I removed them from my patrol rotation last month. I would prefer not to see them in the watch’s holding cells again.”

Rakihi threw an arm over her eyes in theatrical despair.

“Wine on a hill. A private sparring session. A picnic basket. The favouritism is breathtaking.”

“It was not a sparring demonstration,” Shade said, exasperated. “We ate.”

“And drank,” Arcebek supplied, entirely unhelpfully.

“And lounged beneath a windmill,” Rakihi continued, peering between her fingers. “What a scandal. I may never recover.”

“You can have a turn,” Arcebek said, amused. “Schedule it with my secretary.”

“We don’t have a secretary,” Shade pointed out.

“We do now,” Rakihi said. “Me. Elcia, surely you can see the injustice.”

Elcia considered him over her folded knees, clear eyes giving away almost nothing.

“I admit,” she said at last, “to a certain amount of jealousy.”

Shade blinked.

“You are?”

“Yes,” she said. “Arcebek gets a hill and a windmill and wine. I get paperwork discussions and occasional undead. I intend to remedy this.”

“Remedy how?” he asked, wary.

“A walk. A picnic. Perhaps a little training.” Her smile deepened. “You have yet to learn what a paladin considers light exercise.”

Rakihi crowed with delight. “And I’m stealing him for an afternoon of ballad revisions. Three of them. Then we’re visiting the pastry stall by the east gate. As guildmaster, Shade is obliged to support local businesses.”

Shade looked between them, helpless.

“I appear to be getting allocated by committee,” he said.

“Indeed,” Arcebek replied. “The true burden of command.”

He laughed, lightheartedly this time.

They exchanged stories until the candles burned low: Arcebek’s contracts gone sideways, Rakihi’s drunken patron who had requested a nonexistent song and accidentally inspired a new one, and Elcia’s justice dispute in which both claimants were equally at fault.

Each time the hill came up, Rakihi invented another scandalous detail. By the time she claimed the pair had rolled down the slope entwined, even Arcebek was laughing too hard to object.

Shade lay back against the cushions and watched them.

There was Arcebek, hands tracing precise shapes in the air as she explained the etiquette of insulting extraplanar beings. Rakihi, bright-eyed and irrepressible, planning a revenge picnic as carefully as a campaign. Elcia, quietly amused, already deciding what to pack and which route would spare them the city’s mud.

He had councils and ledgers and sparring schedules waiting in the morning.

Tomorrow would bring bandit reports, the threat of demons, and another attempt to keep the guild upright without Lana.

But tonight offered something else.

Petty jealousy over picnics. Exaggerated scandal. Promises of worse mischief to come. A life with room for play, even when duty crowded close.

For one evening, the chaos seemed almost impossibly good.

Chapter 17: The Quiet Work

The day after the picnic and the tavern rescue began with an almost insulting ordinariness.

Shade distrusted it on principle.

At dawn, he passed new notes to the trainers, confirmed that Wolves' Howl and the Wind Dancers had received their assignments, then shut himself in Lana's office with enough parchment to bury the desk.

Yesterday had been about the guild's fighters. Today he would examine what held them together.

Reports, first.

He worked through patrol logs, mission reports, supply tallies, and a temple writ politely noting that the shrine on Farside Street still had kobolds in its basement.

He sorted the work into three piles: urgent, soon, and can wait. The last was depressingly small.

Gold, next.

The senior clerk arrived with ledgers and a slate. Together they picked through mission fees, city stipends, and private contracts, then the costs of repairs, healing, hazard pay, equipment, food, and bunkroom upkeep. A few entries labelled "expedited processing" were suspiciously close to bribes.

Shade traced the columns, hunting for sudden spikes and figures that failed to make sense.

"How much leeway do we have if winter hits hard?" he asked at one point.

The clerk worked through the sums, grimaced, and gave him a figure low enough to make the destruction of a few well-insured noble warehouses sound briefly appealing.

"Understood." He added a note: Discuss grain reserves with Harven. Do not let him wriggle out of it.

When the clerk left, he went to the infirmary.

Warm and quiet, the infirmary smelled of boiled herbs and old timber. He went from bed to bed, matching the injuries before him to the accounts he had read: a broken leg from a ravine fall, a mage's arm bound in silver-threaded bandages, a ranger with cracked ribs who insisted he was perfectly well.

Shade had no stirring speech for them. Instead, he asked what had happened, what had surprised them, and which warning might have made the difference. Then he listened—even when the answers were uncomfortable.

By late afternoon he was back behind Lana's desk, ink on his fingers and golden light slanting through the windows.

The last file in the day's stack was stamped with a familiar sigil: a snarling iron wolf's head over crossed spears.

The Panzer Jägers.

Inside he found exactly what he expected, and precisely what annoyed him.

Their reports read like insults hurled at the enemy. The damage tallies would have made a quartermaster weep. Notes written in several hands all reached much the same conclusion.

Strength: exceptional in direct confrontation. Excellent morale. Hold positions that other squads would abandon.

Weakness: hold positions that ought to be abandoned.

Shade rubbed his forehead.

The Jägers were the guild's armoured wall: stubborn, heavily equipped, and disinclined to dodge anything they could withstand. They excelled at breaking fortifications, pushing demons back into binding circles, and confronting creatures too tough for clever tactics alone.

That reputation was earned. According to the margins, it had also nearly killed them twice in the past year.

He flipped to the most recent mission.

Objective: reinforce village under orc raid threat.

The summary was terse: "We arrived. They hit us. We hit back. They stopped. Walls need work."

Lana's note beneath it read: "Broke the raiders. Also half the palisade. Assign where collateral damage is acceptable."

Shade snorted under his breath.

The roster listed familiar names from sparring and hallway encounters. Their captain was a broad-shouldered dwarf whose shield could serve as a door and whose laughter grew louder as trouble approached.

Facing trouble head-on was their speciality. And, apparently, their only tactic.

Shade leaned back and imagined the map of the region.

Where did he need an indestructible wall that refused to move?

Not caravan work: too constricted. Not scouting: a waste of their strength. Certainly not city security, unless he wanted complaints about walls and doors being treated as optional obstacles.

Siege points, though.

Or missions where breaking formation would mean disaster.

He wrote in the margin: Reserve Jägers for demon incursions and fortified cult sites. Pair with a disciplined support squad. Drill holding positions rather than pursuing kills.

His quill tapped the paper.

"Someone must teach you," he murmured at the file, "that being an excellent hammer does not make every problem a nail."

By the time he finished, the sunlight had faded from gold to copper.

The office darkened around him. The wards hummed at the edge of his awareness, and a distant door closed somewhere down the corridor.

He was halfway through drafting the Jägers' next assignment when he noticed someone in the doorway.

She didn't knock.

Elcia leaned against the frame, arms loosely folded, as though she had been there for some time. Her hair was braided back, with a few pale strands escaping into the last light. Out of armour, she still possessed the alert calm of a paladin who could make a crowded room seem silent.

“You know,” she said, “we have established that the guild will survive if you leave this office before dark.”

Shade looked up, quill hovering over the page.

“Elcia,” he said. “I didn’t hear you.”

“I can tell,” she said dryly. “That is rather why I came.”

He blinked at her.

“Are you… on duty?” he asked. “I wasn’t aware of any—”

“My watch shift ended an hour ago. I am now off duty as a paladin, on duty as a jealous lover, and concerned as a citizen.”

“Jealous?” he repeated, thrown.

She stepped into the room, the corner of her mouth quirking upward.

“You and Arcebek had your hill. Rakihi has plans involving pastries and scandal. If you fall asleep over these ledgers and miss both, I shall have words with Lana about her guildmaster experiment.”

He felt himself flush, absurdly. “I was not planning to fall asleep here,” he said. “I only meant to—”

“One more report,” she supplied. “And after that?”

He did not have a good answer.

She came around the desk. At close range he could see the tiredness beneath her eyes and a new notch on her belt—a trace of some duty carried out on her watch.

“Which squad is that?” she asked, nodding toward the open file.

“The Panzer Jägers. Our heavily armoured line-breakers.”

“Ah. The ones who take retreat as a personal insult.”

“Those,” he agreed.

She hummed. “You were talking to them.”

“I was… thinking aloud,” he said.

“Yes,” she agreed. “To them.”

He shrugged, a little helplessly.

“If they ignore the advice when I give it to them,” he said, “perhaps it will have more authority in writing.”

Elcia smiled, warm and amused.

“You are an exceedingly strange man,” she said. “Fortunately, I like that.”

He opened his mouth to protest being called strange, then closed it again. She was not wrong.

For a moment they simply stood there, the quiet of the office folding around them.

Then Elcia reached out and, very gently, plucked the quill from his fingers.

“Enough. The council meets tomorrow. Your mind will serve you better if it has not turned to ink and numbers.”

“I still have to—”

“You have done enough,” she said firmly. “If you keep going, you will make mistakes, then stay late to correct them. I can carry you home if necessary, but I would rather not have to.”

“I am not that heavy,” he muttered.

“Emotionally,” she said gravely, “you are quite heavy.”

He choked on a laugh.

“Come. Walk with me while there is still colour in the sky. I promise to keep my lectures on justice to a minimum.”

He glanced at the unfinished Jägers file, its last lines of ink still drying.

Then he looked at Elcia, who was not asking him to abandon his work, only to remember there was a life beyond it.

“Very well,” he said. “Before I congeal.”

“Wise,” she said.

At the door, she rose on her toes and stole a quick, almost shy kiss from the corner of his mouth.

It surprised him more than any order she had ever given in battle.

He caught her hand before she could retreat and kissed her properly, slow and warm. Her lips tasted faintly of the mint tea she drank between shifts.

“That makes two,” he murmured when they parted.

Her eyes widened, then crinkled with delight.

“You are counting?”

“Only because you started,” he replied, feeling the day’s tension finally ease.

She stole the third on the threshold, where anyone passing might have seen them.

No one did.

They walked home shoulder to shoulder through the cooling streets. Behind them, the unfinished files lay safely on Lana’s desk, waiting for a guildmaster who would return in the morning.

Tomorrow would bring another council meeting and another careful dance around power.

Tonight, Elcia led him toward the manor and the voices beyond its door, where Rakihi was already complaining about the unfair advantages of paladin dates.

For the first time all week, he approached home without feeling he had left something essential undone.

He was simply going where he belonged.

Chapter 18: A Council of Small Fires

The council had adapted.

There were no blunt demands this time, no grand proposals concealing obvious traps.

Instead, they brought work. A great deal of it.

“Before we move to larger matters,” the Lord of Trade said with an air of weary benevolence, “there are several small questions on which the guild’s guidance would be valuable.”

“Of course,” Shade said, already suspicious.

The questions came one after another.

A border village had lost livestock to something that might be wolves. Two merchant houses disputed who deserved exclusive guild escorts on market days. The masons requested adventurers for a collapsed sewer tunnel. A minor shrine sought help with a haunting the main temple considered beneath its notice.

Every problem was small.

Every one was important enough that neglect would make him appear incompetent.

Shade recognised the tactic within half an hour: bury him beneath pebbles until he lost sight of the boulders.

He answered each request on its merits.

“Send a ranger, a druid, and a reliable Silver squad to investigate the livestock losses. If they find wolves, advise the village on fences. If it is something else, we act.”

“Guild escorts are assigned according to risk and availability, not a merchant’s pride. Anyone wanting guaranteed protection can negotiate a long-term contract under guild terms.”

“We are not builders. But if the sewer collapse threatens the street above, it is a public-safety matter. I can release a team for two days at the usual hazard rate.”

“Give the haunting to a novice priest and a Bronze team with an appetite for ghost stories. If it is minor, they gain experience. If not, they report back.”

They kept coming.

Eventually Shade realised the councillors were testing more than his patience.

They wanted to know whether he understood that the petty and tedious matters—the ones beneath the notice of heroes—were what kept a city standing.

He understood perfectly.

That did not make the hours pass any faster.

During a debate over whether guild funds should pay to repair a collapsed bridge “for the good of trade,” a lesser noble named Lord Vess made the mistake of underestimating Shade’s exhaustion.

“Naturally,” Vess drawled, “someone of adventuring stock may find it difficult to appreciate the obligations of noble birth. Duty to one’s lineage is rather different from duty to one’s purse.”

It was hardly the sharpest insult Shade had heard.

Others had delivered far worse with far sweeter smiles.

But after hours of petitions and financial arguments, his patience was worn thin. His temper was closer to the surface than he cared to admit.

He replied before he could stop himself.

“I am a noble as well,” Shade said evenly. “Of a considerably older court than yours, Lord Vess.”

The chamber fell silent.

His words seemed to hang in the air long after he wished them back.

Vess blinked. “I—pardon?”

Too late. Vess was not the only one listening. An archivist with an interest in old bloodlines leaned forward. The High Priest studied him with sudden care. Harven’s eyes narrowed.

They had long suspected there was more to Shade than the guild had revealed.

Stories of dragons had a way of escaping their tellers.

But suspicion was one thing. Hearing Shade claim ancient nobility with such easy certainty was another.

The old instinct stirred: Be discreet. Blend in. Mother will not be pleased.

That advice had arrived too late.

He could not take the words back.

So he chose to make them sound deliberate.

“The Blue Court,” he added conversationally. “We take infrastructure quite seriously. Bridges in particular. Supply lines do little good without them.”

Several councillors reacted to the name. One made a warding gesture beneath the table.

To most mortals, the Blue Court belonged half to legend and half to the uneasy realities of trade, storms, and ancient obligations. Its name carried a weight that polite society seldom spoke of openly.

Shade offered Vess a smile emptied of all warmth.

“I understand the obligations of birth. I also understand that another collapse could kill travellers and destroy the goods they carry. Repairing the bridge is not an act of noble generosity. It is common sense.”

Someone at the far end of the table stifled a laugh.

He knew the price would come later: invitations, discreet enquiries, and people deciding whether proximity to him was a privilege or a danger.

For now, there was still a meeting to finish.

When the council finally adjourned, Shade’s head throbbed. He could name at least three fresh problems he had created for himself.

The nobles departed in a rustle of expensive fabrics and lingering glances. Several wore the expressions of people already composing invitations.

Shade remained seated until the hall emptied, his palms flat against the table. Without the voices, the high-ceilinged chamber seemed cavernous.

He rose with an effort and made for the doors.

Outside, the late sky was washed with the colours between afternoon and dusk. Three figures waited on the council steps.

They were not councillors.

They were considerably more formidable.

Arcebek stood in her dark cloak, her braid glinting in the light. Rakihi wore a bright sweep of blue, one hip cocked in impatient amusement. Elcia waited at the edge of the steps, relaxed but watchful, ready to fall in beside him.

For a moment Shade could only stare.

He had spent much of his life leaving important rooms alone.

Finding them waiting for him sent a warmth through his chest so sudden he almost mistook it for alarm.

Rakihi spotted him first.

“There he is!” Rakihi announced, startling a few passers-by. “Our conquering war hero and suffering bureaucratic martyr.”

Arcebek tilted her head toward him and smiled. “Survived the avalanche of pebbles, I see.”

Elcia stepped forward and took his arm with quiet assurance.

Only then did he realise how badly he had needed it.

“Walk?” she suggested.

“Yes,” he answered, barely above a sigh.

Rakihi hooked herself around his other arm, cheek pressed briefly against his shoulder.

“You look as though the council tried to eat you with spoons,” Rakihi observed. “Did they?”

“In a manner of speaking,” he said.

Arcebek fell into step close beside them and rested a hand briefly against his back.

They crossed the square together. People looked, as people always did, but with his lovers beside him Shade found it easier to let the attention pass.

“What did they attempt this time?” Rakihi asked. “New taxes? A marriage proposal from someone with a splendid hat?”

“Please do not give them ideas,” Shade muttered.

He intended to describe the steady assault of small problems and the exhaustion of trying to do each one justice.

Instead, he heard himself say something else.

“I made a mistake.”

Arcebek's head tilted. "What kind of mistake?"

"The kind made with my mouth. In front of witnesses."

Rakihi gasped. "You insulted someone deliberately? Oh, I am proud."

"Not deliberately. Lord Vess suggested adventurers could not understand noble duty. I informed him that I too am a noble. From a much older court."

For a heartbeat, none of them spoke.

Then Rakihi burst out laughing.

"Shade!" she managed between laughs. "You did not."

"I did. They already suspected enough. Now I have practically confirmed it for them."

Elcia's grip tightened, just for a moment.

"Dangerous?" she asked. "Or merely inconvenient?"

He considered that. "Inconvenient for now. Dangerous if someone decides to provoke the Blue Court to discover what the claim means."

"They were already trying to place you," Arcebek said. "Now they will ask different questions. And perhaps you were tired of being treated as an upstart mercenary."

He huffed. "I don't care what they call me."

"Liar," Rakihi sing-songed.

He didn't dignify that.

"It is done. I shall deal with the consequences: invitations, probing questions, and attempts to connect someone's distinguished ancestry to mine."

"We shall deal with them," Arcebek corrected gently.

The quiet certainty of it eased a knot in his stomach.

"Tonight," Rakihi declared, "you are forbidden to think of nobles, courts, bridges, or anyone wearing a hat that cannot be eaten."

"I do not—why would I eat a hat?" he demanded.

"Metaphor," she said loftily. "Keep up."

They turned into the quieter street leading to the manor. The air carried the smells of evening meals, damp stone, and distant chimney smoke.

Rakihi squeezed his arm and leaned close, lowering her voice into a theatrical purr with a decidedly sincere edge.

"First we feed you. Then we take turns discovering how thoroughly we can erase the word council from that exhausted mind of yours."

"Rakihi," Elcia protested mildly, though her mouth twitched.

"He looks like a kicked puppy," Rakihi defended herself. "A very large, dangerous kicked puppy. Clearly he requires our attention."

“Sacred?” Arcebek echoed, amused.

“Certainly. Ask my goddess of Chaos and Questionable Timing.”

Shade felt his face warm. To his surprise, the embarrassment was not unpleasant.

“You do not have to—” he began.

“We know,” Arcebek cut in. “That’s half the fun.”

“You told a roomful of ambitious politicians that your bloodline predates theirs,” Arcebek said, nudging him. “I found that rather attractive. Surely it deserves a reward.”

“It was a tactical error,” he muttered.

“Mmm,” she said. “So is trusting me with that information.”

Their laughter followed them down the street, making the city around them feel less imposing.

By the manor gate, Rakihi had outlined an entirely fictional evening featuring several improbable positions and a scandalous quantity of whipped cream.

“None of that is physically possible,” Shade said weakly, halfway through.

“That is what training is for,” she shot back.

Elcia shook her head, smiling despite herself.

Inside, the minor elementals stirred to greet them. The house seemed to settle as all four crossed its threshold.

Shade lingered a moment in the entryway, Arcebek and Rakihi beside him and Elcia’s hand steady at his elbow.

Beyond the walls, the council chamber still waited, along with every obligation he had left there.

Here, Rakihi was already tugging off his cloak; Arcebek was insisting he remove his boots before he collapsed; and Elcia was heading for the kitchen, no doubt choosing between restorative tea and a wine that would not worsen his headache.

He had just told the city’s most powerful people that he belonged to a court older than their own.

Yet he had never felt more certain of where he belonged.

Chapter 19: What the Records Reveal

Shade spent the next morning bent over Lana's desk, his collar pulled higher than usual.

The faint sting of fairy bites along his collarbones flared whenever he shifted.

Rakihi had very sharp teeth when properly motivated.

He did his best not to dwell on the reason.

The reports, at least, offered a distraction.

Today's stack covered three Gold-ranked squads: three very different kinds of elite, each with its own preferences, failings, and quiet legends buried in the margins.

First came the Iron Hands. Shield-and-spear specialists, masters of defensive warfare, led by a former city guard with an unshakable hatred of chaos. Their discipline looked almost dull on paper—until Shade noticed how often they had returned from disastrous assignments without losing a single member.

Next, the Stormbridge Company: mixed arms, plenty of elemental casters, and very little patience. Superb at short, brutal assaults. Terrible at holding a position for an hour without starting a fight.

Last was Crowfall. Scouts, archers, and knife-fighters who treated difficult terrain as an invitation. They excelled at heights, thrived in cities, and grew dangerous when bored.

Shade read through the files again, fitting each squad into the strategic picture taking shape in his head.

The Iron Hands could hold the line while the Panzer Jägers redeployed, anchor street defenses, or steady civilians in a crisis.

Stormbridge belonged at the point of an assault against demon nests and cult strongholds—preferably after the Wind Dancers or another scouting unit had mapped the approaches.

Crowfall could follow rumours through alleyways, hunt bandit officers across ruins, and keep knives away from anyone too valuable to lose.

He was midway through a rotation plan—active duty, reserves, and the sort of assignments that kept restless adventurers occupied—when an uncomfortable thought stopped his pen.

He knew the people now.

He understood how they fought, where they excelled, and where they might fail.

But he barely knew what they fought with.

Shade sat back, frowning.

Gear.

He had seen glimpses in the sparring hall: the Jägers' walking fortresses, the Wind Dancers' staves, the Blood Reavers' impressive collection of knives.

He had never considered the equipment as a whole.

On a battlefield, an army's equipment told its own story. Matching armour, maintained blades, reliable replacements—or the absence of all three—could reveal as much as any formation.

And Shade had yet to learn what his guild's equipment was telling him.

If a Panzer Jäger lost a shield, could the guild supply an equally sturdy replacement? Did Crowfall carry bows suited to each archer's draw strength? Were Stormbridge's casters using sound foci, or making do with cracked crystals because no one had thought to ask?

How many deaths filed away as unavoidable might have been prevented by a better piece of equipment?

His fingers tapped the desk.

He needed an audit of more than missions and personnel. Steel, leather, enchanted wood—everything.

He had begun outlining questions for the quartermaster and an inspection schedule that would not feel like a parade-ground humiliation when two small hands covered his eyes.

His muscles locked on instinct.

Then he caught a familiar scent: wildflowers, tavern smoke, and something sharp as the air before lightning.

"Guess who," Rakihi breathed in his ear, entirely too close and entirely too pleased with herself.

"You are the only one short enough to reach my eyes from this angle without standing on a chair," he said.

She made an offended little sound. "Rude. Accurate, but rude."

Her hands withdrew, though she remained close. She slipped around the chair and draped herself over its arm, pale hair spilling across her shoulder.

"You promised me a picnic," she announced. "Before Arcebek stole you for hers. I refuse to be outdone by a blind warlock with good taste in bread."

"I never said—"

"You did. Or you implied it. You said, 'Yes, we can do that,' and then came demons, councils, bar fights, and noble courts. I waited very graciously until you stopped looking half-dead. I am done waiting."

He opened his mouth to argue.

The bite marks beneath his collar supplied a compelling reason not to.

"Fine. I need to leave this room before the ink seeps into my bones."

"Excellent." She was instantly on her feet again, already turning for the door. "I have food. And wine. And plans."

"…How long have you been waiting outside the office?" he asked, dubious.

She glanced back over her shoulder, slit-pupiled eyes dancing.

"Long enough," she said.

Rakihi's idea of a picnic was closer to a travelling feast prepared for an attack by raccoons—or minor demons—than a quiet lunch outdoors.

She took him away from the windmill. "That's yours and Bek's hill," she insisted, refusing to steal it for herself. Instead, she chose a rise overlooking the city from the opposite side.

There was no windmill here, only grass, a few stubborn bushes, and a view of rooftops spilling toward the river as though a god had shaken the city out of a bag.

They stretched out on the grass to eat, with Rakihi talking almost as quickly as she chewed.

She told him about her mother's court, glittering and treacherous, where music concealed threats and compliments hid knives. She remembered the first mortal bard she had heard—hopelessly out of tune but possessed of a sincerity fey musicians could never quite imitate—and admitted which halls she had deliberately gotten herself barred from as a teenager, simply to escape her mother's parties.

In return, Shade spoke of the Blue Court's winter dances: halls filled with stormlight and silk, bargains moving beneath the music, and the lessons he had spent tracing supply routes across maps marked with stars older and hungrier than mortal gods.

"See?" she said at one point, jabbing a bit of bread at his chest. "You're a noble. I knew it. You sulk like one."

"I do not sulk," he said. "I… glower."

"That is just sulking with better posture."

The food vanished. The sun began its stubborn descent. Eventually, Shade lay on his back with Rakihi half across his chest, her head on his shoulder while one finger traced idle patterns through his shirt.

"You know," she murmured, "we are in a very public place for someone with your reputation."

"There is no one here," he pointed out.

"Yet," she said. "But imagine the songs if some poor shepherd crests that hill right now and sees the Black Guildmaster being ravished by a fairy on his lunch break."

"Ravished," he repeated flatly.

"Shamelessly," she confirmed.

Before he could object, she rolled over him in one fluid motion, settling astride his hips with her hands braced on his shoulders.

He froze.

"Rakihi," he said carefully. "This is not—"

"Appropriate?" she supplied, grinning. "Scandalous? Delicious?"

"Private," he said. "It is not private."

"Is that a no?" she asked. Beneath the teasing lay a genuine question.

He considered her, the ruthless sunlight, and the horizon visible in every direction.

"It is a… redirect," he said finally.

Her brows arched.

"Redirect?"

He sat up, bringing her with him, and turned until his back faced the city and she perched precariously in his lap.

"Rakihi," he said, his hands settling at her waist, "I don't mind scandal. But there are kinds of attention I refuse to draw to you. To any of us."

For an instant, the mischief left her eyes.

“Ah,” she said softly. “That kind of redirect.”

“Yes,” he said.

She studied him, lips pursed, then sighed and dropped her forehead against his shoulder.

Then she sighed dramatically and flopped forward, her forehead thumping against his shoulder.

“You are… incredibly annoying,” she declared into his shirt.

“I am aware,” he said.

She laughed into his shirt, the sound warm against his chest.

“Fine,” she sighed. “No ravishing on the hill. Yet. I will simply have to contain myself until we find a dark alley.”

“Rakihi—”

He didn’t get to finish.

She did, however, pull him into a dark alley on their way home.

It was a harmless enough passage between two buildings, away from the main thoroughfare. Damp stone and cooking smoke filled the narrow space; Rakihi knew better than to wander into the city's less welcoming corners.

“This,” she announced, shoving him gently but firmly back against the cool brick, “is at least semi-private.”

“Rakihi,” he tried again, half-laughing now despite himself. “If someone—”

“Then they get a very educational view of how much fun their local guildmaster is having,” she said, and kissed him before he could marshal anything resembling an argument.

It was… not subtle.

It was, however, effective.

He kept the encounter safely short of becoming another guild legend. Their clothes stayed on; his hands remained, more or less, respectable. But there was nothing restrained about her teeth catching his lower lip, or the pleased sound she made when he finally threaded his fingers into her hair and drew her closer.

When she drew back, breathing hard, she rested her forehead against his and laughed in triumph.

“See,” she murmured. “Barely scandalous. You survived.”

“My self-control,” he said, a little raggedly, “is becoming a tactical asset.”

“Disgusting,” she informed him. “And true. Come on. If we're any later, Bek will think I've stolen you for a ritual and start charging her patrons triple to make up for the distraction.”

That evening, Shade returned to Lana’s office with faintly swollen lips and fresh teeth marks along his shoulder. He sank into his chair and brought the equipment question back to the top of the pile.

He started a fresh page.

Equipment Audit – Priority Squads

Panzer Jägers – shields, plate, reinforcement. Check for fatigue fractures.

Iron Hands – spearheads, shield integrity, formation drills.

Crowfall – bowstrings, spare bows, climbing gear quality.

Stormbridge – foci, wands, staffwork, insulation charms for close allies.

Blood Reavers – knives. Gods, so many knives. Coordinate with armoury on legal limits.

Wind Dancers – staves, mobility gear, emergency potions.

He wrote until the daylight faded and the candle burned low, settling into the meditative rhythm of planning.

By the time he headed home, armour weights and replacement schedules were marching through his head.

The manor greeted him with a comforting jumble of voices.

Rakihi spotted him first, of course.

“There he is,” she crowed, pointing accusingly with a spoon. “The coward who wouldn’t let me make him a public cautionary tale.”

Arcebek, lounging sideways in a chair with a cup between her hands, raised a brow. “Oh?” she asked. “Did he refuse to be ravished on a hill?”

“Twice,” Rakihi said, scandalized. “Hill and alley. Do you know how much work it is to find a dark corner in this city that doesn’t smell like feet and old onions?”

Elcia, at the table polishing a pauldron, looked up with an expression that hovered between amused and approving.

“I am… relieved,” she said. “I prefer our legends to be more about demon-slaying and less about public indecency fines.”

Rakihi gasped. “Traitor. You’re supposed to be on my side.”

“I am on the side of not having to arrest my own guildmaster,” Elcia replied calmly.

All three turned toward Shade. He realised too late that he had walked into a tribunal.

“I…” he began.

“Don’t worry,” Arcebek cut in, smile slow and wicked. “You’ll get other chances to make the ballads more… colourful. Preferably somewhere with doors that lock.”

Rakihi brightened immediately. “Oh, absolutely,” she said. “I’m just getting started. Besides, the best scandal isn’t the one everyone sees. It’s the one everyone suspects.”

Shade pinched the bridge of his nose.

“The legends are already bad enough,” he muttered. “‘Black Guildmaster,’ ‘Grim Reaper,’ ‘Lana’s Dragon’—”

“And now,” Rakihi said smugly, “they’ll whisper about the noble from the old court who keeps vanishing down alleys with his lovers. It adds flavour.”

Elcia’s mouth quirked. “At least you redirected,” she said. “I heard no one was actually traumatised in the making of today’s… alley.”

Rakihi sagged theatrically over the back of a chair. “You’re all no fun,” she declared. “I’m going to have to work twice as hard to corrupt this household properly.”

Arcebek lifted her cup in a lazy toast. “Good luck,” she said. “He redirects like a mythic river when he wants to.”

Despite himself, Shade smiled.

He hung up his cloak and let the room's warmth settle over him.

The audits, council arguments, and tangled logistics could wait until morning.

For tonight, there were fairy bites under his shirt, Arcebek's wicked smile across the table, Elcia's quiet amusement, and Rakihi already humming what was almost certainly an inaccurate ballad about dragons and scandalous alleys.

He could live with that.

Even if the stories eventually grew a little more scandalous.

Chapter 20: The Fey Court Returns

The Court returned on a day perfectly calculated to be inconvenient.

Shade was in the armoury's back room, elbow-deep in other people's bad decisions.

Three Silver-ranked adventurers stood before him: unaffiliated fighters who moved between squads as needed. Without a permanent party, none had had anyone consistently checking their equipment.

Shade rapped his knuckles against a breastplate so thin it rang in all the wrong ways.

“If something strikes you in the chest wearing this, the only thing between you and broken ribs is optimism. Take it off. Quartermaster, reinforced leather until we find plate that won't fold.”

The quartermaster muttered something profane about shortages but nodded.

Shade moved down the line.

The second Silver carried a sword with an uneven edge likely to catch in bone. The third had concealed a cracked shield beneath a freshly painted crest.

He was preparing another lecture on the difference between ‘worn but serviceable’ and ‘dangerous’ when a pale, breathless runner appeared.

“Guildmaster?” the boy blurted. “There’s—uh. A visitor. For you.”

Shade didn’t look away from the cracked shield.

“If it’s not a supplier with the missing mail from the south road, tell them to come back tomorrow.”

“It’s…” The runner swallowed. “It’s an emissary, sir. From the fey court.”

The armoury fell silent.

The quartermaster stopped in her tracks. One of the Silvers made a quick warding sign against his thigh.

Of course, Shade thought. Of course today.

Shade laid the shield down with deliberate care.

“Where?” he asked.

“Small council chamber,” the runner said. “They—uh—they said they bear a writ from the Queen of Thorns.”

Shade nodded once.

“Continue without me,” he told the quartermaster. “None of those three takes a dangerous assignment until I've approved the replacement gear.”

“Yes, Guildmaster.” Her tired expression suggested she understood exactly what it meant when a court came calling.

The small council chamber felt wrong the moment Shade entered.

Nothing had visibly changed: polished table, familiar chairs, the same window overlooking two Bronze-ranked archers arguing about fletching.

Yet the air had a skewed, storm-before-the-storm quality, as though the wind remembered another sky.

The emissary sat with their back to the window. Not Moonthorn.

The newcomer wore a pleasing, almost human face: tall and slender, with frost-pale hair and city-cut clothing dyed in the deep colours of a shaded forest. Their green eyes reflected the light incorrectly, like glass laid over moss.

On the table lay a flat object wrapped in translucent leaf-silk, fastened with a black thorn.

Not a box.

A token.

“Guildmaster Shade,” they said, standing as he entered. Their voice was smooth, unhurried, every word measured like it might be written down. “Thank you for granting me audience.”

“The guild receives envoys of all courts,” Shade said. “As long as they remember they are in this one.”

The emissary’s mouth curved delicately.

“I am Faranell,” they said. “Spoken of by the Western Boughs, bearing the word of Her Radiance, Queen of Thorns and Echoes.”

Shade’s gaze slid briefly to the wrapped object on the table.

“And that?” he asked.

“A courtesy,” Faranell replied. “A sign of… good faith.”

With careful fingers, Faranell slipped the thorn free. The leaf-silk unrolled across the table in a whisper.

Inside, resting on the pale green, was a brooch.

Moonthorn’s brooch.

Shade recognised the intricate silver knots and moonstone shard from the forest pool. Moonthorn had worn the brooch when he first tried to invoke the Queen's authority.

Now its edges were blackened and the moonstone split through the centre. Its light was gone.

Not a head in a box.

Not a severed head, but something almost as pointed: an official mark of authority ceremonially destroyed.

Shade kept his expression still, though his fingers curled into his palm.

He remembered Moonthorn's scream as the Eyes turned, when Shade twisted the slaver-channel and interrupted the Queen's influence long enough to burn out a power the emissary had never been entitled to wield. Punishment had seemed inevitable.

Apparently, they had.

“My predecessor overstepped,” Faranell said softly. “He invoked bindings that were not what had been agreed upon. Her Radiance has made her displeasure known.”

“And sent you,” Shade said, “to… repair things.”

“To clarify them,” Faranell said. “And to resolve a delicate matter that should never have required such… theatrics.”

They brushed the ruined brooch with two fingers and set it aside like a relic.

“You interfered with an authority that belonged to my Queen, not Moonthorn,” Faranell continued. “You twisted it. Broke what you had no right to touch. Some courts would have answered with immediate reprisals.”

“In some courts,” Shade said, “selling your own child like a prize mare would have been grounds for losing your head.”

A flash of something sharp crossed their eyes.

He did not apologize for the thought or the words.

“Her Radiance is willing to consider that her daughter's choices were mishandled,” Faranell said after a pause. “That rogue agents pursued their own profit. That the mortal who tore at those chains did not understand every web he disturbed.”

Shade remembered Moonthorn at the pool, drunk on borrowed power, and the slaver-circle revealed by the Eyes: mortals bleeding away their lives for profit while the Court took its share.

“I grasped enough,” he said evenly.

“Perhaps,” Faranell allowed. “Still, the Queen prefers conversation to war, where possible.”

For the first time they met his gaze fully. In their eyes, Shade glimpsed cold forests and something patient beneath the roots.

“In that spirit,” they said, “Her Radiance asks that you correct a… misunderstanding.”

Here it came.

“I am listening,” Shade said.

“The one you call Rakihi,” Faranell said, testing the name. “Born Rakihana of the Azure Glade. Bound by blood and oath to the Western Court. Taken to the mortal realms and concealed beneath your wing.”

Shade’s jaw tightened.

“She walked here,” he said. “On her own feet. No one stole her.”

Faranell’s expression didn’t change.

“Semantics. To Her Radiance, what is taken remains taken, whether it walks away or is carried. She has been lenient, allowing you to shelter a wayward child while tempers cooled.”

Shade gripped the back of the chair, refusing to sit.

“You call selling her future and denying her a choice ‘details’. Interesting.”

Faranell let that roll off them like water.

“Moonthorn's overreach has been corrected.” Faranell inclined their head toward the ruined brooch. “Those arrangements have been dissolved. No slavers. No ritual channels. Her Radiance regrets the misalignment of expectations.”

Some of the chill in Shade's spine eased. No more slavers. Whatever else happened, that mattered.

But Faranell wasn’t finished.

“However,” they went on, “this does not change the simple truth. Rakihana is of the Queen’s blood. Sworn—by proxy, yes, but sworn nonetheless. The correct course now is simple.”

They folded their hands.

“You will release her into my custody. She will return to her rightful place. The Queen will graciously overlook your interference. No thorns beneath your walls. No spiteful songs woven around your name. And no need to consult the Blue Court.”

Velvet stretched over a blade.

“And if I refuse?” Shade asked.

Faranell considered him with the faint curiosity of someone studying a cornered animal.

“Then my Queen must weigh her patience against the insult: a mortal guildmaster defying a sovereign of the Western Boughs, a runaway daughter sheltered by a dragon prince who has already interfered with our authority.”

That drew Shade's full attention.

So they knew.

From Moonthorn's damaged report and the traces left in the ley-lines, the Court had worked out what he was: more than an oversized adventurer with unusual eyes.

“Her Radiance does not want war. She has other concerns. But she will not be mocked. If Rakihana does not return, the Queen will begin adjusting her songs. You know what that means.”

Harvests rotting. Thorns blighting fields. Caravans vanishing in unnatural fog. A string of disasters everyone would call curses, though the Queen's hand would never be visible.

Shade let the silence stretch.

“You came yourself,” he said finally. “Not a proxy. Not another overconfident nephew with more Court-blood than sense.”

“Her Radiance learns from… errors,” Faranell answered. “We will not make the same mistake twice.”

And with that came the real warning.

He had surprised Moonthorn once, turning the Queen's own channel against her agent. That advantage was spent. The Court had learned, and this time it came armed with patience and precise threats.

His trick had bought time.

It had not bought safety.

“Three days,” Shade said.

Faranell’s brows rose. “Pardon?”

“You will have my answer in three days,” Shade said. “Rakihi is not a blade I can hand over. This concerns more lives than mine, and I won't bind anyone with an answer made in haste.”

Faranell examined him in silence.

“Three days,” they agreed. “On the fourth, I leave the city. I strongly advise you to choose wisely before then.”

They wrapped the brooch in leaf-silk again and secured it with the black thorn.

“Keep this,” they said, sliding it across the table toward him. “A reminder that Her Radiance disciplines her own. She would prefer not to… extend that privilege to others.”

Shade didn’t touch it.

“Good day, Guildmaster,” Faranell said.

Faranell swept past him. For a heartbeat the air bent around the threshold; then they were gone, and the room seemed too large and too cold.

Shade stared at the little bundle on the table.

Moonthorn's broken authority mark carried the Court's message plainly enough: We punish our own. You have made your point once. Do not imagine you can repeat it.

Shade swore with quiet thoroughness in three languages his tutors would have disapproved of.

Then he picked up the leaf-wrapped token, careful not to let the thorn prick his skin, and left.

He took the back streets home.

Not because Faranell would need alleyway spies to follow him. The main road simply felt too crowded, and he needed space to think.

A perceptive air elemental swung the manor door open before he reached it.

The house hummed with life: the smell of supper cooking, Rakihi testing a lute string, Arcebek speaking to an unseen imp somewhere deeper inside, Elcia's armour neatly arranged beside the hearth.

Rakihi perched on the back of a sitting-room chair, plucking a tune and humming under her breath.

She saw his face and the hum broke off sharp.

“What happened?” she said.

Arcebek turned toward his voice, her clouded eyes narrowing. Elcia stopped oiling the pauldron in her lap.

Shade closed the door behind him.

“The Court sent a new emissary,” he said. “Faranell. From the Western Boughs.”

Rakihi’s mouth thinned.

“Let me guess,” she said. “They brought flowers, apologies, and a heartfelt speech about respecting my autonomy.”

He snorted. It came out more tired than amused.

“They brought Moonthorn's brooch,” he said, lifting the bundle. “Broken. Burned. They say he was punished for exceeding his authority.”

For a heartbeat, something ugly and satisfied flickered across Rakihi’s face.

“Good,” she said. “He deserved worse.”

Shade nodded once.

“They’ve also dissolved the slaver-channel,” he added. “No more ritual chains. No more ‘accidental’ payments in blood.”

For an instant, genuine surprise broke through Rakihi's sarcasm.

“She gave that up? Mum doesn't usually abandon a profit vein without throwing a tantrum.”

“She called it a misalignment of expectations,” Shade said. “Blamed rogue agents. Convenient.”

“And?” Arcebek asked quietly. “They did not come all this way just to tell you you were right.”

Shade met Rakihi’s eyes.

Shade held Rakihi's gaze. “She wants you returned. Officially this time. No slavers, no back-room bargains—just a daughter restored to her proper place. If I refuse, she starts keeping score.”

Rakihi blew out a breath between her teeth.

“Of course,” she muttered. “Can’t just let your runaway daughter be happy with her girlfriends and her dragon.”

Elcia set the pauldron down very carefully.

“And what did you say?” she asked.

“I promised an answer in three days,” he said. “After speaking to the people whose lives are at stake.”

Rakihi’s gaze sharpened.

“Shade,” she warned, “if any part of this ends with ‘for your own good’ or ‘perhaps the safest choice is—’ I swear by every god with ears—”

“It doesn't. I won't hand you over to anyone. That isn't an option.”

Her shoulders eased, though anger still lingered in them.

“Good,” she said, voice rough. “Because if you tried, I’d… have to write such an unflattering song.”

Arcebek let out a breath that might have been a laugh.

“So we have three days,” Arcebek said. “A queen who has traded crude greed for polite threats, and an emissary who knows what you did to the last one's power.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “And an advantage I thought I’d bought—surprise—is now spent.”

He lifted the little leaf-wrapped brooch.

“The message is clear: we correct our own mistakes, and we won't step into the same trap twice.”

Arcebek’s fingers tapped the table, already moving along lines he couldn’t see.

“Then we don’t try to repeat the same trick,” she said. “We use the time it bought us instead.”

She looked up toward where she knew he was standing.

“First, we strengthen the wards. Then we warn Lana when we can reach her. And we make it clear that taking Rakihi means confronting the guildmaster, his Black squad, and a paladin of judgment.”

Elcia nodded slightly at that.

“And you sit down, breathe, and sleep before making another decision involving sovereign courts. You smell of old magic and disastrous diplomacy.”

Rakihi slid off the chair back and crossed the space between them, bare feet whispering on the floorboards.

She rested her forehead briefly against his chest.

“She was always going to come after me again,” Rakihi said. “That's who she is. But you gave me time. A life. Friends. All of you. More than I ever expected when I ran.”

He rested a hand lightly on the back of her head.

“I’m not afraid of her,” he said, automatic.

“Liar,” all three of them said at once.

He huffed.

“I am,” he corrected, “only… appropriately wary.”

“That,” Elcia said, “is a far healthier answer.”

The danger remained.

The Queen had returned with sharper threats, and Shade's advantage of surprise was gone.

But he was not facing her alone, and Rakihi was not a possession to be handed back.

For now, that was enough to keep him upright.

Tomorrow they would begin the work of making their refusal stand.

Chapter 21: A Message to the Matriarch

The messenger arrived during breakfast.

Naturally, Shade had a mouthful of toast and half a ledger open on the table when an old war came knocking.

The kitchen was warm with morning sounds: the hearth crackling, cups clinking, Rakihi humming over the jam jar, Arcebek regarding her tea as a personal adversary, and Elcia reading a book of Kael Varis's teachings by the window.

The air twisted.

It was a small distortion, barely enough to notice, but every elemental in the house went still.

Sparky flared in the stove. The air spirit sweeping the corner froze mid-motion, its cloth suspended as though gravity had been dismissed.

Then something tapped, very politely, at the back door.

Three times.

Metal on wood.

Shade's shoulders locked.

Rakihi stopped humming. Arcebek tilted her head, listening past ordinary sound. Elcia marked her place with a finger and closed the book.

"I'll get it," Shade said.

He didn't reach for a weapon.

He didn't need one.

The wards parted for him like mist.

He opened the door.

The courier on the step wasn't dramatic.

The visitor was human-sized, wrapped in the practical clothes of a distant rider—except for the impossible sheen of the dark-blue coat, like a storm cloud trapped in glass. Silver threaded their braids; their skin was the colour of thunderheads. Their eyes…

He didn't look at the eyes.

"Skysunder." The messenger bowed with the polished precision of the Court. "I bring word from the Empress of the Blue Flight."

He hated how readily the old name tightened around him.

"Here," he said. "I am Shade."

After a pause, the messenger inclined their head in acknowledgment.

"Shade," they amended. "By her command, this is for you. Unread, unaltered."

They held out a small cylinder.

Dragonsteel, dark and matte, with a sapphire set into its side. The gem pulsed with carefully contained power.

His mother's seal.

Shade felt his stomach tighten.

He took it.

The sapphire flashed at his touch, recognised him, then sank soundlessly into the metal. Runes along the cylinder's rim came alive.

The messenger stepped back.

"I will await your reply outside the wards," they said. "If there is to be one."

They turned down the garden path and passed through the ward-line with a careful sideways step, avoiding even the brush of uninvited magic.

Shade shut the door.

The kitchen watched him.

Rakihi had half-risen. Arcebek was motionless in the way that meant she was tracing twenty outcomes at once. Elcia set her book aside.

"From your mother?" Arcebek asked quietly.

"From the Empress," he said.

Same person. A very different weight to the words.

He set the cylinder on the table.

No one reached for it.

The runes responded to his touch with a familiar hum, like the memory of cold wind at the edge of the sky.

He twisted.

The cylinder opened with a click and a breath of air scented with frost and ozone.

A strip of flexible metal unfurled inside. Its etched script shifted impatiently whenever he looked away.

He read.

Once.

Twice.

Imperial war-orders seldom wasted words.

Skysunder,

Reports of insult to our blood and hoard have reached us.

A lesser court presumes to threaten what is ours. A queen of thorns thinks to snarl at a dragon across a mortal field.

This will not stand.

Deal with the upstart.

Permission is granted to remove your seals for this purpose where necessary.

Teach them what it looks like to draw the ire of the Blue Flight.

Do not waste my patience or my gifts.

— Your Mother.

The final two words had been etched in a different hand, their sharper strokes unmoving and unmistakably personal.

Shade stared until the letters blurred.

Permission is granted to remove your seals.

As though the goddesses bound to his wrist were valves his mother could order opened. As though Ifret, Terra, and the others were weapons in storage rather than people who had chosen to seal him.

Ifret stirred against his skin, a slow, amused coil of heat.

Oh, now she remembers we exist, came the sultry drawl in his head.

Hush, Terra muttered, earth-warm and steady. Listen first.

Shade released a long breath.

Rakihi's fingers brushed his forearm.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

He handed her the strip.

Rakihi read faster than he had. Her pupils narrowed at 'insult to our blood' and widened at 'remove your seals.'

By the time she finished, her hands were motionless.

"Well," she said at last, voice rough. "That's… a sentence."

Arcebek took the strip when Rakihi offered it. Elcia moved close enough to read over her shoulder.

Shade looked at Rakihi.

"How much," he asked, very quietly, "do you care about your mother?"

The room went even more silent.

Rakihi blinked.

He could see the reflex—joke, deflect, something about beige husbands and dramatic exits—rise behind her eyes.

It didn't make it to her mouth.

Rakihi set the strip down carefully and wrapped her arms around herself, worrying at a loose thread on her sleeve.

"That's a… complicated question," she said at last.

"We have… some time," he replied.

Not much. Faranell's deadline was two days away, his mother's messenger waited beyond the wards, and an imperial war-order lay on the breakfast table.

Rakihi stared at the worn wooden tabletop.

“When I was small,” Rakihi began, “she sang me to sleep. Every night. Herself. Queens aren't supposed to do that; there are nurses and attendants for it. But she'd come back from court smelling of storms and rose-thorns, sit beside my moss-pile, and hum until my wings stopped twitching.”

Her mouth twisted.

“She let me fly higher than any of the other children,” Rakihi continued. “Told the guards to stop panicking whenever I disappeared into the canopy. Said, ‘If she falls, the ground will teach her to respect heights. We do not clip our own.’”

Shade listened without interrupting.

Arcebek gripped her mug. Elcia watched Rakihi with the solemn attention she gave testimony at the temple.

“When I ruined my first important ritual and set half the audience's hair on fire, she laughed. Said it was ‘memorable’. Told me I was meant to shake halls, not soothe them.”

She drew a breath; her shoulders trembled once.

“Then one day she decided my wings were negotiable. A dowry. Something pretty and powerful she could trade for land and influence and an old man with beige magic and even beiger opinions. A fairy wife for his trophy shelf.”

Her hands had curled into fists.

“She never asked,” Rakihi whispered. “Not once. She didn't say, ‘Rakihi, will you?’ Just, ‘It's done. You'll go to him when the season turns. It's a good match.’ As though I wasn't even part of the bargain.”

Silence.

Rakihi gave a shaky laugh.

“So how much do I care about her? I don't know. I love the woman who sang to me. Who told me to fly. And I hate the queen who signed my name away without even looking at me.”

Her gaze lifted to Shade’s.

“And I do not want her court burned to ashes because two powerful women decide to compare horns over who owns me.”

Shade’s throat felt tight.

“It wouldn't be about owning you,” he said. “It would be about protecting you. About the slavers she used, the threats she made, and the guild she thinks she can endanger without consequence.”

“I know,” Rakihi said softly. “That’s the problem.”

Arcebek set the strip down, metal ticking faintly on wood.

“Your mother has just authorised you to take the leash off—or thinks she has,” Arcebek said. “If you use all your power against the Western Court on her orders, this stops being a personal feud and becomes a war between elder powers.”

Elcia nodded once. “With mortals standing in the crossfire,” she said.

“With me at the centre,” Rakihi added. “The prize. The excuse.”

She scrubbed her hands over her face.

“I won't go back. Not ever. But I don't want mortals telling stories about how the Blue Flight and the Western Court tore three valleys apart arguing over one girl.”

Shade looked down at the bracelet on his wrist.

The stones rested quietly against his skin. Heavy. Waiting.

We could, Ifret purred, lazy fire curling through her voice. It has been a long time since anyone let us stretch properly.

We could also not, Fenris said dryly. Last time you lot got into a pissing match over territory, it took five centuries to clean up the rivers.

Djing & Djang shifted, their voices overlapping in a windy whisper.

Storm v. thorn, they mused. Song v. roar. Interesting weather, either way.

Terra spoke last, slow and deep.

Little one, she murmured to Shade. You swore, when we sealed you, that you wanted to learn how not to solve every problem by breaking it. Has that changed?

Shade closed his eyes.

“No,” he said, aloud.

Rakihi blinked. “No…?”

He opened his eyes and met hers.

“I will not return you,” he said. “Not to a cage. Not to beige. Not because your mother is offended that you chose a different life.”

Her lips trembled; she nodded, once.

“But I won't use my mother's anger as an excuse to unleash everything I am against the place you once called home. That isn't why I came here.”

Relief briefly crossed Elcia's face. Arcebek's shoulders relaxed.

Rakihi sagged, as though a weight she had been bracing against had finally lifted.

“So what do we do?” she asked.

Shade picked up the metal strip again, weighing it in his hand.

“As leverage,” he said. “Not a hammer.”

Arcebek’s brows rose. “Explain.”

“Faranell believes the Western Court is facing one isolated dragon playing guildmaster. Dangerous, perhaps, but manageable. They don't believe the Blue Flight would take this as a matter of its own honour.”

He tapped the line Teach them what it looks like to draw the ire of the Blue Flight.

“My mother has formally acknowledged the insult and granted permission to act. That carries weight even if I choose not to strike.”

“You want to… show it to them?” Rakihi asked slowly. “Wave the war-order and say ‘look what happens if you keep poking my hoard’?”

“Something like that,” he said. “Carefully.”

“Carefully?” Arcebek repeated, both sceptical and interested. “How do you stand between two courts without being crushed?”

“By making it clear,” Elcia said quietly, “that escalation will cost all of them more than backing down will. And by giving them an out that satisfies their pride.”

Shade nodded.

“We tell Faranell the Blue Flight considers the Queen's conduct an insult to its blood and hoard,” Shade said. “Continued pursuit of Rakihi becomes a provocation against the Empress, not merely a dispute with a guildmaster. And I make clear that I have been authorised to respond.”

“And then?” Arcebek prompted.

“Then I offer terms. The slaver channels stay closed. No forced marriage. No more attempts to seize Rakihi or threaten this city. In return, the Court may formally acknowledge that she has chosen exile and relinquished her place in the succession. Any harm done here in pursuit of her will be treated as an act of war against more than one power.”

Rakihi flinched at the mention of relinquishing her place in the succession, then fell still.

“That would make it real,” she whispered. “Not just running away. Official, written into the songs. I wouldn't be her heir anymore. Ever.”

“Would you accept that?” Elcia asked gently.

Rakihi studied her cooling tea, the imperial metal strip, and an old scorch mark on the table.

“I think I made that choice when I signed Lana's paperwork instead of my mother's,” she said. “But yes. Having it acknowledged would help. It would hurt, too.”

She looked up.

“And if Mum refuses?” she asked. “If she decides her pride matters more than avoiding a dragon war?”

Shade’s jaw tightened.

“Then we leave the seals in place and stand our ground—with Lana, the guild, and Kael Varis watching. We don't offer her the war she wants us to fear.”

Arcebek frowned. “Wait for what?” she asked.

“For my mother to decide whether she truly wants to spend her strength on this,” Shade said. “For the other courts to consider how much they would enjoy watching the Blue Flight and the Western Court rip at each other while the Void laughs.”

He laid the strip on the table, decisively.

“I'm not a weapon they can aim,” he said, as much to himself as to his family. “Not the Queen. Not the Empress. Not even my anger.”

Rakihi stepped forward until she stood right in front of him.

She rose on her toes and pressed her brow to his.

“I don't want a war fought in my name,” she whispered. “But if one comes anyway, I'm glad you asked whether I still love her before you asked whether you could win.”

He exhaled.

Arcebek cleared her throat. “Touching. All of it. But there's still a fey emissary expecting an answer and a dragon courier standing outside our wards. Perhaps we shouldn't keep either waiting.”

“Write to your mother,” Elcia suggested. “Thank her for her… enthusiasm. Tell her you're handling it, and ask her not to intervene unless you call on her.”

Shade made a face. “She is not good at ‘not acting.’”

“No,” Arcebek said. “But she is good at respecting her favourite wayward son when he says ‘this is my hoard, let me guard it my way.’”

Rakihi grinned, watery but real.

“Besides,” Rakihi said, her grin watery but genuine, “if she starts a war anyway, I'll get to be smug about her stubbornness for the next three centuries. Almost worth it.”

He laughed despite himself.

“All right,” he said. “I’ll write. And then,” he added, looking at Rakihi, “we go talk to Faranell together. If your mother is going to hear about this from anyone, I’d rather it be us, on our terms.”

Rakihi’s eyes flashed.

“Good,” she said. “If she’s going to be furious, let her be furious at both of us.”

She squeezed his hand.

“I’m not going anywhere,” she added. “Not unless we all go together.”

The Empress's war-order lay on the table, its lettering humming softly.

Permission to remove your seals.

Shade picked up a pen instead.

Chapter 22: An Answer from the Storm

His mother's answer arrived with unreasonable speed.

Shade had barely entrusted the courier with his reply—an appeal for restraint, a clear account of Rakihi's choice, and a warning of what might happen if two ancient powers turned one woman's freedom into a war—when the air in the kitchen twisted again.

A tap at the back door. The familiar bite of high-altitude frost in the air.

He opened it to find the courier standing on the same step as before, as though no journey had taken place.

"This returned unread?" Shade asked, his pulse quickening.

"No," the courier said. "She read it."

The courier offered him another cylinder, smaller than the first. There was no sapphire, only bare dragonsteel and his mother's personal sigil—storm-slit eye over a wing curve—pressed into the top.

Shade broke it open with his thumb.

Inside, the message strip was short enough to stop him cold.

Fine.

Do it your way. You always do.

Love you.

— Mom.

That was it.

No titles, no threats, no imperial flourish.

Just that.

Something in his chest loosened with an ache he had not expected.

"Any further orders for me?" the courier asked, sounding faintly bemused.

Shade shook his head. "No. Thank you."

They bowed and stepped back through the wards, vanishing into the morning traffic as though they were any other messenger.

He stood there with the strip between his fingers. Of everything she could have written, it was Love you that struck deepest.

Then he went to keep his promise.

Faranell waited in the same small council chamber as before, sitting with the brittle composure of someone determined not to be surprised twice.

Today they wore a more formal guise: sharper lines to the jaw, hair braided and coiled like a crown, clothes a shade closer to court-cut than city fashion. Moonthorn's ruined brooch rested on the table by their elbow like a paperweight.

They looked up as Shade entered.

Then they saw who came in after him.

Rakihi first, chin raised, her hair braided back in a style Shade recognized from portraits of the Queen in her youth. No glamour, no disguise. Just herself, in her adventurer leathers, lute case slung across her back as if daring anyone to question her choice of court attire.

Arcebek followed, staff in hand, blind eyes focused slightly past Faranell with an uncanny certainty that had nothing to do with sight. Her braid was tied up out of the way; her mouth had that small, unreadable curve that suggested she had considered several outcomes and approved of none.

Elcia came last, in clean but unadorned paladin kit, tabard rolled and left back at the manor. She wore no visible symbol of Kael Varis. She did not need one to carry the authority of her oath.

Faranell's composure cracked, just for a heartbeat.

Their mouth tightened as they noticed Rakihi's wrist resting, very deliberately, against Shade's. A muscle jumped in their jaw when Arcebek's staff clicked once on the stone.

"You brought an audience," they said lightly.

"I brought the people this concerns," Shade replied. "You wanted to negotiate over Rakihana. It seemed wise to let her speak for herself."

Rakihi smiled, all teeth.

"Also," she said, "we're nosy."

Faranell's gaze flicked to her. Family resemblance flashed in the emissary's irritation: the unmistakable offence of hearing their own courtly tone turned against them.

"You look well," they said, a phrase so carefully neutral it could conceal either affection or a threat.

"I am," Rakihi said. "That's sort of the point."

Faranell's jaw was set in the faintest of scowls now, but they rallied quickly, slipping back into the polished cadence of an envoy determined to recover the advantage.

"Have you come," they asked Shade, "to give me your answer? Or to display your… support network?"

"Yes," Shade said.

They blinked.

He set something on the table.

Not the ruined brooch.

The metal strip from his mother.

Faranell's gaze dropped to it, despite themself. The characters were in draconic cant, but the Blue Flight used scripts whose curves and pulses conveyed more than their literal letters. Any decent Court-speaker could sense its tone even without knowing every word.

"This," Shade said, "is the Empress's response to the situation."

Faranell's brows rose.

"You consulted your mother," they said. "After all."

"I informed her," Shade corrected. "There's a difference."

He let the message speak for itself.

He simply slid the strip across the table, letting it come to a stop by Faranell's fingers.

"Read it," he said.

The emissary hesitated.

Then, slowly, they picked it up.

Their eyes tracked the shifting script until it yielded its meaning.

Fine.

Do it your way. You always do.

Love you.

— Mom.

For a heartbeat, Faranell stared.

Shade watched comprehension dawn.

Their jaw slackened. The prepared arguments about proper channels and sovereign dignity died before they could be spoken.

"You… told the Empress everything we discussed," they said slowly.

"Yes," Shade said.

"And she…" Their voice went thin around the edges. "She said… this?"

"Yes," Shade repeated.

Rakihi leaned an elbow on the back of the chair nearest her.

"My almost-mother-in-law," she said pleasantly, "has very strong opinions about anyone threatening her hoard. Fortunately, she currently prefers not to eat your Queen."

Arcebek coughed quietly, badly hiding a laugh.

Faranell tore their gaze away from the strip, looking between them as though the terms of the negotiation had changed beneath their feet.

"You expect me to believe," they said, brittle now, "that the Empress of the Blue Flight will simply… stand aside. After an insult to her blood. To her… hoard."

Shade met their look.

"I expect you," he said, "to understand what happens if she does intervene. A dispute between your Queen and my household becomes a quarrel among powers old enough to make this city collateral damage."

He tapped the strip lightly.

"I asked her not to act without my request," he went on. "She agreed. That doesn't mean she's forgotten the insult. It does mean that if Moonthorn keeps pushing, she'll see it as ignoring my judgement, not hers. She takes that sort of insult personally."

Rakihi gave Faranell a very sweet smile.

“And in case it’s not obvious,” she said, “I’m choosing this court. This guild. These idiots.” She bumped Shade’s shoulder with hers. “You may keep treating me as a misplaced ornament, or you can correct your records.”

Silence.

Faranell stared at the strip again.

They had arrived with a royal writ, a deadline, and the certainty that even severed channels could not diminish the Queen’s authority. They had expected bargaining, perhaps concessions. Perhaps even a tearful farewell.

Instead, the Empress had offered her son something far more dangerous than a threat: permission to handle the matter himself, backed by all the power she had chosen not to use.

The emissary set the strip down with very careful fingers.

“I will,” they said, voice stiff, “have to… confer with my Queen.”

Shade inclined his head.

“Of course,” he said. “You have until tomorrow. If she does not answer, we proceed without her consent.”

Faranell’s mouth compressed.

“This is… highly irregular,” they managed.

“Welcome to my life,” Rakihi said.

Arcebek kept her counsel, listening for the answer behind the emissary’s words.

Elcia took a small step forward, gauntleted hand resting lightly on the back of Rakihi’s chair.

“If your Queen chooses peace,” she said, level and clear, “we will not seek to humiliate her. We will acknowledge a mother’s grief and her daughter’s right to choose. We will let the story be one of parting, not of defeat.”

Faranell’s eyes flicked to her, to the quiet steadiness there, and, perhaps, to the divine authority behind her calm words. They swallowed.

“I will… convey that,” they said.

Then they stood, bowing with stiff, court-perfect form.

“Until tomorrow, Guildmaster,” they said.

“Until tomorrow,” Shade replied.

They left without looking at Rakihi again.

The answer came before Shade had finished preparing for a longer dispute.

No polished envoy this time.

Shortly after noon the following day, a figure dropped onto the wall beside the guild training yard as Shade crossed the courtyard.

A fey—though hardly the sort usually admitted to royal councils.

They looked far more accustomed to escaping them.

Small and wiry, they wore clothes singed at the cuffs; twigs and uncanny burrs tangled in their wild hair. Their wings—what was left of them—were folded tight, feathers singed. A healing cut crossed one eyebrow, and their nose had the crooked shape of an old, poorly set break.

They hopped down off the wall, landed in front of him with the wary confidence of a stray cat, and squinted up.

“You Shade?” they demanded.

“Yes,” he said.

They held out a scrap of something.

Not parchment. Leaf-skin, dried and stiff, edges browned like it had been held too close to a candle.

“From Her Radiance,” they said, with a show of respect so unconvincing that Shade almost admired it. “Direct.”

He took it.

There was only one line burnt into the surface, in the same hand as the Queen’s older, far more elaborate decrees.

Have her.

No titles.

No qualifiers.

No flowery preamble about sorrow and duty.

Just that.

Shade stared at it.

The messenger dug a finger into their ear, then volunteered, “That’s the nice version. The one she sent the first time, I had to eat.”

He blinked. “You… what?”

“Court business,” they said dismissively. “This one’s for you.”

Then, before he could ask anything else, they took three quick backwards steps, sprang, and launched themselves back up onto the wall on battered wings, trailing a stream of inventive profanity.

“Good luck with your mess!” they called over their shoulder. “Try not to break the sky!”

And then they were gone.

Shade stood in the yard, leaf-skin between his fingers, amid the clatter of training, the cries of merchants, and someone cursing a stubborn practice dummy. He read the words again.

Have her.

Not bring her home.

Not return my daughter.

Not even keep her.

Just… Have her.

It was surrender, of a sort.

Not graceful. Not healed. But real.

A relinquishing of claim—and perhaps of kinship.

A disowning.

A cutting of lines.

The cruelty of it stung more than a declaration of feud would have.

He went home with the message folded carefully in his pocket.

Rakihi read it in the kitchen.

He didn't say anything.

He just set the leaf-skin on the table between them and waited.

She looked down.

For a moment, she didn't react at all. She blinked once, her pupils narrowing as she read the scorched letters.

Then her shoulders hitched.

"Of course," she said, voice thin. "Of course that's what she sends."

Arcebek picked the scrap up carefully, mouth tightening as she read. Elcia watched Rakihi, not the message, like a healer watching for the real wound.

"She's not coming," Rakihi said, and her laugh cracked so sharply that Shade had to resist the urge to seek out the Queen of Thorns himself. "No dramatic entrance. No storm at the gates. Just—" she stabbed a finger at the leaf "—'have her.' As though I were an instrument she no longer wanted."

"That's not all it is," Elcia said gently.

Rakihi's head snapped up.

"Feels like it," she said. "Feels like I just got exiled by… one sentence."

"You exiled yourself," Arcebek said quietly. "A long time ago. She's only now admitting it."

"That doesn't help," Rakihi muttered.

"No," Arcebek agreed. "It doesn't. But it might, later."

Shade reached across the table, palm up.

She stared at his hand for a beat.

Then she took it.

"If you want to scream," he said, "I can take you out past the east fields. There's a cliff there with an excellent echo."

She huffed, half-sob, half-laugh.

"If I start," she said, "I might not stop."

"That's all right," he said. "I don't have another council meeting today."

Silence stretched, softer this time.

Rakihi turned the leaf over with her free hand, as if hoping there'd be more on the back. A hidden line, perhaps. A small postscript telling her she was loved.

There wasn't.

She swallowed.

"So that's it," she said. "No more emissaries. No more contracts. If any of her people come sniffing around now, it's not about me. It's about us."

"Yes," Shade said.

She let out a shivering breath.

"Good," she said. "Horrible. Still good."

She lifted the leaf again, studied the words one last time.

"Have her," she murmured. "Fine. You had your chance."

Then she folded it, once, very precisely, and set it down in front of him.

"Burn it?" she asked.

He looked at her.

"Sure?" he said.

"Not really," she admitted. "But I don't want it waiting for me to find it again in the middle of the night."

He nodded.

Warmth stirred at Shade's wrist. With a breath, he drew a thread of Ifret's fire to his fingertips.

The leaf-skin caught fast.

The letters glowed brighter than the flame.

Then they curled, blackened, and were gone, sending a narrow twist of smoke toward the kitchen rafters.

Rakihi watched until the last ember died.

Then she leaned sideways into him, tucking her head against his shoulder with a weariness he could feel through her whole body.

"Okay," she said, voice small and steady all at once. "So. No mother. No court. Just me. You. Us. This idiotic, wonderful city."

"Yes," he said.

"Then let's make sure," she went on, "that when they sing about 'Rakihana who walked away from a Queen,' the important part of the song is what she built after, not what she left."

Shade wrapped his arm around her, felt Arcebek's hand settle warm on her back, met Elcia's quiet, approving nod across the table.

"We will," he said.

Outside, life went on: haggling, training, the endless noise of a city that had no idea two courts had come perilously close to war.

Inside, they sat with the ashes of a single, cruel sentence and the wide, terrifying, beautiful space it left behind.

Chapter 23: The Guildmaster's Chair

The day Lana was supposed to come home arrived beneath a clear, bright sky, which Shade found irritatingly symbolic.

Shade woke with the taut unease of someone who had spent too long expecting bad news. The calendar on Lana's desk had circled the day in Lana's cramped, impatient handwriting.

"Back. Or dead. If dead, burn this."

She'd added a little arrow pointing to an old sealed envelope in the drawer.

The envelope was still there.

By midmorning the guild hummed with anticipation. Everyone knew Lana was due back. Clerks straightened their desks. Adventurers speculated in corners.

Think she'll be impressed?

Think she'll take the chair back?

Think she'll yell? Gods, I kind of miss her yelling.

Shade signed two mission approvals, redirected a supply caravan, informed a Bronze adventurer that a pet basilisk was not permitted in the bunkroom, "even if it's friendly," and tried not to watch the doors.

By noon, no Lana.

By mid-afternoon, the guild's excitement had worn thin.

"She's not always punctual," one of the senior clerks said, half to convince herself. "Sometimes travel—"

"She sent three letters on that trip," Shade said quietly. "All of them arrived on time to the day."

The clerk shut her mouth.

It was late afternoon when the runner came.

He was one of the younger ones, gangly and breathless, with hair sticking up at every angle. He held a small, sealed note as though it might explode.

"Guildmaster," he said, voice a little too high. "This came through the secure channel. Lana's cipher. For you."

Shade took it.

The parchment was plain, but the seal was unmistakable: Lana's personal mark, impressed in blue-black wax—quill crossing a sword, a tiny stylized eye at their intersection.

He broke it with his thumb.

Three lines filled the page in Lana's ruthlessly legible handwriting.

You did good.

Time for me to retire. You will never find me.

Love, Lana.

That was it.

No explanation or forwarding address. Only an infuriating mixture of praise, resignation, and finality.

You did good.

Time for me to retire.

You will never find me.

The meaning settled heavily in his chest.

The guild wasn't hers anymore.

It was his.

"Guildmaster?" the runner asked nervously. "Does she… is she…?"

"She's alive," Shade said. He knew her well enough to recognize this as a deliberate exit, not a farewell written in the face of death. "And gone. You can tell the staff that much. No more."

"Yes, sir."

The boy bolted, plainly relieved to have an answer he could carry back to the staff.

Shade read the note again.

You will never find me.

Not don't look for me. Not don't try. Only the confidence of a woman who knew how thoroughly she could disappear.

He stood there for a while in the suddenly too-quiet office, while the guild's familiar noise continued beyond the office door. Then he folded the note very carefully, slipped it into his pocket, and went home.

He waited until they were all seated.

Over the past month, dinner at the manor had become their one dependable appointment, however badly the day had gone. Tonight the elementals had outdone themselves; the table was crowded with dishes that smelled of herbs and roasted things and a suspiciously elaborate dessert Rakihi had persuaded a market baker to make.

For a few minutes he let it be normal.

Rakihi complained about a patron who had nearly snapped a lute string while offering unwanted tuning advice. Arcebek reported, with great satisfaction, that she'd sent an imp back to its contractor with a corrected contract clause that would torment its legal department for years. Elcia described a petty dispute over a shared well that had somehow turned into a theological argument about holy water.

Then Rakihi narrowed her eyes at him.

"All right," she said. "Out with it. You're doing the 'quiet dragon' thing. The one where you think no one can hear the storm in your head."

Arcebek's blind eyes turned toward him. Elcia set her cup down, waiting.

Shade reached into his pocket.

"Lana sent a message," he said. "Today."

All three turned toward him at once.

He laid the note on the table, unfolded.

Rakihi leaned over it, hair falling like a blue curtain. Arcebek found the page by touch and read the ink through her spell-sense. Elcia simply read.

You did good.

Time for me to retire. You will never find me.

Love, Lana.

Silence.

“That’s it?” Rakihi demanded after a heartbeat. “That’s it?”

“She never was one for long speeches,” Arcebek muttered.

Elcia’s jaw was tight. “She could at least have said goodbye in person,” she said. Shade rarely heard such an edge in her voice when she spoke of Lana.

“‘You will never find me,’” Rakihi repeated, outraged. “Oh, that’s rude.”

“Accurate, though,” Arcebek said dryly. “If she’s really committed to disappearing, tracking her might require half my patrons and three gods, and I’m not sure I want any of them that close to her.”

“That’s not the point,” Rakihi said. “The point is she just… drops the guild in your lap and runs off into the sunset? Who does that?”

“Lana,” Shade said softly. “Lana does that.”

They all looked at him.

He smoothed the note with one thumb.

“This is her way of saying,” he went on, “‘You did what I asked. You kept it standing. You stayed. You didn’t hand it over to the highest bidder. So now it’s yours. I’m done.’”

“And ‘you will never find me’?” Elcia asked quietly.

“Means she doesn’t want me chasing after her when it gets hard,” he said. “She knows I would.”

Rakihi made a face. “I still think it’s cowardly,” she muttered. “Leaving you to clean up all the politics while she goes on holiday forever.”

Arcebek exhaled slowly. “It may also be merciful,” she said, reluctantly. “If she stayed, the council would pull on her to take power back. Or use her as a shadow to undermine you. This way, there’s no question. No one left for them to appeal to over your head. They have to deal with you.”

Shade nodded.

“I’m not… happy about it,” he admitted. “I would have liked to talk to her. Argue, at least.” His mouth twitched. “Probably argue a lot.”

“Understatement,” Rakihi muttered.

“But the guild needs a guildmaster,” he continued. “Not two guildmasters casting shadows over the same chair. We’d end up tearing it apart between us just trying to define whose responsibility was which.”

“Do you want it?” Elcia asked.

There was no attempt to soften it. She wanted the answer that mattered.

Shade looked down at his hands on the table. At the onyx badge at his throat. At the ink stains that never seemed to wash completely from his fingers.

“I…” He stopped, recognizing the instinct to hedge.

He tried again.

“Yes,” he said. “I do. I don’t know for how long. I don’t know what it will make of me—or what I might make of it. But I don’t want the council to have it. I don’t want some ambitious noble’s cousin wearing this badge. I’ve seen what happens when people who understand ledgers better than lives are put in charge.”

Rakihi’s expression softened. Arcebek’s mouth did, too.

Elcia nodded once.

“Then we stand with you,” she said simply. “As we have.”

“We already were,” Arcebek added. “Now we stop pretending this is temporary.”

Rakihi scowled down at the note again.

“I still kind of want to hold her feet to an open fire,” she grumbled.

“If you do,” Shade said, “she will probably show up just to mock us for the quality of the flames.”

Rakihi paused. “…Okay, that does sound like her.”

Arcebek huffed a laugh. “Also,” she said, “if you fry Lana, we inherit not only her job but also every single one of her grudges, and I refuse to add ‘vengeful retired guildmaster’ to our list of enemies.”

“Fine,” Rakihi sighed. “No roasting Lana. Yet.”

“We’ll drink to her instead,” Elcia suggested. “For what she built. For what she handed over. Then we stop expecting her to walk through the door whenever it opens.”

Shade swallowed around something unexpectedly tight.

“That,” he said, “seems fair.”

Rakihi lifted her cup.

“To Lana,” she declared. “Stubborn, terrifying, emotionally hopeless Lana, who left us an entire guild and ran off to a retirement that probably involves cheap wine.”

Arcebek raised hers, amused and fond despite herself. “May she stay far enough away that we don’t have to clean up after her,” she said.

Elcia’s was more solemn. “And may the work she started here outlast all of us,” she added.

Shade lifted his own.

“To Lana,” he said. “Who trusted me with her storm.”

They drank.

For a moment, old habits and unanswered questions hung over the table. Then Rakihi slammed her cup down.

“All right,” she said. “That’s enough melancholy. Our dragon just got promoted from ‘acting guildmaster’ to ‘official, proper, terrifying guildmaster.’ I vote we celebrate in a way Lana would absolutely disapprove of.”

Shade blinked. “She disapproved of most things we do in this house.”

“Exactly,” Rakihi said. “We have a tradition to uphold.”

Arcebek’s lips curved. “You remember,” she said, “that last time we ‘celebrated,’ Shade couldn’t look the training hall staff in the eye for three days.”

“And you nearly hexed a towel into sentience by mistake,” Elcia added, deadpan.

Rakihi pointed her spoon at both of them. “Those are success metrics, not warnings.”

Shade opened his mouth to make a sensible objection about responsibility and an early morning.

Rakihi leaned across the table and kissed him instead, slow and deliberate.

When she pulled back, her eyes were bright and wicked.

“You’ve carried this guild on your back for a month,” she said. “You faced the council, held off a fey queen, and juggled demons, nobles, and budgets. Lana just made it official. Let us celebrate you. Properly.”

Arcebek reached across and took his hand, thumb brushing over his scarred knuckles.

“You’re allowed,” she said quietly, “to enjoy what you’ve built. And what you haven’t ruined.”

Elcia’s smile was small but very real.

“Consider it a… consecration of the new guildmaster,” she murmured.

As they drew him away from the table, he considered objecting on principle.

He didn’t.

A week later, several things were true:

The guild had accepted Lana’s departure and Shade’s permanent appointment. The council had started addressing letters to Guildmaster Shade without the “acting.” The training hall staff had stopped flinching every time he walked in and only occasionally addressed him as “sir” with a hint of terror.

Also: climbing stairs still made his thighs ache in very specific ways, and every time Rakihi smirked at him from across a room, he felt heat creep up his neck.

Their celebration had been a sustained assault on his good sense.

Food and wine and laughter had blurred into hands and mouths and the low, messy tangle of four people determined to make sure he did not think about council politics for a very long time.

They did, eventually, manage to walk again like functional adventurers.

For the first tenday, sitting down required care, paperwork frequently migrated to the bedroom, and the minor elementals exchanged far too many knowing looks whenever all four overslept.

Shade, to his mild surprise, didn’t mind.

The guild was his now.

So were they.

Lana had vanished into a future of her own choosing. The Fey Queen had given up her claim with a single, cruel line. His mother, in her own oblique way, had trusted him to handle this corner of the world himself.

He stood in Lana's—his—office one morning, looking over the city. Beneath his shirt, a few lingering bruises reminded him of home; the weight of the guild reminded him of everything beyond it.

For once, those two lives felt joined rather than divided.

Storm and hearth.

Guild and home.

He smiled, very slightly, and turned back to the stack of reports.

There was work to do.

His work.

Chapter 24: The Shape Rakihi Chose

The question came to Shade in the dark, when the house had finally fallen quiet.

Rakihi lay half across Shade's chest beneath the tangled blankets, a leg draped over his hip as her fingers traced lazy circles around the scar on his shoulder. The candles had burned low. Arcebek and Elcia slept beside them, their breathing soft and even.

Shade stared up at the ceiling, feeling the slow rise and fall of Rakihi's back.

"Rakihi?" he murmured.

"Mmh?" she answered, not bothering to lift her head.

"Why," he asked, "do you still use your glamour? The Court isn't looking for you anymore."

She went very still.

Her fingers stopped their wandering. For a moment he wondered whether she would leave the question unanswered.

Then she made a small, thoughtful noise.

"Wow," she said. "Going straight for the deep questions, huh."

"We have time," he said. "I checked."

That got a quiet snort.

She lifted her head then, propping her chin on his sternum so she could see his face. In the dim light, her wide pupils left only a thin ring of blue around the darkness.

"Honestly?" she said. "I didn't think you'd ever ask."

"I didn't want to pry," he admitted. "It is your body. Your magic. Your history."

She huffed, softer this time.

"Those are all very good words," she said. "Usually followed by people prying anyway. You, at least, waited until we'd thoroughly corrupted you and you were too relaxed to escape."

Her mouth tugged into a half-smile, but the smile faltered at the edges.

He didn't look away.

"I am curious," he said. "Not disappointed."

She studied him for another heartbeat, before rolling onto her back beside him, shoulder pressed to his.

"Okay," she said quietly. "Long version first, then the short."

He waited.

"Once upon a time," she began, in a singsong voice that soon lost its playfulness, "there was a very pretty, very obvious fairy princess. Wings like stained glass. Hair like my mother's. Ears you could cut cheese with. You know the type."

"I have seen portraits," he said.

“Mmh. Those.” She sighed. “That girl was never allowed to be a person. She was always The Princess, or The Bargain, or The Jewel. Everything about her wings and her eyes and her striking features proclaimed ‘Court property.’ People treated her like a walking treaty. Or a very delicate bomb.”

Her fingers twitched restlessly, as if wanting something to fidget with and settling for the edge of the blanket.

“When I first came here,” she went on, “I dropped the glamour because I was scared. New world. New magic. I wanted every scrap of power available to me. Also it amused me to watch mortals try not to stare at my wings.”

He could imagine it too well.

“But then,” she said, “I realized something. Every time I entered a room in my true shape, people saw the Court. Not me. Even here. Even at the guild. I was ‘the fairy,’ or ‘Moonthorn’s brat,’ or ‘that fey noble slumming it with adventurers.’ And I—”

She broke off, exhaled hard.

“I was so tired,” she whispered, “of never getting to be just Rakihi.”

In the silence, the hearthstone ticked as it cooled. Somewhere in the house, a pipe dripped.

“So I tried it,” she said. “Put the glamour on and left it there. Not as a disguise for a job, or a joke. As my everyday face. Smaller ears, duller eyes, no wings, hair more ‘pretty bard’ than ‘possible omen.’”

Her mouth curved.

“And do you know what happened?” she asked.

He rolled his head toward her. “What?”

“Nothing,” she said. “No one flinched. No one genuflected. The innkeeper complained I was occupying a chair again, the guild clerk scolded me for putting my cup on her ledger, and you walked into a post because you were reading.”

“I walked into the post,” he corrected. “I remember.”

“Yes, yes, tragic, very heroic,” she said, waving a hand. “The point is, no one treated me like a declaration of war. I was just… another strange, magical woman in a city full of strange, magical people.”

Her throat bobbed.

“And when I walked into your life like this,” she said more softly, “this is the face you knew. This is how you learned to read my face. These hands.” She wiggled her fingers. “This laugh. This mess.”

She rolled onto her side again, closer, forehead almost touching his.

“This,” she said, “is the form I fell in love with you in. And Bek. And Elcia. This is the shape I wore when I chose all of you. I… like that. I’m comfortable in it. It feels like me, rather than a costume for moving among mortals.”

He let that settle between them.

“Do you…” He searched for the right words. “Do you miss it? The other face?”

Her smile went crooked.

“I miss flying,” she admitted. “More than I let on. There’s a kind of silence three hundred feet above the ground, with nothing speaking but the wind. And I miss the look on people’s faces when they realize you’re not falling, you’re gliding.”

Her gaze slid up toward the ceiling, unfocused.

“And sometimes,” she added, quieter, “I miss looking at my reflection and thinking, ‘That’s mine,’ instead of seeing my mother, the Court, and everything they claimed I represented.”

A long pause.

“But glamour isn’t all or nothing,” she said finally. “It’s not like taking off a coat. It’s layers. Choices.” She tapped her temple. “If I want to wear my old shape again, I can. For a song. For a night. For you.”

There was a teasing lilt on the last word, but it didn’t quite cover the earnestness underneath.

He reached up without quite deciding to and brushed a thumb along her cheekbone.

“Show me?” he asked. “When you’re ready. Not tonight, if it hurts. But someday.”

Her eyes widened, then softened.

“You’re not… disappointed?” she pressed. “That I’m not… like the stories. All wings and light and floating barefoot over dew?”

“I like the way you trip over your own boots,” he said. “It makes you more believable.”

She made an outraged noise, then laughed, half a snort against his hand.

“You are a terrible dragon,” she informed him. “Very bad at flattery.”

“I am being honest,” he said. “And very fond of you. In this shape. In any shape. But you asked why I hadn’t asked. I did not want you to think you had to prove you were truly fey to hold my attention.”

A brief, painful expression crossed her face.

“Too many people have wanted the princess,” she said quietly. “Not the idiot who keeps stealing the good blanket.”

“I want the idiot,” he said. “Preferably not stealing the good blanket, but I will negotiate.”

Her eyes shone, with tears rather than reflected candlelight.

“Okay,” she whispered.

They lay like that for a while, breath mingling, the difficult question eased by what they had said aloud.

After a bit, Rakihi sniffed and scrubbed a hand over her face.

“Also,” she said, lighter again, “let’s be honest. Having wings again could be useful. Purely for… recreational purposes.”

He raised a brow. “Recreational.”

“Imagine the logistics,” she went on gravely. “Night flights over the city. Dramatic entrances. Landing on Lana’s—no, your council table with a flourish just to watch the nobles choke.”

“That would crack the table,” he said.

“Worth it,” she replied.

He tried to picture it: Rakihi in full Court glamour, wings flaring in the candlelight, landing on polished wood with a wicked grin.

He found the image dangerously appealing.

“We will need to reinforce the table,” he said.

She beamed.

“And,” she added, more tentatively, “maybe… sometimes… I could show you what it’s like. With the wings. With glamoured wings at first. Illusion and air. Let you feel the currents. We can’t go too high, not with your seals like this, but… a little. Enough to take the ache out of the dreams.”

Something in his chest twisted.

“We can,” he said at once. “I will speak with Ifret and the others. Find out what the seals allow without risking their purpose.”

From his wrist came a sleepy, sultry murmur only he could hear.

I am amenable to a little wind and spectacle, Ifret said. It has been too long since you courted someone above the clouds.

Fenris’s dry voice followed, amused. Just don’t drop her. I like this one.

Shade suppressed a laugh.

Rakihi watched his expression with the close attention she gave both new songs and old wounds.

“Deal?” she asked softly.

“Deal,” he said.

She curled back into him then, pressing her face into the curve of his neck, one leg sliding between his.

“Good,” she murmured. “Because I don’t want to give this face up just to prove a point to a Court that isn’t even hunting me anymore.”

“You don’t have to prove anything to anyone,” he said into her hair.

“Liar,” she mumbled. “But I’ll take it.”

Her breathing gradually slowed, and the tension left her body. Before long, she was asleep.

He lay awake a little longer, staring into the dim, thinking about wings, courts, and the right to choose who to become.

Beside him, Rakihi’s glamour shimmered faintly at the edges, like heat over stones. It was no mask tonight.

Just a choice.

He tightened his arm around her, closed his eyes, and allowed himself to imagine how the story might one day be told:

Not Rakihana the Bargain.

Rakihi the bard, whose wings—when she chose to wear them—were hers and no one else’s.

Chapter 25: An Invitation Home

Dinner that night was quiet, a rarity worth savouring.

No emergencies, no messengers. Just roasted vegetables, decent bread, a sweet glaze Rakihi had persuaded an inn cook to share, and the slow unwinding of a week that had, so far, made no attempt to kill them.

Naturally, that was when the wards shivered.

The air elementals in the rafters arched like startled cats. Sparky, curled in the stove, puffed a warning jet of flame.

Then came three measured knocks at the front door.

Metal against wood. The same rhythm as before.

Shade put his cup down.

“That’s your mother’s rhythm,” Arcebek said, nose wrinkling. “You have very annoying relatives.”

“I know,” he said, and pushed his chair back.

He opened the door. A breath of cold, high-altitude air slipped past him, utterly out of place in their street.

The same courier as before waited outside: storm-hued skin, dragonsteel coat, the faint scent of an open sky.

“Shade,” they greeted him this time, with a small bow. “Another word from the Empress.”

They offered a cylinder slimmer than the others, its cap chased with an elaborate crest. A personal seal this time, not one from the war office.

Shade took it, nodded to the courier. “Wait here,” he said. “There may be a reply.”

“I am at her service,” the courier replied. “And yours, until this task is done.”

Shade shut the door and returned to the dining room, already aware of three pairs of eyes following his approach.

Rakihi had risen halfway from her chair. Arcebek sat in the peculiar stillness that meant she was bracing for nonsense. Elcia laid down her fork and folded her hands.

He sat back down and turned the cylinder in his hands.

No war-script hummed beneath the metal. Only the familiar prickle of his mother’s magic.

He twisted it open.

A narrow strip of parchment uncurled into his palm.

It would please me if my wayward son would be bothered to come and present his paramours to his beloved mother.

At earliest convenience, of course.

— Empress of the Blue Flight

Beneath her title sat the same tiny flourish she had once used on shopping lists.

Shade read it twice.

Then he handed it to Rakihi.

Her eyes swept the invitation and widened.

“Paramours?” she squeaked. “Oh gods, she knows.”

“She was bound to learn,” Arcebek said, accepting the strip. “You can’t hide a dragonslayer polycule from a court that gossips through weather patterns.”

Elcia read it last. Her mouth twitched at wayward son, but her attention settled on earliest convenience.

“In her court,” she said, “that means…?”

“Last week,” Shade said dryly. “Possibly last century.”

Shade exhaled.

“She wants to meet you. Formally, at the Flight’s court. ‘Beyond the skies, beyond this reality,’ as our poets insist on saying.”

Rakihi blinked. “The place you warned us about? Where everything is a symbol and everyone has too many teeth?”

“That’s the short version, yes,” he said.

Arcebek tilted her head. “Is this optional?” she asked.

He studied the invitation. Its almost teasing tone was unmistakably hers.

“Yes, in that she won’t drag us there in chains. No, in that refusing would hurt her. Then she’d grow curious, and curious dragons meddle.”

“That’s a vote for ‘go sooner rather than later,’” Arcebek murmured.

Elcia nodded. “Better to choose our timing than have her choose it for us,” she said. “And if you wish us to stand with you there, I will not let you go alone.”

Rakihi looked between them, then back at Shade.

“How bad can it be?” Rakihi asked, with the optimism of someone who had never lived at the Blue Court. “We survived your council. And my mother.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “But this will be both at once. With more lightning.”

His first instinct was to refuse: to shield them from the cold, glittering cruelty a bored court could wield, and keep their warm, untidy life far from those halls.

But the invitation said, It would please me.

She had already told him to do things his way. This was no command.

It was an attempt to reach him.

He let that weigh against the rest.

“Do you want us to meet her?” Elcia asked quietly.

He looked at her.

Arcebek's chin was set in the familiar way that meant she would walk into hell with him, then complain about the décor.

Rakihi was making a heroic and unsuccessful effort to conceal her nerves.

"Yes," he admitted. "If you don't come, she'll invent stories about you. They'll be wrong, but she'll act on them anyway."

Rakihi made a face. "That does sound like a her thing to do," she admitted.

Arcebek drummed her fingers once on the table.

"Then we go. Soon, before 'earliest convenience' turns into your mother appearing in the training yard to inspect the merchandise."

Shade choked. "That is not a phrase I needed associated with my love life and my mother."

Rakihi snorted.

Elcia's mouth twitched despite herself.

"All right. Together, then. I'll tell the courier to expect us in a tenday. That gives us time to prepare the guild, warn the council, and arrange for someone to stop the building catching fire."

"And time," Arcebek said dryly, "for me to send a very polite letter to my senior partners informing them that I will be unavailable due to 'unplanned interplanar family obligations.'"

Rakihi perked up. "Ooh, can I help write that?"

"No," Arcebek said. "I want them to take it seriously."

Elcia sighed. "I will need to speak to the watch captain," she said. "And to the temple. Someone will have to cover my rotations. And Kael Varis will want to know why I am voluntarily stepping into another court's judgement hall."

Shade winced in sympathy.

Rakihi poked him with her spoon. "And you, Guildmaster, have to find someone to sit in your cursed chair while we're gone."

"I know. If we vanish for days without warning, the council will assume abduction, treason, or elopement."

Rakihi's eyes sparkled. "We could elope," she teased. "Just… in the opposite direction."

"Focus," Arcebek said, but there was a smile tugging at her mouth.

Shade nodded.

"I'll give the courier our answer. One tenday. Prompt enough to show respect without making it look as though we're running at her call."

He stood, the chair scraping softly on stone, and went back to the front door.

The courier remained outside, hands clasped behind their back, patient as someone who measured time in weather systems.

"She requests?" they asked.

“She invites,” Shade corrected. “We accept. Tell her I’ll bring my… paramours”—he managed the word without quite wincing—“in one tenday to present our respects. We look forward to her hospitality.”

The courier’s brows rose a fraction at paramours, then at we. They bowed.

“It will be done,” they said. “May your preparations be… sufficient.”

Shade didn’t ask if that was a blessing or a warning.

He went back to the dining room instead.

The rest of the evening went to managing expectations.

Not what he expected of his partners.

What they could expect of his mother.

“She is not… like your mother,” he told Rakihi, once they’d cleared the plates and the elementals had claimed the washing-up with little squeaks of joy.

“Thank gods,” Rakihi muttered.

“She’s what my tutors called a ‘high-functioning catastrophe.’ Three things matter most to her: the Flight’s integrity, the security of its hoards, and the safety of her brood. In that order. Most ordinary offences won’t trouble her.”

“Define ‘ordinary,’” Arcebek said.

“Speaking frankly won’t offend her. Neither will your clothes, unless they’re deliberately insulting. Nor does she expect you to bow every other breath. But she will be deeply interested in any hint of dishonesty.”

Elcia nodded slowly. “You said once she has ‘seeing eyes.’”

“Yes. Not the same as the lie-sight we discussed before, but she knows me, and her instincts are formidable. False flattery won’t fool her. If she suspects you’re hiding why you’re with me, she’ll dig.”

Rakihi winced. “So rule one: don’t lie.”

“No lying,” he agreed. “You may evade or change the subject. But if she asks you directly, either tell the truth or decline to answer. She respects an awkward silence more than a graceful lie.”

“Anything else that might… offend?” Elcia asked.

He thought about it.

“She won’t want you performing for her. She cares more about whether you’re good for me than whether you shine at court. Expect small, pointed tests. She’ll want to see how you respond under pressure.”

Arcebek’s smile sharpened. “Oh, goody,” she said. “Another terrifying elder being trying to poke holes in my arguments. I was getting bored.”

Rakihi poked her in the ribs. “You say that,” she said, “but if she tries to rope us into politics I’m pointing at you and running.”

Elcia’s gaze was distant, thoughtful. “Will she ask about my oath?” she asked. “About Kael Varis?”

“Almost certainly. She’ll want to know if your god’s judgement could fall on me—or on her—and what you would do if it did.”

“I would not,” Elcia said calmly. “Unless she starts selling children to demons.”

“I will tell her that,” he said. “In those exact words.”

Arcebek snorted.

Rakihi chewed on her lip.

“She’ll want to see me,” Rakihi said. “But as what? The girl she almost went to war over? The one my own mother cast aside with a sentence?”

Shade’s heart twinged.

“She’ll want to know whether you were worth the risk,” he said, because soothing her with a lie would be worse. “And whether you’ve hurt me. That will matter more than the insult.”

Rakihi’s mouth went thin.

“I haven’t,” she said.

“I know,” he replied.

She blew out a breath. “Fine. Then I’ll just have to be… dazzling.”

“You always are,” he said, then reddened when all three of them gave him matching looks.

“Look at that,” Arcebek murmured. “He can flatter.”

The following ten days disappeared into preparations.

At the guild:

Shade spent three days in Lana’s old office reviewing contingencies with the senior clerks and three trusted Gold captains.

“You all know how this place runs,” he told them. “I’m just… heavier ballast. I’m leaving Captain Mirenne of Wind Dancers as my voice for tactical decisions, Mistress Harla for coin, and Second Clerk Jorin for paperwork triage. The council has been informed. If something truly catastrophic happens—demonic incursion, Void breach, civil war—you may drag me back. Otherwise, assume I am unavailable.”

“You’re going to see your mother?” Harla asked, squinting over her spectacles.

“Yes,” he said.

She pursed her lips. “Take wine. The right bottle makes mothers remarkably forgiving.”

Mirenne smirked. “We’ll keep the roof on,” she promised. “Go make a good impression. Or a memorable one, at least.”

He sent the council a sealed note as dry as he could make it.

I will be unavailable for approximately one to two tendays on private diplomatic business beyond the city.

The guild will continue to function under the authority of my designated deputies (see attached).

If you receive rumours of dragons in the upper atmosphere, please ignore them.

— Guildmaster Shade

Rakihi nearly choked laughing at the final line.

At Arcebek's work:

Arcebek sat cross-legged on the study floor among neat stacks of contracts and extraplanar correspondence, dictating to an imp who plainly wished itself elsewhere.

"…and inform Senior Partner Valern that I will be 'indisposed due to high-level interplanar obligations' for an indeterminate but likely brief period," she said. "If they attempt to schedule anything in that window, remind them that the last time they did so I sent back their demotion papers by mistake."

The imp wrote at a frantic pace.

"And add," she said, "that no, they may not use my absence to reopen the Hellmouth account. I don't care how lucrative the fees are."

Rakihi popped her head in. "Want me to attach a nice little illusion of teeth to the letter?" she offered.

"No," Arcebek said. "I want them to take it seriously."

"Subtle teeth?" Rakihi tried.

"Absolutely not," Arcebek replied, but she was smiling.

At the watch and temple, Elcia made her own arrangements.

Elcia stood before the watch captain, helm under her arm.

"I will be away for a short period," she said. "Guild business. Possibly… above my standard pay grade."

The captain, an older woman with arms like tree trunks and the patience of saints, regarded her narrowly.

"Trouble?" she asked.

"Family," Elcia replied, with the faintest glint of humour. "Not mine. His."

The captain winced in sympathy. "Say no more," she said. "We'll cover your rounds. Just don't come back with a dragon-shaped badge and expect me to salute it."

"I would never," Elcia said gravely.

Later, Elcia knelt in a quiet side chapel. The faint attention of Kael Varis settled around her like cool air.

"I am going into another court's hall," she told the god whose scales weighed hearts. "By my own will. To stand with one whose ledger is… complicated."

No words came in answer, only an unmistakable impression:

⚖️

Observe. Weigh. Do not bind. You go as companion, not as my hand.

She bowed her head.

"Yes," she said aloud. "I understand."

With Rakihi:

Rakihi's preparations involved clothes, music, and an alarming amount of overthinking.

“What does one wear to impress a dragon empress?” she demanded on the third evening, standing in the middle of their room wearing nothing but a chemise and a frown. “Do I go full Court? Wings, silk, the whole terrifying package? Do I go ‘simple mortal bard’ to make a point? Do I—”

“Wear what makes you feel like yourself,” Shade said gently, still polishing his sword.

She threw a stocking at him.

“That is not helpful,” she said. “You’re immune to fashion. You’d wear the same plate to your own execution.”

“Yes,” he said. “It’s good plate.”

In the end she chose cleaned and mended travel leathers, and a cloak that hinted at Court colours without imitating them. She would keep her wings hidden until she chose to reveal them.

And with each other:

Not swordplay.

Not spellwork.

Not spells.

Truth.

Shade gathered them, separately and together, and asked the questions his mother might put to them.

“Why him?” he asked Rakihi, blunt, holding her gaze. “What do you get from this?”

“Noise,” she said without hesitation. “Chaos. Someone who takes me seriously when I’m stupid and stupidly when I’m serious. Shelter. And the one person who doesn’t look at me like a treaty waiting to happen.”

“Why them?” he asked Arcebek.

“Sharp minds,” she said. “Honest hands. Shared trauma. A bed that doesn’t feel like a battlefield. And a dragon who actually listens when I say ‘that clause will bite you.’”

“Do you intend to turn my judgement on my son?” he asked Elcia, voicing the exact fear his mother might have.

“No,” she said, calm as a closing book. “Not unless he starts selling children to demons. Or you ask me to.”

They held that gaze a moment, then both nodded.

By the last night, the fear remained.

But it had acquired edges: questions they could answer and plans they could follow.

They lay tangled together in the big bed, the manor quiet around them, and Shade listened to the three heartbeats pressed up against his ribs.

“Beyond the skies,” Rakihi whispered, somewhere between excitement and dread. “Beyond this reality.”

“Beyond your mother,” Arcebek added wryly.

“Beyond our jurisdiction,” Elcia murmured.

In the darkness Shade pictured the court without flinching:

A high, cold hall. His mother on her throne.

His three partners entering beside him.

Chapter 26: The Gate to the Blue Flight

The gate opened like a wound in the sky.

One moment they stood in the manor courtyard, bags at their feet, while Rakihi complained about a missed braid. The next, a clean tear opened in the air and daylight spilled through as though someone had cut noon itself.

Wind hit them first.

Not the wind of streets or mountains, but air that had never touched a chimney or carried the smell of a cooking fire. It tasted of lightning and the cold above the clouds.

The tear widened.

Beyond the opening, dark metal caught the light without reflecting it. Past the threshold lay sky: endless, layered, restless sky.

Shade exhaled slowly.

“Ready?” he asked.

“No,” Rakihi said. “Yes. Absolutely not. Let’s go.”

Arcebek adjusted her staff, blind eyes turned toward the gate with the wary interest of someone hearing a language she almost remembered.

Elcia settled the unfamiliar weight of formal armour over her shoulders. Cleaner and more neutral than her watch equipment, it still allowed her to move.

They stepped through together.

Behind them, reality closed with a soft, almost courteous click.

The platform beneath their feet was made of dark-blue metal, neither quite steel nor stone. Sigils hummed along its edges. With no walls or railings, three sides opened onto a fall that vanished into storm clouds.

Above, the sky was a riot.

Clouds shouldered past one another in slow battles. Lightning stitched them together in languid arcs, striking up, down and sideways. The distant currents pulled the clouds into patterns that meant something to those raised to read them.

Shade had.

He forced his shoulders to relax.

“Welcome home, Skysunder,” a voice said.

He turned.

The escort waited at the far end of the platform, where a wide arch of the same dark metal framed an opening into something like a hallway.

Six escorts waited there, all in humanoid form, all subtly wrong to mortal eyes.

The leader stepped forward.

The leader stood a handspan taller than Shade, broad-shouldered beneath a sleeveless coat that exposed scaled forearms. His hair was the pale silver of a storm cloud's edge. Slit-pupilled eyes flashed brilliant blue.

"Thundercall," Shade said, before he could stop himself.

The other man's face cracked into a grin that was mostly teeth.

"There he is," Thundercall said. "Little brother finally drags himself home."

They clasped forearms.

Their forearms met, and memory rushed through Shade: training flights, shared scoldings, and the time they had nearly split a valley wrestling over a misjudged jump.

"You look good," Thundercall said, stepping back to study him. "Smaller. But good."

"I am as tall as you," Shade said.

"In the wrong shape," Thundercall replied. "We'll fix that later."

His gaze slid past Shade then, to the three women standing just behind him.

Rakihi stared hungrily at the sky, her cloak stirring in the high wind. Arcebek held her chin high and her staff steady, though the pressure of raw magic set a tremor in her fingers. Elcia watched the exits, the floor and the distances between them.

Thundercall's eyebrows climbed.

"These," Shade said, a little stiffly, "are Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia. My partners."

Rakihi wiggled her fingers in a little wave.

Thundercall bowed, not mockingly. Whatever else he was, he'd been briefed.

"An honour to meet those who kept him from dying somewhere boring," he said. "Welcome to the heart of the Flight."

"Nice sky," Rakihi blurted.

Thundercall's grin flashed again.

"It likes to show off," he said. Then, voice dropping just a fraction, to Shade: "She's in a mood."

"Good or bad?" Shade asked quietly.

Thundercall grimaced. "Both. She's proud, offended and curious. She's been pacing the east balcony muttering about fey courts and 'my idiot child collecting trouble.' Don't lie to her, don't diminish what these three mean to you, and don't mention Moonthorn unless you want to see her chip a fang."

"Understood," Shade said.

"Come on," Thundercall added, clapping him once on the shoulder. "She sent honour guard and opened the main gate. That's as close to 'I missed you' as she gets in public."

The "honour guard" fell into formation around them as they walked through the arch.

The honour guard wore humanoid shapes, though every one carried a tell: eyes too bright, scales rippling at a wrist, a glimpse of sharpened teeth as they exchanged words in Storm Cant. The courtesy was deliberate. Among dragons, one old rule of hospitality was to match the most fragile guest's shape.

Today, that was the mortals.

They walked through the palace.

Palace was too small a word.

Mortal palaces were buildings. This was an act of will.

Metal and stone came from places no ordinary map could name. Their colours shifted as the visitors moved. Balconies opened onto raw cloud, lightning crawled along their rails, and the floors answered distant thunder.

Some walls were waterfalls held upright by invisible force. In one passage, the ceiling was stone; in the next, it was open sky.

Rakihi kept letting out involuntary little sounds of delight.

"Did you see that?" she whispered as they passed a side-chamber where a dragon in humanoid form—scaled hands, human face—played something like a harp made of hanging icicles. The sound slid along Shade's bones.

"Yes," he murmured.

A moment later: "That balcony has no rail," from Elcia, half-appalled, half-impressed.

"It's ten floors up," Shade said mildly. "A rail would be an insult."

"A lawsuit waiting to happen," Arcebek muttered under her breath. "If any of you fall, I am not explaining 'sorry, your paladin fell off a cloud.'"

The dragons they passed looked.

Of course they did.

Some glanced once and moved on. Others watched the three visitors as though weighing an unfamiliar problem.

No one showed teeth.

More than anything else, that restraint told Shade his mother had set the terms of their welcome.

Then the doors loomed.

They weren't carved or painted.

Two enormous slabs of dark-blue metal rose before them, silver veins pulsing in time with the thunder. A dragon could pass through without brushing its horns.

The honour guard split, taking up positions.

Thundercall stepped aside.

"Main throne room," he said. "She doesn't drag just anyone in here anymore."

Shade recognised the significance.

Shade swallowed once. Loud in his own ears.

He looked back at his partners.

“You can still turn back,” he said. He owed them the choice, even now.

Rakihi’s eyes flashed. “Absolutely not.”

Arcebek raised a brow. “We didn’t come all this way to sit in the lobby.”

Elcia set her hand briefly on his arm. “We walk in together,” she said. “Or not at all.”

He nodded.

The doors whispered open.

The main throne room opened before them like a precipice given a floor.

Long silver lines ran through dark stone towards the dais. Where walls should have stood, storm clouds curved around open air. Lightning climbed invisible channels at the edges.

On a raised platform of polished stone, untouched by any mountain, stood a throne.

It was not as big as you might expect.

It didn’t need to be.

Bone, metal, stormglass and things that seemed less like matter than ideas forced into shape. Looking at it too long made Shade’s eyes ache.

On it:

His mother.

She had chosen a humanoid shape for her visitors, but even that courtly concession could scarcely contain her.

Her hair fell like a storm front, dark threaded with silver. Scales shone at her throat and forearms; her slit-pupilled eyes had the fierce blue of a sky about to break.

Heat shimmered around her throne, though the air was cold enough to catch in the lungs.

At the proper distance, Shade stopped. His knees remembered court etiquette before he did.

He went to one knee.

Behind him, he heard Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia follow suit—awkward, maybe, but sincere.

“Rise, Skysunder,” the Empress said.

He did.

“Mother,” he said.

For an instant, something softened beneath her imperial composure.

“My wayward child returns,” she said. “With interesting… accessories.”

Rakihi made a strangled sound at accessories. Arcebek’s mouth twitched, while Elcia kept her shoulders straight.

Shade didn’t smile.

“You sent for us,” he said. “You wished to meet the people I’ve been… investing my time in.”

“Oh, is that what we’re calling it,” she said, amused. “Very well. Introduce them. Properly.”

He turned, gestured.

“This is Rakihi,” he said. “Bard. Sorceress. Former Moonthorn princess. She chose exile rather than a cage.” A pause. “You nearly had to write a war-letter about her.”

The Empress’s eyes flickered.

“A void-fae tangle,” she said thoughtfully. “Yes. I recall the storm that nearly was.”

Rakihi swallowed, squared her shoulders and met the Empress’ss gaze.

“Your Majesty,” she said. “I’m the reason your son eats less and smiles more. I hope that helps.”

Silence held for one long heartbeat.

Then the Empress barked a laugh.

“Oh, I like you,” she said.

Then her attention settled on Arcebek.

“And this one?”

“Arcebek,” Shade said. “Warlock. Contract-weaver. She sees more than most of your heralds ever will. She has also prevented me signing three separate things that would have been… embarrassing.”

Arcebek bowed her head, not too low.

“Your Majesty,” she said. “I keep your son from being tricked by people who think they’re clever. I charge standard rates.”

“Spoken like every quartermaster I ever trusted,” the Empress murmured. “Useful.”

Then Elcia.

“And this?” she asked. “The one who smells of scales and ledgers and… something sharp.”

“Elcia Bramblecrown,” Shade said. “Paladin of Kael Varis. Dullahan by curse, my anchor by choice. She has a god of judgement at her back and still chooses to stand with me.”

Elcia bowed from the waist.

“Your Majesty,” she said evenly. “I am not here to weigh you. Or your court. Only to stand beside him if your storms turn… unfriendly.”

The court fell silent.

Thunder rolled.

Then, very slowly, the Empress smiled.

“Good,” she said. “Someone who’ll drag him out of the sky when he forgets his wings have limits.”

The interrogation came without raised voices or threats.

That made it worse.

The Empress simply asked questions.

Simple, awful questions.

To Rakihi: “Why him? You could have had a court. A throne. Why this battered, stubborn half-dragon in a backwater city?”

Rakihi, voice steady despite the way her fingers twisted in her cloak: “Because with him, I am a person first and a problem second. Not the other way around.”

To Arcebek: “Do you see him as an investment? A power-source? A stepping stone?”

Arcebek, dry as old paper: “I’ve seen what happens to people who try to ride a dragon like a ladder. I prefer a stable floor. He is… a good floor.”

A huff from the Empress at that, halfway between amusement and affront.

To Elcia: “If your god told you to cut his throat, would you?”

Elcia did not flinch.

“If Kael Varis judged him to be a danger to the innocent, beyond redemption, and all amends refused?” she said. “Then yes. But I do not believe that will happen. And until it does, my oath to him stands.”

The Empress stared at her for a long, electric moment.

“Interesting,” she said softly. “You bind yourself to sharp things, Skysunder.”

“I do,” Shade said. “You taught me to.”

Her gaze snapped towards him.

She asked her own questions.

She asked about the guild, the Void wars that still visited his dreams, and, with disarming directness, whether he was happy.

He answered as truthfully as he could, conscious of the sky listening beyond the open hall.

When she was done, she leaned back in her throne, studying the four of them.

“So,” she said at last. “This is the hoard you’ve started.”

Shade opened his mouth to protest the word, then shut it again.

“Yes,” he said. “Part of it.”

Her eyes gleamed.

“You could have done worse,” she said. “And better is… unlikely.”

From her, it was as close to a blessing as he could expect.

She flicked two fingers.

Attendants in servant shapes appeared and bowed.

“Show them their rooms,” she said. “The east guest wing. Not the formal suites; the ones with doors that lock properly.” A glance back to Shade. “You remember the way. Dinner after sunfall. Don’t be late. I want to see if your mortal cooks have ruined your standards.”

The conversation was over.

They bowed, in the various shaky, mismatched ways people who hadn’t been raised kneeling before empires managed.

Attendants led them away through a passage that smelled less of ceremony than of rain.

The guest rooms were extravagant, even by the standards of this place.

Even the “less formal” ones.

Each received a chamber large enough for a gathering, with windows open to the storm behind shimmering barriers. The beds could resize themselves with a touch. The baths filled with warm water unlike any river water Rakihi had ever felt.

Naturally, all four ended up in Shade’s chamber.

The door shut; the lock hummed.

Only then, for the first time since entering the gate, did everyone exhale.

Rakihi flopped face-first onto the bed, then rolled onto her back.

“Okay,” she said. “That was so much.”

Arcebek laughed, a short, surprised sound.

“Your mother is…” she said, searching for a word. “Terrifying. In a… competent way. I hate that I respect her.”

Elcia moved to the window, looking out at the storm.

“The floor hums,” she said. “Not like a ship. Not like a temple. Like… standing in the throat of a thunderhead.”

Shade leaned against a carved bedpost, studying them.

“What did you notice?” he asked.

He meant it.

They saw his home through eyes he no longer possessed. He wanted to understand what they saw.

Rakihi counted on her fingers.

“The guards’ boots,” she said. “They don’t make noise. Not because of magic—because the floor eats the sound. So voices carry better. That’s a bard’s nightmare.”

Arcebek smirked. “The walls aren’t just pretty,” she said. “Every pattern was a ward. Half those ‘decorative’ lightning channels are probably rerouted killing fields. If something breaches this place, it will regret it.”

Elcia turned from the window.

“Your mother didn’t look at us like… toys,” she said. “Or problems. She looked at us like… variables in an equation where you were the constant. I expected more contempt.”

Shade blinked at the observation.

“She fears for you,” Elcia added. “But not in a ‘how dare these mortals touch my son’ way. In a ‘if he loses them, he will break something important’ way.”

Rakihi sat up suddenly.

“And the sky,” she said. “You never told me it sings.”

He frowned. “It doesn’t.”

“It does,” she argued. “Not like music. But there’s… a pattern. The lightning. It’s not random. It’s… I don’t know. A score. Written in flashes. That’s why you lot stare at it so much, isn’t it? You’re reading the weather like a song.”

He opened his mouth to object.

Then thought better of it.

“That’s… not entirely wrong,” he admitted.

Rakihi beamed, absurdly pleased.

Arcebek stretched out on the chaise by the window, staff laid within easy reach.

“And the throne room,” she said. “No railings. No real walls. If someone panics, they’re over the edge. That’s deliberate. It keeps everyone… honest. Makes sure no one forgets where they are.”

Elcia nodded. “And there were no lesser dragons in dragon-form in there,” she said. “Only your mother. That was respect. Or fear. Or both.”

Listening to them, Shade finally understood something he had forgotten.

To him, this had always been ordinary.

The singing storms, the humming floors, the pressure of his mother’s presence.

To them it was beautiful, frightening, exasperating—and entirely new.

“Thank you,” he said quietly.

Rakihi tilted her head. “For… what?”

“For seeing it,” he said. “For telling me. I forget, sometimes, what this place looks like when you haven’t been born into it.”

She smiled, softer now.

“That’s what we’re here for,” she said. “To point at the obvious and go ‘hey, that’s weird,’ so you remember it is weird.”

Arcebek yawned, tension easing from her shoulders.

“We have, what, a couple of hours before dinner?” she said. “Time enough to nap, panic, and argue about clothes again.”

Elcia allowed herself a small smile.

“Or,” she said, “we could simply… rest. For a little while. Before round two.”

In the end, they managed both.

Rakihi dozed with her head on Shade’s thigh, murmuring about lightning patterns. Arcebek fell asleep halfway through constructing her third contingency plan, one hand still curved around her staff. Elcia watched the storm until the strain left her face.

Shade leaned back against the carved post and let the sounds of their breathing and the distant, endless thunder wrap around him.

The place where he had grown up.

And the life he had built elsewhere, meeting at last.

It should have felt like a fracture.

Instead, uneasily but unmistakably, it felt as though two storms were learning to share one sky.

Chapter 27: The Empress’ss Table

Dinner with the Empress felt less like a formal execution than a family reunion conducted in the middle of a thunderstorm.

Instead of the throne room, they entered a long, low hall, open to the storm on one side. A crescent-shaped table curved around a pit of slow, contained lightning.

Dragons had very specific ideas of ambience.

Shade sensed the extra guests before he saw them.

Three figures waited beside the Empress’ss seat.

One wore black and storm-grey, her hair bound in a severe braid and her thunderhead eyes fixed ahead with a general’s discipline.

Another lounged with her boots propped on a chair, silver hair tangled about her face and rings glittering on every finger.

The third had cropped dark curls, a sleeveless coat and gold bars through both ears. She drummed on the table in a rhythm the lightning answered.

His sisters.

Blackthunder noticed him first.

“Well, well,” she said, standing smoothly. “Look who finally remembered which sky he was born under.”

Swiftlightning slid off the chair in a liquid motion. “He brought mortals,” she stage-whispered, delighted. “And they’re all pretty. We’re keeping them, yes?”

Thunderfurry just leaned on the back of a chair and grinned like she’d been waiting for this all week.

“Hi, runt,” she said.

Shade actually laughed.

“Blackthunder. Swift. Furry.” He embraced each in turn, clasping forearms before pulling them close. The scent of ozone, cold metal and something uniquely familiar pierced his carefully controlled composure.

To his surprise, they abandoned the formal forearm greetings for ordinary hugs. Swiftlightning even head-butted his shoulder.

“You grew,” Blackthunder observed, pulling back to eye him up and down. “Finally started eating properly?”

“He found people who feed him,” Thunderfurry said. “Look at his hair. That’s a ‘my partners make sure I sleep sometimes’ shine.”

Rakihi, Arcebek and Elcia tried not to stare. None succeeded.

Shade cleared his throat.

“These are my sisters,” he said. “Blackthunder, first of this clutch. Swiftlightning, third. Thunderfurry, seventh. Please do not ask why her name is that.”

“I lost a bet,” Thunderfurry said serenely.

Rakihi’s mouth opened and closed twice. Arcebek swallowed laughter. Elcia composed her features into something politely neutral with visible effort.

Introductions followed.

Blackthunder shook their hands like a commander meeting new officers. Swiftlightning shamelessly kissed Rakihi’s knuckles and Arcebek’s wrist. Thunderfurry studied Elcia, then nodded when the paladin held her gaze.

The Empress watched the reunion with the forbearance of someone accustomed to unruly children, then straightened.

“Sit,” she said. “Eat. Talk.”

They did.

Food arrived in waves, as was only proper for dragons.

There was seared meat from creatures unknown to mortal plains, vegetables prepared with herbs from gardens that grew only in the sky, and, to Shade’s private delight, baskets of perfectly ordinary bread and butter.

His mother always paid attention.

The conversation rose and fell with the courses.

His sisters, predictably, opened fire first.

“So,” Swiftlightning said to Rakihi around a mouthful of something spicy, “what was he like as a mortal baby? Was he very confused? Did he try to organize your kitchen by ‘strategic value’?”

“He still does that,” Rakihi said. “I woke up once and he’d reordered my sheet music by ‘potential combat utility.’”

Blackthunder snorted. “That tracks.”

They demanded stories.

Shade deflected what he could, but his sisters and partners outnumbered him six to one.

Rakihi told the story of his first dragon sighting in the mortal field, how he’d stubbornly refused to show his true form until she bullied him into it, how he’d panicked about rumours and she’d gone around the city loudly calling him “totally-not-a-dragon, promise.”

Arcebek added the goblin-cave incident in crisp, careful terms, mentioning the way his seals had cracked and how he’d melted stone without meaning to.

Elcia spoke more quietly about the death-god confrontation; how he’d stood between a cult and a cursed halfling and forced a deity to blink first.

Blackthunder listened without missing a detail.

Thunderfurry laughed in all the wrong places and some of the right ones.

Swiftlightning kept studying Shade, as though trying to reconcile the runt she remembered with the man before her.

His sisters were just as curious about his partners.

“How many fights have you pulled him out of?” Blackthunder asked Elcia at one point.

“Three and a half,” Elcia said, deadpan.

“A half?” Thunderfurry demanded.

“He stopped before I reached him,” Elcia replied. “It still counts.”

The Empress let the conversation find its own shape.

She let them swirl.

Only occasionally did she interrupt with a pointed question:

“You said ‘Black Squad.’ Explain.”

“Your guildmaster retired. Why?”

“What, exactly, is a bar fight in this city of yours and why are my future grandchildren in it so often?”

Shade answered when he could. His partners filled in details. His sisters supplied embarrassing anecdotes from his youth to balance the ledger.

Beneath all that power, it was strangely ordinary.

Just family dinner, with extra lightning.

At last the dishes cleared themselves, and the storm beyond the hall deepened to the bruised colours of evening.

The Empress rose.

“Skysunder,” she said. “Walk with me.”

The room stilled.

Shade stood.

His sisters didn’t move to follow. They knew that tone.

Rakihi’s hand brushed his under the table, a brief squeeze. Arcebek gave the smallest of nods. Elcia met his eyes, calm.

He followed his mother out.

The skyfields were quieter.

Not silent—there was never silence here—but quiet in the way a battlefield was quiet once the fighting had ended.

They stepped onto a broad plain of dark, living metal. No walls. No throne. Only open space.

Here, the sky felt closer.

Low clouds hung heavy around them. Lightning shone in lazy veins, and the thin air stung at the lungs of anyone not born to it.

His mother walked to the centre and stopped, hands clasped loosely behind her back.

For a while, they simply stood together, watching the storm.

Then, without looking at him, she said:

“Show me.”

He knew what she meant.

He swallowed.

“You’ve seen me in the fields,” he said. “During the war.”

“You know that is not what I’m asking,” she replied.

He did.

In battle he had been half-mad with purpose, while the gods’ seals tightened and loosened in violent pulses, directing him like a spear.

This was different.

“Nothing here can break beyond my power to repair,” she said. “The fields will adjust, the wards will hold, and your lovers are well beyond the blast. I want to see what you’ve become when you stop making yourself small.”

His unsteady breath would have horrified his tutors.

“The seals,” he said.

Her gaze flicked to the bracelet on his wrist.

“Ask them,” she said simply.

He did.

Ifret. Terra. Fenris. Buyakugan. Djing. Djang. Will you let me? Once, here, where the fields can hold me?

Warm amusement first, from Ifret.

I was wondering when you’d remember how to stretch, she purred.

Terra’s steady weight followed. The ground here is made for it. We will hold.

Fenris was dry, but not unkind. Do not get used to this, she said. But yes. Once. So your mother can stop imagining and start knowing.

The twins whispered like a half-heard breeze. Big big big, they sang. Show the storm its own reflection.

The stones at his wrist flared, one after another, then all together.

For the first time since entering the mortal world, since he had allowed the goddesses to bind him with element and oath, the seals loosened.

They did not break.

Not shattered.

They simply yielded.

The familiar pressure of being compressed, of folding his wings and holding every breath too small, began to ease.

He drew in air.

It tasted like home.

“Step away,” he told his mother quietly. “Just in case.”

She snorted. “If you hit me, I will bite your tail,” she said, but she did take three paces back.

He closed his eyes.

Let go.

It was nothing like the careful transformation he had shown his lovers in the mortal world.

This was… unfolding.

His bones lengthened, then lengthened again. Each vertebra hummed as it settled into place. Limbs thickened and claws unfurled; horns swept back from his skull. His jaws stretched, bearing teeth made to rend gods.

Wings burst from his back, vast membranes cracking open like sails catching a hurricane.

The skyfields took it.

The living metal rippled beneath him, expanding to make room.

He rose.

Past house-size.

Past castle-size.

Past “this is absurd.”

His awareness expanded with his body.

He could feel the storm.

Lightning curled around his horns like affectionate creatures. The thin air offered no resistance; his lungs drew it in and made it strength.

He opened his eyes.

Everything below seemed impossibly small.

The skyfields spread beneath him like a country-sized disc, its metal laced with sigils and anchored to nothing he could name. Beyond its edge curved another world: the Founding Sphere his mother had always called theirs.

He realised, with remote astonishment, that he had grown larger than the mountain range he once used as a couch.

He moved—carefully—and the air boomed.

Far below, at the centre of the skyfield, his mother had taken her full form.

She was enormous. A storm-dragon that had once cowed armies into dropping their weapons just by passing overhead.

Yet even she was smaller than he was now.

She craned her neck up, eyes shining like twin suns.

A slow, proud smile bared too many teeth.

“Look at you,” she said, voice rolled in thunder. “Of your living siblings, you are the biggest now. Quite a change from the runt who used to hide under my wing whenever the Void screamed.”

He rumbled.

It came out as a sound that shook lightning loose from clouds.

You fed me well, he managed, the language of dragons sliding easily now that he had the right throat. And I have been… busy.

Her laugh was a cascade of thunderheads collapsing.

“Modest,” she said. “Terrifying, but modest.”

He shifted his weight, testing the limits.

Here, there seemed to be none.

For once he did not need to hold himself back for the sake of a city, a battlefield, a guild hall or anyone fragile enough to suffer from his presence.

Just sky.

He stayed there longer than he meant to.

He remembered, deep in his bones, what he had been made for before the seals, the oaths and the endless work of protecting others.

Remembering, in his bones, what he had been made for, before oaths and seals and councils and beds with too many limbs in them.

Eventually, he folded back.

He shrank slowly, layer by careful layer, because anything faster might have overwhelmed him.

From world-sized to mountain, from mountain to fortress, from fortress to a castle with wings. Smaller still, until he reached the form his lovers knew.

Then he contracted into human shape, and the goddesses settled the seals into place like familiar clasps.

Back in human skin, he swayed, his heart pounding from something other than exertion.

His mother had resumed her humanoid form as well.

She looked… satisfied.

Beneath her satisfaction, he saw relief.

“That answers that set of questions,” she said.

“What set?” he asked, voice rough.

“‘Will the next time I send him into the dark be the last because he finally outgrew his skin and shattered something important,’” she said lightly. “The Void has been… unusually silent of late. For once, I am not planning an army. I wanted to know if I could afford to leave my favourite weapon in its sheath a while longer.”

He grimaced. “I am not—”

“Don’t,” she said sharply. “Pretend you were not forged as such. You are more now. But you are not less that. I will not insult you by lying about it.”

He let the truth settle between them.

She stepped closer, cupped his too-human face in her claw-calloused hands.

“I will not call on you,” she said, quieter, “unless I absolutely must. The seals are yours and your gods’ to manage, not mine to twist. The Void is sleeping with one eye open, but it is not clawing at the door. While it dozes, my brood may… live.”

For an instant her fierce gaze softened, though standing before it still felt like standing too near a lightning rod.

“Enjoy your stay,” she said. “Enjoy your hoard. And your ridiculous guild. Build something there that is not just a war-camp. When the dark howls again, I would rather you remember what you’re fighting for than just what you’re fighting against.”

There it was: a blessing wrapped around a warning.

Blessing and warning in one.

She turned away, the Empress settling back over the mother like armour.

“I have a delegation from the southern fronts to terrify,” she added, back to her usual dry tone. “And three siblings of yours to keep from starting a bet about whether your bard can outdrink a thunder-lord. Go. Tell your mortals whatever part of this will let them sleep tonight.”

Some young part of him wanted to ask her to stay.

But she was already walking away, hair snapping in the wind, shoulders squared against the storm.

Empress.

Mother.

Both.

He watched her go.

Then he headed back inside.

His partners were all waiting in his room.

Of course they were.

Rakihi sat cross-legged on the bed, drumming an anxious rhythm on her knees. Arcebek paced before the window, the tip of her staff ticking against the floor. Elcia stood by the wall, watching the door.

They all straightened when he came in.

“Well?” Rakihi demanded, before he’d even shut the door. “Is the sky still standing? Did she yell? Did you yell? Are we at war? Are you—”

He held up a hand.

She bit her tongue.

Arcebek’s brows inched up. “Still alive,” she observed. “Good sign.”

Elcia searched his face. “You look… different,” she said slowly. “Lighter. And very tired.”

He sat on the edge of the bed. His body felt strangely small after the immensity he had just inhabited.

“She wanted to see my true form,” he said. “Not the… polite version. The whole of it. Here, where I couldn’t break anything she cares about by accident.”

Rakihi’s eyes went huge. “Did you?” she breathed. “Like, all the way?”

“Yes,” he said simply.

Arcebek stopped pacing.

“Any… collateral?” she asked.

“No. The skyfields expanded, the wards held, and the goddesses loosened the seals before restoring them. Nothing shattered—except possibly my sense of scale.”

Rakihi edged closer. “How big?” she asked, unable to help herself. “Compared to last time.”

“Last time you saw me,” he said slowly, “I was… castle-sized.”

“Mm-hm.”

“Now,” he said, “imagine the castle as a chess piece on a board. And you are… playing with the whole board.”

Rakihi stared at him, speechless.

“Oh,” she said faintly. “Oh, I’m going to write such an inappropriate song about this.”

Elcia let out a slow breath.

“And your mother?” she asked. “What did she say?”

Shade took a breath.

“She laughed,” he said. “Told me that of my living siblings, I’m the biggest now. That the runt of the clutch has outgrown the rest.”

Rakihi made a delighted little noise at that.

“She promised not to call on me unless the need is absolute. The Void has been quiet. She wants me to enjoy this life—the three of you, the guild—and build something more than a forward camp.”

Arcebek sank down onto the chaise, relief loosening her shoulders.

“So no immediate apocalypse,” she said. “Good. I only packed enough clean socks for one.”

Elcia closed her eyes for a moment, like someone silently updating a prayer.

“And the seals?” she asked. “Any new… conditions?”

“They’re still ours,” he said. “She saw what I become without them. She chose not to demand more. That is… more restraint than some courts would show.”

Rakihi crawled forward until she was kneeling right in front of him.

“So,” she said softly. “Thunder Empress has looked at your disaster of a love life, your mortal guild, your Void scars, and her world-sized kid, and her verdict is…?”

He allowed himself a small smile.

“‘You could have done worse,’” he quoted. “And that better is unlikely.”

Rakihi stared at him.

Then grinned so wide it had to hurt.

“That’s a blessing,” she declared. “In Dragon Mom.”

“It is,” he agreed.

Arcebek’s lips quirked. “I will take ‘unlikely to do better’ from a being who measures success in centuries,” she said. “That’s practically romantic.”

Elcia opened her eyes again, calm settling over her features.

“Then we have space,” she said. “To work. To live. Without waiting for the next war-order to drop every time the wind shifts.”

“For a while,” Shade said. “The dark will howl again. It always does. But until then…”

He looked at them.

Rakihi seemed ready to burst with pride and relief. Arcebek was already reconsidering every contingency plan she had made. Elcia’s joy was quieter, but no less fierce.

“…until then,” he repeated, “we have time. And a guild. And a city that keeps trying to fall apart in interesting ways.”

Rakihi reached up, cupped his face between her hands.

“Then let’s not waste it,” she said.

“Agreed,” Arcebek murmured.

Elcia nodded. “We’ll hold you to that.”

He believed every word.

Since falling into the mortal world like a meteor, Shade had rarely felt free.

Now he felt something he had scarcely expected.

His mother trusted him.

So did his goddesses.

So did the three people who had chosen to share his life.

For a while, at least, he could be more than a weapon.

Chapter 28: An Unwelcome Guest

The envoys arrived two days later, bringing politics in their wake.

Shade sensed the change before anyone announced their arrival.

The palace had grown busier. Corridors once closed to visitors stood open, and balconies that had been deserted during their first days now thrummed with traffic. Servants hurried past additional guards, while dragons in almost-human skins moved between the wings.

Dragons of other flights.

The introductions took place in a lesser audience hall. Representatives of the Red, Gold, Steel, and Green Flights bowed before the Empress, who occupied an “informal” throne grand enough to embarrass most mortal kings. Blackthunder and two elders stood beside her.

Shade and his partners waited just behind the royal party—family, rather than the centre of attention. Supposedly.

That was the theory, at least.

They watched the visitors bow, bargain, and display the exquisite manners of dragons who knew precisely how important they were.

Rakihi leaned towards Shade. “Do they all practise in front of mirrors?”

“For decades,” Shade murmured.

Arcebek tapped her staff against the floor, quietly cataloguing voices and inflections. Elcia watched hands, postures, and gazes that lingered a moment too long.

Gradually, Shade became aware of the attention turning towards him.

He was no longer merely the Empress’s half-human son. He was Skysunder, lately confirmed as the largest of her living brood: a dragon with a sealed storm inside him and three mortals at his side who behaved as though they belonged there.

Most of the attention was discreet.

Most of the visitors were courteous.

The Green Flight’s emissary managed neither.

They crossed paths later in a long gallery, after the delegations had dispersed towards their quarters.

One side of the gallery opened onto the storm, lightning pacing its edge like a restless sentry. Shade and his partners were heading towards their wing when a cluster of visiting dragons approached, their polished court attire threaded with emerald, moss, and forest green.

The Green emissary occupied the centre of the group.

He was tall even for a dragon, with hair layered like leaves and yellow-green eyes the colour of fresh venom. His smile, when he bowed to Shade, satisfied every technical requirement of etiquette.

“Skysunder,” he said. “An… honour.”

“Envoy,” Shade replied.

They passed each other.

It should have ended there.

Shade had nearly passed out of earshot when the emissary spoke again, quietly enough to offer the pretence of discretion.

"…there goes the half-breed," he drawled in Dragonspeech. "Still alive. I cannot imagine why they haven't fed him to the Void and finished with it."

His companions laughed under their breath.

Shade felt his shoulders tighten.

Rakihi understood none of the words, but she heard their meaning in his tone. She glanced at Shade, her eyes narrowing.

Before he could decide whether to turn around, the Blue dragons along the gallery changed their posture.

Not much.

Not enough for anyone to accuse them of reacting.

A scribe paused with her quill in midair. Two guards shifted their weight, their spears tilting by a fraction. One of Blackthunder's lieutenants, who had been leaning in a doorway, went utterly still.

Every gaze settled on the departing Green delegation.

Their message was unmistakable:

He is ours. Mind your tongue.

No one drew steel. No one bared teeth.

Even Rakihi, who spoke no Dragonspeech, felt the air sharpen around them.

The emissary felt it too. His laughter died, and he offered no further insult.

Shade allowed the moment to pass.

He knew this particular courtly dance. He had lived with it all his life.

He kept walking, jaw tight, until another bend in the gallery put them beneath a different stretch of sky.

His partners gave him the rest of the day before asking.

There was another strained meeting, then lunch, during which Thunderfurry tried to teach Rakihi a storm-card game and promptly lost. They spent an hour on a balcony watching lightning trace new patterns across the clouds.

Only that evening, back in their shared sitting room, did the question come. A low fire warmed the carpets, and the fruit platter on the table had already been thoroughly pillaged.

Naturally, Rakihi asked it.

She sprawled across the couch on her stomach, chin propped in her hands, her hair spilling over the edge like blue water.

"So," she began with studied casualness, "entirely unrelated to today's badly dressed salad calling you a half-breed… can we talk about your father?"

Shade froze halfway through removing a bracer.

Arcebek, curled into an armchair with her feet tucked beneath her, tilted her head. “You don’t have to. But I would like to know. You’ve always spoken around him.”

Elcia sat cross-legged near the fire, polishing a pauldron that hardly needed the attention. “If the other flights see you as a problem,” she said carefully, “I want to understand why. Beyond the obvious fact that you frighten them.”

“That does account for quite a lot,” Shade muttered, almost smiling.

He set the bracer aside.

For a while he watched the fire. None of them hurried him.

He had once given Arcebek the shortest possible account: his father was human. Mostly. It was a long story.

Now, at last, he would tell what he knew of it.

“All right,” he said quietly. “My father.”

Rakihi’s curiosity softened into the gentleness she reserved for old wounds.

Arcebek stilled her restless hands.

Elcia set the pauldron down.

Shade interlaced his fingers.

“As far as I know, he was a paladin. Good-aligned, as your world would call it. He served a minor god of roads and refuges on his home plane. His order guarded a place where the Void kept testing the walls of reality.”

Rakihi looked as though she were committing every word to memory. Beside the fire, Elcia straightened at the mention of a paladin.

“My mother arrived with a flight when the threat grew worse,” Shade continued. “Cross-planar seepage. The kind of breach that brings dragons because, if it spreads, whole worlds break—and take their hunting grounds with them.”

“How noble,” Arcebek said dryly. “Saving reality for the sake of dinner.”

“Dragons appreciate reliable food sources,” Shade replied. “And realities that obey their own rules.”

He sobered.

“She met him on the front line. By her account, he was infuriatingly heroic. He kept stepping into gaps so that others would not have to, even after a flight of dragons arrived to reinforce his order. And he argued with her—about collateral damage, about the villages behind the line, about every life she was prepared to count as an acceptable loss.”

Shade’s mouth twitched.

“She found him infuriating,” Shade said. “Then interesting.”

Rakihi’s smile grew. “Oh, she fell for him. Your terrifying Empress-mother met a paladin and lost her mind.”

“Apparently. She had raised clutches before—with dragons and other beings. There had been alliances, experiments, curiosities. She cared for her children, in her fashion. But with him…” Shade paused. “She rarely says the word ‘love’. She said it about him.”

“An irritatingly principled paladin who tells dragons what to do,” Arcebek mused. “Good taste. I might have liked him.”

Elcia’s lips quirked. “Mine as well,” she admitted.

Rakihi looked between them. “Our tastes are becoming alarmingly predictable.”

Shade laughed softly, then returned his gaze to the fire.

“She seldom speaks of him. When I was young, I asked constantly. Her answer never changed: ‘He was good. He was stubborn. Time took him from me. I refuse to let grief make him only a wound.’”

Rakihi’s throat worked.

“Time?” she asked softly. “Not battle? Not the Void?”

Shade offered a small, helpless shrug.

“I don’t know. I suspect battle played a part. Paladins have a talent for dying in difficult places. But even had he survived every war, he was mortal. His years were counted in handfuls. Hers are not.”

His fingers tightened together.

“The other flights called it a passing fascination. Then a political risk: the Matriarch of Blue binding herself to an honourable, short-lived human. When she bore me, the question became harder to ignore. I was no longer merely proof of her choice. I was something they had to decide what to do with—a weapon, and a reminder that she had placed a mortal above their expectations.”

Rakihi scowled. “So Leaf-Brain’s little suggestion about feeding you to the Void was really about resenting the fact that your mother loved a human?”

Shade’s jaw ticked.

“That, and fear of a weapon with attachments. Dragons accustomed to predictable loyalties find those particularly inconvenient.”

“They can choke on their expectations,” Arcebek said. “She loved him. You exist. Neither fact is theirs to approve.”

Elcia leaned forward. “Did you ever meet him? In a vision, perhaps? Or through a memory?”

“Not properly. Only fragments: stories my aunt let slip, a sword hilt in the Hall of Relics that hums when I touch it, old war-visions in which I think I see someone who moves like me, only lighter.” He hesitated. “Once I asked Mother why she would show me no more. She told me, ‘Because I am greedy. He was mine. You are his legacy, not his copy. I will not flatten either of you trying to make you match.’”

The room went quiet at that.

Rakihi’s eyes glistened.

“That’s beautiful,” she whispered.

“Painfully romantic,” Arcebek agreed. “I resent how much I like it.”

“And kind,” Elcia said. “To both of you. She has let you become your own person.”

Shade felt a tension he had carried for years begin to ease.

“I used to be angry with them both. With him for being mortal, with her for choosing someone she would inevitably lose. And with the flights for reminding me that I belonged entirely to neither world.” He stared into the flames. “The older I get, though, the more I wonder whether that is the point.”

Rakihi blinked. “What is?”

“Perhaps I was never meant to fit neatly anywhere. Dragon and paladin’s son. Weapon and person. Enough of both to inconvenience everyone who wants the world divided into tidy categories.”

“You certainly are inconvenient,” Arcebek said fondly.

Elcia nodded. “An ongoing disaster for rigid hierarchies. Kael Varis would approve.”

Rakihi slid off the couch and settled beside him, resting her head against his knee.

“For the record,” she said, looking up, “if Time, the Void, or anything else tries to take you early, I’m going to find whatever afterlife your father went to and shout at him for setting the precedent.”

Shade made a sound balanced precariously between laughter and a sob.

“I’m sure he’d appreciate the company,” he said.

From her chair, Arcebek hooked an ankle around his.

“And I’m glad she loved him,” she said. “Because that gave us you. You’re worth offending a few dragon flights over.”

“Agreed,” Elcia said. “If they cannot see your worth, that is a failing in their judgement, not your blood.”

Shade looked at all three of them.

Rakihi, the fey princess who had fled her mother’s court.

Arcebek, the warlock who had surrendered her eyes yet saw truths others missed.

Elcia, the halfling noble turned dullahan who had entrusted her curse to him.

“My father stood before a breach in reality,” Shade said, “and told the dark it could not touch those behind him.”

He touched the onyx badge at his throat, then glanced at the seal-stones around his wrist.

“I would like to believe some of that stubbornness survived in me. It does make being the Empress’s inconvenient half-human son a little easier to bear.”

Rakihi smiled, slow and fierce.

“I think he’d be proud of the glorious mess you’ve made,” Rakihi said.

Nothing was resolved by that conversation beneath the dragon-haunted sky.

The Greens would continue to whisper. Some flights would always regard him as an error that had survived its making. His mother might not mention his father again for another decade.

Yet with the storm humming beyond the walls and his partners close enough to hear his heartbeat, Shade pictured an unknown paladin on another world, standing before a Void breach with sword in hand.

For once, the image brought no fresh hurt.

It felt like an inheritance.

Chapter 29: The Paladin and the Matriarch

Shade found his mother alone on a side balcony, rather than in a throne room.

She stood at the edge, hair streaming in the wind as she watched lightning traverse the horizon. Beyond her, the palace dropped away into open sky. There was no railing—only air, and the certainty of her footing.

He cleared his throat softly.

“Mother.”

She took her time turning.

“Skysunder. You survived the Greens’ visit without biting anyone. I’m almost disappointed.”

“I considered it, but I thought you might object to washing an envoy off the mirrors.”

She gave a short laugh, then looked at him more closely.

“You have that look. The one you wore as a child when you wanted to ask for something you knew I might refuse.”

He winced. “That obvious?”

“Always.” She tipped her head. “Ask.”

He joined her at the edge, the cold air tugging at his sleeves.

“I want to give them storm gems,” he said, deciding not to circle the subject.

Her eyes narrowed in concentration rather than anger.

“‘Them,’” she repeated. “Your mortals.”

“Rakihi. Arcebek. Elcia,” he said. “Yes.”

She let the silence stretch.

Then she faced him fully, leaning against the invisible boundary between balcony and open sky.

“You remember what such a gift means.” It was a statement, not a question.

“Among the Flight, giving a storm gem is an oath to stand beside someone. To answer when called. To count them as part of our hoard in the old sense—not possessions, but anchors.”

“And you remember its cost. You will feel their danger. You will know if they die.”

He swallowed. “I know.”

“Do they?” she asked.

“Not yet,” he admitted. “I will explain everything before they choose.”

She studied him with a gaze that made him feel simultaneously like a foolish child and a dragon centuries old.

“Then why ask permission? You are grown. The gods in those stones answer to you more readily than to me now. You could bind yourself to three mortals and let the court gossip.”

“Because the gems come from the Flight’s heart. I would be taking pieces of our hoard and our history. And when I give them, I do so not merely as Shade of the guild, but as your son.” He paused. “What I place in the world matters to the other flights.”

Her mouth twitched at his restraint, but she did not interrupt.

“And you imagine giving such treasures to a Moonthorn exile, a warlock bound by contract, and a paladin of another god will make court life easier?”

“No. It will make things clear. They are already the centre of my life in the mortal world. I want to acknowledge it openly.”

She watched him a heartbeat longer.

At length she turned back towards the storm.

“When I was young, I gave a storm gem to a paladin. Your father. The flights nearly choked on the scandal. The Void almost took him. Time took him in the end.” Her hand tightened briefly. “I have never regretted it.”

He said nothing.

“At least your recklessness resembles mine,” she said dryly. “You throw your heart at impossible people. Infuriating child.”

He waited.

Finally, she exhaled.

“You may take three from the lower hoard. Not the primal vein; that remains untouched. Tell the forge-keepers I gave my approval personally. And Skysunder—”

“Yes?”

“Make certain they understand: this is no collar. The oath binds you to them, not them to you. If one of them feels trapped by it, I shall consider that an insult to my craftsmanship.”

He almost smiled. “Yes, Mother.”

“Now go, before I decide you are more entertaining when you are sulking and unattached.”

He bowed as her son rather than as a courtier, and left.

His sisters descended on the others as soon as he mentioned the forge.

“You’re abandoning us?” Rakihi demanded, half-dramatic.

“For a little while. Mother approved something I asked for. I need to make it.”

Swiftlightning’s eyes brightened with understanding. “Oh! Storm business. Go on, then. We’ll entertain them. By which I mean we’ll show them all the parts of this palace you’ve neglected.”

Thunderfurry looped an arm around Rakihi’s shoulders. “You haven’t seen the lightning wells, the sky-library, or the kitchen that doubles as a weapons laboratory.”

“I like the sound of that last one,” Arcebek said.

Elcia glanced at Shade. “You’ll find us?” she asked.

“Always.” The word came out more solemnly than he intended.

She nodded, accepting that.

He watched Rakihi bombard Blackthunder with questions, Arcebek listen to one of Swiftlightning's outrageous stories, and Elcia fall into step beside Thunderfurry. Then he turned towards the palace's oldest halls.

The forge lay deep in the bones of the palace.

Here the air was hot and the metal hummed like a sleeping beast. The storm was not outside but overhead, feeding power through channels hidden in the stone.

The forge-master was an older Blue with hammered-steel skin, nearly white hair, and arms marked by scars no accident could have left.

They looked up at his approach.

"Skysunder. Come to prove you still remember how to hold a hammer?"

He bowed his head respectfully.

"Mother gave her leave," Shade said, offering the sigil-tag she had pressed into his palm. "Three storm gems. For personal work."

The forge-master examined the pattern inscribed on the tag.

One brow rose.

"Three," they said again, one eyebrow rising. "Ambitious."

Shade didn't flinch. "Important."

They considered him for another moment.

"Very well. Follow me."

The forge-master led him into a smaller chamber, part jeweller's workshop and part shrine. A cluster of rough crystals lay on a pedestal of dark stone.

At first glance, they were unremarkable.

Thumb-sized shards of cloudy white crystal, each threaded with pale blue veins.

But power vibrated in the air around them.

Lightning made solid.

"Choose carefully," the forge-master said. "And do try not to faint like your cousin did."

Shade snorted. "You will never let him live that down."

"Correct," they said.

Shade extended his hand over the stones.

The trick was not to choose the brightest.

It was to listen.

Every shard had its own pitch. Some sang of sharp edges and impatience; others carried a deeper, steadier tone.

He listened until three of them began to stand apart.

For Elcia he chose a low, even song with an unwavering note at its centre: judgement and endurance. He could already picture the stone resting over her heart.

For Arcebek, a quick crackle danced around a stable core: clever, restless energy. Something that understood a contract could be a cage until one learned to pick the lock.

For Rakihi, the shard hummed like a chord held just beyond its expected ending. Playful, layered, and full of harmonics that shifted as he turned it. Storm as music rather than weapon.

He placed the three crystals on the workstone.

The forge-master examined them and grunted in approval.

“The anvil and tools are yours. I’ll be nearby if you set fire to anything you didn’t mean to.”

“That only happened once,” Shade muttered.

Soon, Shade lost all sense of time.

He found the familiar rhythm of hammer, tongs, and breath again, this time working not great bars of metal but three small, intricate settings.

For Elcia, he fashioned a strong silver chain with clean, simple lines. The setting held the gem like a weight balanced on a scale, while the clasp bore a discreet mark of Kael Varis.

Arcebek’s ring took the shape of a dragon’s talon, each tiny knuckle carefully defined. The gem rested where claw met finger, catching the light with every movement. He reinforced the band against heat and tearing; warlock work seldom treated jewellery kindly.

Rakihi’s earring was a spiralling cuff that followed the curve of her ear. Its gem would catch the light whenever she turned onstage. He left tiny openings for chains, feathers, or whatever decoration struck her fancy later, and etched a few bars of her favourite melody inside the metal.

By the time he finished, his shoulders ached with the honest satisfaction he remembered from reforging his armour in a village smithy.

He quenched the final piece, polished the settings, and stepped back.

The gems glowed faintly as they settled into their new shapes.

Are you sure? Ifret purred at the edge of his mind.

Yes, he answered.

Then give them, Terra said, warm and steady. *Otherwise you will argue with yourself until they have to roll you off the balcony.*

Shade cleaned his hands, laid the three pieces in a padded box, and went upstairs.

The storm garden had become one of Rakihi’s favourite places in the palace.

It occupied a terrace open to the sky on three sides, where the storm had been coaxed—not tamed—into growing in carefully arranged patterns.

Lightning curled around metal trellises like vines. Floating spheres of contained thunder drifted between crystalline flowers glowing faint blue. The air smelled of ozone and something unexpectedly sweet.

He had sent a runner to gather his partners there.

When he stepped out, they were already there.

Rakihi stood near a trellis, static lifting strands of her hair. Arcebek occupied a stone bench, boots planted firmly as she listened to the strange electrical hum. Elcia held her hand beneath a storm-bloom, watching harmless sparks spill across her skin.

They turned together when he approached.

“You were gone for hours,” Rakihi accused. “Your sisters were taking bets on whether you’d run away with a thunder-spirit.”

“Did you?” Arcebek asked mildly.

“Not today. I had something to make.”

He lifted the box.

Their expressions changed at once.

Rakihi grew wary with anticipation. Arcebek fell quiet, recognising the importance of the moment. Elcia straightened.

Shade sat on a low stone wall and placed the box on his knees. Then he opened it.

Three pieces of jewellery caught the lightning and returned it in glimmers of blue.

He let them look.

After a long moment, Elcia spoke. “Those are not ordinary gems.”

“No,” he said. “They’re storm gems. Cut from the Flight’s hoard.”

Rakihi’s eyes widened. “The heart-stones?” She had listened more carefully at court than she let on.

He nodded.

“Among the Blue Flight, we do not offer these lightly. When one of us gives a storm gem, it is an oath—not for the recipient, but for the giver.”

He looked at each of them before continuing.

“I swear to stand beside you and answer when you call, so far as I am able. I count you as part of my hoard in the oldest sense—not as possessions, but as anchors. If you wear the gem and fall into grave danger, I will feel it. And if you die, I will know.”

Silence.

“I asked my mother’s permission because the gems belong to our Flight as much as they belong to me. She agreed, on one condition: you must understand that this binds me to you. It does not bind you to me. You can remove them, break them, or throw them at my head. Nothing about the oath makes you mine to command.”

Arcebek released a slow breath.

“My patrons would call this a primary contract,” she said, searching for the right comparison. “Only yours has more feelings and less fine print.”

“I hope there is a little fine print,” Rakihi muttered, though her voice trembled.

The stormlight caught in Elcia’s eyes.

“And if we say no?” she asked.

“Then I keep them. Perhaps I use them for something else one day. Perhaps I never do. I will love you and answer when I can either way. The gems only make it easier to find you through the noise.”

He lifted the first piece.

“Elcia,” he said.

Elcia approached, steady-handed despite the quickness of her breathing.

He raised the necklace: a strong silver chain with a storm gem cradled like a weight in a scale.

“For you. It will rest above your heart. If you accept it, I promise to answer when that heart calls—even if Kael Varis disapproves of the hour.”

Elcia laughed softly, her eyes damp.

“May I?” he asked.

She hesitated for a heartbeat, as though reviewing the terms of another sacred vow. Then she bowed her head and swept her hair aside.

He fastened the clasp.

The gem warmed beneath his fingers, its gentle pulse finding a rhythm beside her heartbeat. Shade felt a faint answering tug in his chest, a new connection bright and clear.

Elcia’s shoulders loosened.

“I accept,” she said. “And I… welcome it.”

She turned to face him. The tenderness in her eyes caught him unprepared.

Then he turned to Arcebek.

He picked up the claw-ring.

“I considered making yours subtle,” he said. “Then I remembered who would be wearing it.”

She snorted.

He offered the ring in his open palm. A tiny dragon’s claw curved around the stone, which flickered with captured lightning.

“For the hand that keeps rescuing me from bad contracts and worse bargains. If you accept it, I promise to answer when that hand reaches for help—even if you’ve involved yourself in something spectacularly foolish.”

Arcebek’s mouth quirked.

“If my patrons see this,” Arcebek said, her voice rough, “they’ll have to recalculate half their risk tables.”

“Then they ought to know you have other protections.”

She held out her hand.

He slid the ring onto her finger.

The gem flared and settled into a steady crackle. Shade felt its answer as a sharper tug, almost like a thread about his wrist, humming with an energy as competent and exasperating as the woman before him.

Arcebek flexed her fingers, examining the way the light moved across the ring.

“I accept,” she said. “On one condition.”

His chest tightened. “Name it.”

“If you ever regret this, you tell me. We renegotiate. No martyrdom, and no quiet suffering because you think it would be noble. We handle it like grown idiots, not tragic heroes.”

He exhaled.

“Agreed,” he said. “No tragic heroes.”

“Good,” she said softly. “Then… yes.”

At last, he turned to Rakihi.

He picked up the earring.

The cuff shimmered, its stone a fragment of sky caught in silver.

“I wanted yours to move with you,” Shade said. “To catch the light when you dance and irritate every stuffy courtier forced to watch you perform.”

She let out a shaky laugh.

He held it up.

“For the ear that hears music in lightning. If you accept it, I promise to come when you call, whether you need help or have chosen a catastrophically inconvenient moment to sing. Even if your mother is waiting with her thorns.”

Her throat worked.

“You’re certain?” she whispered. “These gems mean something. Give one to the wrong fey girl and you’ll be hearing about it for centuries.”

“I chose the right one,” he said simply.

Her eyes shone.

“Okay,” she whispered. “Then, yes. I… want it.”

“Left ear?” he asked. “It’s closer to me.”

She huffed a wet laugh and swept her hair back, revealing the delicate curve of her ear.

He fitted the cuff gently along her ear and closed its clasp.

As it clicked closed, it pulsed.

This time, the answering tug came from behind Shade’s eyes, a shared rhythm that reminded him of catching the final notes of Rakihi’s song.

Rakihi sucked in a breath.

“Oh,” she whispered. “That tickles.”

“Sorry—”

“No, it’s lovely. Like finding the one note that makes the whole room sing with you.”

She reached up, fingertips brushing the gem.

“I can feel you,” she whispered. “Only a little.”

“A little is enough. If you start falling, I will know which way to reach.”

Rakihi flung her arms around him, nearly toppling him off the wall. Her embrace was careful of Elcia’s necklace and Arcebek’s ring, though not particularly careful of Shade himself.

“Thank you,” she murmured into his shoulder. “For being foolish enough to make an oath to three walking disasters.”

“Someone must keep an eye on you,” he said, his voice unexpectedly hoarse.

Arcebek sat close beside him, leaning against his shoulder. Elcia settled at his feet and rested her head against his knee.

Around them, the garden hummed.

Lightning followed the trellises. Thunder rolled softly beyond the terrace. Above it all, the Blue Flight’s ancient sky watched without comment.

The goddesses at his wrist were unusually quiet.

If anything, they seemed pleased.

Hoard, Terra murmured with affection.

Anchors, Fenris agreed.

Pretty, Djing and Djang chimed together. *Shiny.*

Ifret laughed, warm and delighted.

About time, she said.

Shade breathed in the scent of Rakihi’s hair and felt Arcebek’s weight against him, Elcia’s new heartbeat answering through the gem. Beyond the terrace, darker things still waited in the world. For this moment, none of them mattered.

He had once sworn to fight for all of reality.

Now, in a garden where lightning grew like flowers, he had made a promise both smaller and more difficult:

To be there when they needed him.

Always.

Chapter 30: Thunderbolt's Challenge

Thunderbolt arrived without knocking.

He never did.

Shade was halfway through explaining to Elcia why the eastern training balcony had no railing ("psychological warfare") when the air announced his brother: a sudden drop in pressure, a crack of displaced wind, and the sharp scent of ozone. Someone had evidently treated the no-landing wards as a friendly suggestion.

A blue streak tore past the balcony, banked hard, and climbed in a tight arc.

A humanoid figure landed heavily enough to rattle the stone beneath their feet.

Thunderbolt was tall and broad-shouldered, his black hair streaked with silver like old scars. Lightning burned in his eyes. He looked more like a fighter than a prince—the sort of dragon who considered a sword hilt a perfectly adequate diplomatic instrument.

"Training yard," he announced. "Five minutes. Let's see how much rust you've gathered rolling around in mortal beds."

Rakihi made a strangled noise.

Arcebek raised her eyebrows. "How delightful."

Elcia studied him as she would any other possible opponent.

Shade pinched the bridge of his nose.

"Hello, Thunderbolt. I see your time away has done wonders for your manners."

Thunderbolt grinned, all teeth.

"I've heard stories. Demons, cults, fey queens, council politics. Either you've been remarkably lucky or you still know which end of a sword to hold. I intend to find out."

He tipped his head towards the inner hall.

"Five minutes. Otherwise I'll tell the Reds you've grown soft."

He could hardly have chosen a more effective threat.

Old irritation stirred in Shade: bruises, taunts, and the brother who had driven him hardest because, as Thunderbolt used to say, "If you survive me, nothing else will kill you."

But there was something beneath the irritation.

Curiosity.

Thunderbolt could be unbearable.

He was also the finest fighter Shade knew.

Of all his siblings, Thunderbolt had endured the longest against truly monstrous opponents. He was the only one who had fought the Opalite Empress to a draw in the sky-arenas, though she had later called him a decent warm-up. Shade himself had once faced the Platinum Emperor and lasted less than a minute before finding himself flat on the floor.

Thunderbolt remained the standard by which he measured himself.

“If you don’t want to—” Elcia began quietly.

“I do,” Shade answered. “I want to know.”

He met Thunderbolt’s gaze.

“Five minutes,” Shade agreed. “Try not to break anything irreplaceable.”

Thunderbolt’s grin widened.

“No promises.” Thunderbolt stepped backwards off the balcony. He fell out of sight, then unfolded his wings and shot towards the inner yard.

Rakihi stared after him.

“…He’s your least favourite brother?” Rakihi asked. “What are the others like?”

“Less inclined to stab people. Usually.”

“We’re coming,” Arcebek said. “I want to record his insults for later use.”

“And if you need carrying to a healer,” Elcia added, “I shall be annoyed if nobody is there to do it.”

The third practice yard was occupied.

The fourth rang with mock aerial combat and lightning drills.

The fifth, Thunderbolt’s favourite, stood open to the sky. Rune-lined stone formed a wide oval, with a low barrier around its edges and weapon racks along one side.

Thunderbolt was already warming up when they arrived, although his stretches looked suspiciously like a performance.

He had retained a humanoid shape but left the scales on his forearms exposed. His chest was bare, crossed with scars both pale and silver-bright, and he wore plain trousers suited for combat.

He turned as Shade entered the yard.

“You’re late,” Thunderbolt said.

“It’s been four minutes,” Shade replied.

“Precisely.” Thunderbolt rolled his shoulders. “Armour?”

Shade glanced at the racks.

Practice blades, staves, and several weapons banned from most mortal tournaments lined the racks.

“No armour. If this is a test, I want to know exactly where you manage to hit me.”

Thunderbolt laughed. “Still an idiot. Good.”

He took two weighted practice swords from the rack and tossed one to Shade. They were blunt, but heavy enough to leave bruises.

Shade caught his without thinking.

Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia found places on a bench beside the yard. Other Blues gathered as word spread: Shade’s sisters, several lieutenants, and an elderly aunt who never missed the opportunity to watch someone get knocked flat.

Thunderbolt stalked towards the centre.

“No flying. No full storm-calling. Humanoid forms only. If you cheat, I cheat.”

“Agreed,” Shade said.

“If one of us stays down for three breaths, the other wins. Unless Mother tells us to stop first.”

Shade snorted. “Deal.”

They exchanged quick, sharp salutes.

Thunderbolt attacked before the gesture had fully ended.

He was fast.

He always had been.

Shade barely caught the first diagonal cut. The force jarred his arm, and sparks leapt where their blades struck near the warded stone.

Three lighter blows followed in quick succession. Thunderbolt fought by denying his opponent rest, forcing him to react until he made a mistake.

Shade answered on instinct.

He had trained in countless courts, survived a dozen wars, and fought in alleys with a broken bottle and half a seal-stone’s power. Thunderbolt’s speed was familiar, but he had acquired new feints, new angles, new ways to bait a counterstrike.

They circled.

Shade caught a cut, slipped inside it, and aimed low for Thunderbolt’s knee. His brother leapt the sweep and answered with a thrust that Shade narrowly avoided.

On the bench, Rakihi had fallen silent.

“They’re not… playing,” she murmured.

“No,” Arcebek replied. “They’re having a conversation with swords.”

Elcia tracked every exchange, her gaze intent and analytical.

Five minutes in, Shade’s shoulder throbbed from a blow hard enough to numb his fingers.

After ten, both brothers were breathing harder, sweat gathering on their skin.

By fifteen, Shade knew only the stone beneath his feet, the sword in his hand, and the fierce pleasure of facing someone who understood every move.

Thunderbolt feinted high, dropped low, and rose into a slash that would have gutted a slower opponent.

Shade stepped towards it.

Not away.

Straight into its path.

He turned enough to take the blow along his ribs rather than full on. Pain flashed through him, but the opening let him drive his hilt into Thunderbolt’s jaw.

It was a brutal exchange.

And effective.

Thunderbolt stumbled, blood bright at the corner of his mouth.

A murmur spread through the spectators.

“When,” Thunderbolt demanded, spitting blood onto the stone, “did you learn to trade blows?”

“Mortals fight dirty,” Shade panted. “I adapted.”

Thunderbolt’s laughter rang across the yard.

“Good,” he said. “Again.”

They clashed again.

Twenty minutes passed.

Shade’s arms trembled and his lungs burned. Thunderbolt’s strikes had lost a little precision, sweat making his grip slip just enough for Shade to notice.

Neither tried anything spectacular. No wings, no summoned storms, no tricks of dragon magic. Only skill and endurance.

Step. Strike. Turn.

Near the half-hour mark, an opening finally appeared.

Thunderbolt overcommitted to a thrust. Shade knocked the blade wide, pivoted, and caught sight of an unguarded line along his brother’s back.

He took it.

Shade struck.

Thunderbolt twisted just in time.

The blow drove him to one knee.

Shade lunged to follow through—

—but Thunderbolt swept his ankles out from under him.

Shade landed hard on his back.

For a moment the sky spun above him.

Then a practice sword hovered at his throat.

“One,” Thunderbolt counted, fighting for breath.

Shade clenched his jaw and forced his aching limbs to move.

He pushed himself upwards.

One knee found the ground beneath him.

“Two,” Thunderbolt counted.

His sight blurred at the edges.

The new bonds to Elcia, Arcebek, and Rakihi hummed faintly through him, as vivid as live wires.

He remembered the Opalite Empress's amused smile as she had knocked him down. The Platinum Emperor's disinterested yawn after a fight that had scarcely begun.

And Lana in the mortal training hall, telling him, "You're thinking too hard. Hit him."

Shade growled and drove himself upwards.

He planted his other foot.

He would not yield yet.

Thunderbolt's eyes blazed.

"Three," he said.

Shade surged to his feet.

The movement was ugly and desperate.

But he stood.

His knees locked. His sword rose in time to catch Thunderbolt's blade before it could touch his throat.

A roar went up around the yard.

His legs immediately threatened to buckle.

Thunderbolt held the bind for another heartbeat.

Then he stepped away and lowered his sword.

"Enough."

Shade remained standing through sheer stubbornness for two more heartbeats before dropping into a sitting position, breath heaving.

Thunderbolt's grin had changed.

Its sharp edge was gone.

There was pride in it now.

"Half an hour," he said. "Only the Opalite Empress has lasted that long against me without going down. And she cheated."

Shade wheezed a laugh. "She does not."

"She bent the arena rules," Thunderbolt insisted. "You didn't. Last time you faced the Platinum Emperor, you barely made it beyond the greeting."

"Fifty seconds," Shade muttered.

"Less than a minute," Thunderbolt agreed, his usual obnoxiousness returning.

Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia hurried into the yard.

Rakihi knelt beside Shade, hands hovering over his bruised shoulders as though unsure where to begin checking for injuries.

"You maniac," she said, torn between admiration and fury. "You could have refused. You needn't fight every arrogant thunderstorm with a sword complex that comes calling."

"In this case," Shade managed, "I rather did. Family tradition."

Arcebek crouched beside him, studying the bruises already spreading over his skin.

“Nothing broken,” she declared. “Apart from your sense of self-preservation.”

Elcia offered her hand.

Shade accepted and let her pull him up.

“You held your own against someone who has fought at this level his entire life,” she told him. “That matters.”

Thunderbolt wiped blood from his lip, then acknowledged all three with a nod.

“You’ve been good for him. Someone improved his footwork. And whoever taught him to take a hit instead of retreating forever—” His teeth flashed in a grin. “I owe them a drink.”

“Lana,” Shade wheezed. “And several hundred goblins.”

Thunderbolt snorted.

Thunderbolt looked between Shade and the three mortals. For a moment his expression softened.

“You’re sharper than I expected. More dangerous, too. Good. Next time the Void stirs, I’ll be glad you’re standing against it with these three behind you.”

Coming from Thunderbolt, it was almost a declaration of pride.

Shade nodded, his throat unexpectedly tight.

“Next time,” Thunderbolt called as he turned away, “we use wings.”

“Next time,” Shade called back, “you pay for the healer.”

Thunderbolt’s laughter followed him out of the yard.

After the healers, baths, and a remarkably satisfying nap, Shade found himself sprawled beside his partners, discussing the fight.

“Let me see,” Rakihi said, sketching furiously in her notebook. “The Opalite Empress can fight him to a draw. The Platinum Emperor knocked you out in under a minute. Thunderbolt is still an ass, but at least now he respects you. Anything else?”

“You forgot that our idiot is terrifying in his own weight class,” Arcebek replied.

Elcia smiled and traced a careful finger beside the bruise on his ribs, healing magic easing the soreness.

“And that he kept his strikes clear of the places where he might have endangered the gems he gave us.”

Rakihi blinked.

“I’m not quite that reckless,” Shade protested.

“Yet,” Arcebek said.

Rakihi tapped her pencil against her teeth.

“The next time some noble in the city mistakes you for an ordinary adventurer with an oversized sword, I’ll remember this fight and let them keep their illusions.”

Shade closed his eyes. The distant storm and the quieter hum of three new bonds seemed to settle into the same rhythm.

Thunderbolt had tested him and found less rust than expected.

The Opalite Empress and Platinum Emperor remained formidable measures of how far he had yet to go.

For the moment, the Void lay quiet.

And despite the aches, with his partners around him, Shade felt more capable than he had in years.

Not a weapon held by another.

Simply himself.

Chapter 31: Stormcraft

Thunderbolt's bruises had barely begun changing colour when the next storm arrived.

This one knocked.

It barely bothered with the formality.

Shade was in the sitting room with Arcebek and Elcia, debating whether the guild could survive a week without him—and whether Lana might somehow be here too—when the wards along the inner wall flickered.

Not the sharp disturbance of a landing, nor the subtle pressure of a courtier's arrival.

A low, deliberate roll of thunder, felt as much in the teeth as in the ears.

Rakihi poked her head out of the bedroom, hair a mess. "That one of yours?" she asked.

"Yes," Shade said.

The door slid open without touching.

Thunderstorm walked in as though the storm itself had decided to wear skin.

She did not look older than their mother, but she felt ancient: the part of the sky that had watched mountains rise and offered them lightning by way of greeting.

Tall even by the standards of the Blue Flight, she wore her long dark hair in thick braids threaded with actual lightning. Her deep-blue eyes had slit pupils, but none of Thunderbolt's sharpness. Her gaze was heavier than that, patient and measuring.

Loose trousers and a sleeveless tunic were her only finery, apart from a storm gem at her throat that hummed like a captive thunderhead.

"Little skies," she said, voice like rain on hot stone. "You've been busy."

Shade stood automatically.

"Thunderstorm," he said, and there was more respect in it than he'd used with any of the others. "I was wondering when you'd drop the pretense of being too important to visit."

Her mouth twitched. It might have been a smile.

"I wanted to know whether the rumours were true," she said. "Void scars. A guild. A love life." Her gaze passed over the others. "Apparently so."

Rakihi swallowed beneath that scrutiny, squared her shoulders, and offered a tiny wave. "Hi. We're the rumours."

Arcebek dipped her head without cringing. Elcia inclined hers, hands at her sides, with the composed neutrality of a paladin greeting another authority.

Thunderstorm took them in with one long, thoughtful glance.

"You've chosen a complicated life," she told Shade. "Entirely in character."

"I had a good teacher," he said.

That got him a proper smile.

“There he is,” she murmured. “The brat who thought he could counterspell a Void lord by trying harder.”

“It almost worked,” he protested automatically.

She lifted a hand.

Lightning crawled along her fingers, lazy, affectionate.

“Walk with me. Bring your companions if you like. I want to know whether you remember what I taught you, or whether playing mortal has softened your elements.”

Rakihi’s eyes lit up. “Oh, I’m not missing this.”

Arcebek stood. “Elemental sparring,” she muttered, intrigued. “This I’ve got to see.”

Elcia just nodded. “We’ll stay out of the blast radius,” she said calmly.

As they entered the corridor, Thunderstorm glanced at Shade’s wrist.

“The seals?” she asked. “I can feel them from here.”

He resisted the urge to cover them with his other hand.

“They’ve been tighter,” he admitted. “Mortals are fragile. And so is reality, lately.”

“Mm.” She looked towards the sky. “You unbound yourself for Mother. I felt it from the eastern rim. Thought the field wards were about to have a nervous breakdown.”

“She asked,” he said simply.

“And I’m asking for a partial release. Nothing that would require us to rebuild half the palace. But I cannot test your control with every chain pulled tight.”

He paused.

Again? he asked inwardly.

This one knows what she’s doing, Fenris said. And she taught you half your tricks. I trust her.

Terra rumbled her agreement. We’ll keep the chains close. A longer leash, nothing more.

Ifret sounded amused. I want to see whether you can still weave without panicking, little spark. Say yes.

He nodded.

“All right,” he told Thunderstorm. “Partial release. Nothing that’ll put us through the floor if I sneeze.”

“Generous,” she said dryly. “Arena three.”

The elemental arena bore little resemblance to the combat yards.

For one thing, it was circular.

A vast ring lay open to the sky. Its pale stone floor held five concentric bands: bare rock, water channels, metal inlays, packed earth, and a current of moving air visible only when dust swept through it.

To Shade, it was like stepping inside a diagram of his own body.

Thunderstorm crossed to the centre, her bare feet silent on the inlays. He followed, feeling each ring hum beneath his soles.

His sisters and a few other dragons drifted in to watch. Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia took seats on an upper ledge, safely above the casual line of fire. A ward shimmered into place before them.

Thunderstorm stopped, turned to face him.

“No steel,” she said. “No fists. Just what I taught you. And what you learned away from me.”

“Understood,” he said.

“Ease them,” she added, nodding at his wrist. “Not all the way. Just breathe.”

He closed his eyes.

Breathed.

The gems in his bracelet warmed. There was none of the tearing heat of a full release; the pressure eased like a collar finally unbuttoned.

Power slid closer to the surface.

The air sharpened. Water stirred in the distant channels. Metal hummed, and the mortar beneath his feet seemed to soften.

Above him, lightning turned its attention towards the arena.

“Good,” Thunderstorm said quietly. “Now show me.”

She raised a hand.

The first bolt wasn’t meant to hit.

It cracked from the clouds and forked at the last instant, racing along the metal inlays on either side of him. A warning. A greeting.

He answered without thinking.

Heat gathered in his palm, then spread through the air: Ifret’s familiar warmth. He snapped his fingers, flashing water from the channels into steam. A curtain rose around him, blurring the arena’s lines.

Thunderstorm’s eyebrows flicked up.

“Not bad,” she said. “You used to just throw fire at everything and hope.”

“I’ve met librarians since then,” he said. “I’ve learned to be more precise.”

She laughed once, then moved.

Elemental sparring had no rounds. It had only flow.

Thunderstorm drew water from the channels in thin, slicing ribbons and threaded them with crawling lightning. Years ago, those threads would have stunned him senseless. Now he thickened the stone beneath his feet and raised low ridges to break the ribbons apart.

He didn’t throw a spell for every one of hers.

As a fledgling sorcerer, he had made the mistake of answering every attack with a spell of his own, exhausting himself one exchange at a time.

Now, he picked.

A crackling bolt? He stepped aside and let it pursue his shadow until it grounded harmlessly in the metal band.

A gust meant to throw him off balance? He moved with it and let it carry him into better footing.

When he did answer, he made it count.

When she whipped water at his legs, he froze it mid-strike, spread the ice across the floor, and sent a shard skimming towards her on a focused gust.

She sidestepped. Barely.

On the ledge, Rakihi had a hand clamped over her mouth.

“Oh, wow,” Rakihi breathed. “He never fights like this down below.”

“Too dangerous,” Arcebek said, tracking each sigil and flare through her warlock senses. “Too many civilians. This is what happens when he stops pretending he’s merely very strong.”

Elcia’s eyes were wide, but not afraid.

“He’s… choosing,” she said. “When to take hits. When to let them miss. When to reinforce. That’s new, isn’t it?”

“Very,” Arcebek replied.

Below, the duel ramped up.

Thunderstorm stopped testing and started pressing.

She wove air, water, and lightning into a net that descended like a luminous curtain. A younger Shade would have tried to burn his way through it.

This Shade stepped into the stone ring, dropped to one knee, and spoke a word Terra had pressed into his bones.

The ground under him bulged.

A dome rose—not complete enough to imprison him, but high enough to catch the net and drain its charge safely into the earth.

Thunderstorm’s eyes brightened.

“There it is,” she murmured. “You finally learned to layer.”

He didn’t answer with words.

He answered with wind.

Not the hurricane he could have summoned with the seals removed, but a precise gust that tugged at the loose edge of Thunderstorm’s spell. It unravelled just enough for him to slip a thread of fire into the weave.

The next bolt she called down hit her water shield.

Steam burst up in her face.

She coughed, laughing.

“You little—” She cut herself off, then flung a hand out.

A ring of water exploded up from the channels, high as his chest, then slammed inward.

He couldn't dodge that one.

He braced.

Cold struck from every side and stole his breath. For an instant, he was back in some forgotten battle with Void-touched waves crashing over him.

He reached past it.

Beneath the stone and the storm, he found Fenris's steady, cooling presence.

Breathe, she murmured.

He did.

Then he pushed.

The water she'd trapped him in bulged.

Not outward.

Up.

He forced it along the path of least resistance: a column of spray that shot overhead and burst into harmless rain, hissing against the warm stone.

A drop hit his cheek.

He wiped it off, grinning despite the ache in his ribs.

Thunderstorm shook water out of her hair, laughing outright now.

"Very good. You're still fond of theatrics, but at least they're efficient now."

He didn't try to hit her back with something equally big.

He waited.

She obliged.

Lightning this time. Not a simple bolt, but a scatter—dozens of little forks snapping across the arena floor, searching.

He didn't try to outrun them.

He gave them a path.

Dragging his toe across the metal band, he sketched a quick sigil. The first fork struck it, and the others followed, circling him too closely to find another path to ground.

The bolt chased its own tail until it fizzled.

On the ledge, Blackthunder let out a low, impressed whistle. "He's been paying attention," she murmured.

Thunderfurry grinned. "I told you mortal life would either break him or sharpen him. Glad it was the second."

Thunderstorm finally stopped holding back.

The sky darkened.

Clouds gathered directly overhead, ignoring the palace's normal channels. The hairs on Shade's arms rose; his skin prickled.

Here it comes, Ifret purred.

Don't be stupid, Terra added.

Thunderstorm lifted both hands.

Air, water, fire, earth, all in motion.

Then she called down a bolt as thick as a tree trunk.

He did not try to block that.

He did something stupider.

He caught it.

Not with his body.

He met it with a lattice of tiny sigils scratched into the air so quickly his companions would scarcely have seen them. Fragments of Buyakugan's patterns and Djing and Djang's tricks formed a rough, imperfect net.

The bolt hit.

The world went white.

Rakihi cried out; Arcebek swore; Elcia sprang to her feet with a hand halfway to her sword, though steel would have accomplished nothing.

When the light faded, Shade was still standing.

Barely.

The lattice had vanished, consumed by the discharge.

His hands were smoking.

But he was upright.

And Thunderstorm had to take a half-step back, balance thrown by the recoil.

It was, by any reasonable measure, a hit.

He didn't press it.

He could not. His reserves were a tangle of emptiness and overstretched threads.

Thunderstorm recovered.

She flicked her fingers.

A simple, clean gust hit him square in the chest.

His feet left the floor.

He landed on his back with a grunt, the breath driven out of him.

He tried to sit up.

His limbs refused.

She stepped into his blurry field of vision, rain droplets still clinging to her braids, lightning walking lazily along the gem at her throat.

“Three breaths,” she said.

He managed one and a half before his arms buckled and he fell back, panting.

She chuckled, low.

“Still dramatic,” she said. “Still mine.”

She offered him a hand.

He took it.

She pulled him up with absurd ease and, in a move that would have scandalized half the court, hauled him into a brief, crushing hug.

“You did well,” she said against his shoulder. “You listened. You chose. You didn’t try to out-storm me. You finally remembered that you are more than a battery.”

He swallowed hard.

“It took… some practice,” he managed.

“And mortals,” she added, releasing him and nodding towards the ledge. Rakihi was still trembling with fright. Arcebek looked ready to calculate how many healers she would need to bribe. Elcia’s relief showed in her shoulders.

“Yes,” he said.

Thunderstorm looked at them, then back at him.

“I don’t approve of much,” she said. “But this? This is not a bad use of my favourite experiment.”

He huffed a shaky laugh. “High praise.”

“The highest you’re getting. Come on, before you fall over. I’ll take you to the healers before Mother blames me for frying her guildmaster.”

Later, after restorative tea and muttered healing spells, Shade sprawled in their rooms with his head in Rakihi’s lap, Arcebek’s feet resting against his calf and Elcia seated on the floor within reach.

“That,” Rakihi said, still a little breathless, “was the most terrifying and beautiful thing I’ve ever seen.”

“Same,” Arcebek said. “And I have seen Opalite contract-law in action.”

Elcia studied him with quiet pride.

“You weren’t trying to win,” she said. “But you did win something.”

He let his eyes close, Thunderstorm’s words echoing.

You finally remembered that you are more than a battery.

“I wanted her to know,” he murmured, already half asleep, “that she hadn’t wasted her time. That what she taught me didn’t just… rot.”

Rakihi’s fingers slid through his hair.

“Oh, trust me,” she said softly. “She saw. And so did we.”

The storm outside rolled on, familiar now.

Within him, the seals settled gently back into place, the gods gathering around him like old friends at the end of a long day.

For once, the weight felt right.

Not as chains.

Something he had chosen.

Chapter 32: The General's Test

The last test didn't feel like a test at first.

It felt like a summons.

Shade sat with Elcia on a quiet balcony, discussing the deployment of guild squads across an imaginary demon-infested province—because apparently that counted as a holiday now—when a shadow crossed the sunlight.

Not dramatic like Thunderbolt.

Not heavy like Thunderstorm.

Simply present, with no need to announce itself.

He looked up.

Stormsheart stood in the doorway.

His eldest brother. General of the Blue Flight. A dragon whose decisions moved armies.

He stood taller than Shade, though he was leaner than Thunderbolt and carried none of Thunderstorm's obvious crackling power. Dark hair tied back, plain tunic, a single armband bearing the Flight's sigil: his humanoid form was unadorned.

What set him apart was his stillness.

Every movement was deliberate. Even his breathing seemed measured.

"Shade," he said.

"Stormsheart," Shade answered, standing.

Elcia rose and bowed her head. Stormsheart acknowledged her with the restrained nod of one officer to another, rather than the curiosity sometimes shown to a mortal guest.

"I have seen what Mother wanted: your size and control. Thunderbolt has tested your steel. Thunderstorm has tested your weave." His calm gaze rested on Shade. "But I have yet to see what matters to me."

Shade's mouth went dry. "Which is?"

Stormsheart tilted his head slightly.

"Whether you've learned to think. Not as a weapon—as a commander."

Of course.

"Practice yard?" Shade asked.

"No," Stormsheart said. "Arena two. Five minutes."

It was not a suggestion.

Elcia glanced at Shade, question in her eyes. He gave a small nod.

"I'll be fine. Or I'll learn exactly why I'm not."

Stormsheart's mouth twitched, almost amused.

“Bring your mortals if you like,” he said, turning away. “They should see how you move when you’re not hiding.”

Arena two was different again.

Arena Two was smaller than Thunderstorm’s elemental circle but larger than Thunderbolt’s yard. One half lay beneath a roof; the other opened to the sky. Scattered pillars and low walls made it resemble a battlefield shattered into stone. It was designed to test the use of terrain, not simply the strength of combatants.

Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia found seats on the raised gallery, behind the same kind of translucent ward that had protected them in the elemental spar.

Blackthunder, Thunderfurry, and Swiftlightning had already claimed places by the rail. A few older dragons in humanoid guise watched from the shadows: commanders and aides who cared how the general’s brother performed.

Stormsheart stood in the center of the arena, hands clasped loosely behind his back.

No weapons racks this time.

No visible sigils.

Only stone, wind, and the distant, constant hum of a storm.

Shade stepped onto the floor.

He could feel everyone’s eyes.

“Terms,” he said, because that was always the first step.

Stormsheart nodded once.

“Your seals stay on. No full unbinding, no world-sized theatrics. Use what the mortals have seen you use: blade, body, and the edge of your elements. Enough to scorch, not to shatter.”

“And you?” Shade asked.

Stormsheart’s expression didn’t change.

“I’ll answer whatever you show me. Nothing more, nothing less. And I won’t use a spell you’ve never learned to counter.”

That was… unfairly kind.

Also terrifying.

“Why?” Shade asked quietly.

“I don’t fight my kin to prove that I can win,” Stormsheart said. “I fight when I have something to teach them. Today, I want to see what you have already learned.”

Shade let that sink in.

Then he nodded.

“Accepted.”

Stormsheart’s gaze flicked to the bracelet on his wrist.

“The seals stay as they are,” he repeated. “If you tear them, the lesson is wasted.”

“They stay,” Shade said. “I promise.”

The general inclined his head once.

“Begin when you’re ready. The field won’t give you a signal.”

Shade snorted. “Lana said the same thing,” he murmured.

Then he moved.

He didn’t charge.

Thunderbolt might have met force with force, waiting to see whose stance failed first.

Nor did he open with a spectacular spell. Thunderstorm had cured him of that impulse.

Instead, he watched.

Stormsheart didn’t move at all, at first.

He just… stood.

His weight was evenly balanced, his hands clasped behind him. No visible guard.

Trap.

Shade circled, noting the pillars, the stone beneath his boots, and the faint currents of wind slipping through the open roof.

He tested with a flicker of fire—a dart at Stormsheart’s feet.

His brother stepped aside without even uncrossing his arms.

Simple.

Efficient.

Shade lunged, then broke the movement halfway into a feint and rolled behind a low wall.

No response.

No counter.

Rakihi frowned, fingers gripping the rail. “He’s not… doing anything,” she whispered.

“He is,” Arcebek whispered. “He’s watching. He wants to see what Shade chooses before he puts him under pressure.”

Elcia nodded, eyes never leaving the two figures below.

“The first move was never really his to make,” Elcia murmured. “He’s waiting to see whether Shade fights from his strengths or his fears.”

Below, Shade exhaled, slow.

If Stormsheart wasn’t going to set the pace, he had to.

Fine.

He let the seals sit where they were, a familiar weight on his wrist.

He gathered a narrow gust into his palm—nothing strong enough to crack stone, only enough to turn a misstep into a fall.

Then he committed.

He emerged from behind the wall at an angle, aiming past Stormsheart rather than directly at him. A burst of wind at his back carried him forward faster than his legs alone could have managed.

Stormsheart stepped into his path.

Not fancy.

He was simply there.

Shade cut, stopping short of where a blade's edge would have been; his brother blocked with a forearm Shade hadn't even seen move.

They traded a rapid series of open-hand strikes and blocks, close-quarters work Shade had practised in Lana's training halls and the guild yards. Stormsheart lacked Thunderbolt's explosive speed, but every movement had a purpose.

Shade tried a trick—ducked low, sweeping his leg at Stormsheart's ankle while calling a flicker of static to his fingers to slap at his side.

Stormsheart turned the sweep with a subtle shift of weight and took the shock on a forearm, barely flinching.

Then answered.

Shade landed on his back before he registered the shoulder-check.

Stone hard against his spine.

He rolled. Just in time; Stormsheart's foot came down where his chest had been, hard enough that the impact hummed through the floor.

Shade scrambled up, lungs burning.

"Too linear," Stormsheart said. "You're thinking in duels. I told you I wanted to see a commander."

Shade grimaced.

Right.

He stepped back, out of immediate reach, and stopped.

Not to rest.

To look.

Pillars. Low walls. A shallow slope where rainwater drained away. Open sky to the east, where the wind struck harder.

He thought of guild maps, of Lana's voice: "Where are the chokepoints? Where's the high ground? Where can you force them to fight on your terms?"

Stormsheart made no move to interrupt.

Shade angled toward the sloped side.

A thin layer of frost spread beneath the dust, invisible unless someone knew where to look.

He let Stormsheart see him do it.

A hint.

Then he shifted.

Kept his distance.

He tested Stormsheart with small jets of steam and short bursts of wind, no match for Thunderstorm's raw power but enough to demand an answer.

Stormsheart answered each one in kind.

Never more.

Shade sent a rolling wave of loose gravel toward him, kicked up from the stone.

Stormsheart solidified the ground with a muttered word, letting the pebbles bounce harmlessly off his boots.

Shade pushed a gust at his side.

Stormsheart stepped into it, turning it.

Stormsheart kept his promise to match Shade's power. He simply made better choices with it.

Shade's pulse hammered.

He couldn't out-muscle him.

He couldn't out-magic him, not with the seals on and Stormsheart's years of combat experience.

He'd have to out-think him.

The thought would have terrified the younger version of himself.

Shade felt a fierce, reluctant smile form.

He retreated towards the frost patch, deliberately allowing his footwork to grow untidy.

Stormsheart followed, not falling for the obvious bait; he skirted the worst of the slick spot with neat steps, weight centered.

Shade didn't need him to fall.

He needed him to hesitate.

Just as Stormsheart skirted the icy patch, Shade released a sharp jet of steam through a crack in the stone.

Not enough to burn.

Enough to make the general blink.

A fraction of a heartbeat.

Stormsheart's attention flickered—just long enough.

Shade dropped.

Literally.

He dropped to one knee and drove a focused pulse of air across the slick stone beneath Stormsheart's other foot.

For the first time, Stormsheart's balance slipped.

Not a full fall.

Just a stagger.

It was enough.

Shade drove his shoulder into his brother's middle, using leverage instead of brute force. A thread of static snapped from his palm into Stormsheart's ribs.

Not a full lightning bolt.

A precise, nerve-jangling jolt—Thunderstorm's old "wake-up slap."

Stormsheart's breath hitched.

His stance broke.

Shade pivoted, turning their shared momentum into a throw, just as Lana had drilled into him in the guild yard.

The general of the Blue Flight hit the stone on his back.

The arena went dead quiet.

Shade took two stumbling steps back, chest heaving.

Stormsheart stared at the sky, looking mildly surprised to find himself horizontal.

"One," an older aunt called from the shadows.

Shade didn't move.

He waited.

Two…

Stormsheart's hand twitched.

Three.

Then Stormsheart laughed.

It was a low, pleased sound.

"Enough," he said, before the count could finish.

He sat up slowly, one hand rubbing at his ribs where the static had snapped through.

Shade, still panting, stepped forward and held out a hand.

Stormsheart looked at it.

Then took it.

Shade pulled him to his feet.

Around them, murmurs rippled.

Above them, Rakihi covered her mouth with both hands. Arcebek looked astonished, then fiercely smug on Shade's behalf. Elcia's eyes shone with quiet satisfaction.

Blackthunder raised her brows. Thunderfurry let out a delighted whoop. Even Swiftlightning looked impressed, for once not making a joke.

Stormsheart dusted himself off, then met Shade's gaze.

"You did something I did not expect," he said.

Shade swallowed. "Threw you on your back?"

Stormsheart's mouth curved.

"You won. With your power restricted, against someone who knows every trick you've ever shown at court."

Shade shook his head. "You were holding back," he protested automatically. "You matched my spells. You could have—"

"Escalated?" Stormsheart cut in. "Yes, and broken our terms. This was never about whether I could crush you. I know that answer. I wanted to learn whether you could win a fight without turning it into an apocalypse."

Shade blinked.

Stormsheart stepped closer, dropping his voice so it didn't carry beyond the nearest few.

"You used the terrain and my assumptions. You knew when to spend your strength and when to let an attack pass. You fought like a commander who understands that his reserves are finite and his people vulnerable." His expression softened slightly. "That is new."

Shade breathed out, shaky.

"I had… help," he said.

Stormsheart's gaze flicked toward the gallery, to where his mortals stood.

"I can see that. Lana's teaching is all over your footwork. And trading ground for an advantage? That comes from the guild, not this court."

He put a hand on Shade's shoulder.

Not heavy.

Firm.

"You're ready to hold what you've built below. The guild. The city. Your family. You needn't unleash a storm to break every enemy line." He tapped Shade's forehead lightly. "You need this."

Shade let out something between a laugh and a breath.

"I didn't expect to win," he admitted.

"That's why you did. You stopped trying to prove yourself and started trying to solve the problem."

He stepped back, raising his voice enough for the gallery.

"The general of the Blue Flight formally acknowledges," he declared, dry as dust, "that his wayward brother is not a liability on the ground. Try not to embarrass me."

Rakihi laughed, shaky with relief.

Arcebek shouted, "No promises!"

Elcia just bowed her head, as if accepting a verdict she'd already known.

Stormsheart's mouth twitched.

He leaned in, just for Shade to hear.

"When the Void howls again," he murmured, "I will be glad to have you on my flank, not merely ahead of our line."

Shade's chest tightened.

"I'll be there," he said.

"I know," Stormsheart replied. "I saw your gems."

He glanced at the gem at Elcia's throat, the ring on Arcebek's hand, and the earring glinting in Rakihi's hair.

"Storm-oaths," he said. "More binding than any order I could give. Mother must be furious she didn't think of it first."

Shade huffed a tired laugh.

Stormsheart clapped his shoulder once more, then turned away, already half in his next thought, his next deployment.

Shade stood in the middle of the arena, bruised, exhausted, and—against all his expectations—victorious.

When he finally made it back up to the gallery, Rakihi hit him first, all limbs and delighted noise.

"You won," she insisted into his chest.

"Apparently," he said, arms going around her automatically.

Arcebek punched his arm—not hard, but with intent. "That's going straight on my list of reasons no one gets to call you 'just an adventurer.'"

Elcia rested a hand briefly against his back, the storm gem at her throat warm.

"He wanted to see if you were more than a weapon," she said. "You showed him."

Shade, for once, didn't argue.

He leaned into them, letting himself accept a strange, solid truth. He had endured every storm his family had set before him—his past, his mother, his siblings—and come away bruised, changed, and not entirely victorious in the way he had expected.

But he was still standing.

And this time, he was not alone.

Chapter 33: A Dangerous Amount of Tea

It began, innocently enough, with tea.

“Rakihi, dear, you simply must see the storm orchids from the east rim.”

“Arcebek, I confiscated these contracts from a failed merchant-prince. Would you like to laugh at them over cake?”

“Elcia, come walk the battlements with me. I want to hear what your god thinks of our warding lines.”

At first, Shade simply watched.

His sisters circled his partners like curious, dangerously powerful cats. Even his mother, in rare moments of almost-shyness, invited them into the quieter corners of the palace.

It was good. Better than he had dared hope.

Then it escalated.

Tea became 'casual' excursions through the family hoard.

Thunderfurry: “You like axes, right? Try this one. It’s from a war that doesn’t exist anymore.”

Blackthunder, tossing a bracer to Elcia: “This was forged for a border-guard captain who never took it off. It will keep your shield-arm from shattering if something big hits it. Consider it… professional courtesy.”

Swiftlightning, to Arcebek: “Do you want an office here? You could run half our cross-planar contracts in your sleep. I’ll give you an assistant. Two assistants.”

Rakihi returned from one such expedition with her hair full of tiny floating lightning insects. They were unmistakably sentient and utterly besotted with her.

“It’s fine,” she said when Shade raised a brow. “They said they’d only follow me back to the manor if they liked the sound of it.”

Then came the sky-rides.

Thunderbolt: “Rakihi, you haven’t really flown until you’ve carved your name in cloudbanks. Come on.”

Thunderstorm: “Elcia, you should see how storms look from above. It will make your temple arguments about ‘divine perspective’ easier. Trust me.”

Swiftlightning, to Arcebek, cackling: “We’re going to see how many hell-letters I can deliver in one lap around the world.”

Shade’s partners returned exhilarated, windburned, and glowing.

He started to relax.

Then he walked into one of the strategy rooms and saw it.

The strategy room held a vast, detailed map of the realms: weather patterns, currents of magic, and ancient battlefields marked in meticulous script.

His sisters were standing around it with his mother.

Rakihi, Arcebek, and Elcia stood a little to the side, each holding a cup of something that steamed faintly and smelled expensive.

“Here,” Blackthunder was saying, pointing to mountains beside a tempest. “High ground. An old leyline. You could have your own sky-fortress, Rakihi. Perfect for a bard with too many opinions.”

Rakihi made a strangled sound. “You’re offering me a mountain?”

“Just a small one,” Thunderfurry put in. “With its own storm-well.”

“And this peninsula,” Thunderstorm said, indicating another site, “has been underused for decades. Three trade winds, two major leylines. Arcebek, an arbitration hub here could make half the infernal courts weep.”

Arcebek’s fingers twitched with the effort of not reaching for a quill.

Elcia’s section of the map had several neat circles already.

“Anchor a justice temple here,” Stormsheart was telling Elcia, “and you would oversee three difficult ports. Dragons may not worship your god, but we appreciate sound jurisprudence.”

Shade stopped in the doorway.

His mother and siblings were calmly dividing up the sky for his partners.

Fortresses. Estates. Permanent footholds in a realm they were only supposed to be visiting.

He loved this realm.

He loved his family, in their terrifying, ridiculous way.

But when Blackthunder gestured towards an entire stretch of land and asked, “Rakihi, darling, how do you feel about a small demesne?” something in Shade went still.

Because this was how his family did things.

Slowly.

Lovingly.

A visit became a suite of rooms; a suite became a fortress. Before long, somebody would ask why his partners ever needed to return to the little world below.

He could see where that road ended.

He cleared his throat.

Conversation faltered.

A gathering of lightning-bright gazes turned towards him.

“Enjoying yourselves?” he asked lightly.

Rakihi’s smile was wide and slightly unsteady. “Your sisters want to give me a fort,” she whispered, delighted and horrified in equal measure.

“We are brainstorming,” Arcebek said primly. “Nothing is signed.”

Elcia met his eye, calm, but he could see the understanding there.

He stepped up to the table.

He looked at the marks on the map: mountains, ports, and impossible amounts of power offered almost casually.

Then he summoned the slow, courteous smile his childhood tutors had spent so many years teaching him.

“Mother. Sisters. This visit has been more than I hoped for. Truly.”

The Empress watched him, expression unreadable.

“But?” she asked.

“If we stay much longer,” he said gently, “you will adopt them by accident. Three people who agreed to share a small, messy guild house with me will end up owning more sky than some gods.”

Thunderfurry blinked. “That sounds fun, though.”

“It does,” Shade said. “Which is exactly the problem.”

He straightened.

“We need to go home. Back to our lives down there, before this game goes too far.”

Rakihi opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Arcebek exhaled and nodded. “Before I draft the charter for my new archipelago. Wise.”

Elcia’s smile was faint. “I suspect Kael Varis would send me several very pointed omens if I accepted a sky-fort. Better not to test him.”

His sisters chorused protests, of course.

“You just got here.”

“We were going to show them the north lights.”

“I haven’t even taken the bard to the lower storms yet.”

His mother just watched.

Finally she lifted a hand.

“Enough,” she said.

Even the protests ceased at the Empress’s voice.

She looked at Shade.

“You are not wrong. When we love someone, restraint does not come easily to us. I have no intention of stealing your anchors from the world below. It needs them.”

Rakihi made a small, surprised sound at when we love someone, but said nothing.

The Empress glanced at the storm gems adorning Rakihi’s ear, Arcebek’s hand, and Elcia’s throat.

“You’ve already given enough of us to them,” she added. “Storm-oaths. Weight. Attention.”

Her mouth curved, almost wry.

“If I give Rakihi a fortress, I expect to wake in a century and find her ruling three continents by accident. Tempting. But perhaps later.”

Shade let out a breath he hadn't realized he'd been holding.

"We'll come back," he said quietly.

"You are your father's son. You could never stay away from a broken frontline for long."

She flicked her fingers.

"Go then," she said. "Before my daughters start naming the forts after themselves."

Thunderfurry looked honestly offended. "I was going to name it after Rakihi," she protested.

Rakihi squeaked.

Arcebek pinched the bridge of her nose. "We are leaving," she said firmly.

Elcia bowed first to the Empress and then to Stormsheart. "Thank you. For the hospitality, and the sparring opportunities."

Thunderstorm smirked. "Try not to die," she said. "I'm curious what you'll do with your little guild."

Thunderbolt clapped Shade on the back hard enough to rattle his teeth. "Next time, wings," he said. "No excuses."

Blackthunder embraced each of them, surprisingly gentle. Swiftlightning pressed a folded paper marked with a sigil into Rakihi's palm. "For emergencies," she whispered. "Or parties."

His mother stepped forward last.

She didn't hug them.

She brushed a knuckle beneath Shade's chin, so lightly he almost imagined the contact.

"Take them home, Skysunder," she said. "Before we start building altars for them. The court is already half in love with your warlock."

Arcebek choked. "I beg your—"

"Go," the Empress repeated, amused. "Before I change my mind and keep one as my personal archivist."

A gate opened on the arrival platform, splitting the air with light.

For once, it did not resemble a wound.

It looked like a doorway.

They stepped through together.

They emerged into their own courtyard.

Here the sky was lower, ordinary clouds drifting through familiar blue instead of endless layers of storm. The manor wards hummed a welcome. Somewhere inside, Sparky overboiled the kettle in excitement.

The air smelled of earth, bread, and the city beyond their walls.

Home.

They walked inside in silence, exhausted to the bone by something deeper than bruises.

Boots by the door. Weapons on the rack. The familiar creak of the third stair. A tiny elemental dusting a shelf squeaked and fled when Rakihi blew it a kiss.

Without a word of discussion, they found their way to the large bed.

Not scandalous tonight.

Just four tired people needing to fall somewhere soft.

They landed in a tangle of limbs, blankets, and faintly crackling storm gems settling after their long exposure to the realm where they had been forged.

For a long moment, no one spoke.

Shade lay on his back, looking at the ceiling and listening to the gentle rain against their window. Rakihi sprawled over his stomach, her face buried in his shirt. Arcebek claimed his left side, one arm flung over her eyes. Elcia lay at his right, shoulder pressed to his, a hand resting over his fingers.

He exhaled.

“So,” he said softly, “what did you think?”

“Of…?” Rakihi’s voice was muffled in his shirt.

“My home,” he said. “My family. The court. All of it.”

That woke them all up a little.

Rakihi rolled onto her side, chin on his chest, eyes bright but tired.

“It’s a lot,” Rakihi admitted. “Beautiful, terrifying—like living inside an endless dramatic ballad.” She considered. “Your sisters are wonderful, and they’re going to get us killed someday. Your brothers are mad in three different ways. Your mother is the most frightening person I have ever met, and I desperately want her approval.” She sighed. “I love the sky. I hate the politics. Ten out of ten for a visit. Would not survive living there.”

He huffed a laugh. “Fair.”

Arcebek lowered her arm and turned her blind gaze towards the ceiling.

“Professionally? The most competent organisation I’ve ever encountered that isn’t actively evil. Your mother runs that court like an ethical corporation that happens to battle the end of reality.” She paused. “Personally, I like them more than I expected. I respect the Empress. I owe Thunderstorm a drink for not killing you to make a point. But I prefer days when the sky is simply weather. I won’t be taking a permanent appointment.” Her mouth curved. “As in-laws go, I’ve had worse.”

Elcia’s hand tightened briefly on his.

“It helped me understand you,” Elcia said. “The discipline. Your habit of studying maps. The way you assume you are a weapon before you are a person, even when we tell you otherwise. Up there, you were raised to think that way. I can see why now.”

He swallowed.

“Do you… resent it?” he asked.

She shook her head.

“No. I pity them a little. They stand so high, fighting a war the rest of us scarcely know exists, and sometimes forget how it feels to sit in a crowded hall arguing over the rent.” She smiled faintly. “I think your mother understands. That is why she let you go. And why she did not keep us, although she could have.”

He let that settle.

Rakihi poked him in the chest. “And your ‘I’m just some guy’ routine? A lie. You’re the Empress’s storm-child, brother to a collection of natural disasters, and apparently material for a general.”

“I was trying to be humble,” he protested.

“You were trying to avoid explaining your family,” Arcebek said dryly.

She reached over and flicked his storm bracelet gently.

“For the record,” she said more softly, “I’m glad I saw where you came from. Those pieces you never mention because you think they’ll be too much. I understand them better now.”

“‘Weapon’,” Elcia said.

“‘Duty’,” Rakihi put in.

“‘Home’,” Arcebek finished.

He stared up at the ceiling.

“I was afraid,” he admitted, barely above a whisper, “that once you saw my home, you’d want to stay. Or that you would look at me differently. Less yours, more theirs.”

Rakihi made an outraged noise and bit his chest through his shirt—not hard.

“Idiot,” she mumbled. “We aren’t souvenirs for your sisters to collect. And you are ours. We just understand the warranty a little better now.”

Arcebek snorted. “Besides, having a fortress offered to me doesn’t make the guild any less important. It just means that if the council gets too troublesome, we could relocate the whole operation to a sky-peninsula and let them complain about it.”

Elcia smiled wryly. “And I know that if our world breaks, there are people above it who are already watching. That helps.”

Shade exhaled slowly.

Leaving still ached. Part of him longed for endless sky, his siblings’ laughter echoing across the palace, his mother’s rare, sharp smiles.

But another longing answered it.

The warmth of this bed.

The hum of their small house.

They had walked into the storm that had shaped him and come out together.

“And you?” Rakihi asked. “What do you think, now that you’ve seen us with them?”

He blinked.

Thought.

“Relieved,” he said at last. “That they didn’t eat you.”

Rakihi snorted.

“Grateful that you fit in. Not as ornaments, but as yourselves.”

He swallowed.

“And certain, for the first time in a long while, that I can belong to both places. Here and there. Neither has to swallow the other.”

Arcebek reached up, found his hand, laced their fingers.

“Good. We aren’t making you choose,” Arcebek murmured. “We want all of it. Empress and guild. Storm and leaky roof.”

Rakihi yawned, already half-asleep. “And forts we’re totally not taking. Yet.”

Elcia closed her eyes, resting her forehead lightly against his shoulder.

“Sleep,” she said softly. “We can argue about real estate later.”

He listened until their breathing settled into the slow rhythm of sleep.

Beyond the window, ordinary rain tapped at the glass, indifferent to dragons, courts, and the Void.

His bracelet warmed faintly in response to the storm gems he had given them, each pulsing with the rhythm of its bearer’s life.

For once, Shade did not feel caught between two worlds.

He knew exactly where he belonged.

Home.

Chapter 34: Daughters of the Blue Flight

The knock was polite. Somehow, that made it worse.

Three short raps against the wood. No flash of magic, no warning from the wards beyond their ordinary announcement that someone stood outside.

Shade opened the door, expecting a guild runner.

Instead, a sky-courier in the Empress's livery waited on the step, their hair still faintly crackling from the journey through the upper air.

"Skysunder," they said, offering a sealed strip of leather in both hands. "From Her Majesty. No verbal message."

"Thank you," he said, taking it.

The courier bowed and stepped away. Two heartbeats later, they shot straight into the clouds.

Shade stared at the strip in his hand.

Empress-blue leather, supple and strangely warm, bore his mother's personal seal in lightning-silver.

"Shade?" Rakihi called from the dining room. "Who was—"

"Come here," he said.

The others gathered around him: Rakihi wiping sauce from her fingers with a scrap of bread, Arcebek with ink on one thumb from a half-finished letter, and Elcia with a dish towel over her shoulder.

Shade broke the seal.

The message was brief. Of course it was.

I have officially adopted the three as my daughters-in-law.

Please treat them carefully and with love.

Love, your mother.

He read it twice to make sure he had not imagined the middle line. Then he passed the leather silently to Rakihi.

She read.

The tips of her ears turned pink.

"D-daughters-in-law?" she squeaked. "Plural? She knows that's not how—"

"She very much knows," Arcebek said, taking it next.

The corner of Arcebek's mouth lifted as she read.

"Oh, that is deliciously formal," she murmured. "'Officially adopted.' Somewhere, an entire wing of archivists is updating six genealogies and three succession charts."

Elcia accepted the strip last.

Her gaze moved carefully across the words.

A small, luminous smile touched her lips.

“That is… very clear,” she said.

Rakihi looked up at Shade, wide-eyed.

“Did we just get dragon-married?” she demanded.

“Not quite.” He rubbed the back of his neck. “In Blue terms, it means, ‘I vouch for these three as family. Insult them, and you insult me.’ It also means any dragon who makes advances toward you is technically committing a minor political offence.”

Arcebek snorted. “Good,” she said. “That will thin the herd.”

Elcia folded the strip with almost ceremonial care and placed it on the table.

“‘Treat them carefully and with love,’” she repeated softly. “As if you don’t already.”

Emotion tightened Shade’s throat.

“It’s for her, too,” he said. “A way of saying, ‘I see what they are to you. I accept it. I stand behind it.’ Mother doesn’t send messages like that lightly.”

Rakihi stepped closer, worrying the hem of his shirt between her fingers.

“So,” she said, aiming for flippant and falling a little short, “does this make you our terrifying dragon mother-in-law’s official problem?”

“Yes,” he said. “And you her official problem.”

Arcebek smiled, slow and sharp. “I like that arrangement.”

Elcia nodded once. “So do I.”

Rakihi grinned.

“Then, on behalf of your newly adopted daughters-in-law—” Rakihi wiggled her fingers, as though testing the title for size, “—we accept. And we expect you to follow her instructions.”

Shade blinked. “Which ones?”

Rakihi cleared her throat and offered a dreadful imitation of the Empress’s voice:

“Please treat them carefully and with love.”

Arcebek nudged his shoulder. “The lady has excellent taste in orders.”

Elcia slipped her hand into his.

“You’re already obeying,” she said gently. “But… it’s nice to have it in writing.”

He looked at the three of them, their storm gems glinting faintly, their expressions by turns smug, shy and serene. A helpless, happy breath escaped him.

“Yes, Mother,” he murmured to the air.

Then, to them:

“I’ll do my best,” he said. “For all three of my very officially problematic wives.”

Rakihi choked. “Wives?”

Arcebek laughed outright.

Elcia’s smile only widened.

The strip of leather lay between them on the table, small and unassuming, yet somehow heavier than most crowns.

Chapter 35: Rumours of Betrothal

Shade had expected gossip.

No one could disappear for a tenday, return carrying himself a little differently, with three lovers whose new storm-magic practically hummed, and expect the guild not to talk.

He simply had not expected this particular rumour.

It started small.

Two Bronze-ranked adventurers whispered as he passed. “Did you see Arcebek’s ring?”

“And Elcia’s necklace. And whatever Rakihi’s wearing on her ear. Looks expensive.”

Then the clerk at the front desk:

“Guildmaster, congratulations?” she ventured, cheeks flushing. “On, well… you know.”

Shade blinked. “On… what?”

She looked appalled by the possibility that he did not.

“On… your… engagements?” she whispered. “To… all three?”

And that was only the beginning.

By lunchtime, every corridor held a fresh ambush.

“When’s the ceremony?”

“Do we get a guild holiday?”

“Are you doing three separate weddings or one big terrifying one?”

“Do the goddesses approve? Is Fenris going to officiate?”

Someone had even pinned a crudely drawn “Black Squad Wedding” poster to the noticeboard. It showed all four of them standing atop a cake the size of the guildhall.

Shade took it down, folded it and slipped it into his desk drawer. He was only so strong.

By late afternoon, he had received more congratulations than when the Black Squad earned its onyx badges.

Only when a junior scribe timidly asked whether storm gems were traditional Blue engagement tokens did the truth finally strike him.

Oh.

Oh.

He survived the rest of the day on a commander’s stubbornness, answering with variations of “No date; too many demons left to kill” and “The council will never approve closing the city for a week of feasting.” At last, he escaped home.

The manor was blessedly quiet.

For about five seconds.

“Shade!” Rakihi shouted from the kitchen. “Why does the baker know about our ‘upcoming nuptials’? She gave me a free cake sample for wedding planning. I nearly choked.”

Arcebek appeared from the study, holding a folded letter.

“And why,” she asked, dangerously mild, “did my extraplanar partners send a note saying—and I quote—‘We wish you joy in your multiple binding agreements, both personal and professional’? Shade. What have you been telling people?”

Elcia stepped out of the washroom, drying her hands.

“And three watch officers have offered to provide security for ‘the event,’” she said. “Apparently there’s already a betting pool.”

Shade sank into a chair and buried his face in his hands.

“I think,” he said into his palms, “we have a cultural translation problem.”

There was a short, wary pause.

“Elaborate,” Arcebek said.

He dropped his hands and looked at them.

“In the Blue court, storm gems signify an oath,” he explained. “‘I stand with you. I come when you call. I count you as an anchor, not an asset.’ They aren’t engagement gifts.” He rubbed his temples. “But here, apparently, giving three lovers matching pieces of rare enchanted jewellery in a single evening looks remarkably like proposing. To all of them. At once.”

Rakihi made a tiny squeaky noise.

“Oh,” she said.

Arcebek blinked twice. Then she began to laugh—quietly at first, until she could barely get a word out.

“Oh, that’s perfect,” she wheezed. “Of course they think you proposed. You vanished under mysterious circumstances and came back handing out matching magical tokens. That is practically the definition of engagement behaviour.”

Elcia’s mouth curved.

“To be fair,” she said, “if I saw someone do that without context, I’d assume the same.”

Shade groaned.

“I’m sorry,” Shade said. “I should have thought about how it would look. I just wanted you to have something of that place. Something of me. I didn’t mean—”

“Hey.” Rakihi slipped sideways into his lap and cupped his face, silencing him. “We know.”

“Do you? Because after half the guild spent today asking about a wedding, I started wondering whether I’d somehow broken three more rules of etiquette.”

Rakihi bit her lip, then glanced at the others.

Arcebek stood against the doorframe, arms folded, the storm gem on her finger pulsing gently.

“We didn’t mistake them for engagement gifts,” she said. “Not after seeing where they came from. We know a dragon oath when we see one.”

Elcia nodded. “If you had intended a proposal, you would have said so. Subtext has never been your strength.”

Rakihi snorted. “No offence, love, but accidental romance is about as subtle as you get. You don’t secretly marry people.”

Some of the tension left his shoulders.

“Good. I’d hate you to think I was trying to trap you, or that your choices had somehow narrowed because my siblings wouldn’t stop offering you forts—”

Rakihi kissed him, quick.

“We know what they mean,” she laughed. “We’re not confused.”

She hesitated.

“But,” she said more softly, “if you ever wanted them to mean that as well…”

Arcebek’s smile went crooked.

“…we wouldn’t say no,” she finished.

Shade blinked.

Once.

Twice.

“You’re serious?” he asked, because old doubts did not vanish simply because they ought to.

Arcebek pushed off the frame and came to the table, resting her hand over his.

“Let me put this in terms you understand,” she said. “If you eventually wish to add a clause labelled ‘marriage’ to our current storm oath and domestic chaos, I’m prepared to sign.”

Elcia sat down on his other side, fingers brushing the storm gem at her throat.

“I don’t need a temple,” Elcia said. “Kael Varis honours oaths kept in darkness as surely as those sworn in the light. But if you asked, I would stand beside you and say yes. Publicly. Gladly.”

Rakihi nodded, earnest now.

“And I,” Rakihi said, “would relish the opportunity to throw the most outrageous dragon–guild–fey–paladin wedding this city has ever seen. Purely for professional reasons, naturally.”

Shade looked from one to the next, his throat tightening. His heartbeat seemed to stumble against the faint pull of the gems.

“I hadn’t planned…” He stopped. That was not entirely true. He had not planned it yet. Keeping everyone alive had occupied most of his attention.

But the thought of making their bond official—of putting his name beside theirs in some absurd combination of dragon script, guild ledger and temple register—had lived quietly at the back of his mind.

Sleeping.

Waiting.

Arcebek squeezed his fingers.

“Not now,” she said, reading his face as easily as a contract. “Not tomorrow. We have demons, guild politics and at least three minor crises waiting their turn. Just remember the answer if you ever decide to ask.”

Rakihi kissed his cheek. “And until then, if the guild wants to believe we’re secretly engaged, let them. Perhaps people will stop flirting with us.”

“And if you’d like to start answering their questions with ‘eventually,’” Elcia added, “I wouldn’t object.”

Shade let out a slow breath.

“Eventually,” he repeated, letting the word settle.

His mother’s letter came back to him: I have officially adopted the three as my daughters-in-law.

The storm gems hummed faintly where they touched skin.

“Very well,” he said, dazed and hopeful in equal measure. “If anyone asks, I’ll tell them: ‘Not yet. But don’t make any grand plans for whichever year we finally stop putting out fires.’”

Rakihi beamed.

“Legally noncommittal,” Arcebek said with a smirk, “but romantically promising. I approve.”

Elcia nodded once, fingers curling gently around his.

“Then we’re agreed,” she said.

Outside, the city went on gossiping.

At their own table, among people who had chosen one another, Shade felt the possibility of a future taking shape—fragile, yet more solid than anything he had dared imagine.

Not an accident.

Not just rumour.

A possibility.

Eventually.

Chapter 36: An Adventurer's Education

It took Shade a few quiet weeks to identify what had been troubling him.

Not demons or cults. Those had become depressingly ordinary.

It was the reports.

One evening, with the light beyond his office window fading from gold to blue, he worked through a week of after-action logs.

Goblin nest cleared. Two dead, five wounded. Stabilised with poultices and luck.

Caravan raid repelled. One arm lost; reattached at the guildhall by a healer. Barely in time.

Bandit ambush averted. Severe bleeding stopped with an improvised tourniquet. No healer present.

Again and again, the same phrase.

No healer present.

The guild had excellent healers.

Its infirmary ran with military efficiency: priests and lay healers from three temples, two retired battlefield medics, and one terrifying old woman who could set a bone with her eyes shut and frighten a feverish man back into bed.

The temples had miracle-workers of their own. Given the right donation, they could knit torn flesh and coax breath back into failing lungs.

But none of that helped an adventurer bleeding out a day's ride from town.

In the field, they had bandages, herbs and whatever potions they had managed to salvage.

By the time a wounded adventurer reached the infirmary, the chance to save them had too often passed.

Shade dragged a hand down his face.

If this were a warfront, he thought, Stormsheart would have my head for letting it continue.

He pulled a clean sheet of paper toward him and uncapped his pen.

To: High Hierophant Maelen of the Threefold Temple

From: Shade, Guildmaster of the Adventurers' Guild

Subject: Persistent lack of field-healing capacity

High Hierophant,

I would like to request a formal discussion concerning the gap between temple-based healing and field triage. Adventurers—and, among them, your faithful—are dying on the journey home when basic training and timely aid might have saved them.

I believe a partnership involving training, joint field appointments, or other practical arrangements could benefit both the guild and the temple.

If you are willing, I would be honoured to meet after the next council session, at a time convenient to you.

Respectfully,

Shade

He sanded the ink, sealed the letter with the guild sigil and dispatched it to the temple by runner, with all the proper courtesies.

He did not expect an answer immediately.

He certainly did not expect one before the day was out.

The following afternoon, a courier in immaculate temple robes arrived at the guildhall with a heavy-paper reply that smelled faintly of incense and self-satisfaction.

Shade broke the seal.

The handwriting flowed elegantly across the page, with just enough flourish to irritate him.

Guildmaster Shade,

It is a rare pleasure when someone in your position notices this problem before my clerics begin throwing holy water at council members.

I agree that the situation is serious. I would welcome a discussion of possible remedies: training, shared postings, perhaps even a joint field-medic programme for promising recruits.

I will be occupied until the upcoming council session has concluded. I can, however, make time the following evening.

I propose one good bottle of red wine, a proper meal and a table on which no one is bleeding. Naturally, as the petitioner, you will pay.

Do not worry. We will call it a tithe.

In earnest expectation of being fed well,

High Hierophant Maelen

Shade lingered over the words as the petitioner, you will pay and let out a pained little laugh.

“Of course,” he muttered. “Why would I expect anything else?”

He flicked the letter once, thinking.

Wine. Dinner. A temple leader who apparently approached contracts and jokes with equal enthusiasm.

This would be more than a polite conversation.

It would be a negotiation.

He folded the letter back up and slipped it into his desk.

At dinner that evening, between Rakihi’s account of a bardic duel and Arcebek’s furious explanation of extraplanar tax law, he brought it up.

“The High Hierophant wants to discuss field medics over expensive wine,” he said. “And apparently I’m paying.”

Arcebek brightened. “You’re absolutely taking me. Priest-law and logistics? That’s my idea of a hot date.”

Rakihi grinned. “Can I provide background music that makes everyone feel generous?”

Elcia smiled thoughtfully. “If it works, fewer names will go on the memorial wall. I’ll happily stand behind your chair and look suitably paladin-like.”

Shade looked around the table at them.

“A guildmaster, a temple leader and three troublemakers walk into a meeting over wine,” Shade said. “What could possibly go wrong?”

Rakihi raised her glass.

“Fewer dead adventurers,” Rakihi said. “Worth a few bottles, I’d say.”

He raised his own glass toward hers.

“Agreed,” he said.

Chapter 37: The Healers' Bargain

The council meeting was, mercifully, dull.

Shade had never expected to welcome dullness. After storms, siblings, and an earnest attempt to give him three fortresses, however, he was prepared to cherish it.

The clerk read down the list.

First came the troubles already dealt with.

"Minor cult in the river district. Contained."

"Bandit group in the south broken up."

"Caravan losses down two percent."

"No demon incursions above the usual background idiocy."

Small fires, most already extinguished. No catastrophe waiting at the edge of the agenda. The city had somehow survived the tenday he had been away.

He signed three requisitions, vetoed a particularly foolish proposal for an adventurer tax, promised to revisit guard pay, and escaped before anyone found him another problem.

That left the meeting he actually cared about.

The temple had chosen a side chamber rather than one of its grand halls. Carved screens divided the room, lanterns shed a gentle glow, and the table bore an alarming number of forks.

High Hierophant Maelen waited in robes of deep blue and white, silver embroidery glinting as they rose. Their smile suggested they had already won half the negotiation.

"Guildmaster," Maelen said. "You brought company. Good."

Shade stepped aside to let his companions enter.

Arcebek wore a dark coat that managed to be respectable and faintly threatening at once.

Elcia's armour was polished without ostentation; Kael Varis' sigil fastened her cloak, and the storm gem at her throat caught the lanternlight.

Rakihi had chosen a dress that appeared entirely innocent until someone noticed the slit and the knife sheath at her thigh.

"They're here to stop me from signing away the guild roof," Shade said. "Or giving your temple naming rights to it."

Maelen beamed. "Excellent. Sit, eat, and spend your money."

The food proved excellent.

The wine was better.

Neither helped Shade when Arcebek and Maelen turned the meal into what felt suspiciously like courtship by contract.

“You need healers in the field,” Maelen began after the first course, turning their glass between their fingers. “We need people who understand that stopping a bleed can be holier than arranging a ritual three days later. I suspect we can help one another.”

Arcebek leaned forward. “You want funding and students. We want fewer bodies brought back from the roads and less trouble at your doors. And you want a little influence in the guild—but not enough to summon Lana back to haunt you.”

Maelen lifted an eyebrow. “You are not what I expected when I heard ‘warlock in a polycule.’”

“I get that a lot,” Arcebek replied.

Shade let them fence over tithes, training costs, and Maelen’s ambitious suggestion of a cut from potion sales before steering the talk towards the point.

“Triage first,” he said. “A Bronze party doesn’t need a miracle worker on every expedition. It needs someone who can see an open wound without freezing, stop the bleeding, keep a patient breathing, and get them to the people who can work miracles.”

“And teach them the limits,” Elcia added. “Splints, tourniquets, when a wounded person can be moved and when moving them will make things worse.”

Maelen considered that, one finger tapping against their glass.

“Six weeks,” they said at last. “Evening lessons, taught by our junior healers alongside your retired medics. Those who pass earn a recognised badge. Field stewards, perhaps. They needn’t be priests to be useful.”

Rakihi straightened. “A pin, too. Red and gold, perhaps—a leaf. Something people can recognise when they’re shouting for help.”

Maelen’s smile lost a little of its calculation. “I like that. Yes, a pin.”

“What about the ones who want to go further?” Shade asked. “I’ve read reports about adventurers holding people together with improvised bandages until a cleric arrived. Some of them have a gift.”

Maelen folded their hands.

“For those, we open a proper path,” Maelen said. “Joint sponsorship. Your guild covers their living allowance while they study; the temple trains them as clerics or devoted healers, according to their calling. In exchange, they serve with the guild for an agreed term before choosing a quieter life.”

“Or not-so-quiet,” Arcebek murmured.

Maelen let the remark pass. “You gain healers who know a dungeon corridor from a temple aisle. We gain clergy who have met a little mud.”

Shade weighed the offer. A term of service made sense, provided the students were paid fairly and knew what they were agreeing to.

“Three years after training,” he proposed. “Hazard pay, and the option to renew.”

“Five,” Maelen said.

“Four,” Arcebek countered, “and your people get first offer of the demon assignments. We also want guild rates on emergency potions from your alchemists.”

Maelen blinked, then broke into laughter.

“I see why you brought her.”

“Never,” Shade said.

The bargaining continued through the next course.

By the time the plates were cleared, they had the bones of an agreement:

A joint triage course for adventurers willing and able to learn, taught by the temple and the guild together.

A longer healer track, with sponsored study and several years of paid field service afterwards.

Written rates for emergency treatment, potions, and shared supplies, precise enough to satisfy Arcebek and, to Shade’s surprise, Maelen.

When they raised their glasses, Rakihi looked almost absurdly pleased.

“Think of it,” she said. “The next time someone gets stabbed in a stupid alley behind a stupid tavern, there might be three people close enough to help before the bleeding wins.”

“And fewer names on the memorial wall,” Elcia said softly.

Maelen raised their glass.

“To fewer deaths that could have been prevented,” Maelen said. “And guildmasters who notice the gap before it takes someone they love.”

Shade touched his glass to theirs, feeling the weight of that last remark.

“Deal,” he said.

On the walk home, beneath a sky that held no dragons or divine omens, another problem found him.

Outside the guild, a handful of young adventurers practised sword forms under a guttering lamp. Their stances were poor, their grips worse. The group’s aspiring mage produced more sparks than light.

The guild employed a few general combat instructors.

But no dedicated druid trainer.

No arcane mentor whose advice extended much beyond keeping one’s hands attached.

No bard to teach young performers how to pace their magic when a fight went long.

He had just found a way to bring the temple and the guild together over healing.

How many other gaps had everyone learned to live with?

He tucked the question away for morning.

Another problem, certainly. But not one he could solve tonight.

Tonight he had helped put something in place that might keep an adventurer alive on a muddy road, in the long minutes between a scream and a prayer.

For once, he let that be enough.

Chapter 38: A City Without Teachers

Shade was beginning to suspect the city ran on habit, stubbornness, and the occasional act of charity.

Over the next three weeks, he investigated everything anyone was willing to call training.

An elderly sword master rented a patch of yard behind the eastern wall and charged five copper to anyone who could hold a blade. A retired ranger drilled children in tracking on an empty lot because, as he put it, someone had to. One hedge-witch accepted perhaps two apprentices in a decade, assuming the omens suited her.

But schools with regular instruction?

A college that could take a promising young mage beyond the basics?

Somewhere a farm child might study tactics or healing without leaving the city?

Nothing that deserved the name.

“If you want proper schooling, you go to the capital,” a records-office scribe told him with a shrug. “Or south. Or north. People usually arrive here once they’ve learned a trade.”

Shade returned to the manor with a headache and enough expense reports to make it worse.

He spread guild ledgers, municipal records, and a rough district map across the dining table.

Rakihi stopped beside the paper avalanche with a tray of tea. “Is this a romance plot or a coup? I need to know how to dress.”

“Neither. Education policy.”

Arcebek looked up from her scrolls. “Oh. Foreplay.”

Elcia drew out a chair. “You’ve found something worse than the shortage of healers.”

Shade tapped the map with one finger.

“We have veterans willing to teach and a few mages taking private apprentices, but nothing organised. Talented children leave to study, and many never return. The ones who stay learn while they work.” He glanced at the reports beside his elbow. “Often from their mistakes.”

Rakihi leaned closer, frowning at the map.

“Then we build a school,” she said, as though the answer ought to be obvious.

“I’d like to. But the guild is stretched, and we’ve just committed funds to the healers. We can contribute, not carry the whole thing.”

Arcebek glanced from the guild ledger to the city’s expenditure columns.

“You want the council’s coin.”

“The council’s investment,” Shade corrected. “Fewer untrained adventurers means fewer fires, failed contracts, and accidental demon summonings. Unfortunately, councillors prefer to pay for things they can see. Walls, wells, statues of themselves.”

Elcia’s mouth twitched. “So you intend to bully them.”

“Without starting a war, ideally. I need a plan strong enough to survive their objections.”

They studied the map in silence until Rakihi reached for a piece of charcoal.

Rakihi was the first to move.

“First, prove the cost of doing nothing,” she said, circling three places. “Count the injuries. Count the training accidents. Ask how many talented people leave for schooling and never come back. You don’t need to embellish the picture if the figures are bad enough.”

She drew a heavy line beneath the merchant district.

“Start with the merchants. Lost caravans hurt them. Promise better-trained escorts and they’ll make the argument for you.”

Arcebek claimed another charcoal stick and began writing names along the map’s edge.

“Allies before council day,” she said. “The watch captain. Maelen. The harbourmaster, if you can get him to see reason. Talk to the councillors who aren’t hopeless, one at a time. By the time the full council meets, you want them arguing over whose idea it was.”

Elcia indicated the lower ward, where many of the city’s poorer adventurers lived.

“And remind them who cannot afford to leave,” she said. “Wealthy families send their children away to train. Everyone else trusts to luck. A public hall says their lives are worth teaching, too. Some councillors will understand that. The others may listen when the streets do.”

Shade watched the shapes take form beneath their hands.

The ache behind his eyes began to recede.

“And if the council agrees in principle? I need something they can actually fund without turning it into a monument.”

Arcebek was already making a list.

“First phase: expand the guild yard. Hire those veterans properly. Give them steady wages, apprentices, and a roof that keeps out the rain. The city helps with the building costs because trained defenders are a public benefit.”

“Second phase: classrooms,” Rakihi said. “Literacy, arithmetic, magic safety. You would be amazed how many Bronze adventurers can’t read the terms of their own contracts.”

“Third phase: specialisations,” Elcia added. “Advanced weapon instruction, rotating druid mentors, whatever we can staff responsibly. We develop the paths as we recruit teachers. We needn’t pretend it is a complete college on the first day.”

Shade looked at the growing plan: circles, names, arrows, promises that would have to become budgets.

“That’s a great deal of work.”

“It’s work in stages,” Arcebek said. “We’re not summoning a university out of thin air. We’re giving structure to people who already teach.”

“And publicity,” Rakihi said brightly. “‘Come to the city that teaches you how to survive your first adventure.’ I could make that a song by breakfast.”

Elcia met his gaze across the scattered papers.

“You needn’t repair every failing in a year,” she said. “But you can begin. The healers were a beginning.”

Shade let out a breath he had not realised he was holding.

“Evidence first. Then the allies. Then a phased proposal, with shared costs and benefits we can defend. Maelen can speak for the temple, and the watch captain for the guard.” He glanced at the numbers. “That sounds almost manageable.”

“And when they complain about the price,” Arcebek said, “remind them what it costs to clean demon ichor out of the streets.”

Rakihi tapped her teacup gently against his wrist, careful to miss the ink.

“To the Guild Academy,” she declared. “Name pending.”

“To fewer graves,” Elcia replied.

Shade surveyed the table, the argument taking shape in charcoal and ink.

He had been raised to plan campaigns across continents.

Now he was planning classrooms.

“One step at a time,” he said, finding he finally believed it.

One problem at a time.

That, at least, he knew how to do.

Chapter 39: Ink, Ledgers and Stone

For three days, the guild scribes found new reasons to dislike him.

“I trained to copy contracts,” one complained, massaging his ink-stained temples as another stack appeared. “Not calculate the average number of missing limbs by mission rank.”

Shade could sympathise.

He brought them fresh ink and a tray of pastries before asking for the next set of figures.

The Bronze adventurers hired to gather information outside the city were no more enthusiastic.

“You want us to ask other towns why people leave?”

“And question caravan masters about how well their guards were trained?”

“Then interview the trainers and write everything down?”

“Interview trainers and write it down?”

“Three silver a day,” Shade offered. “Extra if anyone throws you out.”

“Three silver a day,” he said. “Plus hazard pay if anyone throws you out.”

“Will there be a list of questions?” one asked.

“Do we get a script?” one asked hopefully.

Rakihi prepared a courteous but determined questionnaire: Would families use local training if it existed? How often did merchants struggle to find capable guards? Which skills did employers wish their apprentices possessed?

The work took weeks.

The scribes produced piles of figures. The adventurers returned with accounts from towns, workshops, and trade roads. One particularly exacting clerk muttered about sampling errors until Shade gave him the job of checking for them.

Taken together, the evidence was difficult to dismiss.

Too many new adventurers died in their first year.

Too many injuries were dismissed as unavoidable accidents.

Too much of the city’s talent—and its coin—departed for schools elsewhere and failed to return.

Shade spent two nights condensing the findings into three pages and one merciless chart.

Then came a task he dreaded more than fighting a Voidfront.

Private meetings with people who could say no.

There seemed to be hundreds.

He made his case in inn parlours, municipal offices still smelling of fresh ink, and the temple cloister, where Maelen offered tea and increasingly pointed comments.

Some meetings went better than he expected.

The merchant guildmistress listened with sharp eyes and an expression that betrayed nothing.

“Better escorts, fewer lost caravans,” she said at last. “And if we contribute, our members get an early chance to recruit the graduates?”

“An opportunity to recruit them,” Shade said. “The graduates still choose who employs them.”

“Good,” she said. “Then I’ll support it—provided nobody names the place after a sitting councillor. I am not paying for a Lord Foppington Memorial Combat Hall.”

“On that,” Shade said, “we agree completely.”

The smith-god’s priestess struck him between the shoulders hard enough to make his teeth click.

“About time someone remembered apprenticeships cost money,” she declared. “Build the place and I’ll send every decent hammer-swinger who wanders into my temple.”

Other discussions were less promising.

The harbourmaster regarded the figures as though they were a personal insult.

“Education? What use is that on my docks? I need people who can lift crates and follow orders, not scholars who think themselves too fine for honest labour.”

“Better escorts mean fewer raids on incoming shipments,” Shade said. “Fewer raids mean lower losses and less pressure on insurance. That saves your merchants money.”

“Or you’ve invented a crisis to build yourself a fancy yard.”

Shade left with a reasonably accurate prediction of the harbourmaster’s vote.

The watch captain was sympathetic, but she had problems of her own.

“The idea’s good,” she said, rubbing her forehead. “Recruits who don’t stab themselves would be a blessing. But I’m short on boots, and half my towers leak. I can’t spare the money.”

“I’m asking for your support, not your budget. Tell the council what better training would mean to your watch.”

She considered him for a moment.

Then nodded once.

“You’ll have it. But if the councillors take the money out of guard wages, I’ll come to your manor and lecture you myself.”

“I’ll help her,” Elcia offered from the doorway.

Shade had no doubt they meant it.

By council day, exhaustion had settled into his bones without the courtesy of leaving bruises.

At least he knew where matters stood.

Maelen, Captain Sera, Guildmistress Halvern, and the smith-priestess would speak for him, as would three minor nobles who had finally considered the value of competent guards for their heirs.

He also knew which councillors would oppose the plan out of pride, habit, or an aversion to spending coin.

He entered the council chamber with the proposal beneath his arm and the advantage of knowing his audience.

For once, he could see the pieces before he had to move them.

A room changed when he walked into it prepared.

Shade sat beside Lana's old chair and set his summary on the table while the members settled.

The council disposed of old business first:

a minor tariff dispute, repairs to a bridge, and another complaint from the harbourmaster about silt.

At last the council chairwoman turned to Shade.

"Guildmaster. You requested a place on the agenda."

"I did," Shade said.

He stood, lifting the first page.

"I'll be brief," he said, without much conviction.

A few councillors chuckled. Good. At least he had their attention.

He opened with neither a vision nor a speech.

He opened with the numbers.

"This is what the first year looks like for the average Bronze adventurer in our city."

He fastened the chart to the display board.

The figures rose sharply at three months, six, and nine.

Deaths. Serious injuries. People who had abandoned the profession.

"These are our caravan losses," he continued, pinning up a second sheet. "Raids, missing shipments, dead guards. And here is the number of young people leaving for training elsewhere because we cannot offer it here."

He gave the murmurs time to spread.

Then he faced the council again.

"I'm not presenting a problem without offering a way to solve it."

He explained the plan in stages.

An expanded training yard with a roof and proper instructors.

Shared funding from the guild and city, with temple participation where appropriate. Not a grand college, not yet: a practical hall built around instructors who were already working in yards and back rooms.

He looked to the allies who had agreed to support him.

"High Hierophant Maelen and the guild have agreed to establish joint triage training," he said. "The programme is not yet old enough to measure its results, but it addresses the same problem: people are dying because essential skills are missing. Maelen supports taking the next step."

Maelen tipped their head. "Reluctantly. The wine was excellent."

Soft laughter.

He nodded toward the watch captain.

“Captain Sera has seen the consequences of poor training in her own recruits. I asked her to tell you what a proper hall would change.”

“For a start, I might stop teaching every recruit which end of the spear belongs in a bandit,” she said. “That alone would improve my sleep.”

Then Shade turned to the merchants.

“Guildmistress Halvern supports the proposal as well. Better escorts mean fewer caravans lost.”

Halvern turned one of her rings. “Training costs less than replacing guards. Even I can manage that calculation.”

The smith-priestess snorted; several councillors smiled despite themselves.

Then the opposition began.

The harbourmaster leaned forward with a sneer.

“And when these clever young adventurers decide they’re above working on the docks, who will fill my warehouses?”

Shade kept his expression calm.

“Knowing how to lift without injury makes a porter more useful, not less. Knowing how to read a manifest helps a dock guard stop the wrong cargo getting through.” He paused. “Unless you would prefer them untrained?”

A snicker went around the table.

The harbourmaster reddened. “You can twist my words all you please. I won’t pay for it.”

“The proposal asks the city to fund a public service,” Shade answered. “Not for you to open your private purse.”

A representative of the guard’s budget committee cleared his throat.

“It sounds worthwhile,” he said. “But we can’t let the watch lose funding to make room for it.”

Maelen spoke before Shade could answer.

“Then insist upon safeguards. This is public infrastructure, not a temple vanity project. One does not pull stones from a sound wall to mend another.”

Shade accepted the opening.

“We’re proposing a roof over an enlarged yard, several classrooms, and wages for instructors who already live here. The guild will pay a substantial share. The city’s contribution will keep its defenders from learning the basics by losing fingers.”

The chamber fell quiet.

Shade could almost feel decades of habit pressing against the proposal: the belief that because something had always been neglected, it could go on being neglected.

Finally, the council chairwoman spoke.

“Submit a phased proposal in writing. With costs, projected benefits, and a provision protecting existing watch and temple funding.”

“Already prepared,” Shade said, sliding the document towards her.

She examined the first page and passed it to the next member.

The councillors read in turn.

Some nodded. Others frowned.

Shade watched where their eyes lingered, which figures made them pause, which promises they checked twice.

The vote, when it came, was almost disappointingly ordinary.

No shouting. No grand speeches.

Only names called and answers given.

Aye.

Aye.

Nay. The harbourmaster, as expected.

Aye.

Aye.

Abstain.

When the tally was complete, the margin was comfortable.

The motion had passed.

“The council approves a formal training hall in partnership with the Adventurers’ Guild and the temples,” the chairwoman announced, rapping the table. “Funding will be released in stages, subject to review. Congratulations, Guildmaster. You’ve earned yourself more paperwork.”

A ripple of laughter moved around the room.

Shade lowered himself into his chair.

His hands were perfectly steady.

His heart was doing something rather less dignified.

Only when they reached the steps outside did he allow himself to smile. Rakihi nearly collided with him in her excitement.

“You did it,” she whispered fiercely. “You dragon-bullied the council into paying for a school.”

Arcebek clapped his shoulder. “In ten years we’ll be drowning in annoyingly competent newcomers quoting Shade’s Doctrine of Not Dying in the First Week.”

Elcia’s expression was warm and steady.

“You gave it a shape,” she said. “Now people can build on it. That matters.”

Shade glanced back at the council chamber.

Then at the three of them.

At last he noticed the ink beneath his fingernails.

“It’s a yard with a roof and some teachers,” he said.

“For now,” Arcebek replied.

“Most good things begin with less,” Elcia said.

Rakihi linked her arm through his.

“Come on. We have a sword master to tell he’s getting paid properly. And perhaps some scribes to bribe before they learn how much more data you’ll want.”

Shade winced.

“Right. The scribes.”

One battle at a time.

This one, at least, had ended in victory.

Chapter 40: The Training Hall

The guild hall sounded as though it were under siege.

Hammers rang. Saws rasped. Someone shouted for more nails. Someone else shouted that if the carpenters struck that support again, the guildmaster would personally feed them to an earth elemental.

By midmorning, the scribes had staged a quiet revolt.

Their spokesman appeared in Shade's doorway with ink on his nose and murder in his eyes.

"Guildmaster," he said through clenched teeth, "either the building work moves or we do. I cannot copy contracts while the wall is arguing with a hammer."

Shade glanced at the ceiling. Each blow sent another tremor through his inkpots.

"Work from home," he said at last. "Or an inn. Or that pleasant hill by the windmill, for all I care. Take whatever records you need. Just don't lose anyone's will."

The scribe blinked, clearly unprepared for such an easy surrender.

"On paid time?" he ventured.

"Yes. I'll even authorise hazard pay if a carpenter drops a plank on you while you're leaving."

Within the hour, the scribes had vanished with armfuls of ledgers and muttered prayers of gratitude.

That left Shade with a different problem: people.

Trainers, to be precise.

He had spent days hunting down anyone in the city who could credibly call themselves an instructor without endangering their pupils.

The elderly sword-master who taught behind the east wall: hired.

The retired ranger who practised on the vacant lot: hired.

Two hedge-witches who had reluctantly agreed to teach students how not to blow off their eyebrows: hired.

Two former guards who knew how to teach a proper shield line: hired.

Then there were the alarming number whose entire teaching philosophy amounted to hitting students until they learned.

Those interviews had been short.

And now he had reached the problem that none of those appointments solved.

He sat behind his desk, surrounded by notes on candidates for a position he had only recently thought to create:

Master or Mistress of the Training Hall.

Someone to manage the instructors, coordinate timetables, negotiate with builders, and keep the whole enterprise from collapsing the moment Shade turned his attention elsewhere.

The shortlist offered little encouragement.

Too rigid.

Too lazy.

Too drunk.

Too fond of hearing themselves speak.

Too eager to treat pupils as unpaid labour.

Shade pinched the bridge of his nose.

“I can’t run the hall and the guild,” he muttered. “I need someone who understands people and logistics. Someone who won’t sell the building to pay for a party.”

“How about me?”

Shade looked up.

Rakihi leaned against the doorframe, her hair gathered into a messy knot. Sawdust marked one cheek; evidently she had been inspecting the construction. The storm gem in her ear glimmered as she tilted her head.

He blinked.

“You want to run the training hall?” he asked slowly.

Her mouth curved. “Why do you sound as though I offered to juggle live dragons?”

“Because you enjoy chaos, improvisation, and setting things on fire. Frequently on purpose.”

“All transferable skills.” She dropped into the chair opposite his desk. “Hear me out.”

Shade folded his arms. “Go on.”

She leaned forward, eyes alight.

“Who in this household knows what young adventurers coming through Bronze actually need? Who hears their songs and complaints in every tavern? Who knows which veterans can teach and which only want someone to shout at?”

He had no immediate answer.

Rakihi was not finished.

“Who performs three nights a week and hears half the guild grumbling into its ale?”

“You do,” he conceded.

“Exactly.” She counted on her fingers. “I’ve watched you teach. I’ve watched Lana teach. I’ve watched recruits give up because nobody showed them how to fall without breaking something. I’m a bard, Shade. I notice patterns. I can hear when the training is off-key.”

Shade breathed out.

“I know you’re capable. But this is administration. Rosters, budgets, council meetings, arguments with carpenters. You hate meetings.”

“I hate meetings where nothing happens. This”—she gestured at the plans, the desk, the shaking walls—“is building something that matters. Besides, I wouldn’t be doing it alone.”

She glanced over her shoulder, as if waiting for someone to take a cue.

Arcebek appeared in the doorway with a cup of tea.

“She recruited me for this conversation,” the warlock said. “And, irritatingly, she makes sense.”

Shade lifted an eyebrow. “You’re in favour?”

“With conditions. First, she gets a deputy who enjoys paperwork and timetables. Second, the charter defines her authority clearly. I refuse to let anyone dismiss her as a guildmaster’s favourite who got a title because she shares his bed.”

“Thank you for putting it so delicately,” Rakihi said.

“You know what I mean. She earns the post on merit, and the charter makes that plain.”

Elcia spoke from the passage.

“Third,” she said, stepping into view, “we establish boundaries. When Rakihi is acting as Mistress of the Hall, she is your officer. You do not make her carry your stress, and you do not blame her for decisions that are yours.”

Shade looked from one woman to the next.

“You planned this.”

“Of course,” Rakihi said. “You were going to reject every candidate, take the position yourself, and exhaust yourself trying to run both places. We decided to intervene.”

He dragged his hands down his face.

“You understand that every angry trainer will come to you when their schedule changes?”

Rakihi grinned. “People, drama, authority. Whatever shall I do?”

“And frightened pupils,” Elcia reminded her. “Students whose mentors are bullies. Students who are hurt and afraid to admit it.”

Rakihi’s grin eased into something gentler.

“I know.” Her voice softened. “I like the thought that they might come to me before they reach the point of breaking.”

Shade studied her.

She sat with her customary easy confidence, but there was purpose beneath it.

He remembered how she could command a tavern with a song.

How she could read a battle like a changing melody.

How closely she watched the manoeuvring in the council gallery.

And he considered what trusting her with this position would mean.

Not merely giving her a task. Giving her something of her own.

“You truly want this?” he asked, speaking as her partner rather than her guildmaster.

Rakihi met his eyes.

“Yes. Provided you let me make it mine. Not as ‘Shade’s bard’, but as Rakihi, Mistress of the Training Hall, terror of lazy instructors and patron saint of overconfident Bronze idiots.”

Arcebek snorted. “We should put that on a plaque.”

Elcia smiled. “The students will adore you. The bad teachers will fear you. The good ones will learn to work with you.”

Shade released the breath he had been holding.

“Then it’s yours, subject to Arcebek’s conditions. A clear charter, a deputy, and agreed boundaries.”

Rakihi lit up so completely that the mage-lamps seemed unnecessary.

“Really? No grand dragon speech about needing three days to deliberate?”

“I watched you organise a sing-along across three taverns while stopping a brawl. Ignoring that talent would be foolish.”

She nearly vaulted the desk to kiss him, caught herself at the last moment, and seized his shoulders instead.

“Thank you,” she said, with startling intensity.

He squeezed her forearms.

“Make it work,” he said softly.

“Oh, I’ll make you regret it at least once,” she promised. “But you’ll be proud of the result.”

Arcebek raised her tea in a toast. “To Rakihi, Mistress of the Hall. May your scheduling quills never run dry.”

“And may your pupils learn to fall without breaking,” Elcia added.

Shade glanced at the stack of unsuitable applications.

Then at Rakihi.

He pushed them aside.

“Welcome to the command staff,” he told Rakihi.

Outside, the hammers continued their relentless assault.

Inside, the training hall had found its heart.

Chapter 41: More Alive Than Dead

Shade noticed it while passing the salt.

Elcia's fingertips brushed his.

They were warm.

Not the faint, unsettling coolness he remembered from her dullahan curse, nor the strange sensation that part of her remained somewhere beyond the living world.

Warm as any living hand.

He hesitated, his fingers lingering against hers.

Elcia tilted her head. "Shade?"

He glanced around the table. Rakihi was telling a story about a bard in the docks district, and Arcebek was struggling not to laugh into her tea.

He tipped his head towards the kitchen.

"Would you help me with the stew?" he asked, trying to sound casual.

Rakihi's eyebrow rose. "Is that what we're calling it?"

"There is actual stew," Shade replied. "And you'll complain if I burn it."

She huffed. "Fair."

Elcia followed him, closing the kitchen door behind them.

The kitchen held the warmth of the oven and the golden glow of the lamps. Small elementals bustled about their chores while the stew simmered on the stove.

Shade leaned against the counter and turned to her.

"May I ask you something strange?"

A faint smile touched her lips. "You could describe most of our life that way. Ask."

This time he took her hand deliberately.

"You feel warmer. Since the storm gems. Since the visit to the court. Your touch, your kisses… everything." Heat rose to his cheeks, but he continued. "Even when you remove your head, you seem less caught between worlds. More present. Have you noticed?"

Her amusement faded into thought.

She looked at their hands and then at the gem resting against her throat.

Lightning moved faintly within the stone, its pulse just out of step with her own.

"Yes," she admitted. "I thought I was imagining it at first. Hoping for something that wasn't there." She tightened her grip. "But I do feel more alive."

She considered how to explain.

“There used to be a pull beneath everything. If I stood still too long, I felt as though I ought to start walking. Roads, crossroads, graveyards. The death god’s summons, urging me to collect what was owed. Binding the curse to you quieted it, but it never stopped.”

Shade remembered the distant look in her eyes whenever funeral bells rang.

“I still feel it sometimes,” she said, giving a small laugh. “But since the storm gems, and since your family accepted us—your mother’s alarming interest in my neck notwithstanding—it has grown weaker.”

“An unforgettable welcome,” Shade murmured.

Elcia continued as if he had not interrupted.

“Not gone. The curse is still part of me. I can still do this.”

She took hold of her chin and lifted her head free with the effortless, dreadful ease Shade had never entirely learned to accept.

For a moment she held it in one hand, her other hand still entwined with his.

Her eyes remained bright and amused.

“Hello,” she said.

It ought to have felt cold and unnatural.

Yet her hand was warm.

Through the storm gem, Shade could sense her presence as clearly as ever.

He swallowed. “Still unnerving. But it’s becoming less a graveyard horror and more an extraordinarily peculiar party trick.”

Laughing, Elcia settled her head back on her shoulders. The joining left no seam.

“My oath to Kael Varis complicated matters,” she said, growing serious. “Judgement, balance, the hearth. Then came my oath to you and the others, and the storm gem. And your mother all but gave me an imperial seal of approval.”

She reclaimed his hand.

“Oaths have weight. The old curse still pulls, but my paladin vows, my hearth-oath, and the bond carried by this gem pull in other directions. I am less a tool sent wandering by the dead, and more a person who can choose when to answer the road.” Her expression softened. “And choose to come home.”

Something ached pleasantly in Shade’s chest.

“Do you feel free?”

She took time to consider.

“Almost. Free enough that staying home no longer feels like defiance.” She smiled crookedly. “Free enough to wake beside you, with Rakihi draped over my legs and Arcebek snoring in my hair, without immediately thinking of some distant road I ought to be riding.”

“Arcebek does not snore.”

“She does. Very delicately.”

Shade let their joined hands swing between them.

“Is it safe?” he asked. “If the curse weakens, could Kael Varis object? Or your former patron?”

“Kael Varis governs oaths kept, not chains. He expects me to do my work, bring reckoning where it is due, and protect those beneath my hearth. I still do those things.” She squeezed his hand. “The death god lost his claim when I chose you. If he wants another contest, he may challenge a storm-dragon, a god of balance, and three exceptionally angry women. I favour our chances.”

Shade breathed easier.

“Then I’m glad,” he said. “Selfishly glad that you feel more alive here, with us.”

Elcia moved close enough that her breath warmed his throat.

“You gave me more than one place to belong. The road, the hearth, the storm. And I chose the one with stew, dreadful council meetings, and a dragon who blushes whenever anyone calls us his wives.”

His cheeks warmed again. “You noticed?”

“Everyone noticed.”

She cupped his cheek, her thumb brushing his skin.

“Whatever the curse intended to make of me, it never accounted for you. Or Rakihi and Arcebek. I am not becoming less myself.” Her voice steadied. “I am becoming more of the person I wanted to be.”

He rested his forehead against hers, listening to the familiar sounds of their home beyond the door.

“I like that person,” he whispered.

She smiled, close enough that her lips brushed his.

“The warm one? Or the almost-free one?”

“Both. Very much both.”

Rakihi’s voice carried through the door.

“If you two are kissing without me, I’m eating all the bread!”

“And if you aren’t,” Arcebek added, “bring the stew before the potatoes die of old age.”

Elcia laughed and reached for the ladle.

“Later,” she whispered. “We can test the hypothesis more thoroughly.”

Shade made a thoroughly undignified sound.

Together they carried the stew back to the table, steam rising beside the faint glow of the storm gem at Elcia’s throat. Beneath it, her skin looked—and felt—beautifully, impossibly alive.

Chapter 42: The Road and the Hearth

Elcia had been unusually quiet for three days.

Not her familiar watchful calm. This silence made even the household elementals hesitate near her feet before scuttling away.

She finished her chores, attended training, and returned every kiss she was given.

Yet her gaze kept drifting towards roads nobody else could see.

Arcebek finally challenged her at breakfast.

Shade had a mission report open beside his plate. Rakihi hummed as she braided her hair with one hand. Elcia stared into her porridge.

Arcebek set her mug down hard.

“Enough. What is wrong? You’ve been wandering around as though someone is walking over your grave. And you’re the only person here who ought to be allowed to do that.”

Rakihi snorted into her breakfast.

Shade set his attention on Elcia and saw how tired she looked.

She flinched beneath their scrutiny, then sighed.

“The temple has made me an offer,” she said. “The servants of Kael Varis.”

Shade felt his stomach tighten. “What sort of offer?”

“An appointment. A formal position as a justiciar.” She winced at the title. “They want me to ride circuits between towns, settle disputes, hunt the worst offenders, and bring balance where local courts refuse to act.”

Rakihi stared. “That’s serious. They don’t offer those posts to just anyone, do they?”

“No,” Elcia said. “They don’t.”

Arcebek leaned back, eyes narrowing in concentration. “And the difficulty?”

“The time away. Weeks on the road, perhaps longer. I would return between circuits, but I would be here less often.” She looked around the table. “With you less often.”

Shade put aside his report.

“Is it something you want?” he asked.

For him, that was the question that mattered.

Elcia clasped her hands and studied her knuckles.

“Part of me does. It is what I trained for, even before the curse: travelling, setting wrongs right, and moving on.” Her gaze lifted towards them. “But now I have a home. A bed that means more than a place to rest between journeys. People who notice when I’m missing.”

Her voice faltered.

“I don’t know how to choose.”

For a moment, none of them spoke.

Then Rakihi moved around the table, perched beside Elcia, and nudged her shoulder.

“First, you don’t have to decide this morning. Second, it doesn’t have to be the road or us. It can be the road and us.” She smiled. “We are remarkably difficult to get rid of. We’ll still be here when you return.”

“Kael Varis is hardly the sort of god to demand that you tear out your own heart to serve him,” Arcebek said. “They offered because they believe you can do the work. That doesn’t mean you must accept if the cost is too high.”

Shade drew a breath.

“When we bound your curse to me, I promised you a choice,” he said. “Not merely about me. About your life. If you want this, I will not ask you to stay for my sake.”

Elcia’s eyes shone.

“I don’t want to leave you.”

“Good,” Rakihi said promptly. “We’d take that rather personally.”

“But I don’t want to spend the next ten years wondering whether I turned away from my calling because I was frightened of losing what I have here.” Elcia struggled for the words. “I don’t want to resent any of you for a choice I made myself.”

Arcebek’s expression softened.

“That,” she said, “is the clearest thing I have heard anyone say about duty in a very long time.”

She tapped her fingers against the table, thinking.

“My selfish answer is that I would rather share you with a god of balance than lose you to the graveyard. If this work makes you feel more yourself, I’ll help you pack. I shall grumble theatrically, of course.”

“And I shall write vicious ballads about any town that mistreats you,” Rakihi added. “Or tries to keep you for itself.”

Shade reached for Elcia’s hand across the table.

“If you accept, we make some agreements. You come home between circuits, when the work allows. You write when you can. And if the post begins to consume you, you tell us. We find a different arrangement. You have already given enough of yourself to duty.”

Elcia laughed shakily. “You sound like Arcebek.”

“A terrible influence,” Shade agreed.

“And proud of it,” Arcebek replied.

Elcia gazed at their hands, then at the storm gem resting against her throat. The weight of Kael Varis’ unseen scales seemed almost tangible.

“You truly wouldn’t be angry if I accepted?”

Rakihi managed a fierce, unsteady smile.

“Lonely? Absolutely. I intend to steal your side of the bed while you’re gone. But angry? Not for choosing something that matters to you.”

“Worried,” Arcebek admitted, squeezing Elcia’s knee. “Constantly. Yet I worry about you now. At least the temple could offer support on the road.”

Shade spoke quietly.

“I will miss you terribly. But I would rather welcome you home from a distant road than watch you remain here, wondering what you gave up for us.”

Elcia swallowed.

“Then, if I decide I want the position, you’ll support me?”

“Yes,” all three answered together.

Elcia let out a long, trembling breath.

“I’ll speak with the temple again. Ask about the routes, the terms, and how long I would be away. I won’t decide until I understand the commitment.”

“Excellent,” Arcebek said. “Read the contract before signing. I approve.”

Rakihi rested her head on Elcia’s shoulder.

“Whatever you choose, you belong here. Road or no road.”

Shade nodded.

“Whatever road you follow, there will be a place for you at this table. And in our bed. And three people waiting to complain when you are late.”

Elcia laughed then, properly, the tension easing from her shoulders for the first time in days.

“In that case,” she said, “I think I know what I want.”

She kept the decision to herself for now.

But her eyes travelled to the window and the road beyond it, then back to the people gathered around her table.

She would travel.

And she would return.

And her family would be waiting.

Chapter 43: A Place to Call Home

Elcia returned home carrying a document stamped with the seal of Kael Varis and wearing an expression that made Shade set down his quill.

In recent weeks, he had learned to distinguish ordinary paperwork from the sort that changed lives. The former arrived in stacks. The latter tended to be carried in both hands.

Arcebek glanced up from the hearth before Elcia had even crossed the threshold. “Well?”

Elcia paused in the doorway, her travelling cloak still fastened. Rakihi, perched on the back of the sofa with a notebook balanced on her knees, abandoned it without a second thought.

“I accepted,” Elcia said.

For one heartbeat, the room went still.

Then Rakihi sprang across it and nearly swept the halfling off her feet.

“You did it!”

“I did,” Elcia managed, laughing into a shoulderful of pale blue hair. “If you let me breathe, I might even tell you what I agreed to.”

“Details later,” Rakihi declared. “Celebration first.”

“Details now,” Arcebek countered, though the smile in her voice took the sting from the order. “I want to know whether they slipped anything unpleasant into the contract.”

Elcia crossed to the table, laid out the papers, and carefully smoothed their corners. The appointment was genuine: she would serve as a travelling justiciar of Kael Varis, authorised to hear disputes, investigate abuses of power, and pursue matters beyond the reach—or the willingness—of local courts. Her first circuit was modest. She had temple contacts along the route, written authority from the order, and provisions for returning home between assignments.

“And?” Arcebek asked.

“And I read every word,” Elcia replied, giving her a pointed look. “Twice.”

“There's our girl.”

Shade paid closer attention to what Elcia said about coming home than to the list of her new duties. Not because the duties were unimportant; they mattered enormously. But he remembered the way she had once stood at the window, watching the road as though it were both a summons and a sentence.

Now she smiled whenever she looked at the papers.

“Do you feel it?” he asked quietly.

She understood at once. Her fingers rose to the storm gem at her throat.

“The pull?” she asked. “A little. But nothing like before.” She thought for a moment. “It's more like hearing travellers on the road beyond the gate and knowing I can decide whether to join them.”

Shade nodded. He had once believed freedom meant being able to go wherever he pleased. Elcia was teaching him that it could also mean having somewhere he chose to return to.

Rakihi immediately declared that dinner would be a feast and that Elcia was forbidden to help prepare it. Arcebek raised a series of practical objections. Shade, who had survived wars of annihilation as well as city council meetings, knew better than to enter either woman's campaign for control of the kitchen.

He settled for asking the house elementals to make room for an extra dessert.

The following morning brought a different sort of celebration.

The new training hall opened its doors.

From the street, the new training hall still looked like an impossible undertaking sustained by determination, guild coin, and an irresponsible quantity of scaffolding. Yet its courtyard had been swept, its practice circles marked, its lecture rooms furnished with real desks. The medical wing smelled of clean linen rather than plaster dust.

Shade stood beside Arcebek at the entrance as young adventurers streamed past in nervous little groups. Some wore boots so new they squeaked. Others carried gear that had already survived several owners. All tried very hard to look as though they belonged.

He knew that expression well.

“There you are,” Rakihi said, appearing at his elbow with a ledger tucked beneath one arm. “Before you ask: yes, the instructors have rooms. Yes, the healers have supplies. And yes, someone checked that the practice blades are actually practice blades.”

Shade opened his mouth.

“And no,” she added, “you may not inspect every hinge in the building before the first lesson.”

“I was going to say congratulations.”

Rakihi blinked. Suspicion narrowed her eyes. “That's worse. I had an entire speech prepared.”

“You may still give it,” he said.

“Oh, I intend to.”

The mistress of the training hall vanished into a crowd of students and guild uniforms, her pale blue hair briefly visible above the bustle. A moment later, her voice rang out—bright, confident, and impossible to ignore. Somehow, the crowd quieted.

Shade watched her with an affection that caught painfully beneath his ribs.

“I remember when you were the one waiting outside the guild,” Arcebek said.

“I arrived inside a crater.”

“Yes, dragon. Your entrances have improved. Marginally.”

He glanced at her. She had turned her face towards the hall, listening to footsteps and the first scrape of chairs. The storm gem set into her claw-ring caught the morning light.

“You were there for my first test,” he said.

“I was there for the second,” she said. “The one where you saved Jerrin from a harpy, then used that harpy to hit two others.”

“A practical solution.”

“An appalling first impression,” she said fondly. “I was quite taken with you.”

“You did not show it.”

“I am a professional.”

He laughed.

Inside, Rakihi began her opening address. A few solemn words about preparation and duty gave way to a joke that sent the novices into peals of laughter. Shade thought of the guild as it had been when he first arrived: full of capable people who too often learned vital lessons only after surviving the consequences of ignorance.

He remembered the wounded as well. Reports that ended with a carefully recorded number of survivors. Young adventurers who believed courage alone would bring them home.

There would still be injuries, and mistakes, and missions from which not everyone returned. He knew better than most that no training hall could make the world safe.

But it could give them a better chance.

A novice emerged from a side door with three practice shields stacked precariously in his arms. Shade caught the uppermost shield before it fell, settled it back onto the pile, and pointed him towards the yard.

“Thank you, Guildmaster!” the boy said, and hurried off.

Shade watched him hurry away.

“Do you know,” he said slowly, “I once thought helping people meant being strong enough to defeat whatever frightened them?”

Arcebek turned towards him.

“And now?”

He watched a healer usher a group into the medical wing. Nearby, an old swordsman patiently adjusted a girl's grip on a practice blade.

“Now I think it might mean making sure they need me a little less tomorrow.”

Arcebek slipped her hand into his.

“Careful,” she said. “You are beginning to sound like a guildmaster.”

By sunset, the manor had settled into the happy disorder of a household with several reasons to celebrate.

Rakihi returned hoarse but triumphant, having apparently convinced an entire hall of nervous novices that they might become competent adventurers after all. Arcebek had produced an enormous dinner despite insisting she wasn't responsible for one. Elcia placed her appointment papers on a shelf. Whatever duties they represented could wait until morning.

Minor elementals bustled through the kitchen. Fresh bread cooled beneath a cloth. In the firelight, each storm gem caught and returned its own colour.

Before Shade lay a half-written letter.

It was addressed to his mother. The Matriarch's latest message, written in the same severe hand he remembered from childhood, had contained a surprisingly simple question: how was her son's education progressing?

He had spent most of the past hour trying to answer.

He could write about the guild, the council, the training hall, the missions, the demons, and the endless talent mortals had for making simple agreements complicated. He had learned to bargain with people who possessed no armies, to listen to lives that lasted scarcely a heartbeat by dragon standards, and to carry responsibilities that no sword could settle.

Yet none of it seemed to answer her question.

“You are smiling,” Arcebek observed from across the table.

“Am I?”

“Suspiciously,” Rakihi said.

Elcia tilted her head. “Should we be concerned?”

Shade lifted his gaze from the letter and looked around the table.

Arcebek had taught him that being feared was not the same as being understood—and that someone shaped by war could still be loved. Rakihi had filled his days with music and mischief, showing him wonders in things he once would have overlooked. Elcia had shown him a courage greater than obedience to any curse: the courage to choose her own path.

Beyond the windows, Greenhollow eased into evening. Somewhere, young adventurers were preparing for their next lessons. Somewhere else, a merchant was undoubtedly drafting tomorrow's complaint. The world would go on making demands of him.

He found he didn't mind.

“What are you thinking about?” Rakihi asked.

“That I believe I understand why Mother sent me here.”

Elcia smiled. “And?”

Shade looked down at the unfinished letter. His mother had sent him among mortals to learn their fragility, their stubbornness, their maddening habits. He had taken it for a lesson in restraint. At first, he had measured each day by all the things he had managed not to destroy.

At some point, he had stopped keeping count.

He had work worth doing. Friends. Responsibilities. People who challenged him when he was foolish and welcomed him when he came home. A place at this table that belonged to him without command or ceremony.

He reached across the table for Arcebek's hand.

“I believe,” he said at last, “that I would like to stay.”

For a moment, no one spoke.

Then Elcia laid her hand over his. Rakihi leaned across the table to add hers, and Arcebek's thumb brushed his fingers.

Outside, thunder murmured across a cloudless sky.

Five stones chimed softly against his wrist.

And for once, the gods had nothing to add.

Guilds & Dragons

Book Two — The Dragon's Hearth

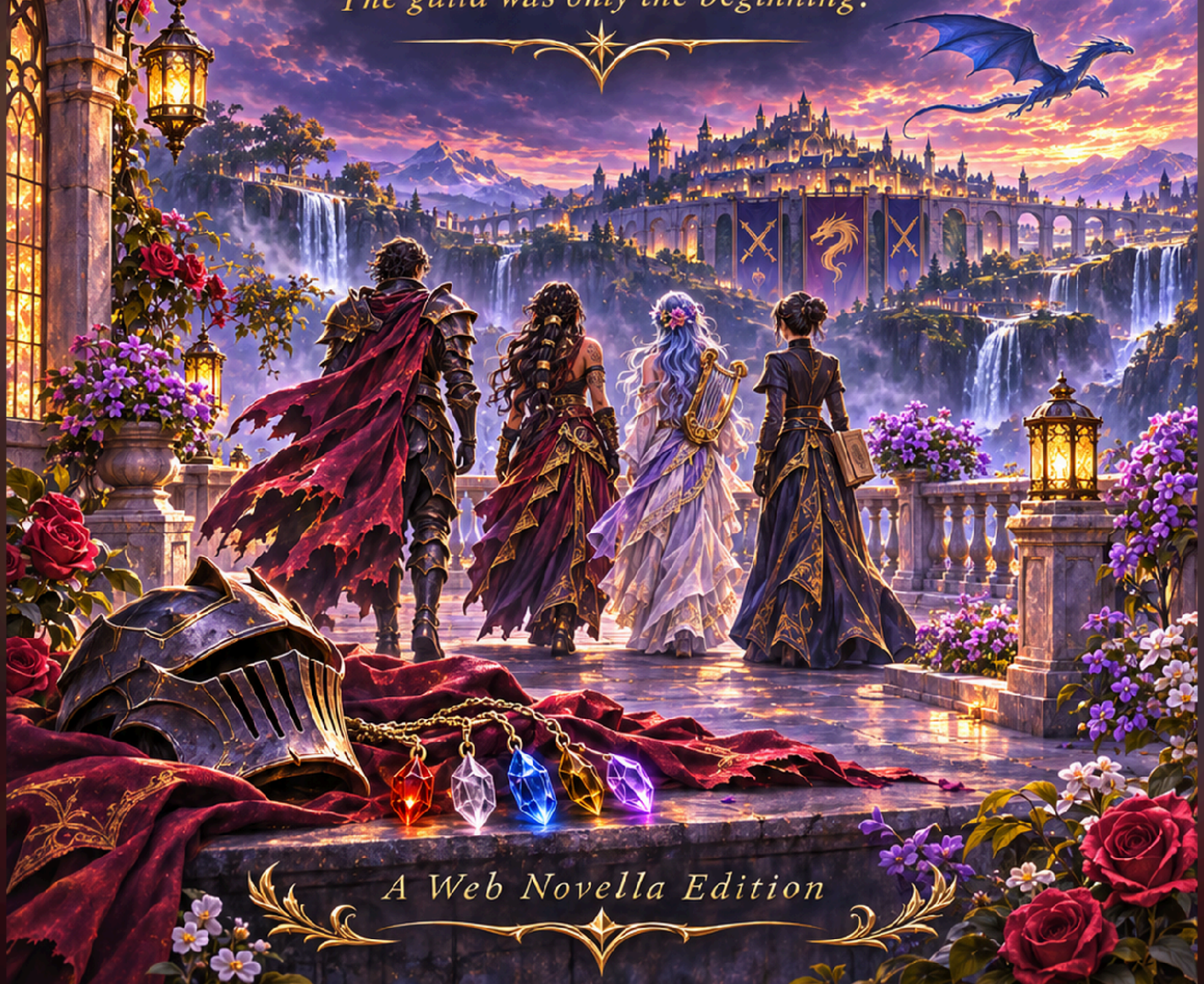
Shade was sent to the mortal world to learn restraint. Instead, he found a guild worth protecting, a home worth fighting for, and three women who turned duty into something dangerously close to happiness.

Now the stakes are rising.

Arcebek walks the line between eldritch bargains and fierce devotion. Rakihi brings music, mischief, and fey trouble in equal measure. Elcia, caught between death and judgment, is forging a new oath at Shade's side. Together they stand at the heart of the Black Squad—Lana's most feared crisis team.

But demons still dig beneath the world. Guild politics turn sharper. Old powers from the Blue Flight stir across the sky. And when Shade is pushed from loyal weapon to reluctant leader, he must decide what kind of future he will build: one forged by duty alone... or one defended by love, hearth, and chosen family.

The guild was only the beginning.



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